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Hebrews

Hebrews 1:1

Section 1:1–4: Introduction: God has spoken through his Son

The first four verses of the book of Hebrews explain what the book is about. In the past God spoke to his people through his prophets. Now during this later time, he has spoken to his people through his own Son. God's Son shows people who God is.

In 1:1–2a the author used parallelism to show a contrast between how God spoke in the past and how he speaks now. In the past God spoke through the prophets, but now God speaks to us through his Son. In your translation, it is important to emphasize this contrast, especially the fact that God now speaks to us by the Son.

1:1	1:2
in the past	in these last days
to our fathers	to us
through the prophets	by His Son

In Greek, the four verses in 1:1–4 are one long sentence that describes who the Son is and what he has done. It is common in Greek to have long sentences like this. Most English versions divide this section into several sentences. You may do what is natural in your language.

In 1:2b–3e there are seven important facts about God's Son:

1. God appointed his Son to be heir of all things (an important theme in 1:5–6).
2. God created everything through his Son (an important theme in 1:7–14).
3. The Son reflects God's glory (an important theme in 2:5–8).
4. The Son shows us exactly what God is like.
5. The Son keeps everything working by his powerful word.
6. The Son made a way to make people clean from their sin (an important theme in 2:10–17, 5:1–10, 7:1–28, and 9:1–10:18).
7. The Son sat down on the right side of God (see 1:13 and 8:1–2).

It is good to translate the section before you decide on a heading for it. Some other possible headings are:

God has revealed himself to us through his Son.

The greatness of the Son of God

Paragraph 1:1–4

There are several ways to arrange the phrases in 1:1–4. The BSB mostly follows the order of phrases in the Greek text. The NIV uses a different order. Compare the order of the phrases in the BSB and NIV below:

¹On many past occasions and in many different ways, God spoke to our fathers through the prophets. ²But in these last days He has spoken to us by His Son... (BSB)

¹In the past God spoke to our forefathers through the prophets at many times and in various ways, ²but in these last days he has spoken to us by his Son... (NIV)

The NIV puts the phrase “at many times and in various ways” at the end of 1:1 instead of at the beginning, as in the BSB. Use an order that is natural in your language.

1:1a

On many past occasions and in many different ways,

- ¶ In past ages, at many different times and in many different ways,
- ¶ Long ago, on many different occasions and in various ways,

On many past occasions: The phrase On many past occasions refers to past times that have already ended. It refers to the past in contrast to the present. In this context it refers to the times when God spoke to people through prophets. This time period ended several hundred years before the author of Hebrews wrote. Refer to it in a natural way in your language.

in many different ways: The letter to the Hebrews begins with two words which sound like each other, and which are linked by kai ‘and.’ They are *polumerōs* and *polutrōps*. Both words start with *polu-* which means “many,” and they make a striking beginning to this book. The phrase in many different ways indicates that God gave different kinds of messages, including laws, promises, instructions, and prophecies. He communicated these messages in different ways, for example, by dreams, visions, direct messages, signs, and symbols, and events. The prophets who communicated the messages lived at different times in the past.

Other ways to translate the phrase “On many past occasions and in many different ways” are:

using various ways on many different occasions

at many different times and in many different ways (GW)

1:1b

God spoke to our fathers through the prophets.

- God spoke to our^(incl) ancestors through the prophets.
- God spoke to our^(incl) forefathers through the prophets,

God spoke to our fathers through the prophets: The phrase spoke...through the prophets indicates that God told the prophets what he wanted them to tell the other people. Then the prophets told the people those messages from God. Some other ways to translate this meaning are:

God spoke to our ancestors by means of the prophets

God sent prophets to speak his messages to our forefathers

to our fathers: The phrase to our fathers refers to the ancestors of the author and readers of Hebrews. It refers in general to the people of Israel in the Old Testament, who were descendants of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob.

prophets: The prophets were men who spoke messages from God. They told others what God revealed to them. Some ways to translate prophets are:

spokesmen for God

men who spoke his/God's words

his message-speakers

It is good to use a general term that does not focus only on foretelling the future. Prophets did foretell the future, but they also gave people other messages from God. They spoke about their own times, and they told people to stop sinning and to obey God.

When choosing a term for prophets, consider how you will distinguish prophets from other words which are similar in meaning such as "angels," "apostles," and "preachers."

See also prophet meaning 1A in KBT.

General Comment on 1:1a-b

It may be helpful in your language to reorder the phrases in 1:1. For example:

^{1a}In the past ^{1b}God spoke to our ancestors through the prophets ^{1b}at many times and in various ways.

^{1a}Long ago, ^{1b}God spoke to our ancestors ^{1a}at many different times and in many different ways. ^{1b}He spoke to them through the prophets.

Hebrews 1:2

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In 1:2b-3e there are seven important facts about God's Son:

1. God appointed his Son to be heir of all things (an important theme in 1:5-6).
2. God created everything through his Son (an important theme in 1:7-14).
3. The Son reflects God's glory (an important theme in 2:5-8).
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5. The Son keeps everything working by his powerful word.

6. The Son made a way to make people clean from their sin (an important theme in 2:10–17, 5:1–10, 7:1–28, and 9:1–10:18).
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The NIV puts the phrase “at many times and in various ways” at the end of 1:1 instead of at the beginning, as in the BSB. Use an order that is natural in your language.

1:2a

But in these last days He has spoken to us by His Son,

- Now in these last days/times, he has spoken to us^(incl) through his Son.
- but in this final age he speaks to us^(incl) by his own Son.

But in these last days He has spoken to us by His Son: The BSB supplies the word But because 1:2a contrasts with 1:1. However, it is also parallel to 1:1. After speaking through the prophets, he spoke through his own Son. The GW translates the contrast and the parallelism without using a conjunction:

¹In the past God spoke to our ancestors...through the prophets. ²In these last days he has spoken to us through his Son. (GW)

Translate the connection between the verses in a natural way in your language.

in these last days: The phrase in these last days refers to the period of time before the world ends. The word these indicates that the last days had already begun when the author wrote Hebrews. Many scholars believe that these days began with the death and resurrection of Christ and continue until his return.

Some ways to translate in these last days are:

at the end of this present age (JBP)

in the final days of this era/time

He has spoken to us by His Son: The phrases “through the prophets” and by His Son both begin with the Greek word en ‘in’ where we might expect the more usual dia ‘through, by means of.’ But en can also have the meaning of ‘through, by means of.’ God did indeed speak through the prophets, but he also spoke “in the person of the prophets.” They were indeed the messengers, but they themselves and the lives they lived were also part of the message to people. In the same way, God’s Son was himself the message about God, as well as being the messenger. The clause He has spoken to us by His Son is similar to the phrase “by the prophets” in 1:1. It indicates that God used his Son to speak to us. God’s Son spoke God’s words to people, and he also is God’s Word. He communicates to people what God wants them to know.

Some other ways to translate the clause are:

he has spoken to us through his Son (GNT)

God sent his Son to speak his messages

us: The pronoun us refers to both the author and readers of Hebrews.

His Son: In the Greek text the phrase His Son is simply Son. It refers to God’s Son, Jesus. In other passages, the full title “the Son of God” is used (see 4:14 and 6:6, for example). This title was often used to refer to a savior who would be a descendant of King David. God would send this savior to rescue his people. This person was often referred to as the “Messiah” or “Christ.”

The title “the Son of God” also indicates that Jesus has the same nature and character as God. The relationship between God the Father and Jesus, his Son, is similar in some way to the relationship between human fathers and sons. God the Father does not have

a physical body. He did not have a sexual relationship with Mary that resulted in her becoming pregnant and giving birth to Jesus. The Son of God existed eternally as the Son with his Father.

In areas where people do not understand the title “the Son of God” in this way, you may want to include a footnote that explains the correct meaning. Here is a suggested footnote:

This title refers to Jesus. It indicates that Jesus has the same nature and character as God. It does not mean that God the Father had a sexual relationship with Mary that resulted in her becoming pregnant and giving birth to Jesus. Mary became pregnant with Jesus in a miraculous way by the Holy Spirit of God.

In some languages, it is natural to speak of a son as a “child,” without specifying male or female. If that is true in your language, you may use a more general term, such as:

the Child of God A translation of the title “the Son of God” must include a familial term such as “son” or “child.” Translations such as “the man who is God,” “the divine man,” or “the God man” are not acceptable, since they do not retain familial language. Examples of acceptable translation options include “the Son who comes from God,” and “the divine/unique/eternal Son of God.”

Other verses will usually make clear that Jesus was a male child. If you use a phrase such as “the male child of God,” be sure that it does not imply that God had another child who was female.

1:2b–3e

In 1:2b–3e the author tells seven facts about the greatness of God’s Son.

1:2b

whom He appointed heir of all things,

- God chose his son to be the heir of all things,
- God declared that his son will someday possess/rule everything.

This part of the verse tells the first fact that the author said about the greatness of God’s Son in 1:2b–3e.

whom He appointed heir of all things: When God appointed his Son as the heir, he declared that his Son owns everything, just as God himself does. God decided that his Son will own all things.

In some languages the word heir may wrongly imply that God will die and his Son will inherit his things. If that is true in your language, you should translate the meaning in a different way. For example:

God has chosen his Son to own all things (NCV)

God made his Son responsible for everything.
(GW)

heir: In this context the Greek word that the BSB translates as heir means “someone who receives something as his own possession.” It does not imply here that he receives it as a result of someone’s death. See the preceding note for translation examples.

1:2c

and through whom He made the universe.

- and it was through him that he created the universe.
- He was the one whom God caused/used to make the universe.

This part of the verse is similar to John 1:3 and Colossians 1:16. It is the second fact that the author said about the greatness of God’s Son in 1:2b–3e.

through whom He made the universe: The phrase through whom He made the universe indicates that God created everything by means of his Son. God caused his Son to create everything. Some other ways to translate this are:

It was through his Son that God made the universe.

God created the universe by means of his Son.

God caused his Son to be the one to create the universe.

the universe: The Greek word that the BSB translates as universe is plural, and it refers to the whole creation. It includes not just the world itself, but everything that God created. It includes the earth, the sea, the sun, the moon, and the stars. In some languages, you may need to use a phrase to express this meaning. For example:

the earth and the sky

the whole world

General Comment on 1:2b–c

In some languages it may be more natural to reorder 1:2b–c. You may need to say that God made everything through his Son, before you say that God made him heir of everything. Several English versions follow this order. For example:

^{2c}He is the one through whom God created the universe, ^{2b}the one whom God has chosen to possess all things at the end. (GNT)

Hebrews 1:3

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1:3a–b

The Son is the radiance of God's glory and the exact representation of His nature: This clause describes God's Son in two similar ways:

1. he radiates God's glory,
2. he shows exactly what God is like.

Connect these two descriptions in a natural way in your language. For example:

The Son reflects the glory of God and shows exactly what God is like. (NCV)

He reveals God's glory because he has the same nature as God.

He is the one who shows us the bigness of God's life. His character and power are the same as the

character and power of God. Uma back translation on TW.

1:3a

The Son is the radiance of God's glory

- God's Son has all the brightness of God's own glory (CEV)
- The Son reflects/reveals God's wonderful greatness

This part of the verse is the third of the seven things that the author says about the greatness of the Son of God in 1:2b–3e.

The Son is the radiance of God's glory: The Greek word that the BSB translates as radiance¹ only occurs here in the New Testament. It refers to the brightness that shines or reflects from a great light. The statement The Son is the radiance of God's glory is a metaphor. It means that God's Son exactly expresses how wonderful God is. When people know the Son of God, they know what God himself is like.

Some ways to translate this meaning are:

- Translate it as a metaphor or simile. For example:

He reflects the glory of God (RSV)

God's Son shines with God's own glory/magnificence.

- Translate the meaning without the metaphor. For example:

He has all the magnificent greatness of God.

He is great and good, just as God is.

The Son's glory/greatness is the same as God's glory/greatness.

Translate the meaning in a natural way in your language.

God's glory: The phrase God's glory refers here to the wonderful greatness of who God is. He is magnificent in his power and his goodness. Sometimes God gives visible evidence of his greatness by appearing with very bright light. In the Old Testament God's glory was also associated with radiance/brightness, for example, when "the glory of the Lord filled the tabernacle" (Exodus 40:34). In this context, the word glory refers to God's greatness.

Some ways to translate God's glory in this context are:

the goodness and greatness of God
Kankanaey back translation on TW.

God's majesty/magnificence

1:3b

and the exact representation of His nature,

- and is like him in every way. (CEV)
- and shows us exactly what God is like.

This part of the verse is the fourth of the seven things that the author says about the greatness of the Son of God in 1:2b–3e.

and the exact representation of His nature: This phrase means that the Son is exactly like God in every way. Some ways to translate the phrase are:

and shows exactly what God is like (NCV)

and is like him in every way (CEV)

Whatever God is, that is also what His son is.
Western Bukidnon Manobo back translation on TW.

His nature: The phrase His nature refers to God's nature or God's essence. It refers to God's character, which is what God is in himself. The Son's nature is exactly like God's nature. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

God's very being (NRSV)

the very character of God (NLT)

his godhood

what he is

1:3c

upholding all things by His powerful word.

- God's Son uses his powerful word to sustain everything that exists.
- The Son speaks with power. By speaking he upholds and rules the universe and everything in it.

This is the fifth of the seven things which the author said about the greatness of God's Son in 1:2b–3e.

upholding all things by His powerful word: The clause upholding all things by His powerful word indicates that the Son uses his powerful words to support and care for everything in the universe. Other ways to translate this are:

He speaks with power to sustain/support everything that he created.

He uses his powerful word to control and care for the whole universe/world.

Notice that the second example uses two phrases to translate the verb upholding.

all things: The phrase all things refers to everything that exists. It includes the whole universe and everything in it. The Son of God sustains all people, animals, plants, and everything else on earth and everything in the sky such as the sun, moon, and stars. Some other ways to translate all things in this context are:

all that exists

the universe and everything in it (NLT96)

by His powerful word: The phrase by His powerful word indicates here that the Son uses his powerful word to sustain everything. He needs only his word to support and rule all things, because he gives his word power to cause what he says to happen. Some other ways to translate the phrase are:

by the mighty power of his command (NLT)

he uses only his word because it/he is powerful
Kankanaey back translation on TW.

1:3d

After He had provided purification for sins,

- He made it possible for people to be cleansed/purified from sins,
- After he did everything that was necessary to make people clean from their sins,
- After the Son had washed away people's sins,

This is the sixth of the seven things which the author said about the greatness of God's Son in 1:2b-3e.

After He had provided purification for sins: The clause After He had provided purification for sins means "After the Son made it possible for people to

be cleansed from their sins." A sacrifice is necessary for people to be purified. God's Son made that sacrifice by dying on the cross for their sins. Jesus made this sacrifice as their high priest. The Greek verb that the BSB translated as had provided implies that the Son completed this purification by his sacrifice.

Some ways to translate this clause are:

When he had provided a way for people to be made clean from their sins

After the Son had washed away people's sins

After he did what was necessary for people to be purified from their sins

purification for sins: The phrase purification for sins contains implied information. It implies that people had sinned against God, and these sins caused God to consider them impure. God would not forgive them unless they were purified from those sins. Jesus did what was necessary for people to be forgiven. He made the sacrifice to purify them. See the translation examples in the preceding note.

In some languages it may be necessary to add some implied information here. For example:

made the necessary sacrifice to cleanse people from sins

sacrificed himself so that people could be purified from their sins

sins: The word sins refers to offenses against God. Sins include acts, thoughts, and attitudes that are not what God wants or approves. In Greek, the verb that English versions translate as sins is also a term that is used in archery to mean "miss the target." When a person sins, he "misses" the target, that is, he fails to reach God's standard. People also offend God by not doing what he wants them to do. In this context the word sins refers to all the ways that people have wronged God.

Try to translate sins with a general term that can include any wrongdoing against God. Here are problems to avoid:

1. The term should not imply that only serious crimes like murder or stealing are sins. Other offenses like gossip, greed, and evil thoughts are also sins. It is

also sinful to avoid doing what God commands or desires.

2. The term should not include accidents or mistakes that are not against God's will.

Some ways to translate sins are:

wrong acts

offenses against God

evil deeds

In some languages it may be natural to translate sins with a phrase that includes a verb. For example:

the evil that people have done

For more information, see sin in KBT.

1:3e

He sat down at the right hand of the Majesty on high.

- and then he sat down on the right side of the Glorious One in heaven.
- he went and sat beside God the All-Powerful in heaven.
- God gave him the place of greatest honor with him in heaven.

This is the seventh thing which the author said about the greatness of God's Son in 1:2b-3e. It tells what the Son did after he finished atoning for people's sins (1:3d).

He sat down at the right hand of the Majesty on high: This clause uses figurative language. It indicates that the Son received the place of greatest honor and authority with God. The phrase the Majesty on high refers to God, the King over everything. Sitting at God's right hand symbolizes that God's Son shares God's authority. In this context, God gave his Son authority to rule with him after the Son atoned for people's sins.

There are several ways to translate this clause:

- Use the figurative language in your translation. For example:

he sat down at the right side of the glorious God in heaven (CEV)

- Use the figurative language and make the meaning explicit. For example:

he sat down in the seat of honor at the right side of God

- Translate the meaning without the figurative language. For example:

God gave him the place of greatest honor/authority with him in heaven

the Majesty: The phrase the Majesty refers here to God himself, not just to his majesty and greatness. Some ways to translate it here are:

- Use a special word or phrase in your language that people use as a way to praise God for his power or glory. For example:

the All-Powerful

- Use a descriptive phrase and make explicit that it refers to God. For example:

God in his majesty

God, the Supreme Power (GNT) Be sure that your translation does not imply a comparison with other gods that are less powerful.

- Simply use the normal word for God in your language. For example:

God

on high: The Greek word that the BSB translates as high means "heights." The phrase on high is used here in a figurative sense. It refers to the place where God lives. Because God lives there, it is more glorious than any other place. Another way to translate on high is:

in heaven (NIV)

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The NIV puts the phrase “at many times and in various ways” at the end of 1:1 instead of at the beginning, as in the BSB. Use an order that is natural in your language.

1:4

In Greek 1:4 is part of the long sentence that began at 1:1. It concludes paragraph 1:1–4 with a statement about the Son's greatness. This statement is also the theme of 1:5–14, so the GNT and GW begin a new section at 1:4. However, in most English versions 1:4 is the final statement of paragraph 1:1–4. The author of Hebrews often uses statements like this that conclude one section but also introduce the next one.

In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of clauses in this verse. See the General Comment on 1:4a–b at the end of 1:4b for suggestions.

So: In Greek 1:4 continues the sentence that began in 1:1. Some English versions supply a conjunction like *So* to indicate that 1:4 is a result of 1:2b–3. Some other ways to show this connection are:

Thus (NET)

This shows that (NLT)

He became as far superior to the angels as the name He has inherited is excellent beyond theirs:

This statement is a comparison. It indicates that God's Son is much greater than the angels. The name that God gave to his Son after his Son made purification for sins (1:3d) is also much greater than the angels' name. Some other ways to translate this meaning are:

This shows that the Son is far greater than the angels, just as the name God gave him is far greater than their names. (NLT)

He received a seat/position that is higher than the seat/position of all the angels, for the name he received from God was more honored than the name given to angels. Uma back translation on TW.

It is true that the angels are great and their names are honorable. But God's Son surpasses

them in greatness, and the name that God has given him also surpasses their name.

Translate the comparison in a natural way in your language.

1:4a

So He became as far superior to the angels

- In this way he became much greater than the angels,
- This shows that God has given him much greater honor/glory than the angels have.

He became...superior to the angels: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as He became...superior means “became greater than.” The Son had greater honor and authority than the angels before he came to earth. Then he became “a little lower than the angels” to die for our sins (2:9). When he finished providing that purification (1:3d), he sat down at God’s right hand (1:3e). At that time, he again became superior to the angels and received even more honor and authority than he had before.

Another way to translate He became...superior to the angels is:

has been given praiseworthiness/glory which is better than the glory of the angels
Tagbanwa back translation on TW.

angels: The Greek word that the BSB translates as angels means “messengers.” It refers here to spirit beings who serve God. Sometimes God sends an angel to tell a message to human beings. He also sends angels to serve him in other ways. Some ways to translate this term are:

- Use a descriptive word or phrase. For example:

messengers from God/heaven

good/holy spirit-beings

- Use a local term that fits the biblical meaning.
- In some areas the churches may already be using a borrowed term or a transliterated word for “angel.” Be sure that this term fits the biblical meaning. If some people do not understand the right meaning from this term, you may need to indicate the meaning in some way. For example:

angelos messengers from God

sacred angelos spirits

Be sure that your term for “angel” is different from your terms for “prophet” and “apostle.” See angel Meaning 1 in KBT for more information. If you translated this word in other books, check to see how you translated it there.

1:4b

as the name He has inherited is excellent beyond theirs.

- and he inherited/received a much greater name than they have.
- In the same way the title Son which God gave him is more honorable/glorious than their title.

as the name He has inherited is excellent beyond theirs:

This clause is the second part of the comparison in 1:4a. Just as the Son himself is greater than the angels, he also inherited a name (title) that is greater than their name (title). In this context the verb inherited implies that he received the name from God. In some languages it is necessary to make that explicit. For example:

and God gave him a name that is much greater than theirs (NCV)

the name He has inherited: The word inherited is a verb form of the noun that the BSB translated as “heir” in 1:2b. The verb is used in a similar way here to mean “gained” or “received.” BDAG, page 547, lists “acquire, obtain, come into possession of” as the second meaning of this word. God’s Son gained this name because God gave it to him. The verb does not imply here that the Son received the name when someone died. Some ways to translate He has inherited in this context are:

he has been given a name (GW)

the name God gave him (GNT)

the name that he received from God

Translate the meaning in a similar way as you translated “heir” in 1:2. In some languages it may be necessary to specify the name that the Son received. If that is true in your language, you may supply “Son” as the quotations in 1:5 indicate. Montefiore (page 39) says, “The name which Jesus has by right must be the name of the Son, as the succeeding verses establish.” Lane (page 17) says, “In verse 4 the superior name is almost certainly the acclamation ‘my son’ of Psalm

2:7 quoted in verse 5....” Ellingworth (page 105) states, “The immediate context suggests that the ‘name’ is that of Son....” An Exegetical Summary of Hebrews (page 31) lists thirteen commentaries that follow this view. For example:

he has been given the name Son of God

the name: The Greek word that the BSB translates as name refers to the authority and role that the Son has. It does not refer here to a name that people called him, such as “Jesus” or “Emmanuel.” It may refer either to his role as God’s Son or to his role in general. Some other ways to translate name in this context are:

authority

position/status

title

excellent beyond: In this context the phrase excellent beyond has almost the same meaning as “superior to” earlier in this verse. It continues the comparison between God’s Son and the angels. As he is much greater than they are, his name is also much greater. You should use an appropriate way in your language to describe an excellent role or rank.

In some languages it may be helpful to use the same word for the comparison in both places. For example:

The Son was made greater than the angels, just as the name that God gave him is greater than theirs. (GNT)

theirs: The pronoun theirs is a short way to refer to “their name,” which the author compares to the Son’s “name.” The word “name” is implied. It refers to the angels’ rank and authority. In some languages it is necessary to translate “name” explicitly here. For example:

their name

their authority/title

General Comment on 1:4a–b

In the Greek text, 1:4 is a long sentence that compares the Son and his name to the angels and their name. In some languages it is more natural to make a compar-

ison by making two separate statements that contrast with each other. For example:

The angels are not great; the Son is great. Likewise, the name that God gave the angels is not great; the name he gave his Son is great.

In this division the author gave evidence to prove that Jesus is greater than the angels. This evidence was important because people honored the angels as the ones who delivered God’s law to Moses. Deuteronomy 33:2; Acts 7:38, 7:53; Galatians 3:19; Hebrews 2:2. See the section on Logical Development of the Theme of Hebrews to see how the author used this division in developing the theme of Hebrews.

The word “angels” in 1:4 is the link to the remaining verses of chapters 1 and 2. The Notes divides Division 1:5–2:18 into three sections that compare Jesus with the angels: Within these sections there are many different contrasts between the angels and the Son. However, these section headings focus on the major contrasts in the section. One of the techniques used to determine the major focus of each of the sections was to observe the ideas which were repeated in later sections of the book due to chiastic patterning of the text.

1:5–14	There is some evidence that 1:5–6 and 1:7–14 are different points to the author. See Heath 2011:133, 300–304. Koester asserts the integrity of Heb 1:5–6 as a smaller unit (2001:199–202). However, many English versions and commentaries combine 1:5–6 and 1:7–14 into one section, although most start a new paragraph with verse 7. The REB and NET place verses 6 and 7 within the same paragraph.	The Son is greater than the angels because God calls Jesus his Son
2:1–4		Warning: Do not ignore Jesus’ message.
2:5–18		The Son is greater because he calls us his brothers and understands our weakness.

Notice that a warning occurs in 2:1–4 before the final contrast is given in 2:5–18. Use a natural way in your language for a person to give a warning in the process of explaining a topic.

Consider whether you want to have division headings in your translation. Many versions do not have them, but they can be helpful to show more about the structure of Hebrews. Another possible heading for this division is:

God's Son is Superior to the Angels (GW)

Hebrews 1:5

Section 1:5–14: Jesus is clearly greater than the angels since God calls him "Son"

In Section 1:5–14 there are seven quotations from the Old Testament, mostly from the Psalms. All the quotations are poetry and contain figurative language.

You will need to decide:

1. how to translate the figurative language in a clear and meaningful way.
2. whether to make paragraph breaks between these quotations. English versions differ in this. For example, the RSV begins a new paragraph only at 1:5. The GNT begins new paragraphs at 1:4, 1:7, and 1:14. The Notes begin a new paragraph wherever the author has a quote introduction.
3. how to format the quotations and whether to include an OT cross reference. English versions differ about this also. If you have made a decision about this for other NT books, you may follow that decision in Hebrews also. The quotations in this section are poetry, so many English versions format them in poetic lines.
4. how to introduce the quotations. Some English versions use past tense ("God said") to introduce the quotations, since God spoke the words in the past. Other versions use present tense ("God says"), since the statements are written in the Scripture and the time when he said them is not in focus. Use an appropriate verb form in your language.

It is good to translate the section before you decide on a heading for it. Some other examples of headings for this section are:

The angels are servants of God but Jesus is his Son

God's Son is Superior to the Angels (GW)

The Greatness of God's Son (GNT)

Paragraph 1:5–6

In this paragraph the author gives three quotations from the Old Testament. These quotations show that Christ is better than the angels, because God calls Christ his Son and tells the angels to worship him.

1:5a

For to which of the angels did God ever say:

- ¶ For did God ever say to any of the angels,
- ¶ God never said to any of the angels what he said to his Son. He said to him,

For: The word For introduces an explanation. In 1:5 the author gave a reason that the Son's name and role is greater than the name and role that the angels have. Another way to introduce the explanation is:

This is evident/clear because

The explanation in 1:5 comes from Scripture. In some languages there may be a special way to introduce quotations from Scripture. For example:

For there is a written word of God to His son which says Western Bukidnon Manobo back translation on TW.

Use a natural way in your language to introduce this evidence from Scripture.

to which of the angels did God ever say: This is a rhetorical question. It emphasizes the fact that God never said to any of the angels what he said to his Son in 1:5b–c. It also implies a contrast. God did say those words to his Son. That proves that his Son is greater than any angel. Some ways to translate this are:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Did God ever say to any angel...?

- Use a rhetorical question and supply the answer. For example:

To whom did God say....? Did he say it to any angel?
No!

- Use a statement. For example:

And God never said to any of his angels.... (GW)

For God never said to any angel what he said to Jesus: (NLT)

Translate 1:5a in a way that emphasizes that God's Son is greater than the angels (1:4).

1:5b

"You are My Son;

- "You^(sing) are my Son;
- "I am your^(sing) Father,

1:5c

today I have become Your Father"?

- and today I declare that I am your^(sing) Father"?
- and on this day I give you^(sing) the honor/authority that you deserve as my Son."

1:5b-c

You are My Son; today I have become Your Father: In this part of the verse the author of Hebrews applied a quotation from Psalm 2:7. Psalm 2 is one of the psalms which speak about the Messiah. These psalms were fulfilled when Christ came to earth many years after they were written. to Christ, the Messiah, as God's Son. In this quotation God declared that Christ is his Son, and God will honor him as his Son.

When God said this, Christ was already fully mature, so the quotation does not refer to the time of his birth. It refers to the time when God gave him glory as his Son. Some other ways to translate this quotation are:

You are my Son. And now it will be known that I am your Father. Otomi back translation on TW.

You are my Child. Today I will show that I am your Father. Kankanaey back translation on TW.

You are My Son: For information on how to translate this reference to Jesus as the Son of God, see the note on "His son" in 1:2a.

today I have become Your Father: In this context the statement today I have become Your Father implies that God is giving Christ the honor and authority that he deserves as God's Son. In biblical culture fathers often gave their adult sons great authority and honor. God gave Christ his own authority and glory after Christ accomplished the purification for our sins (1:3).

Some other ways to translate today I have become Your Father are:

Today I have fathered you. (NET)

On this day I give you the honor/authority that you deserve as my Son.

I declare/reveal today that you are my Son.

In some cultures the relationship between fathers and sons is different from that relationship in biblical culture. If that is true in your language, you may need to include a footnote to explain what the term implies here. For example:

In that culture fathers gave their sons great authority. A father expected people to honor his son. If they did not honor the son, it was also an insult to the father.

1:5d

Or again: "I will be His Father, and He will be My Son"?

- And in another place in Scripture God said, "I will be his Father, and he will be my Son."
- God also said, "I will say/declare to people that I am his Father, and that he is my Son."

Or again: The phrase that the BSB translates as Or again is literally "and again." It indicates that the author will quote another statement from the OT to support what he said in 1:4b. The statement will show again that God's Son is superior to the angels. Introduce this next quotation in a natural way in your language. Some other ways to introduce it are:

And in another place in the Scriptures God said

God proved this again when he said

Notice that in 1:5b-c God spoke directly to the Son, so the text uses the words "you" and "your." Here in 1:5d God spoke to other people about the Son, using words like "he" and "his." In some languages it may be necessary to make explicit that here God spoke to people about his Son. For example:

In another Scripture, God told people, "I will be his Father..."

I will be His Father, and He will be My Son: This second OT quotation is from 2 Samuel 7:14. Here the author used it to emphasize the relationship between God and Christ. It indicates that God will show people that Christ is his Son. That implies that he has the same nature as God, and God honors Christ as his Son.

Some ways to translate this are:

I will declare that I am his Father; yes, he is my Son.

I will show everyone that I am his father and he is my son.

I will be a Father to him, and he will be a Son to me.

His Father: When the Bible refers to God as the Father of Christ, it indicates that the relationship between him and Christ is similar in some ways to the relationship between human fathers and sons. It does not indicate that God procreated Christ. See the note on “you are my Son” earlier in 1:5b–c.

Hebrews 1:6

Section 1:5–14: Jesus is clearly greater than the angels since God calls him “Son”

In Section 1:5–14 there are seven quotations from the Old Testament, mostly from the Psalms. All the quotations are poetry and contain figurative language.

You will need to decide:

1. how to translate the figurative language in a clear and meaningful way.
2. whether to make paragraph breaks between these quotations. English versions differ in this. For example, the RSV begins a new paragraph only at 1:5. The GNT begins new paragraphs at 1:4, 1:7, and 1:14. The Notes begin a new paragraph wherever the author has a quote introduction.
3. how to format the quotations and whether to include an OT cross reference. English versions differ about this also. If you have made a decision about this for other NT books, you may follow that decision in Hebrews also. The quotations in this section are poetry, so many English versions format them in poetic lines.
4. how to introduce the quotations. Some English versions use past tense (“God said”) to introduce the quotations, since God spoke the words in the past. Other versions use present tense (“God says”), since the statements are written in the Scripture and the time when he said them is not in focus. Use an appropriate verb form in your language.

It is good to translate the section before you decide on a heading for it. Some other examples of headings for this section are:

The angels are servants of God but Jesus is his Son

God’s Son is Superior to the Angels (GW)

The Greatness of God’s Son (GNT)

Paragraph 1:5–6

In this paragraph the author gives three quotations from the Old Testament. These quotations show that Christ is better than the angels, because God calls Christ his Son and tells the angels to worship him.

1:6

In this verse the author quoted another verse from the OT to show that the Son is greater than the angels. God did not treat angels like sons or say that he was their father (1:5). Instead, he told them that they must worship the Son as God (1:6).

1:6a

And again, when God brings His firstborn into the world,

- And also, when God brought his own Son, into the world,
- At another time, when God was about to send his only Son to the earth,

And: The word And connects this verse closely to the preceding verses. The Greek connective used here is *de*. It sometimes introduces a contrast. It is different from the word *kai* ‘and,’ which is used in 1:5b–c. Translate the connection in a natural way in your language. In some languages a conjunction may not be needed.

again: There are two ways to interpret the word again in this context:

1. It introduces another OT quote to prove that Christ is greater than the angels. For example:

And again, when he brings the firstborn into the world, he says: (ESV) (BSB, ESV, NIV, RSV, NRSV, NLT, NCV, GW, GNT, JBP, REB, CEV, KJV)

1. It refers to the second coming of Christ into the world. For example:

But when he again brings his firstborn into the world, he says: (NET) (NET, NASB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Most commentaries and versions favor this interpretation. Some versions do not translate the word again, but still imply that the OT quote refers to the Son’s first coming into the world.

when God brings His firstborn into the world: This statement refers to the time when God brought his

Son to the earth. Scholars suggest several different specific times that this clause may refer to. It may refer either to the actual time of Jesus' birth, or more generally to his time on earth as a man, or to his enthronement in heaven after his atoning death and his resurrection. Some other ways to translate the statement are:

when God sent his firstborn Son to this earth

when God caused his firstborn to come to the world

firstborn: The Greek word that the BSB translates as firstborn is used figuratively. In Jewish culture the firstborn son in a family was an important person. He was the heir of his father, and his father often gave him authority to represent him in important matters. See the discussion on "heir of all things" in 1:2b.

The word firstborn is a title that emphasizes Christ's status and importance. In some cultures the term firstborn does not express that meaning. If that is true in your culture, you may need to express the meaning in a different way. For example:

honored Son

his Son who has no equal

In some languages it may be helpful to make the term for firstborn into a different statement. For example:

This Son of God is greater than all. Therefore when God sent....Otomi back translation on TW.

Christ is also called the firstborn in Colossians 1:15, 1:18; Romans 8:29; Revelation 1:5.

into the world: The word world refers to the whole inhabited earth. Some ways to translate into the world are:

to the people on earth

here to this world

1:6b

He says: "Let all God's angels worship Him."

- he said, "All my/God's angels must worship him."

- he declared/said that all his angels must worship his Son.

He says: "Let all God's angels worship Him.":

The words Let all God's angels worship Him are quoted from the Greek translation of Deuteronomy 32:43. There is a textual issue concerning Deuteronomy 32:43. Until the discovery of the Dead Sea Scrolls, it was thought that the author of Hebrews was following the Greek translation of the Old Testament (the LXX) here. However, a Hebrew manuscript from the Dead Sea Scrolls also has this clause. Lane (WBC, page 28) suggests that it may be quoted from a translation provided in the Odes (songs) that were included in the Greek Psalter used in the early church. In this context it is a command. God commands that his angels must worship his Son.

In some languages it may not be natural to use the word God's when God himself is speaking. You may need to use another way to refer to him. For example:

All of my angels must worship that Child of mine. Uma back translation on TW.

he commands all of his angels to worship him (CEV)

He says: The phrase He says introduces what God said when he brought his Son into the world. At the time that the author of Hebrews wrote this, God had already said it. Use a natural verb form in your language to introduce what God said here.

angels: The word angels refers to spirit beings that serve God. It first occurs in this book in 1:4. Check to see how you have translated it there.

worship: The Greek word that the BSB translates as worship means to express devotion, honor, and reverence for God or for other gods. Some ways to express this worship are by praying, bowing down, or kneeling to show submission, serving God obediently, and praising him.

In this context It was used in the Gospels, for example, when Satan tempted Jesus (Luke 4:7-8) and also when people came and knelt before Jesus, as in Matthew 8:2 and Mark 5:6. the word worship indicates that the angels must agree that the Son is God, and they must give him honor. It probably also indicates that they must bow down or prostrate themselves before the Son to show their reverence.

Other ways to translate worship in this context are:

adore

bow down to

serve/revere

Hebrews 1:7

Section 1:5–14: Jesus is clearly greater than the angels since God calls him “Son”

In Section 1:5–14 there are seven quotations from the Old Testament, mostly from the Psalms. All the quotations are poetry and contain figurative language.

You will need to decide:

1. how to translate the figurative language in a clear and meaningful way.
2. whether to make paragraph breaks between these quotations. English versions differ in this. For example, the RSV begins a new paragraph only at 1:5. The GNT begins new paragraphs at 1:4, 1:7, and 1:14. The Notes begin a new paragraph wherever the author has a quote introduction.
3. how to format the quotations and whether to include an OT cross reference. English versions differ about this also. If you have made a decision about this for other NT books, you may follow that decision in Hebrews also. The quotations in this section are poetry, so many English versions format them in poetic lines.
4. how to introduce the quotations. Some English versions use past tense (“God said”) to introduce the quotations, since God spoke the words in the past. Other versions use present tense (“God says”), since the statements are written in the Scripture and the time when he said them is not in focus. Use an appropriate verb form in your language.

It is good to translate the section before you decide on a heading for it. Some other examples of headings for this section are:

The angels are servants of God but Jesus is his Son

God’s Son is Superior to the Angels (GW)

The Greatness of God’s Son (GNT)

Paragraph 1:7–9

In this paragraph the author again quoted from the OT to show that the Son is greater than the angels. The quotation in 1:7 about the angels contrasts with the one in 1:8–9 about the Son. The author shows this

contrast in the way he introduces the quotations. For example:

About the angels, he says...but about the Son he says...

Translate this contrast in a natural way in your language.

1:7a

Now about the angels He says:

- ¶ And when God was speaking of his angels, he said
- ¶ About the angels God said this:

Now: This word introduces another contrast between the angels and the Son. It is not a time word. Other ways to translate this word are:

And

Also,

Some languages can allow the context to indicate the introduction and do not need to translate this word.

about the angels He says: Here the author introduces the fourth quotation that he has given from the OT. It is taken from Psalm 104:4, where God speaks about his angels. Some other ways to introduce this quotation are:

God said about the angels (GW)

And when God speaks about the angels, he says (CEV)

angels: The word angels means spirit beings who serve God. The word angels first occurs in Hebrews in 1:4. For more information, see the note there.

1:7b

“He makes His angels winds, His servants flames of fire.”

- that he makes the angels who serve him into winds and fire.
- “I change my angels into wind and my servants into flaming fire.” (CEV)

This part of the verse is a quotation from Psalm 104:4. It has two parallel statements about God and the angels:

He makes his angels **winds**

and he makes his servants **flames of fire**

Notice that in the second line the words “and he makes” are implied. For examples of how these two statements can be combined into one statement, see the General Comment on 1:7b at the end of 1:7b.

He makes His angels winds, His servants flames of fire: This statement is part of a contrast that the author makes between the angels and the Son. It shows that the angels are part of God’s creation, as wind and fire are. Angels obey God completely, and he can change them in any way he wants to. He can make them like winds or fire. This statement may refer to the time when God gave his law to people on Mt. Sinai. Cockerill 1979:109 says, “When God spoke on Sinai he was accompanied by angels and surrounded by winds and fire (Exodus 19:16–18; Deuteronomy 5:22–26). As awesome as those manifestations were, they betokened the temporality of the angels in comparison to one more awesome.”

Some other ways to translate this statement are:

- As a metaphor. For example:

I change my angels into wind and my servants into flaming fire. (CEV)

- As a simile. For example:

In the angels’ serving of me I can make them like wind or like flames of fire. Tagbanwa back translation on TW.

Translate the meaning in a natural way to fit with the contrast between the angels and the Son in 1:8.

winds: The quotation does not specify how God’s messengers are like winds. In some languages it may be more natural to use a singular form. For example:

wind (CEV)

servants: The Greek word that the BSB translates as servants usually refers to people who serve the public as respected officials. Their duties include religious responsibilities. Here the word refers to the angels as heavenly servants of God. God has given them great power to do his will. Use an appropriate word in your language to refer to such powerful servants. For example:

ministers (NET)

messengers

General Comment on 1:7b

The two statements in 1:7b are parallel, and “angels” and “servants” refer to the same beings. In some languages it may be more natural to translate the meaning without using parallel statements. For example:

God created his angels to be his servants, and he can make them like wind or fire.

Hebrews 1:8

Section 1:5–14: Jesus is clearly greater than the angels since God calls him “Son”

In Section 1:5–14 there are seven quotations from the Old Testament, mostly from the Psalms. All the quotations are poetry and contain figurative language.

You will need to decide:

1. how to translate the figurative language in a clear and meaningful way.
2. whether to make paragraph breaks between these quotations. English versions differ in this. For example, the RSV begins a new paragraph only at 1:5. The GNT begins new paragraphs at 1:4, 1:7, and 1:14. The Notes begin a new paragraph wherever the author has a quote introduction.
3. how to format the quotations and whether to include an OT cross reference. English versions differ about this also. If you have made a decision about this for other NT books, you may follow that decision in Hebrews also. The quotations in this section are poetry, so many English versions format them in poetic lines.
4. how to introduce the quotations. Some English versions use past tense (“God said”) to introduce the quotations, since God spoke the words in the past. Other versions use present tense (“God says”), since the statements are written in the Scripture and the time when he said them is not in focus. Use an appropriate verb form in your language.

It is good to translate the section before you decide on a heading for it. Some other examples of headings for this section are:

The angels are servants of God but Jesus is his Son

God’s Son is Superior to the Angels (GW)

The Greatness of God’s Son (GNT)

Paragraph 1:7–9

In this paragraph the author again quoted from the OT to show that the Son is greater than the angels. The quotation in 1:7 about the angels contrasts with the one in 1:8–9 about the Son. The author shows this contrast in the way he introduces the quotations. For example:

About the angels, he says...but about the Son he says...

Translate this contrast in a natural way in your language.

1:8–9

In 1:8–9 the author contrasted the role of the Son as king and the role of the angels as servants in 1:7. He quoted from Psalm 45, which is a wedding song for a royal bridegroom. He applied these words of Psalm 45:6–7 to God's Son. These verses are the fifth quotation that the author used to contrast the Son and the angels.

1:8a

But about the Son He says:

- But when he speaks of/to the Son, he says,
- But about his Son God said,

But: The word But introduces the contrast with 1:7.

about the Son He says: The Greek word that the BSB translates as about usually means “to,” but it can also mean about. Here it introduces the quotation that God spoke to his Son and also about him. You should use the natural way in your language to introduce the quotation. Some ways to introduce it in English are:

But God said this about his Son: (NCV)

But of the Son he says (NRSV)

But to the Son he says (NLT)

1:8b

“Your throne, O God, endures forever and ever,

- “O God, your^(sing) kingdom will last/continue forever and ever,
- “You^(sing) are God, and you will rule your people as their king forever.

Your throne, O God, endures forever and ever: In this clause God spoke directly to Christ and called him God. The word O is not in the Greek text. It is often

included in English versions when someone speaks directly to God, using a vocative.

Use a natural way in your language to address God directly. In some languages it may be more natural to put the word God at a different place in the sentence. For example:

God, your throne will last forever and ever (NCV)

You God, you will rule forever.

In other languages it may be more natural not to use a vocative. For example:

You are God, and you will rule as King forever! (CEV)

Your throne...endures forever and ever: The word throne is used figuratively here. The phrase Your throne means “your ruling as king.” The whole clause means “Your rule lasts forever” or “You will be king forever.” Some other ways to translate it are:

you are King foreverUma back translation on TW.

Your kingdom...will last forever and ever! (GNT)

your rule/reign will never end

1:8c

and justice is the scepter of Your kingdom.

- and you^(sing) will rule it justly/fairly.
- You^(sing) will use your royal power to provide justice for them.

and justice is the scepter of Your kingdom: Like the clause that refers to “throne” in 1:8b, this clause is also figurative language. The word scepter refers literally to a staff that belongs to a king. It is a symbol of his authority to rule his people.

The whole clause means that the Son will use his authority fairly. He will rule his kingdom with justice. Some other ways to translate the clause are:

You will rule your kingdom with justice.

You will rule your people fairly.

You use your royal power to do what is right/good.

justice: The Greek word that the BSB translates as justice means “just, fair.” It has a similar meaning as the word “righteousness” in 1:9. For other ways to translate justice, see the preceding note. In some languages there may be an idiom to translate this. For example:

straightness

uprightness (ESV)

Your kingdom: The pronoun Your is singular. It refers here to Christ, the Son. God used the phrase Your kingdom to refer to the rule of Christ his Son over his people.

Hebrews 1:9

Section 1:5–14: Jesus is clearly greater than the angels since God calls him “Son”

In Section 1:5–14 there are seven quotations from the Old Testament, mostly from the Psalms. All the quotations are poetry and contain figurative language.

You will need to decide:

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The angels are servants of God but Jesus is his Son

God’s Son is Superior to the Angels (GW)

The Greatness of God’s Son (GNT)

Paragraph 1:7–9

In this paragraph the author again quoted from the OT to show that the Son is greater than the angels. The quotation in 1:7 about the angels contrasts with the one in 1:8–9 about the Son. The author shows this contrast in the way he introduces the quotations. For example:

About the angels, he says...but about the Son he says...

Translate this contrast in a natural way in your language.

1:9a

You have loved righteousness and hated wickedness;

- You^(sing) love justice and hate lawlessness/wrongdoing.
- You^(sing) are pleased with what is right in God’s eyes, and you are disgusted with what is evil.

You have loved righteousness: The clause You have loved righteousness indicates that God’s Son is devoted to what is right and just. He does what is right, and he is pleased when other people do what is right. In this context the clause probably refers to how God’s Son rules people justly in his kingdom. Some other ways to translate this clause are:

You love what is right (GNT)

All that is right is what you have valued

Every work/action which is good is what pleases you very much. Tagbanwa back translation on TW.

You have loved: The pronoun You is singular and refers to God’s Son, the Christ. The verb have loved refers to the attitude that God’s Son has always had and still has. He has always loved righteousness, and he continues to love it. Some other ways to translate this meaning are:

you love

you have always loved

righteousness: The Greek word that the BSB translates as righteousness refers here to doing what is just and right according to a standard. In the Bible the standard of justice is determined by God.

In this context righteousness probably refers specifically to the way that God's Son rules people with justice. This fits with 1:8 that speaks of his kingdom and way of ruling. Some ways to translate righteousness in this context are:

All that is good
Otomi back translation on TW.

what is right (GNT)

justice (CEV)

For more information, see just, sense C3, in KBT.

and hated wickedness: The phrase and hated wickedness indicates that God's Son detests evil and rejects it. Some other ways to translate the phrase are:

and you reject/detest actions that are lawless

You are disgusted with evil behavior.

wickedness: The Greek word that the BSB translates as wickedness is literally "lawlessness." In the Bible it refers to not respecting or obeying God's law. Some other ways to translate it are:

evil (CEV)

what is wrong (GW)

lawlessness (RSV)

For more information, see "lawlessness" under sin, other words to compare, in KBT.

1:9b–c

In 1:9b–c God continued to speak directly to his Son. In some languages it is necessary to indicate this by using first person pronouns like "I." For example:

I, your God, have chosen you. I appointed you....
(CEV)

God...has anointed You above Your companions with the oil of joy: The custom of anointing with oil is used here in a figurative way. When kings and

priests were appointed, oil was poured on their heads to dedicate them to God for their work. It was a joyful occasion. For example, see 1 Kings 1:38–40. In this verse the emphasis is on the joy (joy) and honor that God gave to his Son.

Some other ways to translate the clause are:

- Translate the figure of speech and indicate its meaning. For example:

God blessed you more than your companions and anointed you with oil, the symbol of joy.

God honored you more than your companions: he poured oil on you and made you glad.

- Translate the meaning without the figure of speech. For example:

God...has given you the joy of an honor far greater than he gave to your companions. (GNT)

Translate the meaning in a natural way in your language.

1:9b

therefore God, Your God,

- Because of this, God, your^(sing) God,
- That is why God, the God whom you^(sing) honor,

therefore: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as therefore means "because of this," "for this reason." It introduces what happened because God's Son loved righteousness and hated wickedness (1:9a). Indicate this result in a natural way in your language.

God, Your God: In the phrase God, Your God, the word God is repeated for emphasis. Another way to interpret the phrase God, Your God is that the first occurrence of God is used to address God's Son as God. The second occurrence refers to God the Father. This interpretation is followed by the REB and NLT. However, most English versions, including the BSB, NIV, GNT, RSV, ESV, NASB, NCV, JBP, GW, NLT96, CEV, NET, KJV, and the NJB, interpret both occurrences of God to refer to God the Father. The phrase Your God indicates that God is the One whom Christ the Son honors as God. The context also indicates that God has honored the Son.

The phrase Your God does not mean "the God you possess." If a literal translation of Your God has a wrong meaning in your language, you may need to express the meaning in a different way. For example, in this context you may be able to say:

God who honors you

God whom you honor/obey

Your: The pronoun Your is singular and refers to Christ, the Son of God.

1:9c

has anointed You above Your companions with the oil of joy.”

- has poured oil on you^(sing) to show that he has appointed you above everyone else.”
- made you glad by giving you^(sing) a great honor/position that he did not give to your companions.”

companions: The Greek word that the BSB translates as companions means “those who share or participate together” in something. The word occurs five times in Hebrews, once in Luke, and six times in the Greek OT (LXX). Apart from Luke 5:7, where Peter shouts to their fishing “partners” to come and help with the big catch of fish, the author to Hebrews is the only New Testament author to use this word. It occurs here and in 3:1a, 3:14, 6:4c, and in 12:8, where the word describes believers. It is similar in meaning to the more common Greek word *koinōno* that can be translated as ‘partner.’ The author was probably referring here to the angels. In this whole section he was comparing Christ with the angels. Some ways to translate the word here are:

comrades

everyone else

1:9a–c

(reordered) I am God, the God you serve. I have given you greater honor than all your friends because you love what is right and you hate what is wrong.

Hebrews 1:10

Section 1:5–14: Jesus is clearly greater than the angels since God calls him “Son”

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Paragraph 1:10–12

Hebrews 1:10–12 contains the sixth quotation from the Old Testament. This quote is from the Greek translation of the Old Testament (LXX). The Greek word that the BSB translates as “Lord” was often used in the LXX as a translation of the Hebrew word that is the personal name of God. Here in Hebrews 1:10 the author quoted it to indicate that God addressed Christ his Son as “Lord” (God). It is from Psalm 102:25–27. In that Psalm, the psalmist said these words to God. But when the author of Hebrews quoted them in these verses, God spoke them to his Son. He called him “Lord.” God’s Son is the Lord who created heaven and earth. Heaven and earth will come to an end, but he is eternal and unchanging.

1:10a

And:

- ¶ God also says:
- ¶ Again, God said to his Son:

And: The author used the word And here to introduce another statement that God said to his Son. It is also a quotation from the Old Testament. Some other ways to introduce it are:

God also said (GW)

He also says to the Son (NLT)

Introduce the quotation in a natural way in your language.

1:10b-c

In the Greek text, 1:10b-c are in a different order, more literally:

And you from the beginning, Lord, founded the earth, and the heavens are works of your hands.

The word “you” is emphasized. God emphasized that his Son is God, the one who created the earth and the heavens. Use a natural word order in your language. Here is another way to translate this:

Lord, in the beginning you made the earth, and your hands made the skies. (NCV)

In some languages there may be a different way to emphasize the word “you.” For example:

It was you, Lord, who in the beginning...

O Lord, You laid the foundations of the earth, and the heavens are the work of Your hands: In 1:10b-c there are two parallel statements:

^{10b}Lord, You laid the foundations of the earth,

^{10c}and the heavens are the work of Your hands.

The heavens refer to the sky and all that is in the sky. Together the phrases the earth and the heavens represent everything that God created. In some languages it may be more natural to combine these statements in one clause. For example:

you Lord are the one who created the earth and everything that is in the skyKankanaey back translation on TW.

1:10b

“In the beginning, O Lord, You laid the foundations of the earth,

- “You^(sing), Lord, made the foundations of the earth in the very beginning,
- “Long ago, it was you^(sing), Lord, who made the earth,

In the beginning: The phrase In the beginning refers to the time when God began to create everything that exists. At that time nothing existed. This phrase is similar to the first words of Genesis 1:1 and the first words of John 1:1. If you have translated those books, you may be able to use the same expression here. Some other ways to translate it are:

Before anything was created

At the beginning of time

Long ago

If you use a phrase like “Before anything existed,” be sure that it does not imply that God himself did not exist.

laid the foundations of the earth: Here the author used figurative language to indicate that the Lord caused the earth to exist. The phrase does not mean that the earth has a literal foundation, as a building does.

In some languages it is more natural to translate the meaning without using this figurative language. For example:

created the earth

caused the earth to exist

made the earth

If you have a figurative way in your language to describe God creating the earth, you may be able to use it here.

1:10c

and the heavens are the work of Your hands.

- and with your^(sing) own hands you made the heavens.
- and you^(sing) yourself made the sky and everything in it.

the heavens are the work of Your hands: The phrase the work of Your hands is a figure of speech. It emphasizes the fact that the Son himself created the heavens. Many languages may be able to translate this figure of speech directly. For example:

With your own hands you made the heavens (GW)

It was your hands that made the sky. Uma back translation on TW.

In some languages it may be more natural to translate the meaning of the figure of speech more directly. For example:

and you are the one who made the heavens

the heavens: The phrase the heavens refers to the sky and everything in it, such as the sun, moon, and stars. The BSB probably uses the plural form of the English word heavens here because the Hebrew word is always plural. Use a natural way in your language to speak of the sky and what is in it. For example:

the sky Uma back translation on TW.

the skies and everything in them

Hebrews 1:11

Section 1:5–14: Jesus is clearly greater than the angels since God calls him “Son”

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1:11–12

Hebrews 1:11–12 is a type of poetry in which it is common to repeat the same meaning using different words. These verses contain several pairs of repetition. 1:11a is repeated in 1:11b–12c and in 1:12a–c. For examples of how to translate these two verses with less repetition, see the General Comment on 1:11–12 at the end of 1:12c.

1:11a

They will perish, but You remain;

- They will come to an end, but you will live forever. (GW)
- They will disappear, but you^(sing) remain forever.

They will perish: The clause They will perish indicates that someday the heavens and the earth will be destroyed. Some other ways to translate this are:

Someday they will all be destroyed

They will come to an end (GW)

They will disappear (GNT)

They: The pronoun They refers to the earth and the heavens in 1:10. Together the earth and heavens represent the created universe.

but You remain: This clause contrasts with the preceding clause “you will perish.” The created world will end, but the Son will continue to exist (live) forever. Some other ways to translate this are:

but you will live forever (GW)

but you remain forever (NLT)

You: The pronoun You is singular and refers to Christ, the Son. The Son will continue to live forever.

1:11b–12

In some languages it may be helpful to combine some clauses in 1:11b–12. See the General Comment on 1:11–12 at the end of 1:12c for a way to do this.

1:11b

they will all wear out like a garment.

- They will all become old like a piece of clothing does.
- They will wear out like old clothing. (NLT)

they will all wear out like a garment: This clause compares the way clothing wears out to the way the heavens and earth will become old and useless. Some ways to translate this comparison are:

The sky and earth will become old like clothes do.

As for the earth and sky, they grow old like clothes that become old and useless.

wear out: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as wear out means “become old.” It indicates here that as the heavens and earth become old, they will wear out and become of no further use.

like a garment: The Greek word that the BSB translates as garment refers especially to a cloak or outer garment. However, in this context it is probably used in a general sense to refer to any type of garment. Clothes eventually wear out, and the universe will also wear out. Some other ways to translate the phrase like a garment are:

like any garment

like clothes (GNT)

Hebrews 1:12

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God spoke them to his Son. He called him “Lord.” God’s Son is the Lord who created heaven and earth. Heaven and earth will come to an end, but he is eternal and unchanging.

1:12a

You will roll them up like a robe;

- You^(sing) will fold them up like a person folds a shirt/cloth
- They will be taken off like a coat (GW)

You will roll them up like a robe: The author continued to use a simile here. It indicates that God the Son will bring the heavens and earth to an end as easily as a person rolls or folds an old cloak before he puts it somewhere or throws it away. The context implies that the cloak is too old to be useful anymore. Some other ways to translate the simile are:

like someone folds an old robe, you will fold them

Just like a shirt is rolled up, you will roll up the heaven and earth and replace them.

Use a natural way in your language to describe this action.

them: The word them refers again to the heaven and the earth, which were mentioned in 1:10.

a robe: The Greek word that the BSB translates as robe refers to a type of outer clothing that is “put around” someone. In the Jewish culture it often referred to a robe or cloak. Some cultures may use a shirt or cloth or some other type of outer garment. Use a natural word in your language.

1:12b

like a garment they will be changed;

- and replace them as old clothing is replaced.
- and you^(sing) will change them like someone changes his clothes.

like a garment they will be changed: In this clause the author continued the figurative language of 1:11b–12a. Here he said that the universe was going to be changed just as people change their clothing. Some other ways to translate the clause are:

They will be replaced like clothes that can no longer be used.

It will be like people exchanging old clothes for new ones.

a garment: The Greek word that the BSB translates as garment also occurred in 1:11b.

1:12c

but You remain the same, and Your years will never end.”

- But you^(sing) will continue to be the same, and you will live for ever.”
- But you remain the same, and your life never ends.” (GNT)

but You remain the same, and Your years will never

end: Here the author contrasted God’s Son with the universe. Hebrews 1:11b–12b described how the universe will not last forever. Hebrews 1:12c indicates that unlike the universe, God’s Son will remain the same forever. He will not change, and he will never die. He will live forever.

Some other ways to translate this meaning are:

But as for you, you remain the same, and there will never be any end to your life.

But you, you cannot be changed. You will live forever.

General Comment on 1:11–12

These verses are a quotation from Psalm 102, which is Hebrew poetry. It is natural in this type of Hebrew poetry to repeat the same meanings in different words. In some languages it will be more natural to combine 1:11–12 and have less repetition. For example:

^{11–12}Someday heaven and earth will become useless like old clothes, and they will be replaced. But you will continue to live forever, and you will never change.

Hebrews 1:13

Section 1:5–14: Jesus is clearly greater than the angels since God calls him “Son”

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Paragraph 1:13–14

In this paragraph the author concluded the chapter with a final contrast between the Son and the angels. It shows again that God’s Son is far greater than the angels.

1:13

This verse contains the seventh and final quotation from the Old Testament in this section. The author quoted from Psalm 110:1. The words of Psalm 110:1 are quoted in Matthew 22:44; Mark 12:36; Luke 20:42–43; and Acts 2:34–35, and they are also referred to in other passages.

1:13a

Yet to which of the angels did God ever say:

- ¶ Also/Moreover, did God ever say to any of the angels:
- ¶ God never said to any of the angels:
- ¶ As for the angels, God never said to one of them:

Yet: The conjunction that the BSB translates as Yet introduces the final point in this chapter. Another way to introduce it in English is:

Moreover

Consider how you introduce an important point in your language. In some languages a conjunction may not be necessary.

to which of the angels did God ever say: This clause is the first part of a rhetorical question. It is almost exactly the same as 1:5a, which began this section. It emphasizes the fact that God never said to any of the angels what he said to his son in 1:13b–c. It also implies a contrast. God did say those words to his Son. You should translate 1:13a in the same way (or a very similar way) as you translated 1:5a.

angels: The word angels refers to the spirit beings that serve God. This word occurred in 1:4. You may translate it in the same way here.

1:13b–c

The quotation in 1:13b–c is from Psalm 110:1. The author referred to it in 1:3.

Sit at My right hand until I make Your enemies a footstool for Your feet: Here God invited his Son to sit with him on his right side while God conquered his Son’s enemies. The context implies that God’s Son will also continue to sit with him after his enemies are conquered. In some languages a word like until may imply a limited time. If that is true in your language, it is better to translate it in a different way. For example:

Sit at my right side and I will make your enemies a footstool for you.

Sit here at my right while I make your enemies your footstool.

1:13b

“Sit at My right hand

- “Sit by me at my right side (NCV)
- “Sit with me in the highest position in heaven
- “Sit in honor at my right hand (NLT)

Sit at My right hand: The clause Sit at My right hand has the same figurative meaning as the phrase “sat down at the right hand” in 1:3e. It indicates that God told his Son to take the place of greatest honor and authority with God. You should translate the meaning in a similar way here. Some ways to translate it are:

Sit by me at my right side (NCV)

Come sit here with me, sharing my authority

Sit in honor at my right hand (NLT)

1:13c

until I make Your enemies a footstool for Your feet”?

- until I make your^(sing) enemies like a stool for your feet”? No, he never said that to any angel.
- and/while I will put your^(sing) enemies under your control.”
- until I have conquered your^(sing) enemies completely.”

until I make Your enemies a footstool for Your feet:

This clause refers to a custom of kings at that time. When a king defeated his enemies, he put his feet on them to show that he had complete power over them. In this context, the custom is a metaphor. It means that God will defeat his Son’s enemies, and the Son will have complete power over them. It does not indicate that the Son will literally place his feet on his enemies.

Some other ways to translate the figurative language are:

- Use the same or different figurative language. For example:

until you put your feet on the necks of your enemies

until I make your enemies kneel before you

- Use figurative language and make the meaning explicit. For example:

until I humble your enemies so that they are like a resting-place for your feet

- Translate the meaning without the figurative language. For example:

until I have subdued your enemies completely

until I make all your enemies submit to you

Translate the meaning in a natural way in your language. This metaphor is used again in 10:12-14.

Hebrews 1:14

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Paragraph 1:13–14

In this paragraph the author concluded the chapter with a final contrast between the Son and the angels. It shows again that God’s Son is far greater than the angels.

1:14a–b

Are not the angels ministering spirits sent to serve those who will inherit salvation?: This verse ends the chapter with another rhetorical question. It contrasts the role of angels with the role of God’s Son. In 1:8–13 the author showed that God’s Son rules with God. Here

in 1:14 he indicates that the angels are only servants. He uses a rhetorical question to make this contrast more emphatic.

Some ways to translate the rhetorical question are:

- Use a question. For example:

Are they not all ministering spirits sent out in God's service, for the sake of those destined to receive salvation? (REB)

- Use a question and supply the answer. For example:

What are the angels, then? They are spirits who serve God and are sent by him to help those who are to receive salvation. (GNT)

- Use a statement. For example:

But angels are only servants. They are spirits sent from God to care for those who will receive salvation. (NLT96)

Translate the rhetorical question in a way that will emphasize the contrast between the angels and the Son in your language.

1:14a

Are not the angels ministering spirits

- What are the angels, then? They are spirits who serve God (GNT)
- All angels are only/merely God's servants.

the angels: The word angels refers to the spirit beings that serve God. It first occurs in this book in 1:4. Check to see how you have translated it there.

ministering spirits: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as ministering spirits refers to spirits who serve God. The Greek word that the BSB translates as ministering comes from the same word as "servants" in 1:7b. See the note there.

The word spirits is related to the same word that is translated as "winds" in 1:7, but here it has a different meaning. It refers to the spiritual nature of the angels. Angels are intelligent beings. When they appeared to people in the Bible, they had bodies that resembled human bodies. However, they are often invisible to people.

In some languages a word like spirits may imply a wrong meaning. If that is true in your language, some other ways to translate ministering spirits are:

beings who serve

powerful-ones who serve

1:14b

sent to serve those who will inherit salvation?

- and are sent by him to help those who are to receive salvation. (GNT)
- He sends them to serve the people whom he will save from sin to receive life with him.

sent to serve: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as sent to serve indicates here that God tells the angels to go and help his people in certain ways. God is the one who sends them. The word that is translated as serve is different from the word "ministering" in 1:14a, so you may translate them differently. Some other ways to translate sent to serve here are:

are sent by him to help (GNT)

whom God tells/commands to care for...

those who will inherit salvation: The clause those who will inherit salvation refers to people who will be rescued from sin and given eternal life with God. Some other ways to translate the clause are:

those who will receive salvation (NCV)

the people who will be saved/rescued

those whom God will save

See also the note on salvation below. You may also want to refer to how you translated "inherited" in 1:4.

inherit: Often, the Greek word that the BSB translates as inherit refers to receiving a person's possessions after he dies. However, in this context it means "obtain." BDAG, page 547, lists "acquire, obtain, come into possession of" as the second meaning. It does not imply that God will die.

salvation: The word salvation refers to being rescued (saved) from something harmful or dangerous. A person may be saved from physical dangers like death or enemies or from spiritual dangers like sin and its punishment. In this context it refers to the spiritual sense of being saved from sin and from the punishment that a person deserves because of his sins. It also implies

the blessings of being reconciled with God and being given eternal life with him.

In some languages it may be necessary to translate salvation with a verb or phrase. If that is true in your language, you may need to supply some implied information. For example:

the people who are rescued to live forever with God

The word salvation and the verb “to save” are among the most important words in the NT. For more information, see save, sense B in KBT.

Hebrews 2:1

Section 2:1–4: Warning: Do not ignore what God has spoken

In the last verse of chapter 1, the author mentioned “salvation.” In 2:1–4, he told the people to pay careful attention to this salvation that God’s Son brought them. He warned them that if they did not pay attention to it, God would certainly punish them. Their punishment would be greater than the punishment of people who ignored the law, since the law was brought only by angels. This warning is the first of five important warnings in the book of Hebrews.

In some languages it may be helpful to change the order of some of the parts of 2:2–3 to help readers understand the contrast between the law and the salvation that the Son brought. See the General Comment on 2:2–3 at the end of 2:3b for an example.

It is good to translate the section before you decide on a heading for it. Some other possible headings are:

Warning Against Neglecting Salvation (ESV)

We must give earnest attention to what we have heard

Some translators decide to combine this section with 2:5–10. If you decide to do that, one possible section heading is:

Everything Is Under Jesus’ Control (GW)

2:1a

We must pay closer attention, therefore, to what we have heard,

- ¶ So we^(incl) must think more seriously about the message that we heard,

- ¶ Because of all this, we^(incl) must be committed/faithful to what we were taught about God’s Son.

We: The pronoun We is inclusive and refers to the author and anyone who hears or reads this letter.

must pay closer attention: It is not clear whether the author was making a true comparison here (“greater” attention than what?) or whether he used a comparative form in order to emphasize that his hearers must pay very careful attention to the salvation that God had provided for them. If the author was making a true comparison he did not specify exactly the type of attention that he was telling them to exceed. Some possibilities are: (1) They should pay more attention to his salvation than the Israelites paid attention to the Law. (2) They should pay more attention to his salvation than they would give if the message of salvation had been given by angels (instead of by God himself). (3) They should pay more attention to his salvation than they were paying to it when the author wrote/spoke (Hebrews) to them. No English version makes any of these interpretations explicit. If you need to make one of them explicit, it is recommended that you choose interpretation (1). It fits the context especially well. For more information, see the excellent discussion in *Translator’s Handbook* (page 26). The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as must pay closer attention is literally “it is necessary much-more to hold-to.” It indicates that it is necessary to think seriously about (what God has said), to believe it and obey it carefully. The Greek verb *prosexō* that is translated as pay...attention is used in non-biblical writings to mean “have in close proximity to.” (BDAG, page 879) Here in Hebrews it may be used figuratively to indicate that people should “hold firmly” to the message they have heard from God’s Son. This meaning would go with the figure of speech “drift away” in 2:1b. (A boat must remain firmly tied or anchored to one place or it will drift away, and we must remain attached to what God has said or we will stop obeying it.)

In some languages there may be a figurative way to talk about this type of careful attention. For example:

hold on all the more firmly to (GNT)

take what we have heard and grip it more tightly

be more careful to follow (NCV)

In some languages it may not be natural to use a comparison without being specific about what is being compared. If that is true in your language, you may

want to emphasize the careful attention without the comparison. For example:

listen very carefully (NLT)

give our full attention (CEV)

therefore: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as therefore is literally “because of this.” The BSB puts therefore in the middle of the clause because this is good English style, but the Greek phrase occurs at the beginning of the verse. Put the transition word or phrase wherever it is natural in your language.

The word therefore introduces what people should do as a result of what the author said in chapter 1: Now God has spoken to us through a Son (not just through angels), therefore we must pay greater attention to what we have heard through God’s Son.

Some other ways to translate this connection are:

For this reason (GW)

That is why (GNT)

In some languages it is necessary to refer back to the theme of chapter 1 more specifically. For example:

Since the greatness of God’s Child is like thisKankanaey back translation on TW.

Because all this is true (UBS)

Connect this verse to chapter 1 in a natural way in your language.

to what we have heard: The clause to what we have heard refers to what God spoke to his people through his Son Jesus. The author and readers of Hebrews heard it from Jesus or his apostles or other people who proclaimed it. In 2:3 the author indicates that what they heard was about salvation.

In some languages it is necessary to make the phrase what we have heard more specific. For example:

the message that we have heard

the truth which was taught usTagbanwa back translation on TW.

the good news which was told to usOtomi back translation on TW.

2:1b

so that we do not drift away.

- so that we^(incl) will not be turned/carried away from it.
- Otherwise, we^(incl) may gradually forget/ignore what we heard about him.

so that we do not drift away: The phrase so that... not introduces the purpose for the action in 2:1a. This purpose is to avoid drifting away from what God spoke through his Son. This purpose is also an implied warning. It implies that if we do not pay attention to the message (2:1a), we will drift away from it.

Some other ways to translate this purpose and warning are:

or we may drift away from it (NLT)

Then we will not drift away from it.

we: The pronoun we is inclusive and refers to the author and anyone who hears or reads this letter.

do not drift away: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as drift away often describes how a boat can be carried away by water to a different place. In this verse the verb is used as a figure of speech. It refers to the way that we might stop believing and obeying the truth if we do not pay attention to it.

In some languages this figure of speech may be difficult to understand. It may be more natural to translate the meaning in a different way. For example:

- Use a figure of speech with a similar meaning in your language. For example:

will not stray away from the truth (NCV)

- Translate the meaning without the figure of speech. For example:

will not gradually stop believing/obeying it

Some translations supply the phrase “from it” to indicate that drift away refers back to “what we have heard” in 2:2a. Make this clear in a natural way in your language.

General Comment on 2:1b

In this part of the verse the author used the action of drifting away (on a boat) as a figure of speech. In 6:19 he used a similar figure of speech. He compared our hope to an anchor (the heavy object that keeps a boat from drifting away).

Hebrews 2:2

Section 2:1–4: Warning: Do not ignore what God has spoken

In the last verse of chapter 1, the author mentioned “salvation.” In 2:1–4, he told the people to pay careful attention to this salvation that God’s Son brought them. He warned them that if they did not pay attention to it, God would certainly punish them. Their punishment would be greater than the punishment of people who ignored the law, since the law was brought only by angels. This warning is the first of five important warnings in the book of Hebrews.

In some languages it may be helpful to change the order of some of the parts of 2:2–3 to help readers understand the contrast between the law and the salvation that the Son brought. See the General Comment on 2:2–3 at the end of 2:3b for an example.

It is good to translate the section before you decide on a heading for it. Some other possible headings are:

Warning Against Neglecting Salvation (ESV)

We must give earnest attention to what we have heard

Some translators decide to combine this section with 2:5–10. If you decide to do that, one possible section heading is:

Everything Is Under Jesus’ Control (GW)

2:2–3

Hebrews 2:2a–3b is one long sentence. In many languages it may be necessary to divide the sentence into two or more sentences. See the General Comment on 2:2–3 at the end of 2:3b for examples.

In 2:2–3 the author used a certain type of logical reasoning. First, he used an example about Moses’ Law that everyone already accepted. Then he gave a similar example about Jesus’ message that was based on more powerful reasons. He did this to convince his readers that it was even more important to pay attention to the message of Jesus than to the law of Moses.

2:2a

For if the message spoken by angels was binding,

- We^(incl) know that it was necessary to obey the message which angels gave,
- The message of the law given to our^(incl) ancestors by the angels was shown to be true,

For: The conjunction For introduces a reason for what the author said in 2:1. Another way to describe this connection is in terms of basis-exhortation. The “for” introduces the basis for the exhortation in 2:1. Semantically, this terminology has basically the same meaning as saying that 2:2 gives the reason or explanation for the exhortation. The author explained why we must pay more attention to the message from God’s Son than to the message from angels. Connect this reason to 2:1 in a natural way in your language.

if: The word if introduces a clause that tells two facts about the angels’ message. This type of clause indicates that the facts in it are true. Both the author and the readers already knew these facts, and the author used those facts as the basis and support for what he said in 2:3. Here is another way to translate this basis and introduce the conclusion:

We know that the message that angels brought was valid. We also know that every violation or disobedience of it was justly punished. So...

See the General Comment on 2:2–3 at the end of 2:3b for examples of ways to translate the basis and conclusion in these verses.

the message spoken by angels: The phrase the message refers here to God’s Law (literally “word”) that was spoken by angels. It contrasts with what was spoken by the Lord (2:3). The Scriptures suggest that God used angels to give his law to Moses, and then Moses gave the law to the Israelites. Other Scriptures that indicate that God used angels in some way to give his Law to people are Acts 7:53 and Galatians 3:19. There may also be a poetic reference to this in Deuteronomy 33:2.

God’s law consisted of many laws (which are written in Genesis–Deuteronomy). The word message does not refer to only one particular law. It also does not refer to the type of message that is a short statement or request.

Some other ways to translate the phrase are:

God’s word spoken through angels (REB)

those laws of God that he caused the angels to speak
Tagbanwa back translation on TW.

the laws/words that God gave people through the angels

spoken: The verb spoken is passive. In some languages it is more natural to use an active verb. For example:

the message which angels spoke/gave...

angels: The word angels occurred in 1:4. You should translate it in the same way here.

was binding: The word binding means “legally binding, firm, and in force.” It indicates here that those who received the law had to obey it. The context implies that God would enforce the law. Other ways to translate the word in this context are:

proved to be so firm that... (NET)

it was not possible to ignore/change that law

it was required/necessary that people obey that law

The author will use the word again in 3:6, 3:14, 6:19, and 9:17.

2:2b

and every transgression and disobedience received its just punishment,

- and whoever did not obey it or follow it received the appropriate punishment,
- and God justly punished anyone who disobeyed it.

The clause in 2:2b is the second part of the condition that began in 2:2a.

and every transgression and disobedience received its just punishment: This clause indicates that everyone who broke the law or disobeyed it was justly punished. In some languages it may be necessary to indicate explicitly that 2:2b is also part of the condition that began in 2:2a. For example:

and if anyone broke that law or disobeyed it, that person was justly punished

and since everyone breaking that law received/suffered the proper penalty

In the law God specified the proper punishment for various offenses. The leaders and the whole community of Israel were responsible to ensure that the people were punished in those ways.

In some languages it may be necessary to indicate who punished the people. If that is true in your language, you may supply “God” as the subject or you may use an indefinite subject. For example:

God/They justly punished everyone who violated or disobeyed it.

every transgression and disobedience: The words transgression and disobedience have a similar meaning. In some languages it is helpful to translate this meaning with one phrase. For example:

all who did not do what the law told them to do

every transgression: The word transgression refers to doing something that God forbids in the law or not doing something that he commands. This word is used again in 9:15, as well as in other places in the NT. For example, Romans 2:23, 4:15, 5:14; Galatians 3:19; 1 Timothy 2:14. Some other ways to translate every transgression are:

every time a person did not follow/obey it

whenever anyone broke it

For more information, see “transgression” under sin, other words to compare in KBT.

disobedience: The word disobedience refers to a refusal to listen and obey. The implied object is the message, which was the law that the angels brought. This word only occurs here and in Romans 5:19 and 2 Corinthians 10:6. Some other ways to translate it are:

did not...obey it (GNT)

rejected it
Otomi back translation on TW.

its just punishment: The phrase its just punishment implies that in the law there was a proper punishment for each disobedience. The law specified the particular punishment that a person should receive for various disobedient actions. The word just means “right, fair,

deserved.” A just punishment was a fair or right punishment.

Other ways to translate this meaning are:

and whenever a person disobeyed any of the laws,
he was punished in a fair way

Hebrews 2:3

Section 2:1–4: Warning: Do not ignore what God has spoken

In the last verse of chapter 1, the author mentioned “salvation.” In 2:1–4, he told the people to pay careful attention to this salvation that God’s Son brought them. He warned them that if they did not pay attention to it, God would certainly punish them. Their punishment would be greater than the punishment of people who ignored the law, since the law was brought only by angels. This warning is the first of five important warnings in the book of Hebrews.

In some languages it may be helpful to change the order of some of the parts of 2:2–3 to help readers understand the contrast between the law and the salvation that the Son brought. See the General Comment on 2:2–3 at the end of 2:3b for an example.

It is good to translate the section before you decide on a heading for it. Some other possible headings are:

Warning Against Neglecting Salvation (ESV)

We must give earnest attention to what we have heard

Some translators decide to combine this section with 2:5–10. If you decide to do that, one possible section heading is:

Everything Is Under Jesus’ Control (GW)

2:3

Hebrews 2:3a–b is the second part of the conditional sentence which began at 2:2a. This second part of the sentence is a rhetorical question based on the condition. In some languages it is more natural to change the order of 2:3a and 2:3b. See the General Comment on 2:2–3 at the end of 2:3b for more information.

2:3a–b

(reordered) So if we refuse this great way of being saved, how can we hope to escape? (CEV)

how shall we escape if we neglect such a great salvation?: In this clause the author compared the terrible results of neglecting God’s salvation with the results of disobeying the law in 2:2. If a person disobeyed the law, they were certainly punished. So also we certainly will be punished if we neglect God’s way of salvation. This clause is a rhetorical question that emphasizes that we will not escape punishment.

Some ways to translate the rhetorical question are:

- As a rhetorical question or a rhetorical question that includes a response. For example:

is it possible that we can escape being punished
if we neglect such a great salvation?

will we indeed escape punishment if we neglect
God’s great salvation? No, we will surely be punished.

- As an emphatic statement. For example:

So we also will surely be punished if we do not
pay attention to God’s great salvation.

We shall certainly not escape if we disregard this
great salvation.

Translate this clause in a way that is natural in your language.

we: The pronoun we is inclusive and refers to the author and anyone who hears or reads this letter.

escape: In this context the Greek word that the BSB translates as escape means “to avoid.” It refers back to avoiding the “punishment” that was mentioned in 2:2, the penalty of being punished by God. In some languages you may need to make that clear here also. For example:

how shall we escape God’s punishment?

God will certainly punish us

2:3a

how shall we escape

- so is there any way for us^(incl) to avoid punishment
- So as for us^(incl) who have heard, we will certainly be punished

2:3b

if we neglect such a great salvation?

- if we^(incl) ignore/disregard the greater message about salvation?
- unless we^(incl) pay attention to the great way that God has provided to save people.

if we neglect such a great salvation: This clause gives another condition that is connected to the question “how shall we escape?” This condition is different from the condition in 2:2, which referred to a fact about the past: Everyone who disobeyed the law was justly punished. Here in 2:3b, the condition is present or future. It refers to the possibility that we may ignore God’s great salvation.

Some other ways to translate this condition are:

if we disregard the great salvation

on those of us who will not pay attention to this great salvation

we: The pronoun we refers to both the readers and the author, as it did in 2:1b.

neglect: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as neglect means “disregard, ignore.” The word is also used in Matthew 22:5 when people disregarded the invitation to a feast. See the translation examples in the preceding note.

such a great salvation: The phrase such a great salvation refers to the message about the great salvation that God has spoken of through his Son. The phrase indicates that this salvation is the greatest and most powerful salvation.

For more information, see the note on 1:14a–b, and see save, sense B, in KBT.

In some languages it is more natural to use a verb rather than the noun salvation in your translation. Some ways to translate using a verb are:

the powerful way that God now offers to save us

this great way of being saved (CEV)

salvation: The Greek word that the BSB translates as salvation refers to being rescued from evil or danger. In this context it refers to being rescued from sin. It implies that the people who are saved will not be judged and condemned because of sins. They will be reconciled with God and his people. Some other ways to translate it here are:

deliverance

freedom from sin/judgment

See the preceding note for examples of using a verb to translate salvation.

General Comment on 2:2–3

Hebrews 2:2–3 is one long sentence. You may need to divide it into several different sentences. For example:

²The message about the law which the angels brought could not be changed. Those who broke the law or who disobeyed it were justly punished. ³So how can we escape being punished by God if we ignore the message about such a great salvation?

²Angels brought a message which could not be changed. God rightly punished those who broke the law or who disobeyed it. ³So we also cannot escape if we pay no attention when God offers to save us so wonderfully.

In the Greek text the parts of 2:1–3 are arranged as a chiasm to emphasize the contrast between the message spoken by the Lord and the message received through angels. This special arrangement is a chiasm. The Notes show this chiasm by using the same capital letters (A, A'; B, B'...) to indicate that the clauses have similar meanings: A Because of this, it is necessary B for **us**: to pay attention more carefully C to the things we have **heard**, lest we drift away from it. D 2 For if **through** the angels E was **spoken** F the message was firmly established G and every transgression and disobedience received just punishment G' 3 how will we escape [punishment] F' neglecting such a great salvation E' which was first received being **spoken** D' **through** the Lord [contrasts with angels] C' by the ones who **heard** B' to **us**A' it is confirmed... In some languages it is more natural to arrange the parts in a different way. For example:

¹We should pay greater attention to the things we have heard lest we drift away. ²For we know that the law that the angels spoke was valid, and God justly punished the people for every way they sinned and disobeyed it. ^{3c}But it was the Lord himself who spoke about his salvation, ^{3d}and those who heard him confirmed it to us. Therefore, ^{3b}if we neglect his message, ^{3a}there is no way that we can escape punishment!

2:3c–4

In the Greek text, verses 2:3c–4 continue the long sentence that began at 2:2. Many versions begin a new sentence at 2:3c–4, and some translate 2:3c and 2:4 as separate sentences. Divide or connect the parts of the sentences in a natural way in your language.

2:3c

This salvation was first announced by the Lord,

- It was the Lord who first spoke about this salvation,
- The Lord Jesus himself first proclaimed the message about this way that God provided to save people.

This salvation was first announced by the Lord: This is a passive clause. It indicates that the Lord Jesus was the first person to tell people about the great salvation. The words *This salvation* refer to the “great salvation” that was mentioned at the end of 2:3b. Some ways to translate 2:3c are:

- As a passive clause:

that was first announced by the Lord Jesus himself (NLT)

- As an active clause:

The Lord himself first told about this salvation (NCV)

For suggestions on translating salvation as a verb, see the note on salvation in 2:3b.

announced: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as announced is a common word that means “spoke.” It is the same word that was used in 1:2. Translate it in a natural way in your language for this context.

the Lord: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Lord means “someone who has authority over people. In Greek this word can be used to refer to God and also to others who have great authority. Here it refers to the Lord Jesus. In some languages it may be helpful to make that explicit here. For example:

the Lord Jesus

The title Lord is used for Jesus also in 7:14 and 13:20.

2:3d

was confirmed to us by those who heard Him,

- and those who heard it from him confirmed to us^(incl) that it was certainly true.
- and the people who listened to him reported it to us^(incl), so we know that it is true.

- Then people who heard the message faithfully delivered/told it to us^(incl).

was confirmed to us by those who heard Him: This clause indicates that people who heard Jesus speak told other people what Jesus said. They confirmed that Jesus really said those things. The author and readers heard the testimony of those people who listened to Jesus.

This clause is passive. Some ways to translate it are:

- As a passive clause. For example:

it was confirmed to us by those who heard (NASB)

- As an active clause. For example:

and those who heard him confirmed it to us (REB)

confirmed to us by those who heard Him: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as confirmed indicates that people who heard Jesus speak repeated what he said to other people, including the author of Hebrews. They confirmed that what Jesus said about God’s salvation was true. Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

and those who listened to him told us that it was certainly true

And people who heard that message from his very lips, they were the ones who recounted it to us, with the result that we know that it is true.

those who heard Him: The phrase *those who heard Him* refers to the apostles and other disciples who listened to Jesus while he was living with them on earth. The BSB has supplied the word *Him* to make the sentence more natural in English. It is not in the Greek text. Some English versions supply “it” instead. The meaning is almost the same, since the text refers to hearing what Jesus said.

Hebrews 2:4

Section 2:1–4: Warning: Do not ignore what God has spoken

In the last verse of chapter 1, the author mentioned “salvation.” In 2:1–4, he told the people to pay careful attention to this salvation that God’s Son brought them. He warned them that if they did not pay attention to it, God would certainly punish them. Their punishment would be greater than the punishment

of people who ignored the law, since the law was brought only by angels. This warning is the first of five important warnings in the book of Hebrews.

In some languages it may be helpful to change the order of some of the parts of 2:2-3 to help readers understand the contrast between the law and the salvation that the Son brought. See the General Comment on 2:2-3 at the end of 2:3b for an example.

It is good to translate the section before you decide on a heading for it. Some other possible headings are:

Warning Against Neglecting Salvation (ESV)

We must give earnest attention to what we have heard

Some translators decide to combine this section with 2:5-10. If you decide to do that, one possible section heading is:

Everything Is Under Jesus' Control (GW)

2:4

This verse tells four ways that God testified along with the people who heard Jesus. In some languages it may be more natural to translate this verse as a separate sentence or more than one sentence. In other languages it may be helpful to change the order of information or to combine some of the four types of testimony. See the General Comment on 2:4a-c at the end of 2:4c for examples.

2:4a

and was affirmed by God

- God was also confirming what they said
- At the same time God himself also showed that it is true

and was affirmed by God: The Greek word that the BSB translates as affirmed by means “to witness together with” someone. Here it indicates that God testified along with the followers of Jesus. As they told people about the message of salvation, God showed that what they said was true. He helped them do powerful miracles to confirm the message. Some other ways to translate and was affirmed by God are:

God also joined them in confirming that it was true
Based on the Kankanaey back translation on TW.

God verified what they said (GW)

2:4b

through signs, wonders, various miracles,

- with various proofs, awesome deeds, and different types of miracles,
- by causing/helping them to do many kinds of powerful miracles and wonders,

through signs, wonders, various miracles: This phrase tells how God confirmed that the message was true. He caused the people who spoke the message to do signs, wonders, and miracles. These three words have similar meanings. They all refer to actions that are done by supernatural power.

The word signs implies that the actions have a meaning. The word wonders implies that people are amazed by the actions. The word miracles implies that the actions are done by supernatural power.

In some languages it is more natural to use verbs to describe the actions. In other languages it is more natural to use only one or two words to refer to them. You should translate the meaning in a natural way in your language. Some other ways to translate the phrase are:

he caused them to do amazing miracles to show that the message was true

God helped them to do this work in that they did miracles before the people
Otomi back translation on TW.

all kinds of miracles and wonders (GNT)

These words also occur together in Acts 2:22; 2 Corinthians 12:12 and 2 Thessalonians 2:9. If you have translated these passages, see how you translated the words there. See also the notes on each word below. For more information, see miracle, sign, wonder, mighty work in KBT.

signs: The word signs refers to miracles that have a meaning. They show or prove something. Here the signs showed that Jesus' message about God's way of salvation was true. The word signs is also used in the Gospel of John in this sense, for example, in John 2:11, 3:2, and 4:48.

wonders: The word wonders refers to amazing events or actions. It often occurs with the word “signs” to refer to actions that God causes his messengers to be able to perform.

various miracles: The Greek word for miracles is the plural of the noun “power.” It can refer to a miraculous act of healing or to another act which cannot be done by human power or knowledge. The word various means “many kinds.” Other ways to translate the phrase various miracles are:

many kinds of miracles (NCV)

other powerful acts (GW)

2:4c

and gifts of the Holy Spirit distributed according to His will.

- and by distributing gifts from the Holy Spirit to people as he wanted.
- and with other gifts from the Holy Spirit that he decided to give.

and gifts of the Holy Spirit distributed according to His will: The phrase and gifts of the Holy Spirit distributed according to His will is another way by which God showed that the message of salvation was true. In some languages it may be helpful to translate 2:4c as a separate sentence. For example:

He also confirmed the message by causing the Holy Spirit to distribute special abilities. He did this just the way he wanted to do it.

gifts of the Holy Spirit distributed according to His will: Scholars differ over the exact meaning of this phrase. The most likely meaning is that when God gives his Holy Spirit to people, the Holy Spirit causes them to have the various powers and abilities that God wants them to have. Through using these abilities (gifts), his people show that the message of salvation is true.

Some ways to translate this meaning are:

and with other gifts from the Holy Spirit as he wanted (GW)

and he gave them other kinds of power from the Holy Spirit, just as he decided to give to each one

Holy Spirit: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Holy Spirit refers to the Spirit of God. The Holy Spirit is God, together with God the Father and God the Son. The Holy Spirit is “spirit” in the sense that he is a living being who does not have a physical body. He is

“holy” in the sense that he is God and unique from every other being. He is perfect in every way and is completely pure and sinless.

Some ways to translate Holy Spirit are:

Spirit/Breath of God

Holy/Sacred Spirit

Do not imply that the Holy Spirit is like the ghost of a dead person or that God has died.

according to His will: The phrase according to His will means “just as God wanted.” In some languages it is more natural to translate the phrase His will with a verb or clause. For instance:

just as he wanted (NCV)

as he himself chose

See also the examples in the preceding note.

General Comment on 2:4a–c

In Greek this verse is the final part of a sentence that began in 2:2. Most English versions begin a new sentence here. Some ways to translate this verse are:

God himself confirmed their witness with signs and marvels and miracles of all kinds, and by distributing the gifts of the Holy Spirit in the various ways he wills. (NJB)

At the same time God added his witness to theirs by performing all kinds of miracles and wonders and by distributing the gifts of the Holy Spirit according to his will. (GNT)

Hebrews 2:5

Section 2:5–18: Jesus, the Son of God, became a human being

In the previous section, the author stated the seriousness of ignoring the Son’s message of salvation. In this section he gave more reasons why Jesus is greater than the angels and why we should take Jesus’ salvation more seriously than the law that was received through the angels. Some of these reasons are:

1. Jesus, not the angels, will control the future world (2:5)

2. Jesus humbled himself in order to make himself like us:

- In our lower position (2:7, 2:9)
- In our suffering and death (2:10, 2:14)
- As his brothers, God's children (2:11-14, 2:17)

1. Jesus can:

- Bring us to glory (2:10)
- Bring us to salvation (2:10)
- Make us holy (2:11)
- Break the power of death (2:14)
- Sets us free from the fear of death (2:15)
- Help us (he did not come to help angels) (2:16)
- Be a merciful and faithful high priest before God (2:17)
- Take away the sins of people (2:17)
- Help us when we are tempted (2:18)
- [Angels cannot do this]

Some other possible headings for this section are:

The Son became human to save us

Christ Became like Humans (NCV)

Jesus Became One of Us to Help Us (GW)

Paragraph 2:5-9

There is an interpretation issue in 2:6-8. These verses contain a quote from Psalm 8:4-6. The psalm refers to "man" and "son of man," and uses words like "him" and "his." In the psalm these words refer to human beings (mankind) in general. However, there are two ways to interpret these forms when they are quoted here in Hebrews 2:

1. They refer to both humanity and to Jesus as the Messiah. For example:

What is a mortal that you should remember him, the Son of Man that you care for him? (GW) (BSB, NIV84, RSV, ESV, GW, REB, NASB, NET, NLT96, JBP, KJV)

1. They refer only to humanity. This interpretation is implied by English versions that use plural or collective forms. For example:

What are human beings that you are mindful of them, or mortals, that you care for them? (NRSV) (NIV, GNT, CEV, NRSV, NJB, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The author of Hebrews often used verses from the OT as evidence that Jesus is the Messiah. A number of commentaries, including recent ones, also support this interpretation. There is a growing number of scholars supporting the Messianic tones of Hebrews 2:6-8: Koester (page 221) says, "A tension in the psalm enables it to bear two different lines of interpretation.... The psalm asks about God's will for 'man,' which can be understood as a question about humankind generally so that Hebrews can deal with God's design for people.... The psalm can also be taken as a statement about Jesus, who is God's Son and heir of all things." Lane (47) says that when the author of Hebrews quotes the statement in Psalm 8 "You put everything in subjection under his feet" (verse 8a), he "immediately adds, we do not yet...see everything subject to his control." Lane sees this "not yet" as crucial, "for it indicates that the writer found in the quotation a prophecy that will eventually be fulfilled." He continues (page 48) to explain that since the psalmist recognized that this prophecy has not yet been fulfilled, the author of Hebrews sees "that the promised subjection has reference not to humankind in general (verse 8), but to Jesus (verse 9), whom God has appointed 'heir of everything.'" See also O'Brien (pages 91-93) and Attridge (page 72). For a detailed article on this topic see Guthrie and Quinn (2006: pages 235-246).

In some languages it may not be possible to use a singular form to refer to human beings in general. If this is true in your language, you may want to include a footnote in your translation. For example:

Some scholars believe that "son of man" is used in the psalm to refer to humans in general. However, the author of Hebrews also used it to refer to Jesus as the Messiah who "leads many sons to glory" (2:10). Jesus is the one who fulfilled the psalm's prophecy that God put all things under mankind's control.

It is clear that in the OT the psalmist is praising God for choosing "human beings" to rule over creation. However, the author of Hebrews does not have only humanity in mind. He also uses the psalm to refer to the Messiah. He implies that the psalmist also spoke about Jesus becoming human and being crowned with glory and honor.

2:5

For it is not to angels that He has subjected the world to come, about which we are speaking.

- ¶ It was not angels whom God appointed to rule the future world that we^(incl) speak of.
- ¶ God did not give angels authority over the world/ life that will soon begin, about which I speak to you^(plur).
- ¶ As for the future world that I am talking about, God did not say that angels will be its leaders.

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates literally as For is the same conjunction that it translated as “for” in 2:2. It introduces a second reason and explanation for saying that we must pay attention to what we have heard (2:1). Scholars have different opinions about the function of the Greek conjunction here. The Exegetical Summary on Hebrews (pages 52–53) lists the following: “1. It indicates the grounds for the argument of the preceding verses.... 2. It indicates the second grounds for the exhortation in 2:1.... 3. It indicates the grounds for 1:14.... 4. It indicates the grounds for the exhortation to dedication to salvation through the Son.... 5. It links the present discussion with the preceding discussion concerning the Son’s supremacy.... It is another reason to emphasize the Son’s superiority.... 6. It opens a new stage in the discussion....” These views are not mutually exclusive. The Notes follow the view expressed in option 2, interpreting the word “Now” as an introduction to the second grounds for the exhortation in 2:1. Instead of the word “grounds,” the Notes uses the words “reason and explanation,” as representing the same meaning but being perhaps easier for speakers of English as a second language to understand. Some versions use the English word “Now,” but it does not refer to time here.

Some English versions translate the Greek conjunction as “for” or “because.” Other versions do not have a conjunction here. Connect this paragraph to the preceding section in a natural way in your language.

it is not to angels that He has subjected the world to come, about which we are speaking: In Greek this clause is more literally “not...to angels he subordinated the coming world about which we speak.” The clause emphasizes that it was not angels whom God chose to rule the future world. It implies that he chose a different ruler (or rulers) for it.

Some other ways to translate the clause in English are:

God did not subject the coming world, about which we are speaking, to angels. (NRSV)

For God did not say that angels will be the ones to control the coming world of which we speak.

As for the future world that we are telling about, it is not the angels whom God chose to rule it.

angels: The word angels here refers to the spirit beings that serve God. It first occurs in this book in 1:4. You should translate it in the same way here.

The word angels is in an emphatic position in the Greek sentence to show that the author was making a contrast. It is not angels who will rule over the world to come. Human beings will rule it with Jesus as the leader.

the world to come: The phrase the world to come refers to the world that will exist in the future. The word world refers mainly to the way of life in that future place. The word come refers especially to the time when Jesus will come again and rule everyone.

Some other ways to translate the world to come are:

the future world (CEV)

the life that will replace this present life

about which we are speaking: Here the pronoun we refers to the author. He often referred to himself in this way in the book of Hebrews. Another way to translate this phrase is:

about which I speak

However, when the author used the word we, he probably implied that his listeners were thinking with him about the truths that he was telling them. Use an appropriate pronoun in your language here.

The phrase about which we are speaking is an explanatory comment, so you will need to make that clear in a natural way in your language. For example:

the new world to come—the world of which we speak (GNT)

the future life. This is the life I am talking about.

Hebrews 2:6

Section 2:5–18: Jesus, the Son of God, became a human being

In the previous section, the author stated the seriousness of ignoring the Son’s message of salvation. In this section he gave more reasons why Jesus is greater than the angels and why we should take Jesus’ salva-

tion more seriously than the law that was received through the angels. Some of these reasons are:

1. Jesus, not the angels, will control the future world (2:5)
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 - In our lower position (2:7, 2:9)
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Some other possible headings for this section are:

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There is an interpretation issue in 2:6-8. These verses contain a quote from Psalm 8:4-6. The psalm refers to "man" and "son of man," and uses words like "him" and "his." In the psalm these words refer to human beings (mankind) in general. However, there are two ways to interpret these forms when they are quoted here in Hebrews 2:

1. They refer to both humanity and to Jesus as the Messiah. For example:

What is a mortal that you should remember him, the Son of Man that you care for him? (GW) (BSB, NIV84, RSV, ESV, GW, REB, NASB, NET, NLT96, JBP, KJV)

1. They refer only to humanity. This interpretation is implied by English versions that use plural or collective forms. For example:

What are human beings that you are mindful of them, or mortals, that you care for them? (NRSV) (NIV, GNT, CEV, NRSV, NJB, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The author of Hebrews often used verses from the OT as evidence that Jesus is the Messiah. A number of commentaries, including recent ones, also support this interpretation. There is a growing number of scholars supporting the Messianic tones of Hebrews 2:6-8: Koester (page 221) says, "A tension in the psalm enables it to bear two different lines of interpretation.... The psalm asks about God's will for 'man,' which can be understood as a question about humankind generally so that Hebrews can deal with God's design for people.... The psalm can also be taken as a statement about Jesus, who is God's Son and heir of all things." Lane (47) says that when the author of Hebrews quotes the statement in Psalm 8 "You put everything in subjection under his feet" (verse 8a), he "immediately adds, we do not yet...see everything subject to his control." Lane sees this "not yet" as crucial, "for it indicates that the writer found in the quotation a prophecy that will eventually be fulfilled." He continues (page 48) to explain that since the psalmist recognized that this prophecy has not yet been fulfilled, the author of Hebrews sees "that the promised subjection has reference not to humankind in general (verse 8), but to Jesus (verse 9), whom God has appointed 'heir of everything.'" See also O'Brien (pages 91-93) and Attridge (page 72). For a detailed article on this topic see Guthrie and Quinn (2006: pages 235-246).

In some languages it may not be possible to use a singular form to refer to human beings in general. If this is true in your language, you may want to include a footnote in your translation. For example:

Some scholars believe that "son of man" is used in the psalm to refer to humans in general. However, the author of Hebrews also used it to refer to Jesus as the Messiah who "leads many sons to glory" (2:10). Jesus is the one who fulfilled the psalm's prophecy that God put all things under mankind's control.

It is clear that in the OT the psalmist is praising God for choosing "human beings" to rule over creation. However, the author of Hebrews does not have only humanity in mind. He also uses the psalm to refer to the Messiah. He implies that the psalmist also spoke about Jesus becoming human and being crowned with glory and honor.

2:6a**But somewhere it is testified in these words:**

- Instead, as it is said somewhere in the Scriptures: (GNT)
- We^(incl) can read in God's book/writings that someone says to God,

But: The word But connects the preceding statement in 2:5 with a quotation (2:6b–8) from Scripture. This quotation agrees with what 2:5 says and supports it. In some languages a word like But may be confusing here. If that is true in your language, some other ways to translate the connection between 2:5 and 2:6 are:

- Use a word or phrase that introduces a supporting statement. For example:

For (NLT)

In fact

- Do not use a conjunction. For example, the RSV begins 2:6 with the statement itself:

It has been testified somewhere (RSV)

Translate the connection between 2:5 and 2:6 in a natural way in your language.

somewhere it is testified: This clause refers to a quotation from the OT Scriptures. The verb is testified implies here that God inspired someone to write it, and that person affirmed that it is true. Lane (Hebrews 1–8, page 46) says, “Precisely because it is God who speaks in the OT, the identity of the person through whom he uttered his word is relatively unimportant. A vague allusion is sufficient.” The general term somewhere does not imply that the author did not know the particular book of the Scriptures where the quote is found.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

For somewhere in the Scriptures it says (NLT)

that is the meaning of what God caused to be written, which says:

Somewhere in the Scriptures someone says to God (CEV)

You may want to use the term for “Scriptures” that you have used in other verses in the NT.

somewhere: The word somewhere refers here to a part of the Scriptures. In some languages it is helpful to include your word or phrase for the Scriptures. For example:

in the Holy Book Otomi back translation on TW.

it is testified: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as it is testified means to solemnly declare the truth about something. The author used this verb to indicate the truth and importance of the part of Scripture that he was about to quote. It does not imply that it was used as a testimony in court.

Some other ways to translate the verb are:

has declared (GW)

There is...this solemn assurance (REB)

Verses 2:6b–8a are a quotation from Psalm 8:4–6. If you use footnotes in your translation, you can put the reference in a footnote.

2:6b–c

The words in 2:6b–c are a quotation from Psalm 8:5. In that psalm, 8:5 is part of a longer prayer to God. In 8:2 the psalmist addressed God directly as Lord. Here in Hebrews, it may be helpful to make explicit that the person is praying to God. For example:

Lord, what is man...

What are human beings, O God (GNT)

In the Greek text the word that the BSB translates as “man” is also singular.

What is man that You are mindful of him, or the son of man that You care for him: The words in 2:6b–c are a quotation from Psalm 8, which is Hebrew poetry. The quotation begins with two rhetorical questions that have the same meaning. In the example below, the parts that are similar in meaning are marked in similar ways:

^{6b}What is man, that you **are mindful of** him,

^{6c}or the son of man, that you **care for** him?

The question in 2:6c has an ellipsis. The phrase What is from 2:6b is also implied in 2:6c. In some languages

it may be necessary to make it explicit in 2:6c. For example:

^{6c} what is a human being that you care for him?

In some languages it will be more natural to combine these two questions into one. For examples of how these quotations can be combined, see the General Comment on 2:6b–c at the end of 2:6c.

2:6b

“What is man that You are mindful of him,

- “What makes you^(sing) so concerned about man?
- “It is amazing that you^(sing) care about a human being.

What is man that You are mindful of him: This is a rhetorical question. It expresses surprise that God should be concerned about a human being at all. Some ways to translate this surprise are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

What makes you care about a human being?

Does a man have any status/importance? No, so what causes you to care for him?

- As a statement or exclamation. For example:

I cannot understand why a human being is important to you!

Translate this surprise in a way that is natural in your language.

man: The Greek word that the BSB translates as man means “human being.” The word is singular. It can refer to a single human being or to mankind in general (both male and female). Some scholars believe that the author used this singular form because he intended to be ambiguous. He wanted to use a word that could refer either to the Son of Man as Messiah (Jesus) or to human beings in general.

If it is possible in your language to be ambiguous in that way here, that is a good choice. In some languages that may not be natural or it may imply a wrong meaning. If that is true in your language, you may use a plural form like “human beings,” as in the NRSV. The form should include both the author and the readers. Use appropriate forms in 2:7–8 also.

that You are mindful of him: The Greek word that the BSB translates as mindful means “remember.” When

it is used about God remembering a person or persons, it implies that he remembers them in order to help and care for them.

Some other ways to translate that You are mindful of him are:

that you think of him (NET)

that you are concerned for him

You: The pronoun You refers to God. The psalmist was speaking to God, so he used a singular form of You.

2:6c

or the son of man that You care for him?

- What importance does a person have that you^(sing) take care of him?
- I am amazed that you^(sing) show concern for him, since he is only human.

or the son of man that You care for him: In Greek this clause is more literally “or son of (a) human-being that you care for him.” Like 2:6b, it is also a rhetorical question. It expresses surprise and has the same meaning as 2:6b. Be sure that you have read the note on 2:6b–c before you read the rest of this note.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

What is a mortal that you should remember him... (GW)

- As a statement. For example:

I am amazed that you are concerned about mankind

I do not know/understand why you care for a mere human being.

Translate the clause in 2:6c in the way that is natural in your language for expressing surprise. See the General Comment on 2:6b–c at the end of 2:6c for ways to combine the parts of this verse.

the son of man: In this context, the phrase that the BSB translates as the son of man can refer to any human being and it can refer specifically to the Messiah. Some Bible scholars believe that the phrase “son of man” refers here to Christ as the Son of Man. In the context of the quotation from Psalm 8, it probably referred to mankind (to human beings in general).

In the Greek text of 2:6c the phrase son of man is parallel to “man” in 2:6b. In the context of Hebrews, the author was applying this quotation not only to humanity in general but especially to the Messiah in particular. As Koester (page 215) says, “The use of language from Psalm 8 for Jesus (e.g., Matthew 21:16) does not suggest that the psalm had come to have an exclusively messianic sense by the time Hebrews was written, and Hebrews uses the psalm both for humanity and for Jesus.” It indicates that the author wondered why God concerned himself with a human being. A human seems unimportant compared to God. In some languages it is possible to use the same key term for son of man here that you used in the Gospels.

Other ways to translate the son of man here are:

human being

person

that You care for him: The Greek word that the BSB translates as care for means “be concerned about, show concern for.” Other ways to translate the clause are:

that you notice him

that you take good care of him

General Comment on 2:6b–c

The two questions in 2:6b and 2:6c are quoted from Hebrew poetry. It is common in Hebrew poetry for an author to use similar statements to emphasize his meaning. The rhetorical questions in 2:6b and 2:6c are very similar in meaning. In some languages it will be more natural to combine these two questions into one.

Some ways that you can combine these two questions are:

Why do you think about or care about a human being?

What is a human being that you should be concerned about him?

Why should you care about a human being?

However, the author probably interprets Psalm 8 to be speaking of the Messiah, as well as of human beings.

Hebrews 2:7

Section 2:5–18: Jesus, the Son of God, became a human being

In the previous section, the author stated the seriousness of ignoring the Son’s message of salvation. In this section he gave more reasons why Jesus is greater than the angels and why we should take Jesus’ salvation more seriously than the law that was received through the angels. Some of these reasons are:

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Some other possible headings for this section are:

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What is a mortal that you should remember him, the Son of Man that you care for him? (GW) (BSB,

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What are human beings that you are mindful of them, or mortals, that you care for them? (NRSV) (NIV, GNT, CEV, NRSV, NJB, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The author of Hebrews often used verses from the OT as evidence that Jesus is the Messiah. A number of commentaries, including recent ones, also support this interpretation. There is a growing number of scholars supporting the Messianic tones of Hebrews 2:6–8: Koester (page 221) says, “A tension in the psalm enables it to bear two different lines of interpretation.... The psalm asks about God’s will for ‘man,’ which can be understood as a question about humankind generally so that Hebrews can deal with God’s design for people.... The psalm can also be taken as a statement about Jesus, who is God’s Son and heir of all things.” Lane (47) says that when the author of Hebrews quotes the statement in Psalm 8 “You put everything in subjection under his feet” (verse 8a), he “immediately adds, we do not yet...see everything subject to his control.” Lane sees this “not yet” as crucial, “for it indicates that the writer found in the quotation a prophecy that will eventually be fulfilled.” He continues (page 48) to explain that since the psalmist recognized that this prophecy has not yet been fulfilled, the author of Hebrews sees “that the promised subjection has reference not to humankind in general (verse 8), but to Jesus (verse 9), whom God has appointed ‘heir of everything.’” See also O’Brien (pages 91–93) and Attridge (page 72). For a detailed article on this topic see Guthrie and Quinn (2006: pages 235–246).

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It is clear that in the OT the psalmist is praising God for choosing “human beings” to rule over creation. However, the author of Hebrews does not have only humanity in mind. He also uses the psalm to refer to the Messiah. He implies that the psalmist also spoke about Jesus becoming human and being crowned with glory and honor.

2:7

There is a textual issue at the end of this verse. Some Greek manuscripts include another clause that can be translated as “and set them over the works of your hands.” A number of English versions include notes with this option. For example, the NRSV note says, “Other ancient authorities add and set them over the works of your hands.” In these manuscripts this clause completes Psalm 8:6. The two textual options are:

1. Most Greek manuscripts do not have this clause, and most English versions do not translate it. (BSB, NIV, CEV, NJB, NLT, GNT, NRSV, GW, NCV, REB, NET, ESV)
2. Other Greek manuscripts have this Greek clause. This is followed by only a few English versions. For example:

and have appointed him over the works of your hands. The NASB uses all capital letters for Old Testament quotations. For the Translator’s Notes these letters have been changed to lower case to correspond to what the other versions have done. (NASB) (KJV, NASB, JBP)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). The NET note has a more detailed summary of this issue: “Several witnesses, many of them early and important... have at the end of verse 7, ‘You have given him dominion over the works of your hands.’ Other MSS, not quite as impressive in weight, lack the words.... In spite of the impressive external evidence for the longer reading, it is most likely a scribal addition to conform the text of Hebrews to Psalm 8:6 (8:7 LXX). Conformity of a NT quotation of the OT to the LXX was a routine scribal activity....” Most English versions follow this option. However, since there is also good manuscript evidence for option (2), you may include it in a footnote, as many English versions do. For example, the GNT has this footnote:

Many manuscripts add: You made them rulers over everything you made (see Psalm 8:6).

2:7a

You made him a little lower than the angels;

- You^(sing) caused him to have lower status than the angels for a little while.
- For a short time, you^(sing) gave the human being less status/honor than the angels,

You made him a little lower than the angels: There are two ways to interpret the phrase a little in this clause:

1. It refers to a short time. For example:

You made him lower than the angels for a little while (NET) (ESV, GNT, NRSV, NET, REB, NLT96, NCV, NASB, NJB) The following commentators follow this view: Hughes (Eerdmans), Moffatt (ICC), Ellingworth (NIGTC), Ellingworth and Nida (TH), Lane (WBC).

1. It refers to a slightly lower status. For example:

You made him a little lower than the angels. (GW) (BSB, NIV, NLT, GW, KJV) The following commentators follow this view: Montefiore (HNTC), Lenski, and Miller.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The words that the author quoted from Psalm 2 referred to the status of people, but here in Hebrews the author used the words to refer to a period of time.

Another way to translate this interpretation is:

For this short time

him: The pronoun him is the same as the one that was used in 2:6. See the note on 2:6b. Make sure to indicate this clearly. In English this is done by using the appropriate pronoun.

lower: The word lower refers here to having less status or dignity than someone else. Some other ways to translate it are:

more humble/unimportant

power made less than

In some cultures there are figurative ways to say that someone has lower status than someone else. For example:

was downhill in status a little Uma back translation on TW.

Translate the meaning in a natural way in your language.

2:7b

You crowned him with glory and honor

- You^(sing) honored him by giving him splendor/greatness and respect,
- but then you^(sing) rewarded him with great authority and caused people to honor him.

You crowned him with glory and honor: This clause indicates that God rewarded man by giving him glory and honor. The text continues to refer here both to mankind and to the Messiah. The verb crowned is used in a figurative way. It refers to the custom of honoring someone by placing a wreath (“crown”) of leaves on his head. Among Greek people this custom was used to honor the winner of a race or other competition. Here the figure of speech indicates that God honored man by giving him authority and respect.

In some languages the metaphor of a “crown” may not have this meaning. Some other ways to translate the metaphor are:

you gave him an honored position/seat Uma back translation on TW.

you caused him to be greatly respected

him: The pronoun him is the same as the one that was used in 2:7a.

glory and honor: In this context the words glory and honor are very similar in meaning. Both words refer to a position of great importance. In this context the importance is connected with authority to rule over God’s creation.

In some languages it may be more natural to use a single phrase to translate glory and honor. For example:

a position of great status/authority

Some other ways to translate glory and honor are:

greatly honored him like the honor of a king

made him like a great king who is admired/respected

Hebrews 2:8

Section 2:5–18: Jesus, the Son of God, became a human being

In the previous section, the author stated the seriousness of ignoring the Son's message of salvation. In this section he gave more reasons why Jesus is greater than the angels and why we should take Jesus' salvation more seriously than the law that was received through the angels. Some of these reasons are:

1. Jesus, not the angels, will control the future world (2:5)
2. Jesus humbled himself in order to make himself like us:
 - In our lower position (2:7, 2:9)
 - In our suffering and death (2:10, 2:14)
 - As his brothers, God's children (2:11–14, 2:17)
1. Jesus can:
 - Bring us to glory (2:10)
 - Bring us to salvation (2:10)
 - Make us holy (2:11)
 - Break the power of death (2:14)
 - Sets us free from the fear of death (2:15)
 - Help us (he did not come to help angels) (2:16)
 - Be a merciful and faithful high priest before God (2:17)
 - Take away the sins of people (2:17)
 - Help us when we are tempted (2:18)
 - [Angels cannot do this]

Some other possible headings for this section are:

The Son became human to save us

Christ Became like Humans (NCV)

Jesus Became One of Us to Help Us (GW)

Paragraph 2:5–9

There is an interpretation issue in 2:6–8. These verses contain a quote from Psalm 8:4–6. The psalm refers to "man" and "son of man," and uses words like "him" and "his." In the psalm these words refer to human beings (mankind) in general. However, there are two ways to interpret these forms when they are quoted here in Hebrews 2:

1. They refer to both humanity and to Jesus as the Messiah. For example:

What is a mortal that you should remember him, the Son of Man that you care for him? (GW) (BSB,

NIV84, RSV, ESV, GW, REB, NASB, NET, NLT96, JBP, KJV)

1. They refer only to humanity. This interpretation is implied by English versions that use plural or collective forms. For example:

What are human beings that you are mindful of them, or mortals, that you care for them? (NRSV) (NIV, GNT, CEV, NRSV, NJB, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The author of Hebrews often used verses from the OT as evidence that Jesus is the Messiah. A number of commentaries, including recent ones, also support this interpretation. There is a growing number of scholars supporting the Messianic tones of Hebrews 2:6–8: Koester (page 221) says, "A tension in the psalm enables it to bear two different lines of interpretation.... The psalm asks about God's will for 'man,' which can be understood as a question about humankind generally so that Hebrews can deal with God's design for people.... The psalm can also be taken as a statement about Jesus, who is God's Son and heir of all things." Lane (47) says that when the author of Hebrews quotes the statement in Psalm 8 "You put everything in subjection under his feet" (verse 8a), he "immediately adds, we do not yet...see everything subject to his control." Lane sees this "not yet" as crucial, "for it indicates that the writer found in the quotation a prophecy that will eventually be fulfilled." He continues (page 48) to explain that since the psalmist recognized that this prophecy has not yet been fulfilled, the author of Hebrews sees "that the promised subjection has reference not to humankind in general (verse 8), but to Jesus (verse 9), whom God has appointed 'heir of everything.'" See also O'Brien (pages 91–93) and Attridge (page 72). For a detailed article on this topic see Guthrie and Quinn (2006: pages 235–246).

In some languages it may not be possible to use a singular form to refer to human beings in general. If this is true in your language, you may want to include a footnote in your translation. For example:

Some scholars believe that "son of man" is used in the psalm to refer to humans in general. However, the author of Hebrews also used it to refer to Jesus as the Messiah who "leads many sons to glory" (2:10). Jesus is the one who fulfilled the psalm's prophecy that God put all things under mankind's control.

It is clear that in the OT the psalmist is praising God for choosing “human beings” to rule over creation. However, the author of Hebrews does not have only humanity in mind. He also uses the psalm to refer to the Messiah. He implies that the psalmist also spoke about Jesus becoming human and being crowned with glory and honor.

2:8a

and placed everything under his feet.”

- and you^(sing) caused him to have authority over everything.”
- You^(sing) appointed him to rule over all that you created.”

and placed everything under his feet: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as placed everything under his feet means “put under his authority,” “made him ruler over.” It indicates that God gave the Messiah and/or mankind authority to rule over everything that God created. It does not indicate that the things were literally located under his or their feet.

In some languages it is more natural to translate the meaning without the figure of speech. For example:

and made him ruler over all things (GNT)

The Lord God gives mankind authority to rule everything. Uma back translation on TW.

everything: The word everything refers to all that God created. Another way to translate everything is:

all the things you have made Otomi back translation on TW.

If you have a figure of speech in your language that has this meaning, you may be able to use it here.

his: See the note on 2:6b. Make sure that you translate the whole quotation in 2:6–8 so that the parts agree with each other. For example, if you used a pronoun like his in the previous parts of this quotation, you should also use his here. If you used “us^(incl)” there, you should use “our^(incl)” here.

General Comment on 2:7a–8a

In some languages it is more natural to translate 2:7a, 2:7b, and 2:8a as separate sentences. Some ways to do this are:

You made him for a little while lower than the angels. You crowned him with glory and honor. You put everything under his control.

You made him lower than the angels for a while. Yet you crowned him with glory and honor. And you gave him authority over everything.

2:8b

When God subjected all things to him,

- When God gave him authority over everything,
- As this scripture/writing says, God appointed him to rule over all that he created.

In some languages it will be more natural to combine 2:8b and 2:8c. See the General Comment on 2:8b–c at the end of 2:8c.

This verse begins with a Greek conjunction that is often translated as “for.” As in 2:2a, it introduces a statement that explains something about what the author has just said. Introduce the statement in a natural way in your language. In some languages a connecting word is not necessary.

When God subjected all things to him: The phrase subjected all things is repeated from 2:8a, where the BSB uses “placed.” The word When indicates that the author will explain what the phrase implies. Other ways to translate When God subjected all things to him are:

when he said that he subjected everything under their feet, he meant/implied that...

when it says “all things,” it means that... (NLT)

2:8c

He left nothing outside of his control.

- there was nothing that he did not put under man’s authority.
- God said, “I give you^(sing) the right to control everything.”

He left nothing outside of his control: This clause is a way of repeating what the author said in 2:8a. God put everything under the authority of mankind. When he gave mankind this authority, he did not mention anything that he would not allow them to control. Some other ways to translate this meaning are:

He gave them control over every single thing.

He did not say that there was something that they could not control.

General Comment on 2:8b–c

In 2:8b the author repeated part of the quotation from Psalm 8. In 2:8c he explained the meaning of that part of the quotation. Connect the statements in a natural way in your language.

2:8d

Yet at present we do not see everything subject to him.

- But we^(incl) see/know that right now everything is not under man's authority.
- However, at the present time we^(incl) know that he does not yet rule/control everything.

Yet at present: The phrase that the BSB translates as Yet at present is more literally “but now.” It indicates a contrast between the quotation in 2:8a and what humans experience now. Some other ways to express this contrast are:

however...now (GNT)

But (NLT)

we do not see everything subject to him: The clause we do not see everything subject to him indicates that people do not yet rule or control everything else that God created. The clause contrasts with 2:8a–c, and it repeats some of the words in those clauses. Some other ways to translate this clause are:

But we have not yet seen all things put under their authority. (NLT)

But until the present time we do not see that all the things are ruled by the people. Otomi back translation on TW.

In this statement the word we refers to people in general. Some other ways to translate the statement are:

But today/now, this has not yet happened. Tagbanwa back translation on TW.

But people have not yet seen all this happen.

see: In this context the verb see refers to being aware that something has happened or to experiencing it. It does not refer here to seeing with the eyes.

Hebrews 2:9

Section 2:5–18: Jesus, the Son of God, became a human being

In the previous section, the author stated the seriousness of ignoring the Son's message of salvation. In this section he gave more reasons why Jesus is greater than the angels and why we should take Jesus' salvation more seriously than the law that was received through the angels. Some of these reasons are:

1. Jesus, not the angels, will control the future world (2:5)
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 - In our lower position (2:7, 2:9)
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1. Jesus can:

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1. They refer only to humanity. This interpretation is implied by English versions that use plural or collective forms. For example:

What are human beings that you are mindful of them, or mortals, that you care for them? (NRSV) (NIV, GNT, CEV, NRSV, NJB, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The author of Hebrews often used verses from the OT as evidence that Jesus is the Messiah. A number of commentaries, including recent ones, also support this interpretation. There is a growing number of scholars supporting the Messianic tones of Hebrews 2:6-8: Koester (page 221) says, "A tension in the psalm enables it to bear two different lines of interpretation.... The psalm asks about God's will for 'man,' which can be understood as a question about humankind generally so that Hebrews can deal with God's design for people.... The psalm can also be taken as a statement about Jesus, who is God's Son and heir of all things." Lane (47) says that when the author of Hebrews quotes the statement in Psalm 8 "You put everything in subjection under his feet" (verse 8a), he "immediately adds, we do not yet...see everything subject to his control." Lane sees this "not yet" as crucial, "for it indicates that the writer found in the quotation a prophecy that will eventually be fulfilled." He continues (page 48) to explain that since the psalmist recognized that this prophecy has not yet been fulfilled, the author of Hebrews sees "that the promised subjection has reference not to humankind in general (verse 8), but to Jesus (verse 9), whom God has appointed 'heir of everything.'" See also O'Brien (pages 91-93) and Attridge (page 72). For a detailed article on this topic see Guthrie and Quinn (2006: pages 235-246).

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Jesus as the Messiah who "leads many sons to glory" (2:10). Jesus is the one who fulfilled the psalm's prophecy that God put all things under mankind's control.

It is clear that in the OT the psalmist is praising God for choosing "human beings" to rule over creation. However, the author of Hebrews does not have only humanity in mind. He also uses the psalm to refer to the Messiah. He implies that the psalmist also spoke about Jesus becoming human and being crowned with glory and honor.

2:9

In the Greek text this verse is one long sentence. It may be more natural in some languages to use more than one sentence to translate the verse.

The clauses in the Greek text are in a slightly different order from most English versions. In Greek the verse is more literally: ^{9b}But for a short time, lowered more than angels, ^{9a}we see Jesus ^{9d}because he suffered death, ^{9c}crowned with glory and honor, ^{9e}in order that by the grace of God he might taste death on behalf of each person. In some languages it is more natural to follow the order of the English versions and begin with the clause "we see Jesus." See the General Comment on 2:9a-e at the end of 2:9e for examples.

2:9a

But we see Jesus,

- However/Yet we^(incl) see Jesus.
- But as for Jesus,

But we see Jesus: The clause But we see Jesus introduces a contrast between what we saw in the past and what we see now that Jesus has come. In the past, people did not see that everything was subject to them. But now in the present time, people understand that Jesus fulfilled what the writer of Psalm 8 predicted.

Some other ways to introduce the contrast are:

But what do we see also/now? Jesus became for some time lower than angels, but now...Compare the rendering of Parole de Vie.

But we know that this was fulfilled because of Jesus. Because he is the one who was made a little lower than the angels when he became a person. However, we see that Jesus was...Kankanaey back translation on TW.

But what really happened was this: For a little while Jesus also was made more humble/unimportant than the angels...Tagbanwa back translation on TW.

Translate this contrast in a natural way in your language. See the next note and also the General Comment on 2:9a–e at the end of 2:9e for examples of other ways to translate it.

Jesus: Here the author used the name Jesus for the first time in Hebrews. In chapter 1 he referred to him as the “Son” of God (for, example, 1:2) and God’s “first-born” (1:6). Here in chapter 2, the author calls him Jesus (2:9), “author” (2:10) and “high priest” (2:17).

2:9b
who was made a little lower than the angels,

- For a short time, he was given less status/authority than the angels,
- God gave him a lower position than the angels for a while.

2:9b–c
who was made a little lower than the angels, now crowned with glory and honor: The phrases was made a little lower than the angels and crowned with glory and honor were taken from the OT quotation given in 2:7a. You may want to use quotation marks or bold italics to indicate that these phrases are quotations. For example:

He was made **a little lower than the angels** but he is now **crowned with glory and honor**

For the phrase a little, be sure to follow the same interpretation as you followed in 2:7. For more information, see the notes there.

was made a little lower: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as was made a little lower is passive. The context indicates that God is the one who made Jesus lower than the angels so that he could die on behalf of all people. In some languages a passive verb may not be natural here or may imply a wrong meaning. If that is true in your language, you may indicate God as the subject or cause of the action. For example:

God caused Jesus’ respect/glory to become a little less than the angels’ respect/glory

God caused Jesus to be a little smaller in status than the angels

2:9c–d
now crowned with glory and honor because He suffered death: The clause because He suffered death gives the reason why Jesus was crowned with glory and honor. Jesus suffered death (2:9d), and that is why God crowned him with glory and honor (2:9c).

In some languages it is more natural to change the order of 2:9c and 2:9d so that the reason comes before the result. For example:

^{9d}Jesus suffered death. ^{9c}That is why he is now crowned with glory and honor.

2:9c
now crowned with glory and honor

- but now he has been given greatness and honor as king,
- Yet now God has greatly honored/exalted him

now crowned with glory and honor: Here the author used the phrase that applied to people in 2:7b to refer to Jesus. The verb crowned is used in a figurative way. It refers to the custom of honoring someone by placing a wreath (“crown”) of leaves on his head. Among Greek people this custom was used to honor the winner of a race or other competition. Here the figure of speech indicates that God honored Jesus by giving him great authority and respect. Some other ways to translate this metaphor are:

he has been made big and given an honored position/seatUma back translation on TW.

God has honored him like the honor of a kingKankanaey back translation on TW.

glory and honor: See the note on glory and honor in 2:7b. In this context the phrase refers to the glory and honor that God gave Jesus. In some languages it is helpful to make the translation more emphatic here than in 2:7. For example:

God caused that...Jesus Christ is supremely respected.Otomi back translation on TW.

2:9d
because He suffered death,

- because he suffered/experienced death.
- because of the death that he died.

He suffered death: The phrase He suffered death means that Jesus experienced death. The word suf-

ferred refers to his death. It does not refer here to the pain that he suffered during the process of dying. Some other ways to translate the phrase are:

he suffered by dying

he died

he experienced death

2:9e

so that by the grace of God He might taste death for everyone.

- It was because of God's grace/kindness that Jesus died on behalf of all people.
- Because God was very merciful, he caused Jesus to die as a substitute for all other people.
- God showed his great kindness/love by letting Jesus die for everyone else.

so that...He might taste death for everyone: This clause tells the purpose for Jesus' death (2:9d). The word might helps to indicate that it was God's purpose for Jesus to die. It does not indicate any doubt about the fact that Jesus died. God decided that Jesus should die so that everyone else would not have to die. Jesus died as a substitute for every other person. Some other ways to translate this clause are:

to die for everyone

in order that his death would replace the death of every person

so that he would die substituting for mankind
Yakan back translation on TW.

taste death: The phrase taste death is a figure of speech. It means "die." It does not indicate that Jesus just seemed to die. When Jesus died, he was truly dead, and he remained dead until his resurrection.

In many languages, it will give a wrong meaning to translate this idiom literally. If that is true in your language, you can use the normal way in your language to say that he died. For example:

died (NCV)

experience death (REB)

However, if you have a different idiom in your language that means "died," you may be able to use it here.

for everyone: The phrase for everyone indicates here that Jesus was a substitute for all human beings. If Jesus had not died, every other person would have to die as punishment for his or her own sins. Some other ways to translate this meaning are:

to be the substitute/redemption for all mankind.
Uma back translation on TW.

so that everyone else could be spared/saved

on behalf of everyone (GW)

In some languages there may be a figure of speech to express this meaning.

by the grace of God: The phrase by the grace of God means "as the result of God's grace" or "because of God's grace." Some church fathers and a few Greek manuscripts have "apart from God" instead of "by the grace of God," which would result in the meaning "Jesus tasted death apart from God." However, Metzger (Textual Commentary on the Greek New Testament, 2nd Edition, page 594) gives the reading "by the grace of God" an A rating, indicating that "the text is certain" (page 14). It indicates that the reason that Christ died on behalf of people was because God was very gracious to people. Because God is so gracious and kind, he caused Jesus to die for all people. It was not because the people deserved his kindness.

Some ways to translate by the grace of God are:

through the greatness of God's mercy

because of God's wonderful kindness (CEV)

In some languages there is a figurative way to translate this meaning. For example:

because of the whiteness/bigness of God's heart

grace of God: The phrase grace of God refers here to the kindness that God freely shows to people because he is good and generous. It implies that the people have not done anything to deserve his kindness. Some other ways to translate the phrase grace of God in this context are:

God is kind/generous

God's merciful goodness

The word grace also occurs in 4:16, 10:29, 12:15, and 13:9. For more information, see grace, sense A2(a), in KBT.

General Comment on 2:9a–e

In Greek, 2:9 is one long sentence. In some languages it is more natural to use more than one sentence to translate it. For example:

What we do see is Jesus. For he was “made a little lower than the angels,” but now he is “crowned with glory and honor” because he suffered death for us. By God's grace, Jesus died as a substitute for all other people.

Hebrews 2:10

Section 2:5–18: Jesus, the Son of God, became a human being

In the previous section, the author stated the seriousness of ignoring the Son's message of salvation. In this section he gave more reasons why Jesus is greater than the angels and why we should take Jesus' salvation more seriously than the law that was received through the angels. Some of these reasons are:

1. Jesus, not the angels, will control the future world (2:5)
2. Jesus humbled himself in order to make himself like us:
 - In our lower position (2:7, 2:9)
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 - As his brothers, God's children (2:11–14, 2:17)
1. Jesus can:
 - Bring us to glory (2:10)
 - Bring us to salvation (2:10)
 - Make us holy (2:11)
 - Break the power of death (2:14)
 - Sets us free from the fear of death (2:15)
 - Help us (he did not come to help angels) (2:16)
 - Be a merciful and faithful high priest before God (2:17)
 - Take away the sins of people (2:17)
 - Help us when we are tempted (2:18)
 - [Angels cannot do this]

Some other possible headings for this section are:

The Son became human to save us

Christ Became like Humans (NCV)

Jesus Became One of Us to Help Us (GW)

Paragraph 2:10–13

In this paragraph the author explained more fully why Jesus became a man and suffered and died for us. He did it so that people may share God's glory and become part of God's family. This paragraph is still part of the section which establishes that Jesus is greater than the angels. It implies that no angel provided salvation for us like Jesus did by suffering and dying for us.

Some versions do not begin a new paragraph until 2:11. That is because 2:10 is a verse that links Paragraph 2:5–9 with this new paragraph.

2:10

This verse gives an explanation for 2:9e. It explains why it was fitting for God to cause Jesus to suffer and die in order to be the perfect Savior for mankind. In the Greek text, this explanation is introduced by a conjunction that is often translated as “for” or “because.” Some English versions begin 2:10 with such a conjunction, and others do not. Connect the explanation to 2:9e in a natural way in your language.

In some languages it is more natural to change the order of clauses in this verse. For examples, see the General Comment on 2:10a–d at the end of 2:10d.

2:10a

In bringing many sons to glory,

- ¶ As he brings/takes his many sons/children to splendor/greatness,
- ¶ Since God was leading many sons and daughters to share his great honor,

In bringing many sons to glory: The phrase In bringing many sons to glory means “as part of the process of bringing many sons to glory.” There are two views about who is bringing many sons to glory in this verse:

1. God is bringing them. For example:

while God was bringing many sons and daughters to glory (GW) (BSB, NRSV, NIV, GNT, NET, REB, NCV, GW, ESV, NASB, JBP, KJV)

1. Jesus is bringing them. For example:

as Jesus led many of God's children to be saved and to share in his glory (CEV) (CEV, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), as most English versions and commentaries do. Ellingworth (page 159) says, “Grammatically, *agagón̄ta* may refer either to God or to Christ, but in the context, a great majority of commentators find it more natural to make it refer to God, first because it is anarthrous, and secondly because of the presence of *autōn*, which would be superfluous if Christ were meant....”

bringing many sons to glory: In this context the phrase bringing many sons to glory indicates that God causes his many people to have the glory that is mentioned in 2:7b and 2:9c. You should translate glory in a similar way as you did there. The text does not specify here how God brings his children to glory.

The phrase many sons implies that God has many people. It does not imply a contrast with “all.”

Some other ways to translate bringing many sons to glory are:

while God was bringing many sons and daughters to glory (GW)

God did that so that many would be his children whom he would call to heaven to share in his greatness. Kankanaey back translation on TW.

many sons: The word sons refers here to children of (or for) God. It includes both males and females, as it often does in the NT. It also includes people of all ages. It does not refer only to children. Another way to translate the phrase is:

many sons and daughters (GW)

In this context the word many contrasts with the one God. However, in some languages a phrase like many sons may imply that God did not bring all of his children to glory. (It may imply that he brought only some of them.) If that is true in your language, you should translate in a different way. For example:

his many children (NLT96)

2:10b it was fitting for

- it was right/proper for
- the decision to do that was fitting/appropriate for

it was fitting for: The Greek word that the BSB translates as it was fitting for means “It was appropriate/

right that...” It was right and proper for God to cause Jesus to suffer and die in order to become the perfect savior for people.

Some other ways to translate the phrase it was fitting are:

It was right/proper

This decision...is very appropriate Uma back translation on TW.

So what God did was fitting

2:10c God, for whom and through whom all things exist,

- God to do that. God created everything and causes it all to exist for himself.
- God, because he made everything and it exists for his pleasure/will.

God, for whom and through whom all things exist:

The BSB has supplied the word God here. It is not in the Greek text. The phrase for whom and through whom all things exist describes God. The phrase for whom indicates that everything exists to give God honor, pleasure, or benefit. The phrase through whom indicates that God is the one who caused all things to exist. They exist because he created them.

In many languages it may be more natural to translate the long description of God as a separate sentence. For example:

God is the One who made all things, and all things are for his glory. (NCV)

God is the one who created everything and everything was created in order that he would be praised/honored Kankanaey back translation on TW.

all things: The Greek word that the BSB translates as all things refers to everything that God created. See how you translated this word in 1:2, 1:3, and 2:8.

2:10d to make the author of their salvation perfect through suffering.

- It was right that he caused Jesus to become completely equipped to save them and lead them to salvation through what he suffered.

- /It was right that he used the suffering/death that Jesus endured to fully prepare Jesus to save them.

to make the author of their salvation perfect through suffering: This part of the verse indicates that God made Jesus perfectly able to lead people to salvation through what Jesus suffered. It does not imply that Jesus was sinful or less than morally perfect.

The phrase the author of their salvation refers to Jesus. Be sure that the reference to him is clear in your language. In some languages it may be necessary to repeat the name Jesus. For example:

Exactly correct then was his plan to make Jesus our proper...leader through the hardship he endured because Jesus is the one who leads us in our being saved. Kankanaey back translation on TW.

make...perfect: The verb phrase make...perfect means “make complete.” In this context it implies that Jesus became fully equipped to lead people to salvation. It does not imply that Jesus was sinful and needed to suffer in order to become morally perfect. The word perfect refers here to becoming completely ready to be our leader and savior. Here is another way to translate this:

God made him a perfect leader (NLT)

the author of their salvation: The Greek word that the BSB translates as author refers to a strong leader who saves his people from their enemies. As the pioneer/leader, Jesus saves his people from the devil and from sin and death. He leads them to God to share in his glory. The author of Hebrews also used this title for Jesus in 12:2. The only other occurrences of *archēgos* are in Acts 3:15 and Acts 5:31, both referring to the Lord Jesus.

Some other ways to translate the author of their salvation are:

the leader who saves them

the one who made a way for them to be saved

through suffering: The phrase through suffering indicates the way that Jesus became a perfect leader. Because of the sufferings that Jesus endured, especially the sufferings of bearing people's sins on the cross and of enduring temptation, he became the

perfect leader for God's people. Some other ways to translate the meaning in this context are:

from the things that Jesus suffered, he became a Redeemer who has no lack

through/in the torment that Jesus endured, he became completely able to be the Savior of his people

General Comment on 2:10a–d

In some languages it may be helpful to reorder 2:10. For example:

^{10c}God created/made everything for himself, and he is the one who is ^{10a}bringing/leading many children to share in his own glory/presence. ^{10b}So it was right/necessary that ^{10d}he made Jesus to be the perfect leader who saves them through what he suffered.

^{10c}God is the one who made everything for himself. ^{10a}And since he wanted to bring many children to share his glory, ^{10b}it was right that ^{10d}he should make Jesus the perfect leader who would save them by what he suffered.

Hebrews 2:11

Section 2:5–18: Jesus, the Son of God, became a human being

In the previous section, the author stated the seriousness of ignoring the Son's message of salvation. In this section he gave more reasons why Jesus is greater than the angels and why we should take Jesus' salvation more seriously than the law that was received through the angels. Some of these reasons are:

1. Jesus, not the angels, will control the future world (2:5)
 2. Jesus humbled himself in order to make himself like us:
 - In our lower position (2:7, 2:9)
 - In our suffering and death (2:10, 2:14)
 - As his brothers, God's children (2:11–14, 2:17)
1. Jesus can:
 - Bring us to glory (2:10)
 - Bring us to salvation (2:10)
 - Make us holy (2:11)
 - Break the power of death (2:14)
 - Sets us free from the fear of death (2:15)

- Help us (he did not come to help angels) (2:16)
- Be a merciful and faithful high priest before God (2:17)
- Take away the sins of people (2:17)
- Help us when we are tempted (2:18)
- [Angels cannot do this]

Some other possible headings for this section are:

The Son became human to save us

Christ Became like Humans (NCV)

Jesus Became One of Us to Help Us (GW)

Paragraph 2:10–13

In this paragraph the author explained more fully why Jesus became a man and suffered and died for us. He did it so that people may share God's glory and become part of God's family. This paragraph is still part of the section which establishes that Jesus is greater than the angels. It implies that no angel provided salvation for us like Jesus did by suffering and dying for us.

Some versions do not begin a new paragraph until 2:11. That is because 2:10 is a verse that links Paragraph 2:5–9 with this new paragraph.

2:11a–b

both the One who sanctifies and those who are sanctified: The phrase the One who sanctifies refers to Jesus. In some languages it may be necessary to make that explicit. For example:

Jesus who is making us into the holy people of God and we whom he is making holy
Kankanaey back translation on TW.

2:11a

For both the One who sanctifies

- Indeed, both the one who makes people holy
- Both Jesus, who dedicates people to God

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *For* introduces another reason why it was fitting for God to cause Jesus to suffer in order to bring many people to glory. Some English versions, such as the NIV, imply this connection without using a conjunction. Show the connection in the way that is most natural in your language.

sanctifies: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as *sanctifies* means “makes holy.” It refers here to

dedicating people to God so that they become God's people and are purified from their sins. Some other ways to translate *sanctifies* in this context are:

for he who consecrates (REB)

who makes people holy (GW)

the one who dedicates people to God

For more information, see *holy*, sense B1, in KBT.

2:11b

and those who are sanctified are of the same family.

- and those who are being made holy all have the same Father, God.
- and those people whom Jesus dedicates to God are all from/of the same family.

and those who are sanctified: The phrase *those who are sanctified* refers to the people whom Jesus is making holy. In this context it refers to the same people as the “many children” who are saved by Jesus (2:10a).

The verb *are sanctified* is the passive form of the verb that was translated as “*sanctifies*” in 2:11a. In some languages it is more natural to use an active form here and indicate Jesus as the subject. For example:

and the people whom he sanctifies

and we whom he purifies from our sins

and the people whom he dedicates to God

are of the same family: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as *of the same family* is more literally “all from one.” There are two ways to interpret the word *same* here:

1. It refers to one Father (God). God is the father of Jesus and all people whom Jesus sanctifies. The Greek has two similar sounding participles here —*hagiazōn*, literally, “the-holy-maker” or, “the-one-making-holy” and *hagiazomenoi* the “holy-made-ones.” They are part of the same family. For example:

are all from one Father (NASB)

all have one Father (NRSV) (BSB, NRSV, GNT, NIV, GW, NLT, NASB, CEV, NCV)

1. It refers to one humanity or origin. For example:

share a common humanity (JBP) This interpretation is also translated in various other ways, such as “origin” or “source.” (RSV, ESV, REB, NJB, JBP, NET)

Both interpretations are true. Jesus and the people whom he sanctifies are all children of God, and Jesus has also become like them in sharing their humanity. However, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It fits the immediate context of “bringing many children to glory,” and it has good commentary support. For example, Lane says, “The contextual references to God in verse 10 and to the family relationship in verse 11...tend to support the contention that *hōs* is masculine and has reference to God (GNT ‘all have the same Father,’ NIV ‘are of the same family’). Both the Son and those who are sons share a common familial relationship that is rooted in the gracious determination of God to bring his children to their destiny through the redemptive mission of the Son...” (WBC, Volume 47A, page 58)

2:11c

So Jesus is not ashamed to call them brothers.

- That is why Jesus is not ashamed to call them brothers and sisters. (GW)
- Therefore Jesus willingly/gladly says that they are his siblings.

So: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as So introduces the result of 2:11a–b. Because Jesus and the people whom he sanctifies have the same father (2:11b), Jesus is not ashamed to call them his brothers (2:11c). Some other ways to introduce this result are:

That is why (GNT)

For this reason (NRSV)

And because of this

Jesus is not ashamed to call them brothers: This clause indicates that Jesus is not ashamed to say that he is in the same family with the people whom he sanctifies. The context implies that although Jesus is perfectly holy and much greater than human beings, he accepts people as his brothers and sisters because

he and they all have God as their father. Some other ways to translate the clause are:

Jesus is not ashamed to say that we are his relatives. Uma back translation on TW.

Jesus is not ashamed of us but rather he calls us his younger siblings.

Different cultures have different beliefs about shame. In some cultures the negative statement Jesus is not ashamed to call them brothers may imply a wrong meaning. In the Jewish culture, either God or people could consider a person or the person’s actions to deserve shame. People tried to avoid being shamed, but often people unjustly shamed someone. Koester (page 230) says, “The desire to gain honor...and to avoid shame for oneself and one’s family was an important factor in shaping behavior... Honor and shame could be ascribed to a person by society or by God, and many recognized that public opinion was an unreliable measure of a person’s worth. Therefore, Jewish and philosophical sources exhorted people not to be ashamed of doing justice and speaking the truth even if society regarded these as disgraceful. Those addressed by Hebrews were viewed with contempt by society (Heb 10:32–34, 13:13–14), BUT Christ was not ashamed to identify with them, just as God was not ashamed to identify with Abraham and his family, who spent their lives as foreigners....” If that is true in your language, you may translate the meaning without a negative. For example:

Jesus is glad to call them his brothers and sisters

Jesus considers it right/proper to call them his brothers and sisters

to call them brothers: In this context the phrase to call them brothers means to accept or acknowledge them as his siblings. The author of Hebrews was a believer in Christ, and he was writing to other believers. In some languages it may be more natural to use a form that refers to both the author and his readers. For example:

to say/acknowledge that we^(incl) are siblings

brothers: The Greek word that the BSB translates as brothers includes both males and females. In some languages it is necessary to use different words for males and females. For example:

brothers and sisters (NRSV)

Hebrews 2:12

Section 2:5–18: Jesus, the Son of God, became a human being

In the previous section, the author stated the seriousness of ignoring the Son's message of salvation. In this section he gave more reasons why Jesus is greater than the angels and why we should take Jesus' salvation more seriously than the law that was received through the angels. Some of these reasons are:

1. Jesus, not the angels, will control the future world (2:5)
2. Jesus humbled himself in order to make himself like us:
 - In our lower position (2:7, 2:9)
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 - As his brothers, God's children (2:11–14, 2:17)
1. Jesus can:
 - Bring us to glory (2:10)
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 - Make us holy (2:11)
 - Break the power of death (2:14)
 - Sets us free from the fear of death (2:15)
 - Help us (he did not come to help angels) (2:16)
 - Be a merciful and faithful high priest before God (2:17)
 - Take away the sins of people (2:17)
 - Help us when we are tempted (2:18)
 - [Angels cannot do this]

Some other possible headings for this section are:

The Son became human to save us

Christ Became like Humans (NCV)

Jesus Became One of Us to Help Us (GW)

Paragraph 2:10–13

In this paragraph the author explained more fully why Jesus became a man and suffered and died for us. He did it so that people may share God's glory and become part of God's family. This paragraph is still part of the section which establishes that Jesus is greater than the angels. It implies that no angel provided salvation for us like Jesus did by suffering and dying for us.

Some versions do not begin a new paragraph until 2:11. That is because 2:10 is a verse that links Paragraph 2:5–9 with this new paragraph.

2:12–13

In 2:12–13 the author of Hebrews quotes four statements from the OT. He indicates that these quotations were statements that Jesus said to God or about God. The quotations support what the author said about Jesus not being ashamed to call us his relatives ("brothers and sisters"). He is not ashamed to become human like us and suffer as a human being.

2:12

This verse is a quotation from Psalm 22:22. Psalm 22 is called a "messianic psalm" because it tells about the Messiah whom God promised to send to save people. The author of Hebrews quotes words that the Messiah spoke in the psalm. He indicates that Jesus spoke these words to God.

Verse 12 has two parallel poetic lines. In some languages it may be more natural to combine the two parts of the quotation into one sentence or to change the order of the parts. See the General Comment on 2:12a–b at the end of 2:12b for an example.

2:12a

He says: "I will proclaim Your name to My brothers;

- He says, "I will tell my brothers and sisters about your^(sing) name/character.
- He says, "I will tell my siblings about you^(sing) and the great/glorious things that you have done.

He says: The words He says introduces another quotation from the OT. In the quotation, Jesus spoke to God. In many languages it may be helpful to begin a new sentence here and introduce the quotation in a fuller way. For example:

He says to God (GNT)

For he said to God (NLT)

I will proclaim Your name to My brothers: This statement is a quotation from Psalm 22. The author of Hebrews quotes it as a poetic way to say that Jesus will tell people about God. He will tell them about God's character and about what he has done.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

I will tell my people what you have done (GNT)

I will make your fame known to my brothers (REB)

Then, I will tell my fellow Israelites about you
(NCV)

to My brothers: The Greek word that the BSB translates as to My brothers includes both male and female siblings here, as it usually does in the New Testament.

In this quotation Jesus referred to believers as his brothers to indicate that they are part of God's family with him. They are God's sons and daughters. The word brothers does not refer here to members of Jesus' physical family while he was on earth.

2:12b

I will sing Your praises in the assembly."

- When I meet with your^(sing) people, I will praise you with songs."
- I will sing praises/songs to you^(sing) when I am in the gathering of your people."

I will sing Your praises: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as I will sing Your praises is more literally "I will sing praise/hymns to you." It has a similar meaning to "I will proclaim your name" in 2:12a. It means that Jesus will sing praise to God.

Some other ways to translate the clause are:

I will praise you with songs/hymns.

Your: As in 2:12a, Your refers to God.

in the assembly: The phrase in the assembly is parallel to the phrase "to my brothers" in 2:12a. The word in means "among" or "in the presence of." The word assembly refers to the group of God's people who are meeting together. Some other ways to translate in the assembly are:

in their meeting (GNT)

among all your people (NLT)

when they come together (CEV)

assembly: The Greek word which the BSB translates as assembly refers to a group of people who are meeting together. In the New Testament the word is often translated as "church." In the OT, which is quoted here, it was used for the whole Israelite community. See church, other uses in KBT.

General Comment on 2:12a–b

The two statements in 2:12 have similar (parallel) meanings. The parallel phrases are indicated here with

underlining or italics (the order has been adjusted to match the Greek):

^{12a} I will proclaim your name to my brothers

^{12b} in the assembly I will sing your praises.

Notice that in Greek, the order of the similar phrases are reversed in 2:12b. This makes the phrase a chiasm, which emphasizes that Jesus claims us as his brothers and sisters. In some languages this order may not have that meaning, and it may be confusing. If that is true in your language, you may need to express this emphasis in a different way. For example, in some languages it may be more emphatic to begin the two clauses with this part of the meaning. For example:

To my brothers, I will declare your name. In the presence of the congregation, I will praise you.

Hebrews 2:13

Section 2:5–18: Jesus, the Son of God, became a human being

In the previous section, the author stated the seriousness of ignoring the Son's message of salvation. In this section he gave more reasons why Jesus is greater than the angels and why we should take Jesus' salvation more seriously than the law that was received through the angels. Some of these reasons are:

1. Jesus, not the angels, will control the future world (2:5)
2. Jesus humbled himself in order to make himself like us:
 - In our lower position (2:7, 2:9)
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1. Jesus can:
 - Bring us to glory (2:10)
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 - Help us (he did not come to help angels) (2:16)
 - Be a merciful and faithful high priest before God (2:17)
 - Take away the sins of people (2:17)
 - Help us when we are tempted (2:18)
 - [Angels cannot do this]

Some other possible headings for this section are:

The Son became human to save us

Christ Became like Humans (NCV)

Jesus Became One of Us to Help Us (GW)

Paragraph 2:10–13

In this paragraph the author explained more fully why Jesus became a man and suffered and died for us. He did it so that people may share God's glory and become part of God's family. This paragraph is still part of the section which establishes that Jesus is greater than the angels. It implies that no angel provided salvation for us like Jesus did by suffering and dying for us.

Some versions do not begin a new paragraph until 2:11. That is because 2:10 is a verse that links Paragraph 2:5–9 with this new paragraph.

2:13a

And again: “I will put My trust in Him.”

- In another Scripture he says, “I will put my confidence in God.”
- Jesus also says, “I live by placing my trust in God.”

2:13b

And once again: “Here am I, and the children God has given Me.”

- And he continues, “Here I am, together with the children whom God entrusted to me.”
- And he also says, “Look! I am here with God's children whom he has given me.”

2:13a–b

In this verse the author quoted two more OT verses which he applied to Jesus. These quotations come from Isaiah 8:17–18.

And again: The phrase And again introduces another quotation from the OT. The author implied that Jesus said this about God. Introduce the quotation in a natural way in your language. Some ways to do this in English are:

He also says, “I... (GNT)

Something else he caused-to-be-written says, “I...

In some languages it is helpful to use your usual key term for the Scriptures here. For example:

and in another place in God's book/writings he said

“I will put My trust in Him.” And once again: “Here am I, and the children God has given Me.”: The phrase And once again connects two statements that are one clause in Isaiah. The original clauses from Isaiah 8:18 did not have this connecting phrase. It emphasizes the connection between Jesus and the children (people). The pronoun I is emphatic. It implies that Jesus is the leader of his people, and they must put their trust in God, along with Jesus.

Some other ways to connect these clauses are:

“I will put my trust in him,” that is, “I and the children God has given me.” (NLT)

“I trust God,” and he said moreover, “Here I am joined with the children of God that he has entrusted to me.” Kankanaey back translation on TW.

He also said, “I put my hope in him,” and “I with the children whom God has given me.”

Use a natural way in your language to translate the emphatic connection between Jesus and his people.

I will put My trust in Him: The clause I will put My trust in Him indicates that Jesus is determined to trust in God only. It does not imply that Jesus was beginning to trust in God at the moment when he said this. He also trusted God before he said it.

Some other ways to translate the clause are:

I will keep my trust fixed on him. (REB)

As for me, I have confidence only in God. Uma back translation on TW.

The context implies that Jesus trusts in God as the leader of all who follow him. Jesus trusts in God, and everyone who follows him must also trust God. In some languages it is helpful to make this clear in the introduction to the quotation. For example:

As our leader, he also says “I will live by trusting in God

Here am I: The phrase Here am I is more literally “See/ Look, I.” In this context it is a way for the speaker (Jesus) to focus the readers' attention on himself. It also emphasizes the next statement. He emphasizes the connection between him and the people who follow him. Use a natural way in your language to focus

attention on Jesus and his people here. The Greek text of the quotation begins with the word *idou*, “look/see” and the KJV and NASB have translated the whole phrase as “Behold I and the children...” The implication of the word “Behold” is to draw attention to the words following, and so modern versions have rendered the phrase “Here am I....”

and the children God has given Me: The phrase the children God has given Me refers to all people who believe in Jesus and follow him. There are two ways to interpret this phrase: (1) It refers to **God’s** children, whom Jesus leads to salvation as their brother. (2) It refers to **Jesus’** “children.” (The term “children” is used in a spiritual sense, referring to the people whom God gave him as his followers.) Most English versions can be interpreted either way. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It fits the context and is followed by many commentaries. An Exegetical Summary of Hebrews (page 72) lists ten commentators that follow this interpretation. Jesus and the people he saves are brothers and sisters. They are part of God’s family and therefore God’s children.

Some other ways to translate this quotation are:

Here I am, accompanied by God’s children whom he has given me.

Here I am, joined with the children of God that he has entrusted to me. Kankanaey back translation on TW.

given: Here the word given indicates that God gave Jesus responsibility for those who have become God’s children. Jesus will lead and care for them as the “author of their salvation” (2:10). See John 6:37–39. Other ways to translate “the children whom God has given me” are:

the children of God given me to care for. Otomi back translation on TW.

God’s children whom he told me to lead

Hebrews 2:14

Section 2:5–18: Jesus, the Son of God, became a human being

In the previous section, the author stated the seriousness of ignoring the Son’s message of salvation. In this section he gave more reasons why Jesus is greater than the angels and why we should take Jesus’ salva-

tion more seriously than the law that was received through the angels. Some of these reasons are:

1. Jesus, not the angels, will control the future world (2:5)
2. Jesus humbled himself in order to make himself like us:

- In our lower position (2:7, 2:9)
- In our suffering and death (2:10, 2:14)
- As his brothers, God’s children (2:11–14, 2:17)

1. Jesus can:

- Bring us to glory (2:10)
- Bring us to salvation (2:10)
- Make us holy (2:11)
- Break the power of death (2:14)
- Sets us free from the fear of death (2:15)
- Help us (he did not come to help angels) (2:16)
- Be a merciful and faithful high priest before God (2:17)
- Take away the sins of people (2:17)
- Help us when we are tempted (2:18)
- [Angels cannot do this]

Some other possible headings for this section are:

The Son became human to save us

Christ Became like Humans (NCV)

Jesus Became One of Us to Help Us (GW)

Paragraph 2:14–18

The final paragraph of chapter 2 explains in more detail why God’s Son had to become a human being like us. He came to defeat the devil, and stop people from being afraid to die. He also became human so that he could become the high priest for his people. In these ways, he is greater than the angels, because none of them was able to become human, defeat the devil, and free his people from fearing death.

The author briefly introduces the topic of Jesus as our high priest, which he will discuss more fully in 4:14–5:10 and 7:1–8:1.

2:14–15

In Greek, 2:14–15 is one long sentence. In many languages it is more natural to break it into two or three sentences. For examples of how this can be translated as three sentences, see the General Comment on 2:14–15 at the end of 2:15.

2:14a

Now since the children have flesh and blood,

- ¶ So, because these children are human beings,
- ¶ Because, therefore, these children of God have human bodies,

Now since: This verse begins with the two Greek conjunctions that the BSB translates as Now since. The word translated as Now is usually translated as “therefore” and introduces the connection between this paragraph and the OT quotations in 2:12–13. The word since indicates the connection between 2:14a and 2:14b. It is important to consider each of these connections and how to translate them in a natural way in your language.

Some other ways to translate the connections are:

So then, because the children...

The children have flesh and blood, **so/therefore**

Some versions leave the connection with the previous paragraph implicit and translate only the connection between the clauses (2:14a and 2:14b). For example:

Since all of these sons and daughters...

the children have flesh and blood: The clause the children have flesh and blood means that God’s children are human beings. The phrase flesh and blood refers to being human, and it implies the weakness of human beings. Some ways to translate this clause are:

those children being referred to are people/humans

these children are people with physical bodies (NCV)

the children of God that it is talking about here are people who have bodies that die
Kankanaey back translation on TW.

the children: The phrase the children repeats the phrase from the quotation in 2:13b. It refers to the children of God, whom Jesus said were his “brothers and sisters” in 2:12a. Indicate clearly that the author referred back to the same children that he mentioned in 2:13b. Some ways to do this in English are:

these children (NCV)

God’s children (NLT)

Refer back to them in a natural way in your language.

flesh and blood: The Greek phrase flesh and blood is literally “blood and flesh.” It is an idiom that usually refers to human bodies. It indicates that the children of God he referred to here are human beings. Use the natural way in your language to refer to humans.

2:14b

He too shared in their humanity,

- he also became a human being like them,
- Jesus also has/received a human body like they have.

He too shared in their humanity: The clause He too shared in their humanity means that Jesus also had “flesh and blood.” It indicates that he became a human being and had a human body like the children of God whom he was leading to salvation.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

he also became a human being, (JBP)

Jesus himself became like them and shared their human nature. (GNT)

Jesus took on flesh and blood to be like them. (GW)

their humanity: The phrase their humanity refers back to “flesh and blood” in 2:14a. Refer back to it in a natural way in your language.

2:14c

so that by His death He might destroy

- so that by dying, he could/would defeat
- He did this to have a way/opportunity to die and to use his death to conquer

2:14d

him who holds the power of death, that is, the devil,

- the devil and take away his power/control over death.
- the devil and to stop him from controlling the effects/matters of death.

2:14c–d

so that by His death He might destroy him who holds the power of death, that is, the devil: This clause tells the purpose for which Christ became a human being (2:14a–b). He came to destroy the devil’s power. A similar idea is expressed in 1 John 3:8. The Translator’s Handbook (Ellingworth and Nida, page 46)

points out that the GeCL interprets the clause that begins with this conjunction as the result of Jesus' death, instead of the purpose, saying, "This is possible and produces a clear translation: 'In this way he has freed men who had been slaves....'" The clause indicates that when Christ died, he defeated the devil and took away the devil's power of death. A similar idea is expressed in 1 Corinthians 15:26.

In some languages it may be more natural to make 2:14c-d a separate sentence. For example:

He/Jesus did this so that by dying himself, he might destroy the devil who has power over death.

He might destroy: In this context the verb destroy means "to make powerless." The phrase He might destroy indicates that Jesus' purpose in dying was to take away the devil's power. The context indicates that by dying Jesus was successful in destroying the devil's power. The word might does not imply any doubt about that.

Some ways to translate He might destroy are:

in order that he would spoil the power of
Otomi back translation on TW.

to completely take away the power of

he would totally defeat
Kankanaey back translation on TW.

him who holds the power of death, that is, the devil: Scholars have different views about what the power of death refers to here:

1. It indicates that the devil has power to tempt people to sin, which causes spiritual death (separation from God). For example:

who works to cause spiritual death

1. It indicates that the devil brought sin and death into the world. For example:

Satan, who is the origin of death
Western Bukidnon Manobo back translation on TW.

1. It refers to the power that the devil has to cause people's physical death. For example:

the devil, who causes people to die

English versions are ambiguous. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) or (2). These interpretations fit the context of Hebrews and are supported by various Bible scholars. Ellis Diebler (SSA of Hebrews, page 2) gives the meaning as "the one who has the power to cause people to die spiritually." He continues, "In the phrase 'the one having the power of death' it is difficult to determine just what the genitive phrase means.... It seems best to say that the writer refers to the fall of mankind in Genesis 3, at which time Satan gained the power to cause Adam and his descendants to die—which here refers to eternal death (separation from God), so Kistemaker." Kistemaker says, "Satan...the murderer from the beginning...desired man's death in the fullest sense of the word: physical death and spiritual death (separation from God)." Westcott (page 53) says, "The devil, as the author of sin, has the power over death...not as though he could inflict it at his pleasure, but death is his realm: he makes it subservient to his end." Interpretation (3) is not recommended, because the Scriptures indicate that God is the one who has power to decide when a person will die.

Some ways to translate interpretation (1) or (2) are:

his control over people, that being what leads them to death which is unending punishment
Tagbanwa back translation on TW.

the devil's power that causes people to die eternally

the devil: The phrase the devil refers to the chief of all evil spirits. His name is Satan. In Hebrew this name means "enemy." He is the enemy of God and God's people. The terms the devil and "Satan" refer to the same spiritual enemy. In some languages, you may want to use one term for both terms in your translation.

Here are some ways to translate the devil:

- Use a local name or idiom that refers to the chief of all demons.
- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

the leader of the evil spirits

the spirit enemy of God

- Transliterate the name “Satan.” If this word is not already known in your area, you may also want to add a descriptive phrase. For example:

Satan, the ruler of demons If you transliterate “Satan” or borrow a word from another language, be sure that it communicates the biblical meaning to people in your culture. It is important to check this in each biblical context.

Try to use a term that is acceptable to churches in the area. It is suggested that you also add a footnote or glossary entry that further explains who the devil is. For example:

The devil is the leader of all the evil spirits or demons. Once he was an angel in heaven, but he rebelled against God. God expelled him from heaven, and now he tempts people on earth. Other names for him in the Bible are “Beelzebul,” “Satan,” “the Evil One,” “the Enemy,” and “the Tempter.”

If you have translated the Gospels, you may use the same term as you used there. For more information, see Satan, “other expressions” in KBT.

Hebrews 2:15

Section 2:5–18: Jesus, the Son of God, became a human being

In the previous section, the author stated the seriousness of ignoring the Son’s message of salvation. In this section he gave more reasons why Jesus is greater than the angels and why we should take Jesus’ salvation more seriously than the law that was received through the angels. Some of these reasons are:

1. Jesus, not the angels, will control the future world (2:5)
 2. Jesus humbled himself in order to make himself like us:
 - In our lower position (2:7, 2:9)
 - In our suffering and death (2:10, 2:14)
 - As his brothers, God’s children (2:11–14, 2:17)
1. Jesus can:
 - Bring us to glory (2:10)
 - Bring us to salvation (2:10)
 - Make us holy (2:11)
 - Break the power of death (2:14)
 - Sets us free from the fear of death (2:15)
 - Help us (he did not come to help angels) (2:16)

- Be a merciful and faithful high priest before God (2:17)
- Take away the sins of people (2:17)
- Help us when we are tempted (2:18)
- [Angels cannot do this]

Some other possible headings for this section are:

The Son became human to save us

Christ Became like Humans (NCV)

Jesus Became One of Us to Help Us (GW)

Paragraph 2:14–18

The final paragraph of chapter 2 explains in more detail why God’s Son had to become a human being like us. He came to defeat the devil, and stop people from being afraid to die. He also became human so that he could become the high priest for his people. In these ways, he is greater than the angels, because none of them was able to become human, defeat the devil, and free his people from fearing death.

The author briefly introduces the topic of Jesus as our high priest, which he will discuss more fully in 4:14–5:10 and 7:1–8:1.

2:15a

and free those who all their lives were held in slavery

- Then he would release those people who were like slaves as long as they lived,
- Jesus also died to rescue all of us^(incl) who live each day

2:15b

by their fear of death.

- because they were afraid to die.
- in fear of dying.

2:15

and free those who...were held in slavery by their fear of death: This clause tells the second purpose that Jesus had in becoming a human being (2:14b) and dying (2:14c). Jesus became human and died in order to set people free from the fear of death.

The verb free and the phrase held in slavery by are metaphors. The author used them to compare what Jesus did to the way someone rescues people from slavery. People were living like slaves because they were always afraid to die. After Jesus died for them (and came alive again), the people became free from

fearing death. They did not have to be afraid to die anymore.

Some ways to translate this meaning are:

- Keep the metaphors. For example:

Only in this way could he set free all who have lived their lives as slaves to the fear of dying. (NLT)

- Use a simile and make the comparison more explicit. For example:

and free those who were like slaves all their lives because of their fear of death (NCV)

to release/help those who were living like slaves because they were afraid to die

- Use a different figure of speech that has the same meaning in your language. For example:

he helped those who were afraid to die and took away their fear. For as long as they lived, they were gripped/held tightly by their fear of dying.

- Translate the meaning without the figure of speech. For example:

But he also died to rescue all of us who live each day in fear of dying (CEV)

Translate the figure of speech in a natural way in your language.

those who: The phrase those who is a general way to refer to everyone who feared death, that is, to human beings in general. In some languages it may be more natural to use a different way to refer to them. For example:

all of us who... (CEV)

everyone who

we...our

who all their lives: The phrase who all their lives refers to the time that the people were alive on earth. Some other ways to translate it are:

who live each day (CEV)

beginning from the time of their birthKankanaey back translation on TW.

since our becoming people here in this worldTagbanwa back translation on TW.

Refer to the people's lifetimes in a natural way in your language.

all their lives were held in slavery by their fear of death: Notice that the phrase by their fear of death is the cause or reason for the fact that all their lives people were held in slavery. In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of these phrases so that the reason comes before the result. For example:

all their lives they were afraid to die and/so they lived like slaves

General Comment on 2:14–15

In Greek 2:14–15 is one long sentence. In many languages it is more natural to translate it with two or three sentences. For example:

So because God's children have human bodies, he also received a human body like they had. He did this so that when he died, he would make powerless the one who controls death, that is, the devil. Then he would release those people who were like slaves as long as they lived, because they were afraid to die.

Hebrews 2:16

Section 2:5–18: Jesus, the Son of God, became a human being

In the previous section, the author stated the seriousness of ignoring the Son's message of salvation. In this section he gave more reasons why Jesus is greater than the angels and why we should take Jesus' salvation more seriously than the law that was received through the angels. Some of these reasons are:

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- Bring us to salvation (2:10)
- Make us holy (2:11)
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The author briefly introduces the topic of Jesus as our high priest, which he will discuss more fully in 4:14–5:10 and 7:1–8:1.

2:16

For surely it is not the angels He helps, but the descendants of Abraham.

- For obviously he did not come to help angels but Abraham's descendants.
- So it was certainly we^(incl) human beings, the descendants of Abraham, that Jesus came to help. He did not come to help angels.

For: The conjunction For indicates that 2:16 is an explanation for 2:14–15. The word For introduces the reason why Jesus became a human being, rather than an angel. He became human because human beings are the ones whom he came to earth to help. He did not come to earth to help angels. Use a natural way in your language to indicate that 2:16 is the explanation for the statement in 2:14–15.

surely: The Greek word that the BSB translates as surely only occurs here in the NT. It introduces a fact that is obviously true. Some other ways to translate it here are:

clearly/certainly

We...know that (NLT)

Of course Tagbanwa back translation on TW.

it is not the angels He helps, but the descendants of Abraham: In Greek this clause first tells what Jesus did not do, and then it tells what he did do. In some languages it may be more natural to change this order. For example:

Jesus helps Abraham's descendants rather than helping angels. (GW)

Here the author compared angels and humans (the descendants of Abraham). Since Jesus became human, the author also implied a contrast between the angels and Jesus. That contrast is the theme of this division (1:5–2:18).

The author wanted to show that it was people whom Jesus came to earth to help. It was not angels whom he came to earth to help. He became a human being and shared human sorrows, sufferings, and joys. Then he died for humans so that he would be part of the same family with those who follow him. He did not do those things for angels.

Some other ways to translate this contrast are:

So Jesus helps Abraham's descendants rather than helping angels. (GW)

Clearly it is not the angels' nature/life that he shares but rather he shares the nature/life of human beings, the descendants of Abraham.

Translate the contrast in a natural way in your language.

the angels: The word angels was also used in 1:4. Translate it in the same way as you did there.

He helps: The Greek word that the BSB translates as the phrase He helps literally means "to take hold of." In this context it means "to be concerned about, to help." BDAG, 2976 epilambanomai, Meaning 5. Bible

Works 8. Jesus came to earth to help human beings (the “descendants of Abraham”). Many English versions translate the word as “help” in this verse, as in the BSB. Versions that translate in this way include the BSB, NIV, GNT, RSV, NCV, NET, REB, NASB, NLT, GW, and CEV. However, some scholars believe that the meaning here is “to become, to take on.” This meaning would imply here that Jesus took on human nature, not the nature of angels. This interpretation is also followed by a number of early church fathers. Westcott (page 55) says, “This sense is given, I believe, uniformly by the Fathers both Greek and Latin who understand the phrase of the fact and not of the purpose of the Incarnation.” However, he points out that the other interpretation [the meaning “be concerned with, help”] “is both more in accordance with the usage of the word and falls in perfectly with the argument.” Another way to translate the meaning is:

his concern is not for angels, but he is concerned for Abraham’s descendants (NET)

the descendants of Abraham: The phrase the descendants of Abraham has both a literal and figurative meaning here. Literally, it refers to the Jews, the people of Israel. Abraham was their ancestor. However, in this verse the phrase also expresses two figurative meanings:

1. It refers generally to human beings in contrast to the angels.
2. It refers especially to people who have faith in God, as Abraham did.

In some languages it is necessary to indicate in some way that the phrase has a figurative meaning. For example:

us people who are counted/considered as Abraham’s descendantsKankanaey back translation on TW.

the people who follow the faith of AbrahamOtomi back translation on TW.

The author of Hebrews and also the people who heard his message were among the descendants of Abraham. In some languages, you may need to make this explicit. For example:

descendants of our^(incl) ancestor Abraham

us who are Abraham’s spiritual descendantsSSA of Hebrews, prepublication copy, page 27.

General Comment on 2:16

In Greek this verse first tells what Jesus did not do, and then what he did do. In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of these statements. For example:

We all know that Jesus came to help the descendants of Abraham, not to help the angels. (NLT)

It is clear/obvious that Jesus helps Abraham’s descendants rather than helping angels.

Hebrews 2:17

Section 2:5–18: Jesus, the Son of God, became a human being

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- Bring us to salvation (2:10)
- Make us holy (2:11)
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The final paragraph of chapter 2 explains in more detail why God's Son had to become a human being like us. He came to defeat the devil, and stop people from being afraid to die. He also became human so that he could become the high priest for his people. In these ways, he is greater than the angels, because none of them was able to become human, defeat the devil, and free his people from fearing death.

The author briefly introduces the topic of Jesus as our high priest, which he will discuss more fully in 4:14–5:10 and 7:1–8:1.

2:17a

For this reason He had to be made like His brothers in every way,

- That is why it was necessary for him to become human in every way like his brothers and sisters
- Therefore, it was necessary for Jesus to become a real human being like us^(incl) his siblings.

For this reason: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For this reason introduces a conclusion from 2:16. This conclusion is also a summary and conclusion of 2:10–16. Some other ways to introduce this conclusion are:

That is whyUma back translation on TW.

Therefore (NRSV)

As a result

Introduce it in a natural way in your language.

He had to be made like His brothers: The Greek word that the BSB translates as had to means “to be obligated”ophelō BDAG, (page 743), meaning 2, “to be under obligation to meet certain social or moral expectations, owe.” The use in Hebrews 2:17 is listed under sense **β**. of this meaning, “one must, one ought.” to do something. The clause means that Jesus was obligated to become human like other humans so that he would be a good high priest for them.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

it was necessary for him to be made...like his brothers and sisters (NLT)

he needed to become a man/human so that he could be the same as his siblingsTagbanwa back translation on TW.

The reason it was necessary for Him to become a human was so that He might become like us^(incl) His siblings.Western Bukidnon Manobo back translation on TW.

be made like His brothers in every way: The phrase be made like His brothers in every way has a special meaning in this context. It indicates that in every way Jesus became a real human being, just as his brothers and sisters were human beings. However, the phrase in every way does not imply that Jesus was sinful like other human beings.

Some other ways to translate be made like His brothers in every way are:

become completely human like his people

to become a real human being like his fellow human beings

to become just like any human beingEllingworth and Nida, A Translator's Handbook on the Letter to the Hebrews, page 47, also on TW.

His brothers: The phrase His brothers refers back to 2:11. There the author indicated that people whom Jesus sanctifies become his brothers and sisters. The author also implied that these brothers and sisters are the descendants of Abraham that he mentioned in 2:16. In many languages it is good to translate the phrase His brothers in the same way as you did in 2:11.

In some languages it may be necessary to add a phrase to indicate that brothers is used in a spiritual instead of a physical sense here, as it was in 2:11. For example:

us whom he calls his own siblingsEllis Diebler, SSA of Hebrews, prepublication copy, page 27.

If you include a pronoun like “us,” it should refer to both the author and the people who heard his message.

2:17b

so that He might become a merciful and faithful high priest in service to God,

- in order to be a high priest who has compassion for his people and who is trustworthy as he serves God

- Because he did this, he can serve God as a high priest who acts mercifully toward us^(incl). He can also be trusted

Here in 2:17b the author first used the term “high priest” to refer to Jesus. In this chapter the author of Hebrews has used three titles/terms to refer to Jesus. In 2:9 he used the name “Jesus.” In 2:10 he used the phrase “author of their salvation.” In this verse, he used the term “high priest,” which is a thematic term. Tagbanwa back translation on TW. Western Bukidnon Manobo back translation on TW. A Translator’s Handbook on the Letter to the Hebrews, page 47. Ellis Diebler, SSA of Hebrews, pre-publication copy, page 27. In this chapter the author of Hebrews has used three titles/terms to refer to Jesus. In 2:9 he used the name “Jesus.” In 2:10 he used the phrase “author of their salvation.” In this verse, he used the term “high priest.” In Hebrews the author compared the work of a Jewish high priest in the Old Testament to what Jesus did for people. Jewish high priests represented the people and offered sacrifices to God on their behalf. Jesus also represented his people to God, and he offered himself as a perfect sacrifice so that God would forgive the people’s sins.

so that He might become a merciful and faithful high priest in service to God: This clause tells the purpose for which Jesus became completely human (2:17a). He became human in order to be a good high priest for human beings. The words merciful and faithful both describe the phrase high priest. They do not indicate that Jesus was not merciful or faithful before he became human.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

so that he would be a high priest who treats people with compassion. He would also be faithful toward God and toward people as he does the work of the high priest.

Because he did that, when he does the work of the high priest, he sympathizes with the people. Both God and people can trust him.

a merciful...high priest: The Greek word that the BSB translates as merciful means “sympathetic, compassionate.” BDAG, page 316. It refers to a person who is concerned about the needs of other people and sympathizes with them. The phrase a merciful...high priest implies that as a human high priest, Jesus knows the temptations of human beings, and he has compassion for them.

See the examples in the preceding note for translation advice.

faithful high priest in service to God: The word faithful means “worthy of trust, dependable.” It refers to someone who is worthy to be believed and trusted. BDAG, page 820. The phrase in service to God indicates here that Jesus was faithful to both God and people as he served God as high priest. Both God and human beings could trust him.

Some other ways to translate the phrase faithful high priest in service to God are:

a high priest who is...trustworthy as he represents us to God

to serve God as our high priest in a faithful way

high priest: The high priest was the leader of all the priests of the people of Israel. All the priests offered sacrifices on behalf of the people, but the high priest offered certain special sacrifices that no other priest could offer. Once a year, he offered the special sacrifice that atoned for the people’s sins. In a special way, he represented them to God.

Some ways to translate high priest are:

the chief/leader of all the priests

the main/principal priest

the highest/leading priest

The author described the work of Jesus as a high priest in more detail from 4:14 onwards. Translate the term high priest in the same way here and in the Gospels. For more information, see priest in KBT.

in service to God: There are two ways to interpret the Greek phrase that the BSB translates as in service to God:

1. It means “toward God.” In this context it refers to service to God or to relationship with him. For example:

in his service to God (GNT) (BSB, GNT, NIV NRSV, ESV, CEV, REB, NCV, NLT, NJB)

1. It means “about God.” It refers to things concerning God or about God. For example:

things relating to God (NET) (NET, NASB, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), as most English versions and many commentators do. In this context in service to God refers to what the high priest did as he served God on behalf of the people. It refers especially to the sacrifice he made so that God would forgive the people's sins (2:17c).

Some other ways to translate the phrase are:

to represent us to God
Kankanaey back translation on TW.

working the work that God gave him
Uma back translation on TW.

as he served God

Be sure to connect this phrase to 2:17c in a natural way in your language.

2:17c

in order to make atonement for the sins of the people.

- to make atonement/expiation for their sins.
- to offer sacrifice to God so that God will forgive people's sins.

in order to make atonement for the sins of the people: This clause tells the purpose for Jesus being a merciful and faithful high priest. As a high priest like that, Jesus was able to make atonement for the people's sins. He did this by offering himself to be killed as a sacrifice to God. Jesus himself took the punishment that people deserve for their sins so that God would forgive them. Then they themselves would not have to be killed.

Some other ways to translate this purpose are:

in order to offer sacrifice so that the people's sins would be forgiven

so he would undergo the punishment of our sins so that it would thus be possible for our sins to be forgiven
Kankanaey back translation on TW.

Then he could offer a sacrifice that would take away the sins of the people. (NLT)

make atonement: The phrase make atonement is one word in Greek. It refers to the way that people can

obtain forgiveness from God for their sins. The Greek word that the BSB translates as "make atonement" only occurs here in the NT, and in Luke 8:13, where it means "be merciful" or "have pity on." Here it means "make propitiation for." The corresponding noun, *hilastērion*, occurs in Romans 3:25 (NIV: "sacrifice of atonement") and in Hebrews 9:5, where it refers to the actual physical covering of the ark of the covenant. Another related noun, *hilasmos*, occurs in 1 John 2:2 and 4:10, and has the same meaning of "atoning sacrifice" (NIV) or "the sacrifice that takes our sins away." (JB). These words are used in the Septuagint (the Greek translation of the OT) for the Hebrew verb *kaphar*, "to cover" or "conceal," and hence also to "atone for." "The Day of atonement" is literally, "the Day of covering." Sin against God must be dealt with, and the physical symbol of this was the lid which covered the wooden box in the most holy part of the Tabernacle. Once a year, the high priest sprinkled this with blood, showing that there had been a sacrifice to atone for the sins of the people. In the Bible the word implies that people have sinned against God. God is just, and he must punish people for sin. Jesus offered himself as a sacrifice to be punished instead of other people so that God could forgive them.

In many cultures people make sacrifices for other reasons that do not fit the meaning of the Greek word. It is often necessary to use a descriptive phrase to translate it. See the translation examples in the preceding note. Since the Greek word is a key biblical term, it is especially important to check the meaning of your translation of it with other speakers of your language.

Other forms of this Greek word occur in 1 John 2:2 and 4:10. For more information, see reconcile, sense B, in KBT.

the sins of the people: The phrase the sins of the people refers to the sins which the people have committed. Some other ways to translate the phrase are:

the sins that the people have done

the offenses that the people committed against God

sins: The word sins was used in 1:3d. You may translate it in the same way here. For more information, see the note on 1:3d.

the people: In the original context of the OT the word people refers to the same people as "the descendants

of Abraham” in 2:16 and “his brothers” in 2:17a. Refer to them here in a natural way in your language.

Hebrews 2:18

Section 2:5–18: Jesus, the Son of God, became a human being

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Christ Became like Humans (NCV)

Jesus Became One of Us to Help Us (GW)

Paragraph 2:14–18

The final paragraph of chapter 2 explains in more detail why God’s Son had to become a human being like us. He came to defeat the devil, and stop people from being afraid to die. He also became human so that he could become the high priest for his people. In these ways, he is greater than the angels, because none of them was able to become human, defeat the devil, and free his people from fearing death.

The author briefly introduces the topic of Jesus as our high priest, which he will discuss more fully in 4:14–5:10 and 7:1–8:1.

2:18

Hebrews 2:18 is one sentence which has two clauses. Hebrews 2:18a tells why Christ is able to help us (the reason) and 2:18b tells about his helping (the result). In some languages, it is more natural to reorder these two clauses or to make them separate sentences. For examples of how this verse can be reordered or translated as two sentences, see the General Comment on 2:18a–b at the end of 2:18b.

2:18a

Because He Himself suffered when He was tempted,

- For because he also was tempted by the suffering he endured,
- Since Jesus himself was tempted and suffered as a human being,

Because: In Greek this verse begins with two connectors that many English versions translate together as “For since.” The word that the BSB leaves implicit (“for”) explains more about why Jesus is a merciful and faithful high priest for people (2:17). The word Because indicates that 2:18a is the reason why Jesus is able to help people when they are tempted (2:18b).

In some languages it is not necessary to make both of these connections explicit. Make the meaning clear in a natural way in your language.

He Himself suffered when He was tempted: The Greek phrase the BSB translates as suffered when He was tempted is literally “suffered being tempted/ tested.” Scholars interpret the connection between “suffered” and “being tempted” in different ways:

1. Jesus was tempted, and the temptation caused him to suffer. For example:

he himself suffered when he was tempted (NIV)
(BSB, NJB, NIV, JBP, NET)

1. Jesus suffered, and the suffering caused him to be tempted. For example:

Jesus experienced temptation when he suffered (GW) (GW, NRSV, NASB, REB)

1. Jesus was tempted and he also suffered. For example:

he himself was tempted and suffered (GNT) (NLT, RSV, CEV, NCV, GNT)

The meanings of these interpretations are similar, and the differences seem to be mainly a matter of emphasis. Interpretation (1) emphasizes Jesus' temptation and the result—he is able to help those who are tempted. This theme is repeated in Hebrews 4:15. For this reason, the Notes has listed it as interpretation (1) here. You may translate any of these interpretations in a natural way in your language.

He Himself: The phrase He Himself emphasizes Jesus in contrast to “those who are being tempted” in 2:18b. Translate this contrast in a natural way in your language. See the Display for examples.

suffered: The Greek word that the BSB translates as suffered is a general word that can refer to enduring any kind of pain or hardship. The form of the word implies that Jesus endured this suffering over a period of time. Some other ways to translate it are:

has suffered (NASB)

has gone through suffering (NLT)

experienced distress/hardship

In some languages there may be an idiom that expresses this meaning.

He was tempted: The phrase He was tempted is passive. The Greek text does not specify who or what tempted Jesus. This clause may refer to temptation by Satan. It may also include other sources of temptations, such as other people or the weaknesses of human nature. For that reason, it is best not to make explicit who or what tempted him. For example:

Jesus experienced temptation (GW)

However, if you must provide a subject, you may indicate that Satan tempted Jesus. For example:

Satan tempted Jesus

was tempted: There are two ways to interpret the word tempted in this context:

1. It means tempted. It refers here to temptation to sin. For example:

and was tempted (NCV) (BSB, NIV, RSV, GNT, NASB, NET, JBP, KJV, GW, NLT, NCV, CEV)

1. It means tested. It refers here to a test of Jesus' faithfulness to God during suffering. For example:

he himself has passed through the test of suffering (REB) (NRSV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It is followed by most English versions and a majority of Bible scholars.

2:18b

He is able to help those who are being tempted.

- he is able to help others when they are tempted.
- he is able to strengthen other people so that they do not sin when they experience temptation.

He is able to help those who are being tempted: This part of the verse tells the result of 2:18a. Jesus was tempted (2:18a), so he is able to help those who are being tempted. Other ways to translate this result are:

That is how/why he is able to help those who are being tempted.

therefore he can really help us when we also are tested/tempted. Tagbanwa back translation on TW.

Translate the result in a natural way in your language.

help: The Greek word that the BSB translates as help is a general word that can refer to different ways to assist or support someone. In this context, Jesus helps people to resist and overcome temptation so that they do not sin.

Jesus uses many different ways to help people who are tempted. For example, he encourages them, he gives them spiritual and physical strength, he shows them what he wants them to do, and he may cause other people to help them. Having been tempted himself, Jesus understands how to help those who are being tempted.

Jesus helps those who are tempted so that they can resist the temptation and not sin against God. This is the main purpose for Jesus' help. In some languages it may be necessary to make this purpose explicit. For example:

he can help the people who are tempted so that they are not carried to sinYakan back translation on TW.

those who are being tempted: The phrase those who are being tempted is a general statement that is true for anyone who is tempted. Languages have different ways to refer to people in general statements like this. For example, some languages may use “we,” “anyone,” or “whoever.” For example:

anyone who is tempted

when we are tempted

In other languages it may be more natural to refer only to the temptation without mentioning who is tempted. For example:

during the time of temptation

Use a natural option for your language.

are being tempted: The form of the Greek verb which the BSB translates as are being tempted indicates that the temptation continues for some time or that it happens often over a period of time. Here is another way to translate this:

are tempted (NET)

Translate this meaning in a natural way in your language.

General Comment on 2:18a–b

In some languages it may be more natural to reorder the clauses in this verse. For example:

^{18b}And now he can help those who are tempted,
^{18a}because he himself was tempted and suffered.
(GNT)

In some languages it may be more natural to translate this verse as two sentences. For example:

He himself was tempted and suffered. So he is able to help us when we are tempted.

The author mentioned temptation and the help of our great high priest again in 4:15–16.

In chapters 1 and 2, the author showed that God has now spoken through his Son Jesus. Jesus is greater

than the angels, so people must pay more attention to him than to the angels.

In 3:1–4:13, the author showed that Jesus was also greater than Moses, who led God’s people, the people of Israel, out of Egypt. Moses led them as God’s faithful servant, but Jesus leads them as God’s own Son. Now God’s people include all the people who follow his Son, whether they are people of Israel or not. Jesus is the high priest of the better covenant that God made with his people.

Hebrews 3:1

Section 3:1–6: Jesus is greater than Moses

In this section the author explained how Jesus is greater than Moses. Moses was faithful as a servant in God’s house, but Jesus is God’s Son. He is faithful as a Son, taking care of God’s household for God. Because of that he is worthy of more honor than Moses.

Some other examples of headings for this section are:

Moses was God’s faithful servant, but Jesus was God’s faithful Son

Jesus and Moses (NET)

Some English versions include all of chapter 3 in one section. However, Section 3:7–19 is the second of the important warning sections in the book of Hebrews. (The first warning was in 2:1–4.) It is often helpful to readers to provide separate headings for each of these warning sections.

3:1

This verse is complex. In some languages it is more natural to change the order of clauses or to translate the clauses as two sentences. For examples of how to reorder the clauses in this verse, see the General Comment on 3:1a–b at the end of 3:1b.

3:1a

Therefore, holy brothers, who share in the heavenly calling,

- ¶ So then, holy brothers and sisters, who share God’s call/invitation,
- ¶ My fellow Christians, God himself called you to be his children. Because of all that I have said,
- ¶ Fellow Christians, we^(incl) are among the people whom God chose/told to give ourselves to him. So because of what I have said to you,^(plur)

Therefore: The Greek word which the BSB translates as Thereforehothen. Koester (page 242) says that this Greek conjunction “indicates that the author is draw-

ing out the implications of what has just been said. The term consistently appears in the middle of an argument rather than at the beginning of a new section (2:17, 2:25, 8:3, 9:18, 11:19).” introduces the exhortation in 3:1 to “set your focus on Jesus.” The Greek word implies that readers should focus on him because of what was said about him in chapters 1 and 2, and more specifically because of 2:17–18. Those verses indicate that Jesus is a merciful and faithful high priest for his followers. Therefore they must think about him and pay attention to him.

Some other ways to translate this connection are:

So (NCV)

Because of all this

Now therefore Tagbanwa back translation on TW.

Because of all that I have said

Translate the connection in a natural and clear way in your language.

holy brothers, who share in the heavenly calling: Scholars differ about what the word holy describes in this phrase:

1. It describes holy brothers. For example:

holy brothers and sisters (NIV) (BSB, NIV, RSV, ESV, NASB, NLT, NET, NCV, JBP, REB, KJV)

1. It describes share. For example:

holy partners (NRSV) (NRSV, GW)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), along with most English versions and many commentaries. Among these are Translator’s Handbook (page 51), Bruce (page 91), Ellingworth (page 198), Koester (page 242), Lane (page 74), Miller (page 64), and Westcott (page 73). Mitchell (page 80) says, “Given the distance between it and *metochoi*, the adjective more naturally modifies *adelphoi*, which encompasses both brothers and sisters...”

Here the author addressed his readers directly for the first time in Hebrews. The phrase holy brothers, who share in the heavenly calling addresses the readers directly, as if the phrases were names. The author used

them to focus special attention on what he was about to say in 3:1b (“set your focus on Jesus”).

In some languages it may not be natural to use a long phrase to address someone directly. So it may be more natural to translate 3:1a in a different way. For example:

holy brothers and sisters, you share in a heavenly calling

relatives, you belong to God and he has called you to enter heaven

In this sermon (letter) the author rarely used this type of direct address. The only other places are in 3:12, 10:19, 13:22 (“brothers”), and in 6:9 (“dear friends”).

holy brothers: The phrase holy brothers refers back to 2:11, where the author mentioned Jesus as the one who makes people holy. He said also that Jesus is not ashamed to call them brothers and sisters. They are brothers and sisters of Jesus and of each other. Translate the words holy and brothers in a similar way as you did in 2:11.

Some ways to translate holy brothers here are:

brothers and sisters dedicated to God

Relatives who belong to God Uma back translation on TW.

holy: The word holy means “dedicated to God,” “belonging to God,” “sanctified.” In 2:11, the author spoke of Jesus as the one who “sanctifies.” That means that he is the one who dedicates people to God so that they belong to him. See the examples in the preceding note.

The fact that God’s people are holy is one of the themes of the book. See also 10:10, 10:14, 12:10, and 12:14. For more information, see holy, sense A3(a), in KBT.

brothers: The Greek word that the BSB translates as brothers refers here to fellow believers in Christ. It includes both male and female. Believers call each other “brothers and sisters” because they have all been received into God’s family through becoming followers of Jesus.

Some ways to translate the word here are:

My Christian friends (GNT)

dear brothers and sisters who belong to God (NLT)

who share in the heavenly calling: The Greek word that the BSB translates as who share (“sharers”) means “people who use or own (something) in common or participate together in (something).” *μέτοχος*, BDAG, page 643. Here it indicates that the author and readers have all been called by God (they share that calling).

In some languages, it may not be natural to share a calling. If that is true in your language, some other ways to translate the meaning are:

who share in being called by God

whom God called along with others to be in his family

This word is also used in 3:14 in the phrase “to share in Christ.” In 2:14 another form of the word referred to Jesus “sharing” blood and flesh.

heavenly calling: There are two ways to interpret the phrase heavenly calling in this context:

1. It indicates that the calling is from God. The word heavenly is a way to refer to God. For the Jews, “heaven” could be used as a reference to God. They avoided using God’s name directly, out of reverence. Thus Matthew often refers to “the kingdom of heaven” rather than “the kingdom of God.” For example:

called by God (GNT) (GNT, NCV, CEV)

1. It refers to being called to heaven. For example:

called to heaven (NLT) (NLT)

Most English versions are ambiguous, and the interpretations are similar. However, if you must choose, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). In this context the author focuses more on the call to be in God’s family than on our call to heaven.

A heavenly calling indicates that God has invited or chosen people to be his children. Some other ways to translate this are:

God chose you to be his people. Otomi back translation on TW.

you whom God invited/told to be his children

In some languages “God called” a person implies a wrong meaning here. It implies that the person died. If that is true in your language, you should use a different word.

3:1b

set your focus on Jesus, the apostle and high priest whom we confess.

- meditate^(plur) on Jesus, the apostle and high priest whom we^(incl) acknowledge/follow.
- concentrate^(plur) on Jesus. He is the one whom God sent to us. He is the high priest whom we^(incl) say that we believe/trust.
- think^(plur) about Jesus. God sent him to us^(incl), and he is the high priest whom we profess and follow.

In this verse the author compared Jesus to Moses. The BSB and other English versions use a different order of words than the Greek text uses. In Greek, 3:1b–2 is literally:

consider carefully the apostle and high priest of our confession, Jesus

Notice that the name “Jesus” is the last word in the verse. Another way to translate this order is:

Pay attention to the one who is the apostle of God and the High Priest that we believe in: He is Jesus.

In Greek this order of words emphasizes Jesus. English versions have probably changed the order to emphasize Jesus more clearly in English. Use an order of words in your language that emphasizes Jesus.

set your focus on Jesus: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as set your focus on Jesus is more literally “consider...Jesus.” This phrase means “think carefully about.” BDAG, page 522. This verb occurs once more in Hebrews in 10:24, where people are encouraged to “think about” other believers. Some other ways to translate the phrase set your focus on are:

reflect on Jesus (NAB)

think seriously about Jesus

In some languages there is an idiom to express this. For example:

fix your thoughts on Jesus (NIV)

turn your minds to Jesus (NJB)

Jesus, the apostle and high priest whom we confess: The phrase Jesus, the apostle and high priest whom we confess indicates that we believe and publicly declare that Jesus is our apostle and high priest. In this context the word confess refers to “confessing the faith.” To confess the faith refers to making a statement that tells what followers of Jesus believe.

Some other ways to translate the apostle and high priest whom we confess are:

Jesus, the apostle and chief priest about whom we make our declaration of faith (GW)

this Jesus whom we declare to be God’s Messenger and High Priest (NLT96)

the apostle and high priest: The phrase that the BSB translates as the apostle and high priest indicates the roles that God gave Jesus. God sent him (so he is called apostle), and God made him the high priest for us.

apostle: The English word apostle comes from the Greek word which means “one who is sent.” An apostle can be sent to say something or to do something. In the New Testament the word apostle usually refers to the disciples whom Jesus sent to tell people the Gospel. Here it refers to Jesus. It indicates that Jesus is the one whom God sent to people for a special purpose. Hebrews 3:1 is the only verse in the NT where apostle refers to Jesus himself. However, Koester (page 243) lists the following NT verses that refer to Jesus as the one “sent” from God (e.g., Matthew 10:40, 15:24; Mark 9:37; Luke 10:16; John 3:17, 5:36, 17:3; 1 John 4:9–14).

Some ways to translate apostle in this context are:

God’s Messenger (NLT)

who was sent to us (NCV)

In some languages, the term for apostle in the Gospels is “the messenger of Jesus Christ.” Here in Hebrews a term like that should be changed. The term should indicate that God sent Jesus as the apostle (messenger). Also be sure to use a different term for apostle than you use for “prophet” or “angel.” For more information, see apostle, sense 1, in KBT.

high priest: Here the author repeated the phrase high priest that he used in 2:17. He repeated it here because

he was about to teach people more about Jesus being our high priest. He gave the main part of this teaching from 4:14 onwards. Translate high priest in the same way as you did in 2:17.

whom we confess: The phrase whom we confess means “what we say/declare that we believe.” In this context the word confess refers to people making a statement in public about what they believe. It does not refer here to confessing sins.

The word that the BSB translates here as confess occurs six times in the New Testament. For translation examples, see the note on “Jesus, the apostle and high priest whom we confess” earlier in this part of the verse.

General Comment on 3:1a–b

The clauses in 3:1 are complex. In some languages it is more natural to translate the connections in a simpler way or to use more than one sentence. For example:

My Christian friends, who also have been called by God! Think of Jesus, whom God sent to be the High Priest of the faith we profess. (GNT)

My holy brothers/relatives, you share in being called by God. Think about Jesus. He is the one whom God sent to us, and he is the supreme priest of our faith.

Hebrews 3:2

Section 3:1–6: Jesus is greater than Moses

In this section the author explained how Jesus is greater than Moses. Moses was faithful as a servant in God’s house, but Jesus is God’s Son. He is faithful as a Son, taking care of God’s household for God. Because of that he is worthy of more honor than Moses.

Some other examples of headings for this section are:

Moses was God’s faithful servant, but Jesus was God’s faithful Son

Jesus and Moses (NET)

Some English versions include all of chapter 3 in one section. However, Section 3:7–19 is the second of the important warning sections in the book of Hebrews. (The first warning was in 2:1–4.) It is often helpful to readers to provide separate headings for each of these warning sections.

3:2a**He was faithful to the One who appointed Him,**

- He was trustworthy toward God, who appointed/sent him,
- God is the one who sent him, and he did exactly what God told him to do.

He was faithful to the One who appointed Him: This clause indicates that Jesus was faithful to God. God is the one who appointed Jesus to be the high priest for God's people.

In some languages it may be helpful to begin a new sentence in 3:2a. It may also be helpful to refer explicitly to God as the one who appointed Jesus. For example:

He was faithful to God, who chose him to do this work (GNT)

Jesus is faithful to God, who appointed him. (GW)

He was trustworthy to obey God, as he did what God appointed/chose him to do

was faithful: The word faithful means “reliable, trustworthy.” Here it indicates that Jesus was worthy to be trusted. God could depend on him to do what is right and good. Some other ways to translate it in this context are:

did what God trusted him to do

was trustworthy/dependable

It was also used about Jesus in 2:17.

to the One who appointed Him: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as appointed is the common verb that is sometimes translated as “do” or “make.” Here it indicates that God gave Jesus the role of apostle and high priest. Use an appropriate verb in your language to refer to appointing someone to be a priest.

3:2b**just as Moses was faithful in all God's house.**

- in the same way that Moses was faithful/dependable in God's whole household.
- Moses also did exactly what God told him to do when he served in God's house for all God's people.

In this part of the verse, the author quoted Numbers 12:7, where God said that he spoke to other prophets

in dreams or visions. Then he said, “But this is not true of my servant Moses who is faithful in all my house.”

just as Moses was faithful in all God's house: Here the author compared Jesus to Moses. Jesus was faithful to God, just as Moses was faithful. The phrase faithful in all God's house indicates that Jesus and Moses were both faithful as they led all God's people. You should translate the word faithful as you did in 3:2a.

Some other ways to translate the clause are:

just as Moses was faithful in serving all of God's people (CEV)

in the same way that Moses was faithful when he served/worked in God's house

he was faithful doing the work that God ordered him to do, like Moses long ago was faithful doing his work taking care of the people of God

Moses was: Moses is mentioned here for the first time in Hebrews. The RSV adds the word “also” to refer back to Jesus, who was mentioned in 3:1b. Moses and Jesus were both faithful.

The Jews respected Moses as their great leader and the one who gave them God's Law. If you use footnotes, you may want to include a footnote about Moses. An example of a possible footnote is:

Moses was a great leader in the Old Testament. He led the people of Israel out of slavery in Egypt, and guided them to the land that God had prepared for them. Throughout the books of Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers, and Deuteronomy, he is the chief leader of Israel.

was faithful: See the note on 3:2a.

in all God's house: There is a textual issue here concerning the word that the BSB translates as all:

1. Some Greek manuscripts have a word that means “whole.” For example:

with God's entire house (NLT) (BSB, NIV, NRSV, NLT, CEV, NJB, NASB, KJV)

1. Other Greek manuscripts do not have the word “whole.” For example:

in God's house (RSV) (RSV, GNT, REB, JBP, GW, NCV, NET)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). In 3:5 the author includes the word "all" when he refers to the Greek text of Numbers 12:7. However, there is good support for both options in manuscripts, English versions and commentaries. For various reasons, it is difficult for scholars to decide which option is better. Metzger (4th Edition, page 594) says, "Both external evidence and transcriptional probabilities are...difficult to evaluate." The committee decided to include "all" in the text with a C rating, which indicates that the textual decision was uncertain. You may choose to follow either text and include a footnote to give the other possibility. For example, the NRSV has this footnote:

Other ancient authorities lack all

Other ways to translate all here are:

all God's people

God's entire house (NLT)

God's house: The Greek word that the BSB translates as house occurs six times between 3:2 and 3:6. It has two different meanings in these verses:

1. household/family BDAG, oikos, meaning 2, page 699.
2. dwelling BDAG, oikos, meaning 1, page 698. (building where one or more people live).

In some contexts the author has used the word in a way that can imply both of these meanings. In many languages there is no word that can have both of these meanings. If that is true in your language, you will need to translate the most likely meaning in each context.

In this context the word house refers to the people of Israel. Some ways to translate the phrase in this context are:

God's people (CEV)

God's family (NCV)

General Comment on 3:2a–b

In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of 3:2a and 3:2b. For example:

^{2b}Moses served God faithfully among all God's people. In the same way, ^{2a}Jesus worked faithfully for God who had appointed him.

Hebrews 3:3

Section 3:1–6: Jesus is greater than Moses

In this section the author explained how Jesus is greater than Moses. Moses was faithful as a servant in God's house, but Jesus is God's Son. He is faithful as a Son, taking care of God's household for God. Because of that he is worthy of more honor than Moses.

Some other examples of headings for this section are:

Moses was God's faithful servant, but Jesus was God's faithful Son

Jesus and Moses (NET)

Some English versions include all of chapter 3 in one section. However, Section 3:7–19 is the second of the important warning sections in the book of Hebrews. (The first warning was in 2:1–4.) It is often helpful to readers to provide separate headings for each of these warning sections.

3:3a

For Jesus has been counted worthy of greater glory than Moses,

- However, Jesus deserves more honor than Moses,
- Although both Moses and Jesus were faithful, Jesus deserves more respect/praise than Moses,

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates literally as For introduces a statement that explains or supports what the author has said. In 3:2 the author showed that Jesus and Moses were both faithful to God. Here in 3:3 he shows that Jesus deserves even greater honor than Moses.

Some ways to connect the two verses are:

But Jesus, he is considered to be greater than Moses Kankanaey back translation on TW.

For Jesus has been counted worthy of more glory than Moses (ESV)

In some languages a connector is not needed. For example:

Jesus has been found worthy of greater honor than Moses (NIV)

Connect 3:3 with 3:2 in a natural way in your language.

Jesus has been counted worthy of greater glory than Moses: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as counted worthy of means “to consider worthy.” In this context, it is God who considered Jesus worthy to receive more glory than Moses.

Some other ways to translate this sentence are:

Jesus deserved more glory than Moses

God considered that Jesus deserved more honor than Moses.

It is fitting/right that Jesus should receive more respect/praise than Moses

glory: In this context the Greek word which the BSB translates as glory means “honor,” “praise,” or “great respect.” For more information, see glory, sense 3(a) in KBT.

3:3b

just as the builder of a house has greater honor than the house itself.

- because the builder of a house deserves more honor than the house that he builds.
- because people should honor/respect the person who builds/makes a house more than they honor/respect the house itself.

just as the builder of a house has greater honor than the house itself: In this clause the author used a comparison to illustrate the reason that Jesus deserves more glory than Moses. Just like a person who builds a house deserves more honor than the house, Jesus deserves more honor than Moses. There are two ways to interpret the words builder and house here: (1) It means someone building a house. For example, the JBP says: just as the builder of a house may be truly said to have more honor than the house itself. (BSB, NIV, JBP, RSV, NASB, GNT, NET, CEV, NJB, KJV, GW, NLT, NCV) (2) It means someone beginning a lineage/family or a family line. For example, the REB says: the founder of a house enjoys more honor than his household. (REB) It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and the majority of versions and Bible scholars. Some other ways to translate the comparison are:

like a person who builds a house deserves more praise than the house itself

just as the one who builds a house is greater than the house

the builder of a house: The phrase the builder of a house refers to the person who plans and builds a house. He causes the house to exist.

General Comment on 3:3a–b

In 3:2 the author showed that Jesus was similar to Moses. Both were faithful in doing what God wanted them to do. In 3:3, the author showed that Jesus was more important than Moses. Just as a housebuilder is more important than the house he builds, so Jesus was more important than Moses. In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of clauses in this verse. For example:

^{3b}A man who builds a house receives more honor than the house itself. ^{3a}In the same way Jesus is worthy of much greater honor than Moses. (GNT)

Hebrews 3:4

Section 3:1–6: Jesus is greater than Moses

In this section the author explained how Jesus is greater than Moses. Moses was faithful as a servant in God’s house, but Jesus is God’s Son. He is faithful as a Son, taking care of God’s household for God. Because of that he is worthy of more honor than Moses.

Some other examples of headings for this section are:

Moses was God’s faithful servant, but Jesus was God’s faithful Son

Jesus and Moses (NET)

Some English versions include all of chapter 3 in one section. However, Section 3:7–19 is the second of the important warning sections in the book of Hebrews. (The first warning was in 2:1–4.) It is often helpful to readers to provide separate headings for each of these warning sections.

3:4

In this verse the author made a general statement that helps to explain what he said in 3:3. This statement in 3:4 is background information, so the RSV uses parentheses. Use a natural way in your language to indicate this background information.

3:4a

And every house is built by someone,

- Obviously every house had someone to build it,

- Everyone knows that a house cannot cause itself to exist; there must be a builder/person to build/make it,

And: The Greek word that the BSB translates as And is translated as “For” in many English versions. It introduces a statement that reminds readers of a fact that they already know. Other ways to indicate that the readers know this information are:

Of course (CEV)

We all know that...Tagbanwa back translation on TW.

every house is built by someone: The clause every house is built by someone is passive. It indicates that if a house exists, someone must have built it. This fact is a general principle that is true for any house. Some other ways to translate the clause are:

if there is a house, of course there is someone who built that house

Certainly every house that exists had someone to make/build it.

3:4b

but God is the builder of everything.

- but God is that one who built everything.
- and the builder/person who made all things is God.

but God is the builder of everything: This clause is a general principle that goes with the specific truth in 3:4a. Every house has a human builder (3:4a), but God is the actual builder who makes each building possible (3:4b). God is the one who caused everything to exist.

Translate this clause as a general truth, and connect it to 3:4a in a natural way in your language. Some other ways to translate it are:

and God is the one who has built all things (GNT)

but the one who built everything is God (NLT)

Hebrews 3:5

Section 3:1–6: Jesus is greater than Moses

In this section the author explained how Jesus is greater than Moses. Moses was faithful as a servant in God’s house, but Jesus is God’s Son. He is faithful as a

Son, taking care of God’s household for God. Because of that he is worthy of more honor than Moses.

Some other examples of headings for this section are:

Moses was God’s faithful servant, but Jesus was God’s faithful Son

Jesus and Moses (NET)

Some English versions include all of chapter 3 in one section. However, Section 3:7–19 is the second of the important warning sections in the book of Hebrews. (The first warning was in 2:1–4.) It is often helpful to readers to provide separate headings for each of these warning sections.

3:5–6a

Now...But: In Greek, the introductory phrases for 3:5 and 3:6 are more literally:

^{5a}and Moses, as for (him)...^{6a}but as for Christ...

These phrases indicate a contrast between the ways that Jesus and Moses were faithful. Moses was faithful as God’s servant (3:5), but Christ was faithful as God’s Son (3:6). The word Now (literally “and”) is not used as a time word here. It implies that in 3:5–6 the author will continue to speak about what he said in 3:2–4. David L. Allen (Hebrews, NAC, page 245) gives three possible functions for kai here, listing them in “descending order of probability: (1) It could be an explicative, connecting a clause that explains and summarizes vv. 2–4, and thus translated ‘and so.’ In this vein, some see it introducing an additional reason for expecting to find Jesus to be faithful; others as a second proof of Jesus’ superiority over Moses. (2) It could be ascensive, sharpening the contrast being drawn, and thus translated ‘indeed.’ (3) It could be adding another reason for expecting to find fidelity in Christ and thus ascribing to him greater glory. Both Lane and Ellingworth take it as further clarifying and explaining the previous comment concerning the faithfulness and superiority of Jesus contrasted with Moses.”

Some ways to translate these connections are:

So Moses was certainly faithful...as a servant, but Christ was faithful as a son

It is true that Moses was faithful in serving.... But Christ...was rather his Child who was faithful as being in charge

Translate the connection between 3:5 and 3:6 carefully so that the contrast between Moses and Jesus is clear in your language. For another translation example, see the General Comment on 3:5–6a at the end of 3:6a.

3:5a

Now Moses was faithful as a servant in all God's house,

- It is true that Moses was trustworthy as a servant in charge of God's household
- We^(incl) know that Moses did exactly what God told him to do when he was the servant who took care of God's people/family.

Moses was faithful as a servant: The words Moses was faithful as a servant implies that Moses obeyed God and did what God told him to do, just as a faithful servant should. Some ways to translate this clause are:

Moses was certainly faithful in God's house, but only as a servant. (NLT)

It is true that Moses served faithfully in the household of God. But he was only like a servant in that household.

faithful: The word faithful describes someone who is worthy to be trusted. He is reliable and God can depend on him to do what God wants him to do. This is the same Greek word used in 3:2a. You should translate it in the same way here.

servant: The Greek word that the BSB translates as servant appears only here in the NT. It refers to a worker who serves another person willingly, not as a slave. The service is honorable. Usually the word also implies a good relationship between the servant and the person whom he serves. Moses was a faithful servant of God. This is the only occurrence of the Greek word *therapōn* in the NT, though it is used in the Greek OT (the Septuagint).

Use an appropriate way in your language to refer to this type of relationship. Some other ways to translate it are:

worker

steward

in all God's house: The phrase in all God's house was also used in 3:2b. Translate it in the same way in both verses.

3:5b

testifying to what would be spoken later.

- to tell his people about the things which were to be spoken afterward.
- He made known to them what God planned to say in the future.

testifying to what would be spoken later: This phrase tells how Moses was faithful (3:5a). He was faithful to tell the people of Israel that in the future God was planning to speak new things to them. The Greek expression which the BSB translates as testifying to means "for/as a testimony." Most English versions agree that this refers to things that Moses said. But it was also Moses' faithful life and service that anticipated the coming Christ. So the NLT has: "His work was an illustration of the truths God would reveal later." Moses testified to things that would happen after he died.

Some ways to translate this clause are:

and his work was only a foreshadowing of the truth that would be known later (JBP)

His work was an illustration of the truths God would reveal later (NLT)

And what he did was like a prophecy/picture of what God planned to make clear in the future.

See also Deuteronomy 18:15–19, where God promised to send a prophet greater than Moses. Bible scholars believe that this promise refers to the Messiah.

what would be spoken later: The clause what would be spoken later refers to what God would reveal at a future time (when he sent Jesus to the people). This is a passive clause. In some languages it is more natural to use an active verb and indicate that God is the subject. For example:

things God would say in the future (GNT)

later: Here the word later refers to a time hundreds of years after Moses died. Use an appropriate word in your language to refer to such a time in the future.

Hebrews 3:6

Section 3:1–6: Jesus is greater than Moses

In this section the author explained how Jesus is greater than Moses. Moses was faithful as a servant in God's house, but Jesus is God's Son. He is faithful as a Son, taking care of God's household for God. Because of that he is worthy of more honor than Moses.

Some other examples of headings for this section are:

Moses was God's faithful servant, but Jesus was God's faithful Son

Jesus and Moses (NET)

Some English versions include all of chapter 3 in one section. However, Section 3:7–19 is the second of the important warning sections in the book of Hebrews. (The first warning was in 2:1–4.) It is often helpful to readers to provide separate headings for each of these warning sections.

3:6a

But Christ is faithful as the Son over God's house.

- However, Christ was faithful as God's son in charge of God's household.
- But Christ was not a servant like Moses. He was God's son over God's house. He did everything as God told him to do.

But Christ is faithful as the Son over God's house:

This clause implies that Christ was faithful in a different (and better) way than Moses was. Christ was faithful as God's son to fulfill all the responsibilities of a son. As the son, he was in charge of God's house. In contrast, Moses (3:5) was a servant to God, so he only had to fulfill the responsibilities of a servant.

Some ways to translate the contrast are:

But Christ is a faithful son in charge of God's household. (GW)

but Christ is faithful as a son, set over the household (REB)

However, Christ was not only a servant of God, but rather his Child who was faithful in being in charge of his Father's family.

Connect this part of the contrast to 3:5 in a natural way in your language.

Christ: Here the author used the word Christ for the first time in Hebrews. He used it as a title to refer to Jesus as the person whom God had appointed and promised to send as king and savior. The title Christ is the Greek translation of the Hebrew word "messiah," and the two words have the same meaning. You should use the same word for Christ here as you use in the Gospels.

Some ways to translate Christ are:

- Use a title or a descriptive phrase in your language that has the same meaning as Christ. For example:

Messiah

Promised Deliverer

the Rescuer-King whom God appointed

- Transliterate Christ and include a phrase that explains the meaning. For example:

Christ, the appointed one

Cristo, the Savior whom God promised to send

the Christ who comes from God

- Transliterate Christ and indicate in some way that it is a title. For example:

the Christ

the Kirisita

If you do not indicate the meaning of Christ in your text of your translation, you may want to include a footnote to explain it. Or you may want to explain the meaning in a glossary. For example:

The word/title "Christ" refers to the king and savior whom God had promised to send.

See also Christ in KBT.

faithful: The word that the BSB translates as faithful here is the same Greek word used in 3:2a. See the note there.

as the Son over God's house: The phrase as the Son over God's house refers to Christ's role in God's

household. It implies that Christ is in charge of the household and is responsible for it. God completely trusts Christ to take care of the household, as a human father trusts his oldest son. The term Son does not imply that God procreated Jesus as a human father procreates a son.

Some other ways to translate as the Son over God's house are:

as God's son he takes care of God's family/people

He is the son of God whose being in charge of the house was carried out faithfully. Western Bukidnon Manobo back translation on TW.

For more information, see the note on "his Son" in 1:2a.

God's house: The phrase God's house refers here to God's household. A few scholars take the word "his" to refer to Christ. However, the context favors "God's," since Christ is faithful as a son over God's house. This view is supported by a majority of English versions, including the BSB, NIV, RSV, GNT, NET, GW, NLT, NCV, and the CEV. Some versions are ambiguous, including the NASB and ESV. The KJV explicitly follows the interpretation "Christ's house" by saying "Christ as a son over his own house." For more information on the use of house in 3:1–6, see the notes on 3:2b and 3:5a. Translate house here in the same way as you did there.

General Comment on 3:5–6a

In 3:5–6a the author contrasted Moses (3:5) and Christ (3:6a). Notice how the contrast is emphasized in the example below:

⁵It is true that Moses was faithful in serving all his companions in the family of God, but he was only a servant of God and what he did, it was an illustration of what God would make known in the future. ⁶But as for Christ, he was not just a servant in the household of God but rather the boss, because he is the Son of the Householder.

Emphasize this contrast in a natural way in your language.

3:6b–c

And we are His house, if we hold firmly to our confidence and the hope of which we boast: The statement in 3:6b–c gives the condition for being part of God's household. It indicates that we must firmly continue to have confidence and to proudly hope in Jesus Christ. Other ways to translate this statement are:

We are his household if we continue to have courage and to be proud of our hope.

and we belong to his family if we continue to be courageous and we are not ashamed of what we hope/anticipate. Similar to the Kankanaey back translation on TW.

And we are God's household, if we keep up our courage and remain confident in our hope in Christ. (NLT)

In some languages it is more natural to change the order of 3:6b and 3:6c.

3:6b

And we are His house,

- We^(incl) are members of God's household,
- And we^(incl) who believe in Christ belong to God's people/family,

we: The pronoun we refers both to the author and the people to whom he was speaking.

His house: The phrase His house refers here to God's household, as in 3:2b, 3:5a, and 3:6a.

3:6c

if we hold firmly to our confidence and the hope of which we boast.

- if we^(incl) continue to be courageous and confident about what we^(incl) hope for.
- if we^(incl) keep trusting him and if we^(incl) are not ashamed to expect what he promised us.

if we hold firmly to our confidence and the hope of which we boast: This clause is more literally "if the confidence and the boast of hope we hold-firm." It implies that we must continue to have confidence in Christ and to be proud of our hope in him (3:6b).

Some other ways to translate the clause are:

if we continue to have courage and to be proud of the confidence we have (GW)

if we keep trusting Christ and are not ashamed of what we hope/expect

we: The pronoun we refers to both the author and the people to whom he wrote.

hold firmly: Here the Greek word that the BSB translates as hold firmly means to "firmly continue to believe." BDAG assigns its use in this verse to meaning

2, “to adhere firmly to traditions, convictions, or beliefs,” and sense b, “hold fast, retain faithfully” (page 533). In this context it refers to always continuing to trust Christ. A person who trusts him in that way continues to have faith in him through every problem or persecution.

Some other ways to translate this meaning are:

continue to be very sure

maintain our trust (JBP)

our confidence: The Greek word that the BSB translates as confidence means “boldness” or “fearlessness.” Some other ways to translate it here are:

we do not fear

we continue to be courageous

and the hope of which we boast: There is a textual issue at the end of 3:6d: (1) Some Greek manuscripts end the verse after the phrase “pride that belongs to hope.” For example, the GW says, and to be proud of the confidence we have (BSB, NIV, GNT, NRSV, GW, NLT, CEV, NJB, NCV, NET, REB)(2) Other Greek manuscripts have the phrase “firm to the end.” For example, the JBP says, and joyful hope steadfast to the end (KJV, NASB, JBP) It is recommended that you follow option (1), as the majority of English versions do. The phrase the hope of which we boast indicates that we expect that Christ will save us, and that causes us to be confident and courageous. Some other ways to translate the phrase are:

the hope that gives us confidence/boldness

what we boldly expect from God/Christ

hope: The word hope refers here to confidence that God will do everything that he promised to do. This is the first time that the word occurs in Hebrews.

of which we boast: The Greek verb which the BSB translates as boast refers to being joyfully confident. We (God’s people) are confident about our hope in Christ. The verb does not imply being arrogant or too confident in ourselves or our own achievements. (Notice that boast is used as a verb here.)

Hebrews 3:7

Section 3:7–19: Warning: Do not reject God’s offer of rest

In the earlier sections of Hebrews the author showed that Jesus was greater than both the angels and Moses. In 2:1–4 he gave a first warning not to refuse the message which Jesus brought. Here in 3:7–19 he gave a second warning not to refuse Jesus’ message, especially the “rest” that God offers through Jesus. The author quoted from Psalm 95, which says that God wanted to give the people of Israel a land where they could have rest from their enemies. When they were slaves in Egypt, he sent Moses to lead them to that land, but they rebelled against God in the wilderness. Then God did not allow them to enter the land of rest.

It is often difficult to decide how to translate “rest” in this section and in chapter 4. Psalm 95 and Hebrews do refer to the time when Moses was alive and God promised to give the people of Israel land. However, King David was already in that land when he wrote the psalm, so the “rest” could not refer to the land. It refers to a different type of “rest.” That rest is a way of trusting God and depending on him for everything. We especially trust him to save us from our sins and give us eternal life. Because of the rest that God gives, we can have peace even when we suffer.

Be careful not to imply that the rest that God promises his people today is a certain place or land. Some scholars believe that the rest refers to heaven. It is true that we will have perfect rest in heaven, but Hebrews indicates that the rest that God provides for us begins on earth when we trust in Jesus.

Some other headings for this section are:

Rest for God’s People

Warning Against Unbelief (NIV)

We Must Continue to Follow/Obey God

Scholars differ about where to end this warning section. Some scholars end the warning at 3:19. Others make the warning section continue to 4:13. In these notes, 3:19 is the end of this second warning section, and the following section is 4:1–13.

Paragraph 3:7–11

This paragraph contains a long quotation. You should use the format which you usually use for such quotations. This quotation from Psalm 95:7b–11 refers to the years when the people of Israel were traveling through

the desert to the land of Canaan. God did many miracles for them, but they often complained against him.

In 3:8a–9a the quotation from Psalm 95 probably refers to a specific time when the people of Israel complained. There are two main views about which “rebellion” and “day of testing” the author referred to here: (a) He referred to the time that the Israelites rebelled against God at Kadesh Barnea. They refused to enter the land of Canaan that God promised to give them (Numbers 14:22). (b) He referred to the time that the Israelites rebelled against God at the place that was later named Meribah and Massah. They complained that they had no water, and they made God angry by their attitude and by what they said (Exodus 17:1–7). Option (a) is probably more likely in this context. It may refer to Exodus 17:1–7, when they did not find water to drink where they camped. However, it is more likely that it refers to Numbers 14, where they refused to enter the land that the Lord wanted to give them. That interpretation fits well with the theme of “rest” in Hebrews 4.

In 3:9b–11 the author referred to what the people of Israel did during the whole forty year period when they wandered through the desert. In 3:7–8a he indicates that followers of Jesus must not stubbornly reject what God tells them to do, as the people of Israel did in the desert.

3:7–8

The Greek text of 3:7 refers to God’s voice as “his voice,” and in 3:8 the author does not need to refer to him explicitly. However, in 3:9–11, the author uses pronouns like “I,” “me” and “my” to refer to God. English versions differ in the way they refer to God in 3:7–8. Refer to him in those verses in a way that is clear in your language.

Some ways to translate 3:7–8 are:

As the Holy Spirit says, “If you hear God speak today, don’t be stubborn. Don’t be stubborn like those who rebelled and tested me in the desert. (GW)

So then, as the Holy Spirit says, “If you hear God’s voice today, do not be stubborn, as your ancestors were when they rebelled against God, as they were that day in the desert when they put him to the test. (GNT)

3:7a

Therefore, as the Holy Spirit says:

- ¶ So as the Holy Spirit says:

- ¶ Because of this, we^(incl)/you^(plur) must do as the Holy Spirit says in the Scripture:
- ¶ As the Holy Spirit said/spoke through King David in God’s Word/book:

Therefore: The conjunction ThereforeIn the book of Hebrews, this conjunction (dio) occurs in the following verses: 3:7, 3:10, 6:1, 10:5, 11:12, 11:16, 12:12, 12:28, and 13:12. It always occurs first in the sentence. introduces a conclusion from 3:1–6. We are God’s house (family), so we must listen to him and do what he says. Some ways to translate the conjunction are:

Because of that

Now, therefore

So

as the Holy Spirit says: This phrase introduces a quotation from Scripture. It implies that the Holy Spirit is the one who spoke those words and inspired a person to write them. The phrase is another way to refer to what Scripture says. This is the first time that the author introduced a quotation from the Old Testament in this way.

Here the author quoted what King David wrote in Psalm 95:7b–11. In some languages it may be helpful to refer to King David by name here, as the author does in 4:7, when he quotes from Psalm 95 again. Be sure to indicate or imply that the author referred to Scripture. It is often helpful to use the normal way that you refer to Scripture in your language. For example:

As the Holy Spirit said and King David wrote in God’s book

The Holy Spirit spoke through King David and it was written saying

It is also helpful in some languages to include part of the meaning of the quotation in the introduction, so that it sounds more natural. Notice the implied words in the following example:

Therefore you must do as the Holy Spirit said,

Holy Spirit: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Holy Spirit refers to the Spirit of God. The Holy Spirit is God, together with God the Father and God the Son. The Holy Spirit is “spirit” in the sense that he is a

living being who does not have a physical body. He is “holy” in the sense that he is God and unique from every other being. He is perfect in every way and is completely pure and sinless.

Some ways to translate Holy Spirit are:

Spirit/Breath of God

Holy/Sacred Spirit

Do not imply that the Holy Spirit is like the ghost of a dead person or that God has died. The term Holy Spirit also occurred in 2:4c. See how you translated it there.

3:7b

“Today, if you hear His voice,

- “Today as you^(plur) hear his voice,
- “Listen^(plur) to what he says today:
- “Be^(plur) sure to listen to those words of his today.

Here the author began to quote from Psalm 95.

Today: In this context the word Today refers to the present moment or time. Some ways to translate Today in the context are:

right now

now at this time

on this very day

Here the word Today comes first in the sentence to emphasize it. It implies that when a person hears God voice, he should respond immediately. He should not delay.

if you hear His voice: There are several ways to interpret the if clause here:

1. It means that you should listen to what God says. (It is a command or exhortation. Allen (page 235–236, Kindle edition) says, “The hortatory nature of Hebrews 3:1–6 is signaled by...the use of an imperative in 3:1 and an imperatival idea semantically encoded in the conditional clause of verse 6.”) For example:

you must listen to his voice (NLT96)

Oh, that today you would listen...! (NET) (NET, NLT96, NCV)

1. It means when you hear what God says. For example:

when you hear his voice (NLT04) (NLT04, RSV)

1. It means if you hear what God says. (It is a condition.) For example:

If you hear God speak (GW) (BSB, NIV, NRSV, ESV, NASB, REB, GW, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), along with many Bible scholars. The Translator’s Handbook (page 60) says, “The Greek word usually means ‘if,’ but sometimes, as in John 12:32, 14:3; 1 John 2:28, it is virtually equal to ‘when.’ Here the question is not whether people will ‘hear God’s voice (since God is speaking or is about to speak in this very passage), but whether, when people have heard his voice, they will obey it.” Although more English versions have if, it may imply a wrong meaning here. In this context, the if clause does not imply that the listeners may not hear God’s voice. The author is about to tell them what God says.

you: The pronoun you is plural and refers to all the people who hear (or read) what God said.

hear His voice: The phrase hear His voice refers here to listening to what God says. It implies listening in order to obey. For example:

listen to him!

hear what he says and obey it

Hebrews 3:8

Section 3:7–19: Warning: Do not reject God’s offer of rest

In the earlier sections of Hebrews the author showed that Jesus was greater than both the angels and Moses. In 2:1–4 he gave a first warning not to refuse the message which Jesus brought. Here in 3:7–19 he gave a second warning not to refuse Jesus’ message, especially the “rest” that God offers through Jesus. The author quoted from Psalm 95, which says that God wanted to give the people of Israel a land where they could have rest from their enemies. When they were slaves in Egypt, he sent Moses to lead them to that land, but they rebelled against God in the wilderness. Then God did not allow them to enter the land of rest.

It is often difficult to decide how to translate “rest” in this section and in chapter 4. Psalm 95 and Hebrews do refer to the time when Moses was alive and God promised to give the people of Israel land. However, King David was already in that land when he wrote the psalm, so the “rest” could not refer to the land. It refers to a different type of “rest.” That rest is a way of trusting God and depending on him for everything. We especially trust him to save us from our sins and give us eternal life. Because of the rest that God gives, we can have peace even when we suffer.

Be careful not to imply that the rest that God promises his people today is a certain place or land. Some scholars believe that the rest refers to heaven. It is true that we will have perfect rest in heaven, but Hebrews indicates that the rest that God provides for us begins on earth when we trust in Jesus.

Some other headings for this section are:

Rest for God’s People

Warning Against Unbelief (NIV)

We Must Continue to Follow/Obey God

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Paragraph 3:7–11

This paragraph contains a long quotation. You should use the format which you usually use for such quotations. This quotation from Psalm 95:7b–11 refers to the years when the people of Israel were traveling through the desert to the land of Canaan. God did many miracles for them, but they often complained against him.

In 3:8a–9a the quotation from Psalm 95 probably refers to a specific time when the people of Israel complained. There are two main views about which “rebellion” and “day of testing” the author referred to here: (a) He referred to the time that the Israelites rebelled against God at Kadesh Barnea. They refused to enter the land of Canaan that God promised to give them (Numbers 14:22). (b) He referred to the time that the Israelites rebelled against God at the place that was later named Meribah and Massah. They complained that they had no water, and they made God angry by their attitude and by what they said (Exodus 17:1–7). Option (a) is probably more likely in this context. It may refer to Exodus 17:1–7, when they did

not find water to drink where they camped. However, it is more likely that it refers to Numbers 14, where they refused to enter the land that the Lord wanted to give them. That interpretation fits well with the theme of “rest” in Hebrews 4.

In 3:9b–11 the author referred to what the people of Israel did during the whole forty year period when they wandered through the desert. In 3:7–8a he indicates that followers of Jesus must not stubbornly reject what God tells them to do, as the people of Israel did in the desert.

3:8a

do not harden your hearts,

- do^(plur) not become stubborn/disobedient,
- ‘Do^(plur) not reject my words.
- Do^(plur) not refuse to obey him

do not harden your hearts: The clause do not harden your hearts is figurative. It means “do not be obstinate” or “do not refuse to listen.” Some other ways to translate the clause are:

do not be stubborn (GNT)

do not rebel

do not refuse to do what he says

your hearts: The Jews speak of their hearts as the part of a person that thinks, feels, and makes decisions. This word occurs eleven times in Hebrews, four of which are in this chapter. It also occurs often in quotations from the Old Testament.

In many languages, people use a different part of the body, such as the stomach or the liver, as the part of a person that thinks and feels. In other languages people do not use a part of the body to refer to the source of feelings or thoughts. They may use a different idiom or no idiom at all. Other ways to translate “harden your hearts” are:

make your ears hard/dull

refuse to listen/obey

Use a natural expression in your own language. For more information, see heart, sense 1(b) in KBT.

3:8b

as you did in the rebellion,

- as you^(plur) did when you rebelled

- Do not be stubborn as your ancestors were when they refused to obey me.
- as your ancestors refused to obey

3:8c**in the day of testing in the wilderness,**

- and provoked me in the wilderness.
- Do not test me, as they did in the desolate area where no people live.
- and tested him in the wilderness.

3:8b-c

as you did in the rebellion, in the day of testing in the wilderness: The phrases in 3:8b and 3:8c refer to a time when the ancestors of the Hebrews rebelled against God. After God took them from slavery in Egypt, they rebelled against him as he led them through the wilderness.

There are two different views about which rebellion and day of testing the author referred to:

1. He referred to the rebellion at Kadesh Barnea. There the Israel people refused to enter the land of Canaan that God promised to give them (Numbers 14:22).
2. He referred to the rebellion at the place that was later named Meribah and Massah. There the people of Israel complained that they had no water. They made God angry by their attitude and by what they said (Exodus 17:1-7).

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It fits well with the theme of a resting place in Hebrews 4. Your translation should indicate that rebellion and day of testing refer to the same event. For example:

when they continually rejected what I said until they caused me to become angry

where your ancestors challenged my authority and tried my patience

rebellion: The Greek word that the BSB translates as rebellion refers here to a revolt against God. *παραπικρασμός*, BDAG, page 770. The ancestors of the Hebrews rebelled against God and refused to enter the land, as he told them to do. They refused to believe that God would help them conquer the land that he promised them.

Some other ways to translate rebellion are:

your ancestors rebelled against God

they refused to do what God told them to do

the day of testing in the wilderness: The phrase the day of testing in the wilderness refers to the same occasion as “the rebellion.” It implies that the Israelites tested God when they rebelled against him.

testing: The Greek word that the BSB translates as testing can refer either to a test or to a temptation. It is an action that a person does to see what someone else will do (or not do). *πειρασμός* meaning 1, BDAG, page 793. The word may also refer to tempting someone to sin or to become angry. The choice between these meanings depends on the context where the word is used. In this context the people tested God to see what he would do.

Some ways to translate testing in this context are:

as they were that day in the desert when they put him to the test (GNT)

when they tested God’s patience in the wilderness (NLT)

in the wilderness: The word wilderness means an uninhabited place. Some ways to translate this word are:

in the land where no people live Western Bukidnon Manobo back translation on TW.

the uninhabited place

Hebrews 3:9**Section 3:7-19: Warning: Do not reject God’s offer of rest**

In the earlier sections of Hebrews the author showed that Jesus was greater than both the angels and Moses. In 2:1-4 he gave a first warning not to refuse the message which Jesus brought. Here in 3:7-19 he gave a second warning not to refuse Jesus’ message, especially the “rest” that God offers through Jesus. The author quoted from Psalm 95, which says that God wanted to give the people of Israel a land where they could have rest from their enemies. When they were slaves in Egypt, he sent Moses to lead them to that land, but they rebelled against God in the wilderness. Then God did not allow them to enter the land of rest.

It is often difficult to decide how to translate “rest” in this section and in chapter 4. Psalm 95 and Hebrews do refer to the time when Moses was alive and God

promised to give the people of Israel land. However, King David was already in that land when he wrote the psalm, so the “rest” could not refer to the land. It refers to a different type of “rest.” That rest is a way of trusting God and depending on him for everything. We especially trust him to save us from our sins and give us eternal life. Because of the rest that God gives, we can have peace even when we suffer.

Be careful not to imply that the rest that God promises his people today is a certain place or land. Some scholars believe that the rest refers to heaven. It is true that we will have perfect rest in heaven, but Hebrews indicates that the rest that God provides for us begins on earth when we trust in Jesus.

Some other headings for this section are:

Rest for God’s People

Warning Against Unbelief (NIV)

We Must Continue to Follow/Obey God

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Paragraph 3:7–11

This paragraph contains a long quotation. You should use the format which you usually use for such quotations. This quotation from Psalm 95:7b–11 refers to the years when the people of Israel were traveling through the desert to the land of Canaan. God did many miracles for them, but they often complained against him.

In 3:8a–9a the quotation from Psalm 95 probably refers to a specific time when the people of Israel complained. There are two main views about which “rebellion” and “day of testing” the author referred to here: (a) He referred to the time that the Israelites rebelled against God at Kadesh Barnea. They refused to enter the land of Canaan that God promised to give them (Numbers 14:22). (b) He referred to the time that the Israelites rebelled against God at the place that was later named Meribah and Massah. They complained that they had no water, and they made God angry by their attitude and by what they said (Exodus 17:1–7). Option (a) is probably more likely in this context. It may refer to Exodus 17:1–7, when they did not find water to drink where they camped. However, it is more likely that it refers to Numbers 14, where they refused to enter the land that the Lord wanted to

give them. That interpretation fits well with the theme of “rest” in Hebrews 4.

In 3:9b–11 the author referred to what the people of Israel did during the whole forty year period when they wandered through the desert. In 3:7–8a he indicates that followers of Jesus must not stubbornly reject what God tells them to do, as the people of Israel did in the desert.

3:9a–b

where your fathers tested and tried Me, and for forty years saw My works: This verse tells about the Israelites’ time in “the wilderness” (mentioned in 3:8). In many languages it may be more natural to begin a new sentence at this verse. For example:

^{9a}There your ancestors tested and tried my patience, ^{9b}even though they saw my miracles for forty years. (NLT)

In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of 3:9a and 3:9b. See the General Comment on 3:9a–b at the end of 3:9b for an example.

3:9a

where your fathers tested and tried Me,

- There your^(plur) ancestors tested me and tried my patience,
- That was the place where your forefathers challenged me to see/know what I would do.
- They continually rejected what God said until they caused God to be angry,

where your fathers tested and tried Me: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as where your fathers tested and tried Me is more literally “where your fathers tested me with a trial.” The word dokimasia only occurs here in the NT. It is an emphatic way to tell what the Israelite ancestors did.

Some other ways to translate the phrase are:

when your ancestors challenged me and put me to the test (NJB)

when they tested God’s patience in the wilderness (NLT)

Translate the phrase in a natural way in your language.

fathers: The word fathers refers to the ancestors of the Hebrews to whom the author wrote. It refers specifically to the ancestors who were alive in the time of Moses. It includes both male and female ancestors.

3:9b**and for forty years saw My works.**

- and during forty years they saw the great things that I did.
- Yet/However, they already were seeing the amazing things that I did during their forty years in the wilderness.
- though for forty years they witnessed the many miracles he did for them.

and for forty years saw My works: This clause implies that the way the people of Israel acted toward God was surprising and wrong. The Greek conjunction that begins the clause is *kai*. BDAG (page 495) lists its sense here as “emphasizing a fact as surprising or unexpected or noteworthy.” In this context the text implies that the Israelites should have reacted to the Lord’s mighty works with obedience, not by rebelling against him. Allen (page 258, Kindle edition) says, “The *kai* (“and”) can introduce an added thought...or, more likely, a concession: ‘although they saw.’” When they saw what God did, they should have obeyed him. They should not have put him to another test.

Some other ways to translate the clause are:

though for forty years they saw what I did (REB)

yet they saw with their own eyes what I did for them for forty years Uma back translation on TW.

for forty years: The phrase forty years refers to the forty years when God caused the people of Israel to wander in the desert. They refused to trust him and enter the land of Canaan after they heard the report of the spies. To read more about this, see Numbers 13–14.

My works: The phrase My works refers to the supernatural acts that God did for the Israelites during their forty years in the wilderness. For example, he gave them manna and quails to eat (Exodus 16), and water out of the rock to drink (Exodus 17). He also guided them with a pillar of cloud by day and a pillar of cloud by night (Exodus 13:21–22). These acts may also include how he punished them when they disobeyed him.

Some other ways to translate My works are:

what I did

the mighty/supernatural acts that I did

General Comment on 3:9a–b

In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of 3:9a and 3:9b. For example:

^{9b}Although your ancestors witnessed God’s miracles for them during those forty years, ^{9a}they repeatedly tested him.

Hebrews 3:10**Section 3:7–19: Warning: Do not reject God’s offer of rest**

In the earlier sections of Hebrews the author showed that Jesus was greater than both the angels and Moses. In 2:1–4 he gave a first warning not to refuse the message which Jesus brought. Here in 3:7–19 he gave a second warning not to refuse Jesus’ message, especially the “rest” that God offers through Jesus. The author quoted from Psalm 95, which says that God wanted to give the people of Israel a land where they could have rest from their enemies. When they were slaves in Egypt, he sent Moses to lead them to that land, but they rebelled against God in the wilderness. Then God did not allow them to enter the land of rest.

It is often difficult to decide how to translate “rest” in this section and in chapter 4. Psalm 95 and Hebrews do refer to the time when Moses was alive and God promised to give the people of Israel land. However, King David was already in that land when he wrote the psalm, so the “rest” could not refer to the land. It refers to a different type of “rest.” That rest is a way of trusting God and depending on him for everything. We especially trust him to save us from our sins and give us eternal life. Because of the rest that God gives, we can have peace even when we suffer.

Be careful not to imply that the rest that God promises his people today is a certain place or land. Some scholars believe that the rest refers to heaven. It is true that we will have perfect rest in heaven, but Hebrews indicates that the rest that God provides for us begins on earth when we trust in Jesus.

Some other headings for this section are:

Rest for God’s People

Warning Against Unbelief (NIV)

We Must Continue to Follow/Obey God

Scholars differ about where to end this warning section. Some scholars end the warning at 3:19. Others

make the warning section continue to 4:13. In these notes, 3:19 is the end of this second warning section, and the following section is 4:1–13.

Paragraph 3:7–11

This paragraph contains a long quotation. You should use the format which you usually use for such quotations. This quotation from Psalm 95:7b–11 refers to the years when the people of Israel were traveling through the desert to the land of Canaan. God did many miracles for them, but they often complained against him.

In 3:8a–9a the quotation from Psalm 95 probably refers to a specific time when the people of Israel complained. There are two main views about which “rebellion” and “day of testing” the author referred to here: (a) He referred to the time that the Israelites rebelled against God at Kadesh Barnea. They refused to enter the land of Canaan that God promised to give them (Numbers 14:22). (b) He referred to the time that the Israelites rebelled against God at the place that was later named Meribah and Massah. They complained that they had no water, and they made God angry by their attitude and by what they said (Exodus 17:1–7). Option (a) is probably more likely in this context. It may refer to Exodus 17:1–7, when they did not find water to drink where they camped. However, it is more likely that it refers to Numbers 14, where they refused to enter the land that the Lord wanted to give them. That interpretation fits well with the theme of “rest” in Hebrews 4.

In 3:9b–11 the author referred to what the people of Israel did during the whole forty year period when they wandered through the desert. In 3:7–8a he indicates that followers of Jesus must not stubbornly reject what God tells them to do, as the people of Israel did in the desert.

3:10a

Therefore I was angry with that generation, and I said,

- Therefore I was angry with those ancestors and said,
- So I was angry with them, and I said, (NLT)
- Because of that, he was angry with them, and he said about them,

Therefore: The word that the BSB translates as *Therefore* introduces the result of the people rebelling and testing God in 3:8–9. It implies that God was angry because they tested him and did not believe in him. Some ways to translate the connection in English are:

So

As a result

I was angry with that generation: This clause explains why God was angry with the people who rebelled against him. He was angry because they did not believe him and disobeyed him. This is the way in which they “tested” him (3:9).

For more information about the way the people of Israel rebelled against the Lord, see Deuteronomy 1:19–40 and Numbers 13–14.

that generation: The phrase *that generation* Allen (page 258, Kindle edition) points out, “The author also substituted ‘this’ for ‘that’ before ‘generation,’ implying that his generation was included along with those of the Old Testament.” However, no English version uses “this” in 3:10. *refers* to the Israelites who lived at the time when God rescued them from Egypt and led them through the desert. Consider how you refer to a group of ancestors who lived at a specific time more than a thousand years before you. In some languages a general reference back to them will be sufficient. For example:

those people/ancestors

Refer to them in a natural way in your language.

and I said: This phrase introduces what the Lord said about the people. He did not speak directly to them. Hebrews does not make explicit to whom he spoke. He probably spoke to Moses, since in Numbers 14:22 God said to Moses, “They have already tested me many times.” Lane (page 86) says, “The complaint, ‘Their hearts are always going astray’ (v 10b), corresponds to Num 14:22b, ‘They have already tested me many times.’”

Some other ways to introduce God’s decision are:

I thought

I said about them

3:10b

‘Their hearts are always going astray,

- ‘They always want to go their own way.
- ‘They are always disloyal (GNT)
- “These people always reject me in their hearts.

3:10c

and they have not known My ways.’

- They refuse to do what I tell them.’ (NLT)

- and refuse to obey my commands.’
- They do not want to understand the way/commands that I teach them.”

3:10b–c

Their hearts are always going astray, and they have not known My ways: The two clauses in 3:10b and 3:10c are parallel. They have a similar meaning, and they are closely connected. Together they indicate that the people refused to obey God. In 3:10b the emphasis is that the people were not loyal to God. In 3:10c the emphasis is that they refused to know and follow God’s ways.

Some ways to translate these clauses are:

^{10b}They are always disloyal ^{10c}and refuse to obey my commands. (GNT)

^{10b}They continually go astray to someone/something else. ^{10c}They refuse to follow my commands. Kankanaey back translation on TW.

^{10b}these people have determined that they will separate from me. ^{10c}They do not want to follow the word I speak about how they should live.

Their hearts are always going astray: This clause is figurative. It indicates that the people were not loyal to God. They did not do what he told them to do. For ways to translate this clause, see the examples for 3:10b in the preceding note.

hearts: For more information on the use of hearts as an idiom, see the note on 3:8a.

and they have not known My ways: The clause and they have not known My ways indicates that the people did not want to understand the way that God wanted them to live. It implies that they did not choose to obey him. The people of Israel did not understand what God wanted because they refused to obey his commands. That is why he was angry with them.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

They refuse to do what I tell them. (NLT)

they will not hear/listen-to the way I teach them to live

and they have no desire to know who I am and how I want them to live

For more information on what the people of Israel did, see Deuteronomy 1:32–33.

Hebrews 3:11

Section 3:7–19: Warning: Do not reject God’s offer of rest

In the earlier sections of Hebrews the author showed that Jesus was greater than both the angels and Moses. In 2:1–4 he gave a first warning not to refuse the message which Jesus brought. Here in 3:7–19 he gave a second warning not to refuse Jesus’ message, especially the “rest” that God offers through Jesus. The author quoted from Psalm 95, which says that God wanted to give the people of Israel a land where they could have rest from their enemies. When they were slaves in Egypt, he sent Moses to lead them to that land, but they rebelled against God in the wilderness. Then God did not allow them to enter the land of rest.

It is often difficult to decide how to translate “rest” in this section and in chapter 4. Psalm 95 and Hebrews do refer to the time when Moses was alive and God promised to give the people of Israel land. However, King David was already in that land when he wrote the psalm, so the “rest” could not refer to the land. It refers to a different type of “rest.” That rest is a way of trusting God and depending on him for everything. We especially trust him to save us from our sins and give us eternal life. Because of the rest that God gives, we can have peace even when we suffer.

Be careful not to imply that the rest that God promises his people today is a certain place or land. Some scholars believe that the rest refers to heaven. It is true that we will have perfect rest in heaven, but Hebrews indicates that the rest that God provides for us begins on earth when we trust in Jesus.

Some other headings for this section are:

Rest for God’s People

Warning Against Unbelief (NIV)

We Must Continue to Follow/Obey God

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This paragraph contains a long quotation. You should use the format which you usually use for such quotations. This quotation from Psalm 95:7b–11 refers to the years when the people of Israel were traveling through the desert to the land of Canaan. God did many miracles for them, but they often complained against him.

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In 3:9b–11 the author referred to what the people of Israel did during the whole forty year period when they wandered through the desert. In 3:7–8a he indicates that followers of Jesus must not stubbornly reject what God tells them to do, as the people of Israel did in the desert.

3:11

There are two ways to interpret the way 3:11 connects to 3:10. The connection depends on the interpretation of the word that the BSB translates as “So”:

1. The word “So” indicates that God’s oath was a result of the people’s disobedience (3:8–10). For example:

So I vowed in my anger (REB) (BSB, NIV, REB, GW, NLT, NJB, KJV,)

1. The word “So” implies that the people who disobeyed will not enter God’s rest, just as God said they will not enter it. For example:

As I swore in my wrath (ESV) (NRSV, ESV, NET, NASB)

Several English versions (GNT, CEV, and NCV) do not translate the word “So.” It is recommended that you

follow interpretation (1), along with the majority of English versions and commentaries. With the notable exception of Westcott (page 82), a majority of English commentators follow interpretation (1), including Allen, Bruce, Cockerill, Ellingworth, Lane, Miller, and Montefiore. The Translator’s Handbook (Ellingworth and Nida) also follows this interpretation.

3:11a

So I swore on oath in My anger,

- So I angrily promised,
- Because of that, I became angry, and I spoke these words that cannot change/fail:
- So I angrily took a solemn oath (GW)

3:11b

‘They shall never enter My rest.’”

- ‘They will never come into my rest.’”
- ‘I will never allow these people to have/receive the rest that I offered them.’”
- that they will never obtain my rest.”

3:11a–b

So I swore on oath in My anger, ‘They shall never enter My rest’: The clause So I swore on oath in My anger indicates that God was angry when the people disobeyed him, so he vowed that they would never enter his rest. Some other ways to translate the clause are:

I was angry and made a promise, “They will never enter my rest.” (NCV)

So in my anger I made a vow: “They will never enter my place of rest.” (NLT)

They shall never enter My rest: Here God vowed that those who did not trust and obey him would never receive the type of rest that he wanted to give them. Some ways to translate the meaning in this context are:

They will never receive the rest that I planned to give them.

they certainly will not be able to rest under my care

For information on how to translate rest in this context, refer again to the introduction to Section 3:7–19.

Hebrews 3:12

Section 3:7–19: Warning: Do not reject God’s offer of rest

In the earlier sections of Hebrews the author showed that Jesus was greater than both the angels and Moses. In 2:1–4 he gave a first warning not to refuse the message which Jesus brought. Here in 3:7–19 he gave a second warning not to refuse Jesus’ message, especially the “rest” that God offers through Jesus. The author quoted from Psalm 95, which says that God wanted to give the people of Israel a land where they could have rest from their enemies. When they were slaves in Egypt, he sent Moses to lead them to that land, but they rebelled against God in the wilderness. Then God did not allow them to enter the land of rest.

It is often difficult to decide how to translate “rest” in this section and in chapter 4. Psalm 95 and Hebrews do refer to the time when Moses was alive and God promised to give the people of Israel land. However, King David was already in that land when he wrote the psalm, so the “rest” could not refer to the land. It refers to a different type of “rest.” That rest is a way of trusting God and depending on him for everything. We especially trust him to save us from our sins and give us eternal life. Because of the rest that God gives, we can have peace even when we suffer.

Be careful not to imply that the rest that God promises his people today is a certain place or land. Some scholars believe that the rest refers to heaven. It is true that we will have perfect rest in heaven, but Hebrews indicates that the rest that God provides for us begins on earth when we trust in Jesus.

Some other headings for this section are:

Rest for God’s People

Warning Against Unbelief (NIV)

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Scholars differ about where to end this warning section. Some scholars end the warning at 3:19. Others make the warning section continue to 4:13. In these notes, 3:19 is the end of this second warning section, and the following section is 4:1–13.

Paragraph 3:12–15

In this paragraph the author told his readers and listeners how they should apply the quotation in 3:7b–11 to themselves. Just as God warned the people of Israel to be careful not to turn away from him, the Hebrews

should also be careful. They should not refuse to believe what God said, as the Israelites did.

3:12a

See to it, brothers,

- ¶ Be careful, brothers and sisters, (GW)
- ¶ Fellow members of God’s family, see/beware

See to it: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as See to it is literally just See. In this context it is a warning. It means “be careful,” “watch out.” The author warned his readers not to commit the same sin of unbelief and disobedience that the Israelites committed. Other ways to translate this verb are:

Be careful (GW)

Take care (NRSV)

brothers: As in 3:1a, the Greek word that the BSB translates as brothers refers to the author’s fellow believers in Christ. You should translate it in the same way here. Remember that the term includes both men and women. For more information, see the note on 3:1a.

In some languages it is more natural to place the word brothers first in the sentence or in a different place in the sentence. You should place it where it is most natural for your language. For example:

So brothers and sisters, be careful (NCV)

My friends, watch out! (CEV)

Be careful then, dear brothers and sisters. (NLT)

3:12b

that none of you has a wicked heart of unbelief

- that none of you^(plur) lets his mind/heart become sinful and unfaithful
- that none of you^(plur) develops an evil way of thinking that causes you^(plur) to not believe/trust God,

3:12c

that turns away from the living God.

- so that you^(plur) reject the living God.
- and then you^(plur) refuse to continue following him. He is the One who has/owns life.

3:12b–c

that none of you has a wicked heart of unbelief that turns away from the living God: In this context the word heart represents a person himself. It especially

refers here to a person's decision to believe in and trust God. The phrase a wicked heart of unbelief indicates that it is evil for a person to refuse to trust God.

Some other ways to translate this part of the verse are:

so that none of you has an evil mind that does not believe in God
See the Kankanaey back translation on TW.

in which his inner-being is not focused on his believing/obeying God
See the Tagbanwa back translation on TW.

In other languages it may be more natural to refer to the person himself, rather than to a part of him. For example:

so that no one among you becomes evil and refuses to believe

Don't let evil thoughts or doubts make any of you turn from the living God. (CEV)

you: The pronoun you is plural and refers to all of the readers and hearers of Hebrews.

heart: The word heart refers here to a person's thoughts, feelings and decisions. For more information, see the note on "harden your hearts" in 3:8a.

that turns away from the living God: The phrase turns away from is figurative. It refers to deciding to reject God. It does not literally mean that a person turns himself in a different direction. Use a natural way in your language to refer to deciding to reject someone. For example:

so that none of you turns his back on the living God

that is what will lead you to give up God who is alive without end

that will cause him to reject/refuse the living God

the living God: The phrase the living God implies that God has always been alive, and he will always continue to live. He is the one who gives life. God is a living God, not a dead god. He contrasts with false gods and idols who have no life. The author described God like this also in 9:14, 10:31, and 12:22. Other New

Testament authors also used this description, for example, Matthew 16:16; Romans 9:26; 1 Thessalonians 1:9.

Some other ways to translate the living God are:

God who lives forever

the life-giving God

Hebrews 3:13

Section 3:7-19: Warning: Do not reject God's offer of rest

In the earlier sections of Hebrews the author showed that Jesus was greater than both the angels and Moses. In 2:1-4 he gave a first warning not to refuse the message which Jesus brought. Here in 3:7-19 he gave a second warning not to refuse Jesus' message, especially the "rest" that God offers through Jesus. The author quoted from Psalm 95, which says that God wanted to give the people of Israel a land where they could have rest from their enemies. When they were slaves in Egypt, he sent Moses to lead them to that land, but they rebelled against God in the wilderness. Then God did not allow them to enter the land of rest.

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Paragraph 3:12–15

In this paragraph the author told his readers and listeners how they should apply the quotation in 3:7b–11 to themselves. Just as God warned the people of Israel to be careful not to turn away from him, the Hebrews should also be careful. They should not refuse to believe what God said, as the Israelites did.

3:13a

But exhort one another daily,

- But/Rather caution^(plur) each other every day
- Instead, each day you^(plur) should help/warn one another

But: The word But introduces what believers should do in contrast to what the author warned believers not to do in 3:12. Instead of turning away from God and not believing him, they must encourage each other every day to keep away from sin and unbelief. Some other ways to translate this connection are:

Instead (GNT)

Rather (REB)

In some languages no conjunction is needed. For example:

You must warn each other (NLT)

exhort one another daily: This clause tells what believers should do (in contrast to refusing to trust the Lord in 3:12). Believers should encourage each other to continue to trust in God. The Greek verb which the BSB translates as exhort occurs frequently in the NT. *parakaleō* is a frequent verb in New Testament Greek and has different sets of meanings depending on the context: (1) call for (help), ask, beg; (2) exhort, urge; and (3) encourage, comfort.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

Encourage each other every day (GW)

Every day strengthen/advise each other

In some languages it may not be natural to use a word like “encourage” or exhort when telling people what they should not do. If that is true in your language, use a word that is natural for this context. For example:

You must warn each other every day (NLT)

What you should do daily until our days are used up is to admonish one another Kankanaey back translation on TW.

3:13b

as long as it is called today,

- while it is still what the Scripture calls “Today.”
- while you^(plur) still have the opportunity that God’s book calls “Today,”

as long as it is called today: The clause as long as it is called today is a figure of speech. It refers to this present time period while people still have the opportunity to hear God’s voice and obey him, as the quotation of the psalm in 3:7b said (“Today, if you hear his voice, do not harden your hearts”). When the time ends and they have not obeyed him, God will punish them, as he punished the Israelites who disobeyed him.

This special meaning of the word today is discussed more fully in chapter 4.

Some other ways to translate 3:13b are:

While you are still living in the time that is called “today” Uma back translation on TW.

while you have the opportunity (GW)

3:13c

so that none of you may be hardened by sin’s deceitfulness.

- Do not let sin deceive any of you^(plur) and make you obstinate/stubborn.
- so that you^(plur) will not become deceived/confused by sinning and then refuse to obey God.

so that: The conjunction that the BSB translates as so that introduces the purpose for encouraging one another (3:13a). The purpose of encouraging one another is so that sin will not harden any of the readers.

none of you may be hardened by sin’s deceitfulness: This clause refers back to the quotation in 3:7–11. It is similar to the phrase “Do not harden your hearts” in 3:8a. Here the warning is even more explicit. It indi-

cates that if the people continue to sin, the sin will deceive them and they will not be able to know the truth. The phrase may be hardened indicates that they may become stubborn and refuse to listen to God (as the Israelites did in the wilderness).

Some other ways to translate this purpose clause are:

If you do this, none of you will be deceived by sin and become stubborn. (GW)

so that none of you will be deceived by sin to the point that your hearts cannot understand/obey what God says

you: The pronoun you is plural and refers to all the readers and hearers of Hebrews.

be hardened: The phrase be hardened is a figure of speech. It refers to becoming stubborn and refusing to listen to God. In some languages there may be a figure of speech to describe this. For example:

make your minds numb/insensitive

so that our breaths might not become hard

sin's deceitfulness: The phrase sin's deceitfulness is figurative. It means "sin that deceives." It indicates that when a person sins (especially when he continues to sin for some time), the sins cause him to be unable to understand the truth. He believes what is not true. Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

your sinning causes you to believe lies

you sin and become deceived/confused

Hebrews 3:14

Section 3:7-19: Warning: Do not reject God's offer of rest

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land, but they rebelled against God in the wilderness. Then God did not allow them to enter the land of rest.

It is often difficult to decide how to translate "rest" in this section and in chapter 4. Psalm 95 and Hebrews do refer to the time when Moses was alive and God promised to give the people of Israel land. However, King David was already in that land when he wrote the psalm, so the "rest" could not refer to the land. It refers to a different type of "rest." That rest is a way of trusting God and depending on him for everything. We especially trust him to save us from our sins and give us eternal life. Because of the rest that God gives, we can have peace even when we suffer.

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3:14

Verse 14 is similar to verse 6, both in meaning and in actual words. It is good to consider how you translated verse 6 as you translate verse 14. Below are some of the parallels between the two verses:

Verse 6	Verse 14
We are His house	We have come to share in Christ
Christ	Christ
if	if

confidence	assurance
hold firmly	hold firmly

3:14a**We have come to share in Christ**

- For we^(incl) now share with Christ
- For we^(incl) all share in what our^(incl) Messiah gives/has

The Greek begins this verse with a word that many versions translate as “For.” It introduces the basis for the warning in 3:13. Believers must encourage one another so that we will resist sin, because we have become partners of Christ. Some English versions, including the BSB, leave the connection implied. Show the relationship between these verses in a way that is natural in your language.

We have come to share in Christ: The Greek word that the BSB translates as share was also used in 3:1. The clause We have come to share in Christ means “we all share in the life of Christ himself.” This sharing includes all those who have become believers in him.

Some ways to translate this are:

we share in Christ (RSV)

Because as for us, Christ is our constant companion
Tagbanwa back translation on TW.

We: The pronoun We includes both the author and his readers.

3:14b**if we hold firmly to the end the assurance we had at first.**

- if indeed we^(incl) continue to believe strongly until the end, just as we did at the beginning.
- if we^(incl) remain confident/firm in our initial conviction that Jesus is the Messiah until the end of our lives.

if we hold firmly to the end the assurance we had at first: This clause tells the condition for 3:14a. We continue to share in Christ’s life if we firmly continue to have confidence in him. Some other ways to translate this clause are:

if we are faithful to the end, trusting...just as firmly as when we first believed (NLT)

if we keep till the end the sure faith we had in the beginning (NCV)

The word hold occurred in 3:6c with the same sense as it has here. The author wrote about perseverance at other places in the letter of Hebrews. See, for example, 4:14 and 10:23.

we: The pronoun we is inclusive and refers to the author and his readers and hearers.

to the end: The phrase to the end means “to the end of our lives” or “always.”

the assurance we had at first: The Greek word that the BSB translates as assurance was also used in 1:3, where it referred to God’s “nature” (what he is really like). Here it refers to the reality of the things which the readers strongly believed when they first committed their lives to Jesus. They trusted Jesus himself and they also had confidence in what they were taught about him.

Another way to translate the assurance we had at first is:

trusting God just as firmly as when we first believed (NLT)

our initial conviction that Jesus is the Messiah

the sure faith we had in the beginning (NCV)

General Comment on 3:14a–b

In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of 3:14a and 3:14b. For example:

^{14b}For only if we maintain firmly to the very end the original assurance, ^{14a}then are we sharers of Christ
The Modern Language Bible, The New Berkeley Version, Revised Edition. Grand Rapids: Zondervan, 1969.

Hebrews 3:15**Section 3:7–19: Warning: Do not reject God’s offer of rest**

In the earlier sections of Hebrews the author showed that Jesus was greater than both the angels and Moses. In 2:1–4 he gave a first warning not to refuse the message which Jesus brought. Here in 3:7–19 he gave a second warning not to refuse Jesus’ message, especially the “rest” that God offers through Jesus. The author quoted from Psalm 95, which says that God wanted to give the people of Israel a land where they could have rest from their enemies. When they were slaves in Egypt, he sent Moses to lead them to that

land, but they rebelled against God in the wilderness. Then God did not allow them to enter the land of rest.

It is often difficult to decide how to translate “rest” in this section and in chapter 4. Psalm 95 and Hebrews do refer to the time when Moses was alive and God promised to give the people of Israel land. However, King David was already in that land when he wrote the psalm, so the “rest” could not refer to the land. It refers to a different type of “rest.” That rest is a way of trusting God and depending on him for everything. We especially trust him to save us from our sins and give us eternal life. Because of the rest that God gives, we can have peace even when we suffer.

Be careful not to imply that the rest that God promises his people today is a certain place or land. Some scholars believe that the rest refers to heaven. It is true that we will have perfect rest in heaven, but Hebrews indicates that the rest that God provides for us begins on earth when we trust in Jesus.

Some other headings for this section are:

Rest for God’s People

Warning Against Unbelief (NIV)

We Must Continue to Follow/Obey God

Scholars differ about where to end this warning section. Some scholars end the warning at 3:19. Others make the warning section continue to 4:13. In these notes, 3:19 is the end of this second warning section, and the following section is 4:1–13.

Paragraph 3:12–15

In this paragraph the author told his readers and listeners how they should apply the quotation in 3:7b–11 to themselves. Just as God warned the people of Israel to be careful not to turn away from him, the Hebrews should also be careful. They should not refuse to believe what God said, as the Israelites did.

3:15a

As it has been said:

- Just as the Scripture already quoted said:

As it has been said: The words *As it has been said* is a way to introduce a quotation of Scripture. Here it introduces a verse in Psalm 95 that has already been quoted in 3:7b–8b. The words in the quotation are the same in both Hebrews and the Psalm, but they are introduced in different ways. Some other ways to introduce this scripture are:

As the scripture that was already quoted said

But never forget the warning (NLT96)

Always remember what is written in God’s book:

Introduce the quotation here in a natural way in your language.

3:15b

“Today, if you hear His voice,

- “Today as you^(plur) hear his voice,
- “Listen^(plur) to what God says today:
- “Be^(plur) sure to listen to those words today.

3:15c

do not harden your hearts,

- do^(plur) not become stubborn/disobedient,
- ‘Do^(plur) not reject my words,

3:15d

as you did in the rebellion.”

- as you^(plur) did when you rebelled.”
- as your^(plur) ancestors did when they refused to obey me.”

3:15b–d

Today, if you hear His voice, do not harden your hearts, as you did in the rebellion: Here the author referred back to the quotation in 3:7–11 to emphasize what he was saying. The quotation is exactly the same as the original in 3:7b–8b. It is important to translate it in exactly the same way here.

Hebrews 3:16

Section 3:7–19: Warning: Do not reject God’s offer of rest

In the earlier sections of Hebrews the author showed that Jesus was greater than both the angels and Moses. In 2:1–4 he gave a first warning not to refuse the message which Jesus brought. Here in 3:7–19 he gave a second warning not to refuse Jesus’ message, especially the “rest” that God offers through Jesus. The author quoted from Psalm 95, which says that God wanted to give the people of Israel a land where they could have rest from their enemies. When they were slaves in Egypt, he sent Moses to lead them to that land, but they rebelled against God in the wilderness. Then God did not allow them to enter the land of rest.

It is often difficult to decide how to translate “rest” in this section and in chapter 4. Psalm 95 and Hebrews do refer to the time when Moses was alive and God promised to give the people of Israel land. However,

King David was already in that land when he wrote the psalm, so the “rest” could not refer to the land. It refers to a different type of “rest.” That rest is a way of trusting God and depending on him for everything. We especially trust him to save us from our sins and give us eternal life. Because of the rest that God gives, we can have peace even when we suffer.

Be careful not to imply that the rest that God promises his people today is a certain place or land. Some scholars believe that the rest refers to heaven. It is true that we will have perfect rest in heaven, but Hebrews indicates that the rest that God provides for us begins on earth when we trust in Jesus.

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Paragraph 3:16–19

In 3:16–18, the author asked his readers three rhetorical questions about the quotation from Psalm 95:8–11 (in 3:8–11). In these questions the people of Israel who rebelled against the Lord are an example for the readers of Hebrews. In 3:19 he stated his conclusion: the Lord did not allow the Israelites to enter the land where he planned to give them rest because they did not trust him.

In these verses the author answered his own rhetorical questions with other rhetorical questions. In some languages it is more natural to translate the answers as statements.

3:16

who were the ones who heard and rebelled? Were they not all those Moses led out of Egypt?: Here the author asked two rhetorical questions about the people who were “in the rebellion” (3:15). The second question answers the first question. The questions indicate that the people who heard God’s voice but then rebelled against him were the people whom Moses led out of Egypt.

Some other ways to translate this meaning are:

- Use a rhetorical question and a statement for an answer. For example:

¹⁶Who heard God’s voice and was against him? It was all those people Moses led out of Egypt. (NCV)

Who were the people who heard God’s voice and rebelled against him? All those who were led out of Egypt by Moses.

- Use two statements. For example:

You know who the people are who rejected the word that God spoke. They are the people whom Moses took out of Egypt. Otomi back translation on TW.

Translate the rhetorical questions in a natural way in your language.

3:16a

For who were the ones who heard and rebelled?

- ¶ Which people heard God’s voice but rebelled against him?
- ¶ The people who heard what God said and refused to obey him, who were they?
- ¶ You know who heard God but rebelled against him.

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates literally as For here probably indicates that this verse supports earlier statements that the author has made. It may support the statement in 3:12 about not having an evil, unbelieving heart. Many English versions do not translate the conjunction.

Connect the verse to the context in a natural way in your language. In some languages a connector may not be necessary.

the ones who heard and rebelled: This phrase refers to the people who heard what God said, but they rebelled against him. In some languages it is necessary to make the meaning more explicit. For example:

who heard God’s voice and rebelled against him (GNT)

who rebelled against God, even though they heard his voice (NLT)

3:16b

Were they not all those Moses led out of Egypt?

- It was all the people whom Moses led out of Egypt who rebelled like that.
- They were all the people whom Moses guided out of the country of Egypt.

those Moses led out of Egypt: This phrase refers to all the people of Israel whom Moses led out of captivity in Egypt. The book of Exodus tells this story.

Moses: For more information about Moses, see the note on 3:2b.

Egypt: In some languages where people do not know the country of Egypt, you may need to say “the country of Egypt.”

Hebrews 3:17

Section 3:7–19: Warning: Do not reject God’s offer of rest

In the earlier sections of Hebrews the author showed that Jesus was greater than both the angels and Moses. In 2:1–4 he gave a first warning not to refuse the message which Jesus brought. Here in 3:7–19 he gave a second warning not to refuse Jesus’ message, especially the “rest” that God offers through Jesus. The author quoted from Psalm 95, which says that God wanted to give the people of Israel a land where they could have rest from their enemies. When they were slaves in Egypt, he sent Moses to lead them to that land, but they rebelled against God in the wilderness. Then God did not allow them to enter the land of rest.

It is often difficult to decide how to translate “rest” in this section and in chapter 4. Psalm 95 and Hebrews do refer to the time when Moses was alive and God promised to give the people of Israel land. However, King David was already in that land when he wrote the psalm, so the “rest” could not refer to the land. It refers to a different type of “rest.” That rest is a way of trusting God and depending on him for everything. We especially trust him to save us from our sins and give us eternal life. Because of the rest that God gives, we can have peace even when we suffer.

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In these verses the author answered his own rhetorical questions with other rhetorical questions. In some languages it is more natural to translate the answers as statements.

3:17

And with whom was God angry for forty years? Was it not with those who sinned, whose bodies fell in the wilderness?: In this verse there are another two rhetorical questions about the people who were “in the rebellion” (3:15). As in 3:16, the second question answers the first question. The meaning is that the people who angered God were those who sinned. They were the ones who died in the wilderness because they sinned against God.

Some other ways to translate this meaning are:

- Use a rhetorical question and a statement for an answer. For example:

¹⁷And with whom was God angry for forty years? He was angry with those who sinned, who died in the desert. (NCV)

With whom was God angry for forty years? With the people who sinned, who fell down dead in the desert. (GNT)

- Use two statements. For example:

And you know that these are the people God became angry with because they committed sin during forty years. Therefore all of these people

died there in the desert. Otomi back translation on TW.

Translate the rhetorical questions in a natural way in your language. See Numbers 14:29, 14:32 for an account of this event.

3:17a

And with whom was God angry for forty years?

- Who were the people with whom God was angry for forty years?
- God was angry with those people for forty years

And: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as And introduces a question that has a similar meaning as the one in 3:16. Most English versions have And here or do not use a conjunction. Do what is natural in your language.

with whom was God angry for forty years: This rhetorical question implies that the people angered God many times during the forty years when he was leading them through the wilderness. It does not imply that he held onto his anger over one particular sin for forty years. Translate in a way that will imply the right meaning. For example:

who was he angry with during those forty years?

who was it who angered God repeatedly during forty years?

3:17b

Was it not with those who sinned,

- It was the people who sinned,
- because they sinned against him,

3:17c

whose bodies fell in the wilderness?

- and then they died and their bodies/corpses fell and lay there in the desert.
- so they fell dead in the desert.

3:17b–c

Was it not with those who sinned, whose bodies fell in the wilderness: This part of the verse answers the rhetorical question in 3:17a. It indicates that the people who sinned were the ones who made God angry. Because God was angry with them, he let them die in the wilderness. Some other ways to translate this part of the verse are:

And you know that these are the people God became angry with because they sinned, and they died there in the desert.

They were the same descendants of Israel who sinned against God and because of this, He punished them and they died there in the land where no people live. Western Bukidnon Manobo back translation on TW.

whose bodies fell: The phrase whose bodies fell is figurative. It indicates that the people died. Some other ways to translate it are:

- Use a different figurative expression that has the same meaning in your language. For example:

fell down dead in the desert (GNT)

- Translate the meaning directly. For example:

died in the desert (GW)

Translate the phrase in a natural way in your language.

Hebrews 3:18

Section 3:7–19: Warning: Do not reject God's offer of rest

In the earlier sections of Hebrews the author showed that Jesus was greater than both the angels and Moses. In 2:1–4 he gave a first warning not to refuse the message which Jesus brought. Here in 3:7–19 he gave a second warning not to refuse Jesus' message, especially the "rest" that God offers through Jesus. The author quoted from Psalm 95, which says that God wanted to give the people of Israel a land where they could have rest from their enemies. When they were slaves in Egypt, he sent Moses to lead them to that land, but they rebelled against God in the wilderness. Then God did not allow them to enter the land of rest.

It is often difficult to decide how to translate "rest" in this section and in chapter 4. Psalm 95 and Hebrews do refer to the time when Moses was alive and God promised to give the people of Israel land. However, King David was already in that land when he wrote the psalm, so the "rest" could not refer to the land. It refers to a different type of "rest." That rest is a way of trusting God and depending on him for everything. We especially trust him to save us from our sins and give us eternal life. Because of the rest that God gives, we can have peace even when we suffer.

Be careful not to imply that the rest that God promises his people today is a certain place or land. Some scholars believe that the rest refers to heaven. It is true that we will have perfect rest in heaven, but Hebrews indicates that the rest that God provides for us begins on earth when we trust in Jesus.

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In 3:16–18, the author asked his readers three rhetorical questions about the quotation from Psalm 95:8–11 (in 3:8–11). In these questions the people of Israel who rebelled against the Lord are an example for the readers of Hebrews. In 3:19 he stated his conclusion: the Lord did not allow the Israelites to enter the land where he planned to give them rest because they did not trust him.

In these verses the author answered his own rhetorical questions with other rhetorical questions. In some languages it is more natural to translate the answers as statements.

3:18c

Was it not to those who disobeyed?

- It is obvious that he said it to the people who disobeyed him.
- You^(plur) know that he said it to the people who refused to obey him.

3:18

And to whom did He swear that they would never enter His rest? Was it not to those who disobeyed?:

This verse is one rhetorical question, which has another rhetorical question within it. It means that God swore to the people who disobeyed him that they would not enter his rest.

Some other ways to translate this meaning are:

- Use one or two rhetorical questions. For example:

To whom did God swear that they would not enter his rest? Wasn't it to those who disobeyed him?

- Use one rhetorical question and a statement for an answer. For example:

¹⁸And to whom was God speaking when he vowed that they would never enter his place of rest? He was speaking to those who disobeyed him. (NCV)

When God made his solemn promise, "They will never enter the land where I would have given them rest"—of whom was he speaking? Of those who rebelled. (GNT)

- Use two statements. For example:

And you know that these are the people God became angry with because they committed sin during forty years. Therefore all of these people died there in the desert. Otomi back translation on TW.

Translate the rhetorical question in a natural way in your language.

3:18a

And to whom did He swear that

- And who were the ones to whom God said with an oath:
- You^(plur) know those people about whom God made a solemn promise

3:18b

they would never enter His rest?

- "You^(plur) will never enter my resting place"?
- that they would never come to live in the place/land that he prepared for them to rest.

3:18a–b

And to whom did He swear that they would never enter His rest?: This question indicates that God swore to certain people that they would never enter his rest. This event was mentioned in 3:11: "So I swore on oath in My anger, 'They shall never enter My rest.'" (BSB)

In some languages it may be more natural to translate what God swore in direct speech. For example:

To whom did he swear, saying, "Now you will never enter the land that I wanted you to have as a place to rest with me?"

swear: The word swear means to take an oath or make a binding promise. In Hebrew culture, such a promise must not be broken. Here God's promise implied that he would certainly do what he said. What he said would certainly happen.

You may be able to use the same phrase that you used in 3:11.

that they would never enter His rest: The phrase His rest refers here to the life of dependence on God that God wanted his people to live. He wanted them to depend on him and trust him for everything.

See the note on 3:11a–b. It is important to use the word rest here because the author is going to write more about rest in chapter 4.

Hebrews 3:19

Section 3:7–19: Warning: Do not reject God's offer of rest

In the earlier sections of Hebrews the author showed that Jesus was greater than both the angels and Moses. In 2:1–4 he gave a first warning not to refuse the message which Jesus brought. Here in 3:7–19 he gave a second warning not to refuse Jesus' message, especially the "rest" that God offers through Jesus. The author quoted from Psalm 95, which says that God wanted to give the people of Israel a land where they could have rest from their enemies. When they were slaves in Egypt, he sent Moses to lead them to that land, but they rebelled against God in the wilderness. Then God did not allow them to enter the land of rest.

It is often difficult to decide how to translate "rest" in this section and in chapter 4. Psalm 95 and Hebrews do refer to the time when Moses was alive and God promised to give the people of Israel land. However, King David was already in that land when he wrote the psalm, so the "rest" could not refer to the land. It refers to a different type of "rest." That rest is a way of trusting God and depending on him for everything. We especially trust him to save us from our sins and give us eternal life. Because of the rest that God gives, we can have peace even when we suffer.

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Paragraph 3:16–19

In 3:16–18, the author asked his readers three rhetorical questions about the quotation from Psalm 95:8–11 (in 3:8–11). In these questions the people of Israel who rebelled against the Lord are an example for the readers of Hebrews. In 3:19 he stated his conclusion: the Lord did not allow the Israelites to enter the land where he planned to give them rest because they did not trust him.

In these verses the author answered his own rhetorical questions with other rhetorical questions. In some languages it is more natural to translate the answers as statements.

3:19a

So we see that it was

- So, we^(incl) know that
- Therefore we^(incl) can understand clearly that
- So it is obvious that

3:19b

because of their unbelief

- because they did not believe/trust God,
- because they refused to trust him,
- since they would not believe what God said,

3:19c

that they were unable to enter.

- they could not enter it.
- God did not enable/allow them to come into the rest.
- they were not able to enter.

3:19a–c

So we see that: The phrase So we see that introduces the conclusion of what the author said in 3:7–18. It indicates that the author is about to tell the Hebrews what they should learn and know from what he said in those verses. Some ways to introduce this conclusion are:

So we clearly know that...

From all this we learn that...

Introduce this conclusion in a natural way in your language.

we: The word we includes both the author and his hearers. However, it is used here as a natural way to introduce a conclusion. In some languages it may be more natural to introduce the conclusion without using we. For example:

Thus it is seen here that...

see: Here the verb see is used in a figurative way to mean “understand, know, learn.” Use a natural verb in your language to introduce the conclusion in this context.

it was because of their unbelief that they were unable to enter: The phrase because of their unbelief tells the reason that the people were unable to enter God’s rest. God did not allow them to enter his rest because they did not believe him. Some other ways to translate the clause are:

^{19b}they couldn’t receive that rest ^{19c}because they did not believe

¹⁹the reason they were unable to enter the resting place God had prepared, it was their not believing in him
Kankanaey back translation on TW.

In some languages it is more natural to put the result of not being able to enter God’s rest before the reason (their unbelief). For example:

^{19c}they were unable to enter ^{19b}because of unbelief (NRSV)

^{19c}they were not able to enter God’s rest. ^{19b}That is because they refused to trust God.

they could not enter for lack of faith (NABRE)

Use a natural order in your language.

because of their unbelief: In 3:18 the sin of the Israelites was called disobedience. Here the author called it unbelief. Disobedience and unbelief are very closely connected.

In some languages it may be more natural to use a verb rather than a noun like unbelief. One way to express this meaning as a verb is:

because they did not believe

they were unable to enter: The words unable to enter refer back to the phrase “enter his rest” in 3:18. It is clear from the historical context that “his rest” refers here to Canaan, the country that God promised the Israelites.

In some languages, it may be necessary to say where the people of Israel were unable to enter. If that is true in your language, you should supply a phrase that will agree with how you translated 3:18. For example:

they were not able to enter God’s rest

Hebrews 4:1

Section 4:1–13: We must have faith in God and enter his rest

The word “rest” is used in 4:1, and it is the important topic that connects chapter 4 to chapter 3. It is the link between chapters 3 and 4, just as 2:1 was the link between chapter 1 and chapter 2, and 3:1 was a link between chapter 2 and chapter 3. The author used the word “rest” in a figurative way to refer to depending on God. God wants his people to rest from their own work, as God rested from his work on the seventh day after he created the world. In chapter 3, God promised the people of Israel a place to rest. In chapter 4, the author used a special time of rest as a symbol. This time was one day each week, which the people called the Sabbath Day (seventh day). Both the place and the time of rest are symbols of the rest that God’s people have when they depend on him for everything.

Two sentences in this section are especially important in stating this theme:

4:9	There remains, then, a Sabbath rest for the people of God. (BSB)
4:11	Let us, therefore, make every effort to enter that rest, (BSB)

The theme of this section is clear: God has planned a good life of rest for believers when they depend on him. We must be careful to believe and obey him so that we do not miss the life of rest that he promised. Some words that are connected to this theme in chapters 3 and 4 are “faith,” “believe,” “unbelief,” and “disobedience.”

Some other examples of headings for this section are:

God’s people can still experience God’s rest

We should trust God and receive his promise of rest

Paragraph 4:1–5

At the end of chapter 3, the author indicated that the people of Israel whom God led out of Egypt refused to enter his rest (3:19). Chapter 4 begins by saying that God still offers that rest to people who believe him (4:1a). Connect chapter 4 with chapter 3 in a natural way in your language. Notice the examples in the note on “Therefore” in 4:1a.

4:1a

Therefore, while the promise of entering His rest still stands,

- ¶ So while God still offers his promise about entering/receiving his rest,
- ¶ Now what God promised about giving his people rest can still be fulfilled for us^(incl). Therefore,

Therefore: The word Therefore introduces the warning in the next part of the verse (4:1b). In some languages it is necessary to put the introductory word or phrase at the beginning of 4:1b to make the connections clearer. For example:

But God’s promise that he has prepared a resting place for his people can still be fulfilled to us.
^{1b}Therefore...

God’s promise of entering his rest still stands,
^{1b}so... (NLT)

while the promise of entering His rest still stands:

The phrase the promise...still stands is a figure of speech. It indicates that God still promises to give rest to his people who believe and obey him. When the people of Israel refused his rest, he did not take away his promise to give rest to the people who were willing to receive it.

Some other ways to translate this meaning are:

And now, God still offers his promise that we may enter his rest

God’s promise to give his people rest can still be fulfilled to us

Languages have many ways to indicate that a promise made in the past is still valid, and it can still be fulfilled. Use a natural way in your language to translate that meaning.

the promise: A promise tells a person’s intention to do something. It indicates that the person must do what he has said. Here the promise refers to what God said about his rest. He promised to welcome people into his rest if they believe. A promise is different from an oath, so you should use different ways to translate these two words.

entering His rest: The phrase entering His rest is used as a figure of speech here. It means to begin to rest as God promised. This promise does not refer here to the land where God promised to give the people rest from their enemies. The rest that God now offers his people is a life of depending on him for everything we need.

In some languages it is not natural to speak of entering rest. Some other ways to translate the meaning are:

receive that rest (GNT)

can be included in being able to rest under his care
Tagbanwa back translation on TW.

His rest: The word rest is the theme of this section. It should be translated in the same way throughout the section. The phrase His rest symbolizes dependence on God, especially for salvation and also for everything that he has promised his people.

A minority of scholars believe that His rest may refer to heaven. It is not recommended that you follow this interpretation or make it explicit in your translation.

still stands: The Greek word that the BSB translates as still stands refers here to a promise that is still valid. See *καταλείπω*, meaning 4, BDAG, page 521. The word refers here to a promise that is still in force. People can still benefit from the promise. In this context, it indicates that God still makes his promise of rest available to people who will receive it. Some other ways to translate the meaning are:

is still good/valid

continues to be offered

4:1b

let us be careful that none of you be deemed to have fallen short of it.

- let us be careful that none of us^(incl) will fail to obtain/receive it.
- we^(incl) must not neglect to receive it. If we do, someone among you^(plur) may miss the opportunity.

let us be careful: The Greek command which the BSB translates as let us be careful is more literally “we should fear.” It is interesting that the author of Hebrews is the only New Testament author to use the corresponding adjective phoberos, “fearful, terrible” in connection with God and his judgment. For other examples, see 10:27, 10:31 and 12:21. It means that we should be afraid that we might not enter God’s rest. The word “fear” implies that failure to enter God’s rest is terrible. That is why we must be careful to enter his rest.

Some other ways to translate this command are:

we must be very careful

we ought to tremble with fear (NLT)

Beware! (NJB)

Translate this command in a way that is natural in your language.

that none of you be deemed to have fallen short of it: There are different ways to interpret the phrase that the BSB translates as be deemed to have fallen short of it:

1. It means “fail to receive it.” For example:

might fail to experience it (NLT)

will fail to enter (NCV) (NLT, NCV, NRSV, KJV, NASB, ESV, JBP, NET)

1. It means “will be judged/considered (by God) to have failed to receive it.” For example:

will be found to have failed to receive that promised rest (GNT)

be judged to have failed to receive it (RSV) (BSB, NIV, GNT, RSV, REB)

1. It means “thinks that they will not attain it.” For example:

think you won’t enter his place of rest (GW) (GW, NJB) The NJB has “think you have come too late.” This wording seems to give a slightly different sense from either of the two main interpretations. It may be following interpretation (2) in

“seems to have failed,” but it is at least more specific in saying that coming “too late” is the possible reason for failure.)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Interpretations (1) and (2) are similar, but interpretation (1) is more general. It is possible that interpretation (2) implies that God is the one who will judge someone to have failed. However, no English version supplies “God,” and a phrase like “to be found to have failed” is not a clear reference to him. It is also followed by more English versions and many commentaries. Interpretation (2) fits the context of serious warning. Ellis Diebler (SSA of Hebrews, prepublication copy, page 16) points out that this interpretation “fits the theme of the whole book much better: Hebrews is not an encouragement but a series of strong warnings.” Miller (page 100) also takes this view, saying that it “fits well with the analogy being drawn from the experience of the children of Israel in the wilderness generation. Their repeated rebellion stirred God to anger and brought on an oath excluding them from the promised rest of God. They continued to exist until they died along the way, but there was no more possibility of entering. They were judged to have failed to enter. They were considered as having been already excluded.” but no English version makes it explicit.

none of you be deemed to have fallen short of it: This clause indicates that the author wanted every one of his hearers to receive the rest that God offers. He implied that it is a serious matter if anyone fails to believe God and then is not able to enjoy the rest that God promised.

Some other ways to translate this meaning are:

that some of you might fail to experience it (NLT)

that perhaps someone will not be included in that rest

you: The pronoun you is plural and refers to all the people who hear or read what the author said to them in Hebrews.

to have fallen short of it: The phrase to have fallen short of it means “to fail to gain or experience something because of one’s own fault.” ὑστερέω meaning 1, BDAG, page 1043, has “to miss out on something through one’s own fault, to miss, fail to reach.” The word it refers to God’s rest. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

to have failed to receive that promised rest (GNT)

who is not able to enter/attain it

General Comment on 4:1a–b

In some languages it may be more natural to use more than one sentence to translate this verse. For example:

Beware! God still promises that we may enter his rest. So each of you must make sure to gain/receive it.

Hebrews 4:2

Section 4:1–13: We must have faith in God and enter his rest

The word “rest” is used in 4:1, and it is the important topic that connects chapter 4 to chapter 3. It is the link between chapters 3 and 4, just as 2:1 was the link between chapter 1 and chapter 2, and 3:1 was a link between chapter 2 and chapter 3. The author used the word “rest” in a figurative way to refer to depending on God. God wants his people to rest from their own work, as God rested from his work on the seventh day after he created the world. In chapter 3, God promised the people of Israel a place to rest. In chapter 4, the author used a special time of rest as a symbol. This time was one day each week, which the people called the Sabbath Day (seventh day). Both the place and the time of rest are symbols of the rest that God’s people have when they depend on him for everything.

Two sentences in this section are especially important in stating this theme:

4:9	There remains, then, a Sabbath rest for the people of God. (BSB)
4:11	Let us, therefore, make every effort to enter that rest, (BSB)

The theme of this section is clear: God has planned a good life of rest for believers when they depend on him. We must be careful to believe and obey him so that we do not miss the life of rest that he promised. Some words that are connected to this theme in chapters 3 and 4 are “faith,” “believe,” “unbelief,” and “disobedience.”

Some other examples of headings for this section are:

God’s people can still experience God’s rest

We should trust God and receive his promise of rest

Paragraph 4:1–5

At the end of chapter 3, the author indicated that the people of Israel whom God led out of Egypt refused to enter his rest (3:19). Chapter 4 begins by saying that God still offers that rest to people who believe him (4:1a). Connect chapter 4 with chapter 3 in a natural way in your language. Notice the examples in the note on “Therefore” in 4:1a.

4:2

The BSB translates 4:2a–c as one sentence. In some languages it is more natural to use more than one sentence. For example:

We heard the good news, as our ancestors did. But the message did not help our ancestors because they did not join those who accepted it with faith.

4:2a

For we also received the good news just as they did;

- For good news has been proclaimed/told to us^(incl), just as it was to them,
- For we^(incl), too, heard that good news, as our ancestors did.

For...also: This part of the verse begins with two Greek conjunctions that the BSB translates literally as For and also. Some versions translate also as “indeed” here, because it emphasizes the statement in 4:2a. The word For indicates that 4:2c will explain why the good news did not help the Israelites who heard it (as 4:2b says). Connect the clauses in this verse in a natural way in your language.

we...received the good news just as they did: The Greek phrase which the BSB translates as we...received the good news just as they did is more literally “we were evangelized.” It uses a passive verb form, implying that someone told the listeners good news.

In this context the good news refers to the promise of rest that God offers his people. It does not refer specifically here to the gospel of salvation through Jesus’ death and resurrection. The phrase just as they did indicates that the Israelites whom Moses led out of Egypt (3:16) were also told good news.

Some ways to translate the phrases in 4:2a are:

- Use passive verbs. For example:

The good news was told to us, just as it was told to them

- Use verbs that focus on receiving the good news. For example:

We received the good news just as they did.

We have heard the good news just as they have.

- Use active verbs and supply subjects. For example:

Someone told us the good news, just as someone told the good news to them.

Translate the verbs in a natural way in your language. A different form of the same verb is used again in 4:6.

we: The pronoun we refers to both the author and the readers.

just as they did: The phrase just as they did indicates that the readers and hearers of Hebrews received good news, just as the Israel people whom “Moses led out of Egypt” (3:16) also received good news. In some languages it may be helpful to refer to them more specifically. For example:

our ancestors

those Israel people of long ago

Refer back to them in a natural way in your language.

4:2b

but the message they heard was of no value to them,

- but what they heard did not benefit/help them,
- But although they heard the message, it did not help them at all,

but: The word but introduces a contrast. Both the readers of this letter and their ancestors received good news, but their ancestors failed to profit from the good news.

the message they heard was of no value to them: This clause indicates that hearing the message without believing it did not help the people of Israel. Some ways to translate this meaning are:

they listened to the message but they received no help from it

They heard his word but they gained nothing from hearing it

the message they heard: The phrase the message they heard refers to the good news that was told to the people of Israel (4:2a). It was God’s promise that he would give them rest in the land to which he was leading them. Indicate clearly that the message and the “good news” refer to the same message. For example:

this message that they heard

that good news that they heard

4:2c

since they did not share the faith of those who comprehended it.

- because they did not believe it and join/unite with the others who accepted it.
- since they did not accept/share the faith of those who believed it.

since: The word since introduces the reason that God’s message did not benefit the people of Israel.

they did not share the faith of those who comprehended it: There is a textual issue concerning the word that the BSB translates as share. The form of this word causes scholars to interpret 4:2c in different ways. The two textual options are:

1. In some Greek manuscripts the verb share is plural. The clause indicates that the people who did not enter God’s rest (3:19) did not “join” with the people who listened to what God said. For example:

they did not share the faith of those who did listen (NJB) (BSB, NRSV, NJB, ESV, NASB, NET, NLT, NIV)

1. In other Greek manuscripts the word share is singular. The clause indicates that the message was heard but was not combined with faith in some people. For example:

it was not combined with faith in those who heard it (REB) (GNT, JBP, REB, NCV, CEV, NIV84)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). It is followed by many Greek manuscripts, including some of the oldest and most reliable ones. Metzger (2nd Edition, page 595) says about this textual issue, “Among the bewildering variety of readings preserved among the manuscripts...the one that best explains the origin of the others is [this one]...Supported by early and

diverse testimony representing both the Alexandrian and the Western types of text..., as the most difficult reading it would naturally have been altered to the easier nominative singular.” However, many scholars also support option (2), and it is also acceptable.

Since both options are acceptable, you may want to include a footnote in your translation to mention the option that you decide not to follow. For example, the NRSV has this footnote:

Other ancient authorities read: “it did not meet with faith in those who listened.”

did not share the faith of those who comprehended it: This phrase refers to the time when most of the people of Israel did not believe the good news that God told them. He promised to give them rest in the land of Canaan. However, only Moses, Joshua, and Caleb trusted God to do what he said. The phrase did not share the faith indicates that most of the people refused to join the ones who listened to God and believed him.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

they did not join in with those who heard it in faith (NET)

they refused to unite with the ones who believed that good message

faith: In this context the word faith refers to believing the message that God was able to give the people rest in the land that he promised them. The people of Israel did not believe that this message was true. See the examples in the preceding note. For more information, see believe, sense C2, in KBT.

General Comment on 4:2b–c

In some languages it may be helpful to change the order of 4:2b–c. For example:

^{2c}They, however, did not believe the good news that they heard, ^{2b}and so it did not help them.

^{2c}but they did not believe the good news which they heard, ^{2b}and so it was not of any use to them

Hebrews 4:3

Section 4:1–13: We must have faith in God and enter his rest

The word “rest” is used in 4:1, and it is the important topic that connects chapter 4 to chapter 3. It is the link between chapters 3 and 4, just as 2:1 was the link between chapter 1 and chapter 2, and 3:1 was a link between chapter 2 and chapter 3. The author used the word “rest” in a figurative way to refer to depending on God. God wants his people to rest from their own work, as God rested from his work on the seventh day after he created the world. In chapter 3, God promised the people of Israel a place to rest. In chapter 4, the author used a special time of rest as a symbol. This time was one day each week, which the people called the Sabbath Day (seventh day). Both the place and the time of rest are symbols of the rest that God’s people have when they depend on him for everything.

Two sentences in this section are especially important in stating this theme:

4:9	There remains, then, a Sabbath rest for the people of God. (BSB)
4:11	Let us, therefore, make every effort to enter that rest, (BSB)

The theme of this section is clear: God has planned a good life of rest for believers when they depend on him. We must be careful to believe and obey him so that we do not miss the life of rest that he promised. Some words that are connected to this theme in chapters 3 and 4 are “faith,” “believe,” “unbelief,” and “disobedience.”

Some other examples of headings for this section are:

God’s people can still experience God’s rest

We should trust God and receive his promise of rest

Paragraph 4:1–5

At the end of chapter 3, the author indicated that the people of Israel whom God led out of Egypt refused to enter his rest (3:19). Chapter 4 begins by saying that God still offers that rest to people who believe him (4:1a). Connect chapter 4 with chapter 3 in a natural way in your language. Notice the examples in the note on “Therefore” in 4:1a.

4:3a

Now we who have believed enter that rest.

- We^(incl) who believe it are the ones who enter/receive that rest.
- And we know that only we^(incl) who believe that message receive/obtain God's rest.

Now we who have believed enter that rest: The word Now introduces an explanation of what the author said in 4:2. The Greek logical connective *gar* (often translated as “for/because”) is not always used to introduce the reason for a preceding statement. It often functions as a more general explanatory link, marking a progression to the next point in the discussion or argument. When *gar* has this function, the BSB sometimes translates it but sometimes leaves it untranslated, as in 5:1 and 7:1. It also introduces a contrast. We who have believed contrasts with the people who did not believe what God promised. They could not enter God's rest. Instead, we who have believed are the ones who enter the rest that he promised.

Some ways to translate this explanation and contrast are:

For only we who believe can enter his rest. (NLT)

It is only we who believe who will enter that resting-place. Kankanaey back translation on TW.

But as for us, because we believed the word that God spoke, now we are able to enter the rest.

we who have believed: The pronoun we includes the author and everyone who believes the good news (4:2a), which is the message (4:2b) about the promise of entering his rest (4:1a). The word believed is used in the same sense as “faith” in 4:2, and the Greek words are closely related.

In some languages it is necessary to indicate what is believed. In this context they believed the good news that they heard in 4:2. Some ways to refer back to it are:

we who believed it

we who believe the message

we who have trusted/accepted the good news

Remember that the “message” and the “good news” in 4:2 referred to what Joshua, Caleb, and Moses told the people. They told the people that God was able to give them rest, just as he promised them. In 4:3 we

also believe the good news that God still offers rest to us, and he is able to give us that rest.

enter that rest: There is a textual variant here. Most Greek texts have “the rest.” Some texts omit “the.” Among English versions, only the KJV omits “the.” The difference seems to be more a matter of form than a meaning difference. The phrase enter that rest has the same meaning as “entering his rest” in 4:1. Translate it in a similar way here.

4:3b

As for the others, it is just as God has said:

- This agrees with what God said in the Scripture:
- It is just as God said about those who did not believe,

just as God has said: In this part of the verse, the author spoke again about the people who did not believe God. The phrase just as God has said introduces what God said about them. In many languages it may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

As for those who didn't believe, God said (NLT)

This agrees with what God said in the Scripture about those who did not believe him:

Translate the connection in a natural way in your language.

4:3c

“So I swore on oath in My anger,

- “So I angrily promised,
- “Because of that, I became angry, and spoke these words that cannot change/fail:

4:3d

‘They shall never enter My rest.’”

- ‘They will never come into my rest.’”
- ‘These people will never receive/obtain the rest that I promised them.’”

4:3c–d

So I swore on oath in My anger, ‘They shall never enter My rest’: These words from Psalm 95:11 were quoted in 3:11. You should translate them exactly as you did there.

4:3e

And yet His works have been finished

- And yet God completed/finished his work and provided a time of rest
- He said this even though he finished making everything

4:3f
since the foundation of the world.

- as soon as he created the world.
- at the time when he created the world.

4:3e-f
And yet His works have been finished since the foundation of the world: The word yet implies that the clause in 4:3e-f tells an unexpected fact. The clause indicates that when God finished creating the world, his work was done (and he rested). It implies that at that time, he also provided rest for his people. However, the people whom he led out of Egypt will never enjoy that rest (4:3a-d).

Some other ways to translate this unexpected fact are:

Yet from when God created the world, he has been resting.

But God’s work was finished from the time he made the world.

even though this rest has been ready since he made the world (NLT)

since the foundation of the world: The phrase since the foundation of the world refers to the time when God created the world (and everything in it). Then he rested. God’s “work” came before his “rest.” He finished his work of creating the world a long time before the people of Israel made their journey to Egypt.

In some languages it is more natural to translate foundation (“creation”) as a verb. For example:

the time he created the world (GNT)

when he created everything

Hebrews 4:4

Section 4:1–13: We must have faith in God and enter his rest

The word “rest” is used in 4:1, and it is the important topic that connects chapter 4 to chapter 3. It is the link between chapters 3 and 4, just as 2:1 was the link between chapter 1 and chapter 2, and 3:1 was a link between chapter 2 and chapter 3. The author used the word “rest” in a figurative way to refer to depending on God. God wants his people to rest from their own work, as God rested from his work on the seventh day after he created the world. In chapter 3, God promised

the people of Israel a place to rest. In chapter 4, the author used a special time of rest as a symbol. This time was one day each week, which the people called the Sabbath Day (seventh day). Both the place and the time of rest are symbols of the rest that God’s people have when they depend on him for everything.

Two sentences in this section are especially important in stating this theme:

4:9	There remains, then, a Sabbath rest for the people of God. (BSB)
4:11	Let us, therefore, make every effort to enter that rest, (BSB)

The theme of this section is clear: God has planned a good life of rest for believers when they depend on him. We must be careful to believe and obey him so that we do not miss the life of rest that he promised. Some words that are connected to this theme in chapters 3 and 4 are “faith,” “believe,” “unbelief,” and “disobedience.”

Some other examples of headings for this section are:

God’s people can still experience God’s rest

We should trust God and receive his promise of rest

Paragraph 4:1–5

At the end of chapter 3, the author indicated that the people of Israel whom God led out of Egypt refused to enter his rest (3:19). Chapter 4 begins by saying that God still offers that rest to people who believe him (4:1a). Connect chapter 4 with chapter 3 in a natural way in your language. Notice the examples in the note on “Therefore” in 4:1a.

4:4a
For somewhere He has spoken about the seventh day in this manner:

- Somewhere in Scripture God has spoken about the seventh day like this:
- There is a Scripture which says this about the seventh day:

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For introduces the basis for the author’s comment in 4:3e-f. Another way to introduce this basis is:

We know that because

Connect this basis to 4:3 in a natural way in your language.

somewhere He has spoken...in this manner: The phrase somewhere He has spoken...in this manner introduces a quotation. The word somewhere refers to a part of the Scripture. The author used a similar reference to Scripture in 2:6a, which the BSB translates literally as “somewhere it is testified in these words.”

Some other ways to introduce this quotation are:

somewhere in the Scriptures this is said (GNT)

in God’s Word/Book it tells/says

In some languages it is more natural to use indirect speech for this verse. For example:

In fact, somewhere the Scriptures say that... (CEV)

Use a natural way in your language to introduce a quotation from the Scriptures.

about the seventh day: The phrase about the seventh day refers to the seventh day after God began to create the world. In some languages it may be necessary to make this phrase more explicit.

Some other ways to translate the phrase about the seventh day are:

what God did on the seventh day
Otomi back translation on TW.

the seventh day after he began to create the world

4:4b

“And on the seventh day God rested from all His works.”

- “God rested on the seventh day after finishing his work of creating everything.”
- “God finished all his work, so/and he rested on the seventh day after he began to create the world.”

And on the seventh day God rested from all His works: This clause is a quotation from Genesis 2:2b. The author used this quotation to support what he said in 4:3e–f. It indicates that on the seventh day, after God created everything, he rested.

Some other ways to translate this quotation are:

On the seventh day God rested/stopped from all his work.
Uma back translation on TW.

It says that God rested on the seventh day, having finished the work that he had done.

on the seventh day God rested: The phrase on the seventh day God rested contrasts with the first six days, when God was creating everything. When he finished this work of creating, he rested on the seventh day. Notice that the seventh day was also mentioned in the phrase “about the seventh day” in 4:4a.

from all His works: The phrase from all His works indicates that God rested after he finished all the work of making the universe and everything in it.

Hebrews 4:5

Section 4:1–13: We must have faith in God and enter his rest

The word “rest” is used in 4:1, and it is the important topic that connects chapter 4 to chapter 3. It is the link between chapters 3 and 4, just as 2:1 was the link between chapter 1 and chapter 2, and 3:1 was a link between chapter 2 and chapter 3. The author used the word “rest” in a figurative way to refer to depending on God. God wants his people to rest from their own work, as God rested from his work on the seventh day after he created the world. In chapter 3, God promised the people of Israel a place to rest. In chapter 4, the author used a special time of rest as a symbol. This time was one day each week, which the people called the Sabbath Day (seventh day). Both the place and the time of rest are symbols of the rest that God’s people have when they depend on him for everything.

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4:9	There remains, then, a Sabbath rest for the people of God. (BSB)
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The theme of this section is clear: God has planned a good life of rest for believers when they depend on him. We must be careful to believe and obey him so that we do not miss the life of rest that he promised. Some words that are connected to this theme in chapters 3 and 4 are “faith,” “believe,” “unbelief,” and “disobedience.”

Some other examples of headings for this section are:

God’s people can still experience God’s rest

We should trust God and receive his promise of rest

Paragraph 4:1–5

At the end of chapter 3, the author indicated that the people of Israel whom God led out of Egypt refused to enter his rest (3:19). Chapter 4 begins by saying that God still offers that rest to people who believe him (4:1a). Connect chapter 4 with chapter 3 in a natural way in your language. Notice the examples in the note on “Therefore” in 4:1a.

4:5a
And again, as He says in the passage above:

- Also, the Scripture already mentioned says,
- He also already mentioned

And again, as He says in the passage above: The phrase And again introduces another quotation from the Scriptures. The author already quoted this Scripture in 3:11 and in 4:3. The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as in the passage above is literally “that place.” The author was referring to the same quotation that he used in 4:3.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

but to repeat the verse that was quoted earlier:

This same matter is spoken of again: (GNT)

4:5b
“They shall never enter My rest.”

- ‘They will never come into my rest.’”
- the people who will not get to rest with him. He said, ‘These people will never receive/obtain the rest that I offered them.’”

They shall never enter My rest: Here the author repeats the same verse that he just quoted in 4:3c–d. Because it is an exact repetition, you should translate it here in the same way as you did there.

Hebrews 4:6

Section 4:1–13: We must have faith in God and enter his rest

The word “rest” is used in 4:1, and it is the important topic that connects chapter 4 to chapter 3. It is the link between chapters 3 and 4, just as 2:1 was the link between chapter 1 and chapter 2, and 3:1 was a link between chapter 2 and chapter 3. The author used the

word “rest” in a figurative way to refer to depending on God. God wants his people to rest from their own work, as God rested from his work on the seventh day after he created the world. In chapter 3, God promised the people of Israel a place to rest. In chapter 4, the author used a special time of rest as a symbol. This time was one day each week, which the people called the Sabbath Day (seventh day). Both the place and the time of rest are symbols of the rest that God’s people have when they depend on him for everything.

Two sentences in this section are especially important in stating this theme:

4:9	There remains, then, a Sabbath rest for the people of God. (BSB)
4:11	Let us, therefore, make every effort to enter that rest, (BSB)

The theme of this section is clear: God has planned a good life of rest for believers when they depend on him. We must be careful to believe and obey him so that we do not miss the life of rest that he promised. Some words that are connected to this theme in chapters 3 and 4 are “faith,” “believe,” “unbelief,” and “disobedience.”

Some other examples of headings for this section are:

God’s people can still experience God’s rest

We should trust God and receive his promise of rest

Paragraph 4:6–8

It is important to notice that the clauses in this paragraph are closely connected. However, the author did not always talk about events in the order in which they happened. In the Greek text, verses 4:6–7 are one long sentence, which begins with two connecting words, epei oun, “since therefore.” “Therefore” (oun) indicates that the following statement is a conclusion of the previous argument. “Since” (epei) indicates that statement is a reason for the following statement. These two connecting words also occurred in 2:14, and oun occurred again in 4:1. The RSV and the BSB reflect the structure of this long sentence exactly. The NIV omits both connectives. In some languages it is more natural to use a different order. For examples, see the General Comment on 4:6b–8b at the end of 4:8b.

4:6a
Since, then, it remains for some to enter His rest,

- ¶ All this shows that it is still possible for some other people to enter that rest.
- ¶ These words teach that God now invites other people to receive/obtain the rest that he promised.

Since, then: In this verse the author repeats the two facts in 4:5. He gives them as the basis for his conclusion in 4:7. In many languages it is more natural to have a word like then at the beginning of 4:7, rather than here in 4:6.

The word Since implies that the facts were already mentioned (in 4:5), and the author is about to repeat them. In some languages it may be natural to leave the connection implied. Some other ways to introduce the facts in 4:6 are:

So we learned from this that...

All this teaches/implies that...

So/Now we see/understand that

Make these connections clear in your language.

it remains for some to enter His rest: This statement tells what the first scripture in 4:4 teaches people. That scripture says that God rested on the seventh day. By that statement, God implied that his people may also rest. See the notes on 4:1a for more advice about how to translate this statement.

Some other ways to translate the meaning are:

it is still allowed/possible for others to enter that rest

now God gives others the opportunity to enjoy that rest

4:6b

and since those who formerly heard the good news

- It also shows that the other people who heard the gospel which was preached to them in the past
- They also teach that the people who listened to the good news in past times

4:6b-c

and: The word and introduces the second reason why God set another time for people to enter his rest. That second reason contrasts with 4:6a, so some versions indicate that contrast with a word like “but.” Introduce this reason in a natural way in your language.

those who formerly heard the good news: The phrase those who formerly heard the good news is more literally “those-who at a previous time were-evangelized.” It uses the same passive verb (“were evangelized”) that was used in 4:2. You should translate it in a similar way here. For example:

those who earlier heard/received the good news

those who were told that good message in the past

formerly: The word formerly means “first,” “in the past” or “previously.” It refers to the time when the Israel people were rescued from Egypt and God promised them rest in a new land. Some other ways to refer to this time are:

first (GNT)

in the past (GW)

heard the good news: As in 4:2a, the good news refers to the good news about the rest that God promised his people. It does not refer to the good news about Jesus. In some languages it may be necessary to refer to the good news more specifically. For example:

heard the good news about his rest
Bukidnon Manobo back translation on TW.

4:6c

did not enter because of their disobedience,

- were not able to enter that rest, because they disobeyed him.
- could not receive/obtain that rest, because they refused to believe/obey.

did not enter because of their disobedience: This part of the verse has two actions:

1. They failed to enter God’s rest.
2. They disobeyed God.

The second action is the cause of the first. In some languages it is more natural to change the order of these actions. For example:

they disobeyed God and so were unable to enter his rest

Translate this cause and its result in a way that is natural in your language.

did not enter: The phrase that the BSB translates literally as did not enter indicates that the people did not enter the rest that God wanted to give them. In some languages it is necessary to make this phrase more specific. For example:

- did not receive that rest (GNT)
- did not get rest with GodUma back translation on TW.

because of their disobedience: The people of Israel could not enter God’s rest because they disobeyed God. Notice that in 3:19 the author said that the Israelites could not enter the land because of unbelief.

Disobedience and unbelief are similar. The Israelites did not believe that God was able to help them conquer the people living in the land, so they disobeyed God and refused to enter the land. Not believing God and not obeying him are sins. Both of these sins caused the people of Israel not to be able to enter the land.

Some ways to translate because of their disobedience are:

- because they disobeyed God (GW)
- because they did not submit to himUma back translation on TW.

General Comment on 4:6a–c

In some languages it may be helpful to reorder some parts of this verse to make the connections with 4:5 and 4:7 clearer. For example:

- ^{6b}Those who first heard the Good News ^{6c}did not receive that rest, because they did not believe.
- ^{6a}There are, then, others who are allowed to receive it. ^{7a}This is shown by the fact that God sets another day... (GNT)

Hebrews 4:7

Section 4:1–13: We must have faith in God and enter his rest

The word “rest” is used in 4:1, and it is the important topic that connects chapter 4 to chapter 3.It is the link between chapters 3 and 4, just as 2:1 was the link

between chapter 1 and chapter 2, and 3:1 was a link between chapter 2 and chapter 3. The author used the word “rest” in a figurative way to refer to depending on God. God wants his people to rest from their own work, as God rested from his work on the seventh day after he created the world. In chapter 3, God promised the people of Israel a place to rest. In chapter 4, the author used a special time of rest as a symbol. This time was one day each week, which the people called the Sabbath Day (seventh day). Both the place and the time of rest are symbols of the rest that God’s people have when they depend on him for everything.

Two sentences in this section are especially important in stating this theme:

4:9	There remains, then, a Sabbath rest for the people of God. (BSB)
4:11	Let us, therefore, make every effort to enter that rest, (BSB)

The theme of this section is clear: God has planned a good life of rest for believers when they depend on him. We must be careful to believe and obey him so that we do not miss the life of rest that he promised. Some words that are connected to this theme in chapters 3 and 4 are “faith,” “believe,” “unbelief,” and “disobedience.”

Some other examples of headings for this section are:

- God’s people can still experience God’s rest
- We should trust God and receive his promise of rest

Paragraph 4:6–8

It is important to notice that the clauses in this paragraph are closely connected. However, the author did not always talk about events in the order in which they happened.In the Greek text, verses 4:6–7 are one long sentence, which begins with two connecting words, epei oun, “since therefore.” “Therefore” (oun) indicates that the following statement is a conclusion of the previous argument. “Since” (epei) indicates that statement is a reason for the following statement. These two connecting words also occurred in 2:14, and oun occurred again in 4:1. The RSV and the BSB reflect the structure of this long sentence exactly. The NIV omits both connectives. In some languages it is more natural to use a different order. For examples, see the General Comment on 4:6b–8b at the end of 4:8b.

4:7a
God again designated a certain day as “Today,”

- Therefore/So God appointed another day, which he called “Today.”
- Because of this, God set another special time, and he called it “Today.”

Remember that some translators begin this verse with a connector like “Therefore” or “So,” as in the GW. In the BSB, as in the Greek text, 4:6 and 4:7 are one long sentence. The Notes separates them into more than one sentence in the examples in the Display. Use an option that is natural in your language.

God again designated a certain day as “Today”: This statement indicates that God appointed another time when people can enter his rest. The word again implies that he already set one time, which was for the Israel people whom he led out of Egypt. Now he sets another time. He called this time “today.”

Some ways to translate this statement are:

So God set another day. That day is today. (GW)

again he appoints/offers a certain time and calls it “today.”

In some languages it is necessary to mention the purpose for which God set the day. God’s purpose was to give people the opportunity to enter (have) his rest. Some ways to say that are:

there is another time that God has given to people so they will have opportunity to enter, and now/ today is that time. Kankanaey back translation on TW.

So God set another time for entering his rest and that time is today. (NLT)

God again designated a certain day: The phrase God...designated a certain day indicates that God chose a particular time. The phrase a certain day refers to a particular time or to an opportunity. Some ways to translate this phrase are:

there is still a time set by God Western Bukidnon Manobo back translation on TW.

he proclaims a further opportunity (JBP)

In some languages it may be more natural to use a present form of the verb. For example:

again he appoints a certain day (ESV)

God again designates a certain day

a certain day as “Today”: Here the BSB puts the word “Today” in quotation marks to emphasize it. It also uses quotation marks because it occurs in the psalm that the author will quote later in this verse. These quotation marks are not part of the original Greek text, and some other English versions use different punctuation. You should use natural punctuation in your language here.

Some other ways to translate the phrase a certain day as “Today” are:

a certain day that he calls Today

another day which God prearranged for people to enter. That day is called “This Day.” Yakan back translation on TW.

“Today”: The word “Today” is used in part of Psalm 95, which he quoted in 3:7 and 3:15 and will quote again in 4:7e–f. The author emphasized this word “Today” several times to indicate that it is important for those who hear God’s voice to respond now. The time that he calls “Today” will not continue forever. Emphasize this meaning in a natural way in your language. Refer to the other notes and the Display of 4:7a for examples.

4:7b when a long time later He spoke through David

- After a long time, he spoke about this by causing David to say
- He said this a long time after the Israelites came out of the desert. At that time, he told David

when a long time later He spoke through David: The phrase spoke through David indicates that God inspired David to write the words that the author quotes in 4:7d–e. These words are from Psalm 95. They were written hundreds of years after Moses led the people of Israel out of Egypt.

Some ways to translate this clause are:

God announced this through David a long time later (NLT)

For a long time after the time of those first people who did not believe, God inspired His word in King

David and David saidWestern Bukidnon Manobo back translation on TW.

a long time later: David lived many years after the Israelites traveled through the desert. However, he also lived a long time before the book of Hebrews was written. Make sure you choose the right time phrase to make this clear.

4:7c
as was just stated:

- the words that were already quoted:
- what I already repeated/quoted to you from scripture:

as was just stated: The phrase as was just stated refers to what the author said in 3:15. There he quoted the same words that he will quote again in 4:7d-e. Some ways to translate this clause are:

in the same Scripture used before (NCV)

in the words already quoted from the Psalms (REB)

what I said/quoted a little earlier from God’s Word, which said...

These examples indicate that the words that the author quoted are from the Scriptures. You may also refer to the Scriptures in an accepted way in your language.

4:7d
“Today, if you hear His voice,

- “Today as you^(plur) hear his voice,
- “Listen^(plur) to what he says today:
- “Be^(plur) sure to listen to these words of his today.

Today, if you hear His voice: Translate this clause in the same way as you did in 3:7. For more information on how to translate it, see the notes on 3:7b.

4:7e
do not harden your hearts.”

- do^(plur) not become stubborn and refuse to obey me.”
- “Do^(plur) not reject my words.”
- Do^(plur) not refuse to obey him.”

do not harden your hearts: Translate this clause in the same way as you translated it in 3:8. For more information on how to translate it, see the notes on 3:8a.

Hebrews 4:8

Section 4:1–13: We must have faith in God and enter his rest

The word “rest” is used in 4:1, and it is the important topic that connects chapter 4 to chapter 3. It is the link between chapters 3 and 4, just as 2:1 was the link between chapter 1 and chapter 2, and 3:1 was a link between chapter 2 and chapter 3. The author used the word “rest” in a figurative way to refer to depending on God. God wants his people to rest from their own work, as God rested from his work on the seventh day after he created the world. In chapter 3, God promised the people of Israel a place to rest. In chapter 4, the author used a special time of rest as a symbol. This time was one day each week, which the people called the Sabbath Day (seventh day). Both the place and the time of rest are symbols of the rest that God’s people have when they depend on him for everything.

Two sentences in this section are especially important in stating this theme:

4:9	There remains, then, a Sabbath rest for the people of God. (BSB)
4:11	Let us, therefore, make every effort to enter that rest, (BSB)

The theme of this section is clear: God has planned a good life of rest for believers when they depend on him. We must be careful to believe and obey him so that we do not miss the life of rest that he promised. Some words that are connected to this theme in chapters 3 and 4 are “faith,” “believe,” “unbelief,” and “disobedience.”

Some other examples of headings for this section are:

God’s people can still experience God’s rest

We should trust God and receive his promise of rest

Paragraph 4:6–8

It is important to notice that the clauses in this paragraph are closely connected. However, the author did not always talk about events in the order in which they happened. In the Greek text, verses 4:6–7 are one long sentence, which begins with two connecting words, epei oun, “since therefore.” “Therefore” (oun) indicates that the following statement is a conclusion of the previous argument. “Since” (epei) indicates that statement is a reason for the following statement. These two connecting words also occurred in 2:14, and

oun occurred again in 4:1. The RSV and the BSB reflect the structure of this long sentence exactly. The NIV omits both connectives. In some languages it is more natural to use a different order. For examples, see the General Comment on 4:6b–8b at the end of 4:8b.

4:8a–b

if Joshua had given them rest, God would not have spoken later about another day: Here the author asked his audience to imagine something that did not happen. The clause if Joshua had given them rest implies that Joshua did not give the people the type of rest that God promised. If the people already had the rest that God promised, God would not need to promise it again.

Some other ways to translate this sentence are:

We know that Joshua did not lead the people into that rest, because God spoke later about another day. (NCV)

Joshua was not able to cause people to rest as God promised, that is why God spoke again about another day. Compare Translator's Handbook (page 80).

Suppose that Joshua gave the people rest. Then God would not need to speak about a future day when he will give them rest.

In some languages a rhetorical question may be a natural way to translate this sentence. For example:

If Joshua had given them rest, would God speak later about a different day when he will give it to them?

4:8a

For if Joshua had given them rest,

- For if Joshua had caused them to get/enter that rest,
- We know that Joshua was not able to give/provide true rest for the people of Israel, because

For: The word For introduces an explanation or reason for the previous statement. Many English versions leave it implied.

if Joshua had given them rest: Here the author referred to background information about 4:8a. Most people who heard or read Hebrews already knew that Joshua led the people of Israel into the land of Canaan. God wanted to give them rest there, but they

disobeyed him. So they did not receive the true rest, which is a life of depending on God.

Some ways to translate if Joshua had given them rest are:

If Joshua had given the people the rest that God had promised... (GNT)

Now if Joshua had succeeded in giving them this rest (NLT)

For more information about Joshua, see the OT book of Joshua, especially Joshua 11:23 and 23:1. God did use Joshua to give the people of Israel the promised land. But the book of Judges shows that they did not gain true rest because they did not obey the Lord.

Joshua: After Moses died, Joshua became the leader of the Israelites. It was Joshua who led the Israelites into Canaan, the land God promised them. See Joshua 1:1–11:23 to read about those events.

The name Joshua and the name “Jesus” are different forms of the same name. The KJV has the form “Jesus” in this verse to refer to the Joshua who led the Israelites into Canaan. It is recommended that you spell the names Joshua and “Jesus” differently so that readers will not become confused.

4:8b

God would not have spoken later about another day.

- God would not speak later about a future/different day when they will enter it.
- after that, God talked about another day when he will give it to them.

God would not have spoken later about another day: Here the author implies that sometime after Joshua died, God spoke again about another day when he will give his people rest. The author refers here to the quotation from Psalm 95:7b–11, where God used King David to repeat that promise about rest. King David lived hundreds of years after Joshua died.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

there would no longer have been any of God's words speaking of another day

it would not be necessary for God to tell us again about a different future time

about another day: In this context, the phrase about another day refers to another time for people to have the opportunity to obtain God's rest.

General Comment on 4:6b–8b

In some languages it is more natural to combine verses 4:6b–8b to tell the events in the order that they happened. One way these three verses can be combined is:

^{6b}Those who first heard the Good News did not receive that rest, ^{6c}because they did not believe/obey God. ^{8a}If Joshua had given the people the rest that God had promised, ^{8b}God would not have spoken later about another day. ^{7a}But many years later God set another day, which he called "Today." ^{7b}He spoke of it through David ^{7c}in the Scripture already quoted: ^{7d}If you hear God's voice today, ^{7e}do not be stubborn.

Hebrews 4:9

Section 4:1–13: We must have faith in God and enter his rest

The word "rest" is used in 4:1, and it is the important topic that connects chapter 4 to chapter 3. It is the link between chapters 3 and 4, just as 2:1 was the link between chapter 1 and chapter 2, and 3:1 was a link between chapter 2 and chapter 3. The author used the word "rest" in a figurative way to refer to depending on God. God wants his people to rest from their own work, as God rested from his work on the seventh day after he created the world. In chapter 3, God promised the people of Israel a place to rest. In chapter 4, the author used a special time of rest as a symbol. This time was one day each week, which the people called the Sabbath Day (seventh day). Both the place and the time of rest are symbols of the rest that God's people have when they depend on him for everything.

Two sentences in this section are especially important in stating this theme:

4:9	There remains, then, a Sabbath rest for the people of God. (BSB)
4:11	Let us, therefore, make every effort to enter that rest, (BSB)

The theme of this section is clear: God has planned a good life of rest for believers when they depend on him. We must be careful to believe and obey him so that we do not miss the life of rest that he promised. Some words that are connected to this theme in

chapters 3 and 4 are "faith," "believe," "unbelief," and "disobedience."

Some other examples of headings for this section are:

God's people can still experience God's rest

We should trust God and receive his promise of rest

4:9

There remains, then, a Sabbath rest for the people of God.

- ¶ Since God did speak about it, we know that he has provided a sabbath rest for his people.
- ¶ So from this we^(incl) conclude/understand that there is still rest for God's people, like the way God rested on the rest day.

This verse is important in Section 4:1–13. It tells what readers should conclude from 4:1–8. In those verses the author used two OT scriptures (Psalm 95 and Genesis 2:2) to lead to this conclusion in 4:9: God still provides a sabbath rest for his people.

There remains, then: The Greek word *ἄρα*. It is used here to introduce "an inference made on the basis of what precedes." (BDAG, page 127). that the BSB translates as then introduces a deduction or conclusion from 4:1–8. It implies that the statement in 4:9 will tell what readers should realize and conclude from the preceding verses.

Some other ways to introduce it are:

That is how we know that...

This shows that...

So from all this we know/conclude that...

There remains...a Sabbath rest for the people of God: This clause indicates that a Sabbath rest is still available for God's people to enjoy. Some other ways to translate it are:

there is still opportunity for the people of God to get rest with him. That rest is like God's rest on the seventh day.

as for us, God's people, it is possible for us to have rest like God's rest on that seventh day

there is a special rest still waiting for the people of God (NLT)

remains: Here the Greek word that the BSB translates as remains means “to be reserved.” It indicates here that a sabbath rest is still available for God’s people. In this context it is God who has reserved (provided) this rest for his people. Some ways to translate it in this verse are:

is still waiting/provided

God has reserved

is still coming (NCV)

Sabbath rest: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Sabbath rest is a rare word. It occurs only here in the Greek New Testament. Allen (page 280, Kindle edition) says, “Many believe the author of Hebrews coined the term sabbatismos since it occurs nowhere in Greek literature prior to Hebrews and this is its only occurrence in the New Testament.” The Jews rested on the seventh (final) day of every week. They called this weekly rest day the Sabbath. The phrase Sabbath rest is related to the word for “sabbath.” It is used in a figurative way here to refer to a special type of rest. This word does not occur in the Greek Old Testament, but it is related to the Greek word for the Sabbath, which is based on the Hebrew word, *shabbat*. This noun is related to the verb *shabat* which means “cease from, rest.” The Jews had to “cease” work on the seventh day and “rest,” as God did after his work of creation.

There are two main views about what this Sabbath rest refers to:

- 1. It refers to a spiritual rest that begins on earth when a person believes in Christ. Then the person depends on God for salvation and for the strength to do God’s will.
- 2. It refers to rest in heaven with God after a believer in Christ dies. It is symbolized in the OT by the rest that God promised the people of Israel in the land of Canaan.

Probably the word implies both of these meanings here. Some other ways to translate it are:

rest like God’s resting on the seventh day (GNT)

special rest (NLT)

people of God: The Greek word that the BSB translates as people often refers to a group of people who share kinship. It can also refer to people who share a common culture but are not related by blood. God created everyone, so all people belong to him. However, in the Bible the term “God’s people” is usually used in a special way to refer to the people who believe in him and obey him.

Some other ways to translate people of God here are:

the people who worship/serve God

God’s worshippers/subjects

Hebrews 4:10

Section 4:1–13: We must have faith in God and enter his rest

The word “rest” is used in 4:1, and it is the important topic that connects chapter 4 to chapter 3. It is the link between chapters 3 and 4, just as 2:1 was the link between chapter 1 and chapter 2, and 3:1 was a link between chapter 2 and chapter 3. The author used the word “rest” in a figurative way to refer to depending on God. God wants his people to rest from their own work, as God rested from his work on the seventh day after he created the world. In chapter 3, God promised the people of Israel a place to rest. In chapter 4, the author used a special time of rest as a symbol. This time was one day each week, which the people called the Sabbath Day (seventh day). Both the place and the time of rest are symbols of the rest that God’s people have when they depend on him for everything.

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4:9	There remains, then, a Sabbath rest for the people of God. (BSB)
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The theme of this section is clear: God has planned a good life of rest for believers when they depend on him. We must be careful to believe and obey him so that we do not miss the life of rest that he promised. Some words that are connected to this theme in chapters 3 and 4 are “faith,” “believe,” “unbelief,” and “disobedience.”

Some other examples of headings for this section are:

God’s people can still experience God’s rest

We should trust God and receive his promise of rest

4:10a
For whoever enters God’s rest also rests from his own work,

- Whoever enters/receives that rest stops the work that he was doing,
- All those who rest as God did/does stop doing their work,

4:10b
just as God did from His.

- just as God stopped his work and rested.
- as God did when he finished doing all his work of creating.

4:10a–b
For: The word For introduces an explanation of 4:9. The verse explains why the author used the word “Sabbath rest” to describe the rest that God’s people will enter. In some languages it is not necessary to introduce 4:10 with a connector. Connect the explanation to 4:9 in a natural way in your language.

whoever enters God’s rest also rests from his own work, just as God did from His: The phrase God’s rest refers to the rest that God offers to his people. The author compares that rest to God’s rest on the Sabbath after he created the world. There are two main ways to interpret the phrase rests from his own work here:

1. It means that God’s people should not try to earn God’s approval by doing certain actions that they themselves decide to do.
2. It means that God’s people will not work after they “enter God’s rest” by dying and going to heaven.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). English versions are ambiguous, but the theme of Hebrews supports interpretation (1). The author did not want his hearers to try to earn God’s approval by their own sacrifices or other work. He indicated that they must trust in Jesus, their great high priest. He made the perfect sacrifice to reconcile them with God.

Some other ways to translate this are:

whoever enjoys resting with God has ceased doing things to gain God’s favor just as God ceased doing his work of creating everything.Ellis Diebler, SSA of Hebrews, prepublication copy, page 20.

anyone who rests with God stops doing special actions/work to earn his approval. He rests from

doing that, as God rested from his work of creation.

whoever enters God’s rest: The phrase enters God’s rest is also used in 4:1a, 4:3a, 4:5b, and 4:6a. You should translate it in the same way here. See the note on 4:1a for more information.

just as God did from His: The clause just as God did from His means “as God stopped his work” (after he created the world). See the note on 4:4b for an explanation of the similar phrase “rested from all his works.” You should translate the phrase here in a similar way.

Hebrews 4:11

Section 4:1–13: We must have faith in God and enter his rest

The word “rest” is used in 4:1, and it is the important topic that connects chapter 4 to chapter 3.It is the link between chapters 3 and 4, just as 2:1 was the link between chapter 1 and chapter 2, and 3:1 was a link between chapter 2 and chapter 3. The author used the word “rest” in a figurative way to refer to depending on God. God wants his people to rest from their own work, as God rested from his work on the seventh day after he created the world. In chapter 3, God promised the people of Israel a place to rest. In chapter 4, the author used a special time of rest as a symbol. This time was one day each week, which the people called the Sabbath Day (seventh day). Both the place and the time of rest are symbols of the rest that God’s people have when they depend on him for everything.

Two sentences in this section are especially important in stating this theme:

4:9	There remains, then, a Sabbath rest for the people of God. (BSB)
4:11	Let us, therefore, make every effort to enter that rest, (BSB)

The theme of this section is clear: God has planned a good life of rest for believers when they depend on him. We must be careful to believe and obey him so that we do not miss the life of rest that he promised. Some words that are connected to this theme in chapters 3 and 4 are “faith,” “believe,” “unbelief,” and “disobedience.”

Some other examples of headings for this section are:

God’s people can still experience God’s rest

We should trust God and receive his promise of rest

4:11

This verse is the second key verse of this section (along with verse 9). It is a solemn exhortation. The RSV, CEV, and some commentaries make 4:11 the beginning of the next paragraph. There is some reason for this, if we consider 4:11–13 to belong together as the final paragraph of the section, since 4:12–13 gives supporting reasons for the exhortation in 4:11. Most versions, however, make 4:12 the beginning of the new paragraph.

4:11a

Let us, therefore, make every effort to enter that rest,

- ¶ So let us^(incl) do all we can to enter that place of rest,
- ¶ Therefore, let us^(incl) be very eager to enter God's place of rest.

Let us, therefore: The word therefore introduces an exhortation to enter God's rest. It is based on what the author said in 4:1–10. Another way to translate it is:

So then

As a result of all this Ellingworth and Nida, Translator's Handbook, page 82.

Let us...make every effort to enter that rest: The verb make every effort means "be eager, try hard, strive." Based on the explanation of *σπουδαζω*, meaning 3, BDAG, page 939. Here the command Let us...make every effort includes both the author and those who heard him. This command is similar to the one in 4:1 ("let us take care that none of you should seem to have failed to reach" his rest.) The author emphasized the command by saying it at the beginning of the section and repeating it (in a slightly different way) near the end.

You should translate the two commands in a similar way. Some other ways to translate the command here are:

Let us...do our best to receive that rest (GNT)

we must be committed/diligent to get that rest with God

Let us try as hard as we can to enter God's rest (NCV)

4:11b

so that no one will fall by following the same pattern of disobedience.

- so that no one will fail to enter because he refused to obey God like the Israelites did.
- Do not let it happen that someone disobeys God like they did. Then he may become unable to receive/obtain God's rest.

so that no one will fall by following the same pattern of disobedience: This clause tells the purpose for trying hard to enter God's rest in 4:11a. It indicates that if we do not strive to enter God's rest (4:11a), we may disobey God and then fall (4:11b). Another way to translate the clause is:

so that no one will fall by following their example of disobedience (NIV)

Notice that this clause mentions two actions: they may fall and they may disobey. The disobedience causes the fall, so in some languages it is more natural to translate the actions in a different order. For example:

so that no one will disobey God like they did and then fall

so that no one will fall: The phrase no one will fall is a figure of speech. The word fall refers to sin that causes a person not to receive God's rest. It implies that a person may disobey God and refuse the rest that God offers him, just as the Israelites disobeyed God in the wilderness and did not receive God's rest. That implies here that the person will fail to receive salvation.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

so that no one among us will retreat from our faith

so that none of us will lose/reject the rest

by following the same pattern of disobedience: The phrase by following the same pattern of disobedience means "by disobeying God, as the people of Israel did." In this context the word disobedience refers to refusing to believe God. See the note on 4:6c. This is the same word that the author used in 3:18 and 4:6c.

In some languages it is more natural to use a verb to translate disobedience. For example:

by following the example of those who refused to obey (GW)

the same pattern of disobedience: The pronoun the same refers to the pattern of disobedience of the people of Israel at the time of Moses. In some languages it is helpful to refer to them more explicitly. For example:

like the people of Israel disobeyed long ago

Hebrews 4:12

Section 4:1–13: We must have faith in God and enter his rest

The word “rest” is used in 4:1, and it is the important topic that connects chapter 4 to chapter 3. It is the link between chapters 3 and 4, just as 2:1 was the link between chapter 1 and chapter 2, and 3:1 was a link between chapter 2 and chapter 3. The author used the word “rest” in a figurative way to refer to depending on God. God wants his people to rest from their own work, as God rested from his work on the seventh day after he created the world. In chapter 3, God promised the people of Israel a place to rest. In chapter 4, the author used a special time of rest as a symbol. This time was one day each week, which the people called the Sabbath Day (seventh day). Both the place and the time of rest are symbols of the rest that God’s people have when they depend on him for everything.

Two sentences in this section are especially important in stating this theme:

4:9	There remains, then, a Sabbath rest for the people of God. (BSB)
4:11	Let us, therefore, make every effort to enter that rest, (BSB)

The theme of this section is clear: God has planned a good life of rest for believers when they depend on him. We must be careful to believe and obey him so that we do not miss the life of rest that he promised. Some words that are connected to this theme in chapters 3 and 4 are “faith,” “believe,” “unbelief,” and “disobedience.”

Some other examples of headings for this section are:

God’s people can still experience God’s rest

We should trust God and receive his promise of rest

4:12a

For the word of God is living and active.

- For the word of God is alive and powerful/effective.
- What God says/speaks has life, and it accomplishes great things.
- Remember that God is alive and powerful, so whatever he says/said

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates literally as For introduces a list of reasons why we must be diligent to obey God and enter his rest (4:11). These reasons are descriptions of the word of God. It is living, powerful, and discerning. It exposes a person’s secret thoughts. Introduce these reasons in a natural way in your language. In some languages a conjunction may not be necessary.

the word of God is living and active: This statement indicates that God’s word has power to accomplish what God intends. God used his word to create the world, and he uses it to affect what people believe and what they do. Some other ways to translate the statement are:

God’s word is alive and it does great things.

What God says has power to do/accomplish what he intends.

the word of God: The phrase the word of God refers to what God says. It includes the Scriptures. It also includes whatever God says, whether it is spoken or written. Jesus is also called “the word of God” (for example, in John 1:14). Hebrews 1:2 says that God spoke in (or by) a Son. Some other ways to translate the phrase are:

God’s word/message

the Word that God speaks (JBP)

living and active: The two words which the BSB translates as living and active have a similar meaning here. The author often used pairs of words with similar meanings to emphasize what he wanted to communicate. This pair indicates that God’s word has power to accomplish what God intends. God used his word to create the world, and he uses it to affect what people believe and what they do.

In some languages it may be more natural to emphasize the meaning in a different way. For example:

full of living power (NLT96)

it is powerful and it has resultsKankanaey back translation on TW.

Notice that there are other pairs in 4:12–13. Translate these pairs in a way that will emphasize the meaning in your language.

living: In this context the word living is used in a figurative way. It means “able to accomplish things.” Here it does not refer to breathing or to having physical life. See the preceding note for translation examples.

active: Here the word active means “effective.” It indicates that God’s word accomplishes what he intends.

4:12b

Sharper than any double-edged sword,

- It is better than a sharp sword with two edges.
- It penetrates a person’s thoughts more effectively than the sharpest knife.
- will certainly be accomplished.

Sharper than any double-edged sword: This statement is a figure of speech. The author compared the word of God to a sword. A sword can be used to cut a person open, and then people can see what is inside his body. The Word of God can do this in a spiritual way. It can reveal a person’s mind and heart and cause him (or other people) to understand it. It reveals to a person what is right and what is wrong about his way of thinking.

Some other ways to translate this figure of speech are:

- Use a simile. For example:

God’s word cuts better than a sword that is sharp on both sides.

God’s word is like a sword with two sharp edges.

- Use a simile and also indicate the meaning. For example:

God’s Word exposes a person’s thoughts and motives, just as a sharp sword with two edges cuts into something and exposes what is in it.

- Translate the meaning without using the figure of speech. For example:

God’s Word exposes our hidden thoughts/motives.

Use a natural way in your language to translate the figure of speech.

any double-edged sword: The Greek word used here for sword occurs only three times in the New Testament. A sword (or “dagger”) is a long knife. The word double-edged indicates that the knife has two sharp (cutting) edges. A double-edged knife is more effective than a knife that has only one sharp edge. That type of knife can cut into something and divide it accurately into parts.

Another way to translate double-edged sword is:

a long knife with two sharp edges

In some languages there is an idiom to describe this. For example, in Hebrew the idiom is literally:

a sword that has two mouths

any: The word any indicates here that there is no sword (even one with two edges) that is more effective than God’s word.

4:12c

it pierces even to dividing soul and spirit,

- It pierces/exposes the most hidden parts of his soul and spirit,
- His words reveal what is in the heart/thoughts of a person.

4:12d

joints and marrow.

- as a sword can pierce even a person’s joints and bone marrow.
- They reveal his most secret motives.

4:12c–d

it pierces even to dividing soul and spirit, joints and marrow: This part of the verse continues to describe the word of God. In Greek the phrase even to dividing is literally “as far as (the place of) division.” It implies that God’s word enters even the part of a person where soul and spirit meet or where his joints and marrow meet.

In some languages a phrase like to dividing may wrongly imply that the Word of God separates a person’s soul from his spirit and separates a person’s joints from his marrow. For that reason the Notes uses the GW as the source text for 4:12c:

and cuts as deep as the place where soul and spirit meet, the place where joints and marrow meet (GW)

(GW) and cuts as deep as the place where soul and spirit meet, the place where joints and marrow meet: The phrase where soul and spirit meet is a figure of speech. The phrase place where joints and marrow meet is also a figure of speech. No one can tell exactly where a person's soul and spirit meet or where joints and marrow meet.

Together these two figures of speech refer to every part of a person. Some other ways to translate this meaning are:

It penetrates even the inner-being and thinking of a person. Therefore no matter what a person's motive is or what he intends, this word of God can reveal it.

It pierces into even our thinking and our purpose, and it shows us what God thinks about it.

(GW) soul...spirit: In this context the Greek words that the BSB translates as soul and spirit have similar meanings. In many scriptures the word soul refers to the inner part of a person which thinks, feels, and makes decisions. The word spirit refers to the person himself, especially to the essential part of himself that is responsible to give an account to God. Here the words soul and spirit are used together to refer to the hidden part of a person, his thoughts, and motives.

Other ways to translate soul and spirit here are:

our innermost thoughts and desires (NLT96)

a person's inner-being and mind/thinking

Most English versions (except the NLT) use the words soul and spirit. See soul, sense A1(a), and spirit, sense A1(a), in KBT.

(GW) joints...marrow: The word joints refers to the material in the body that joins bones together. The word marrow refers to the substance inside the big bones of the body. Another way to translate the literal meaning is:

a person's joints and the substance inside his bones

Here the phrase "the place where joints and marrow meet" is a metaphor to refer to a person's secret thoughts and desires. It emphasizes the statement in 4:12c, which has the same meaning. In some languages the metaphor may not be natural, and you may need to translate the meaning in a different way. For example:

every part of a person

4:12e

It judges the thoughts

- His word judges what a person thinks
- God's word shows whether his thoughts are good or evil,

4:12f

and intentions of the heart.

- and what he plans in his heart/mind.
- and it reveals whether what he intends to do is right or wrong.

4:12e–f

It judges the thoughts and intentions of the heart:

Here the author says that the word of God (It) is able to judge people's thoughts and intentions. This is figurative language. It implies that God's word causes people to know how God wants them to think and act. When a person reads it, it teaches him whether his thoughts are good or bad. Some other ways to translate this statement are:

it pierces into even our thinking, our breath, our purpose, and it shows us what God is thinking about it. Western Bukidnon Manobo back translation on TW.

God's word judges a person's thoughts and intentions. (GW)

It exposes our innermost thoughts and desires. (NLT)

In some languages it may be necessary to translate the meaning without the figurative language. For example:

God uses his Word to show people whether their way of thinking and what they intend to do is right or wrong.

It judges: The Greek word which the BSB translates as judges can describe a judge in a legal case. However, it is often used in a more general way. Here it refers to the ability to distinguish what is right and what is wrong. People can use what God says to examine their thoughts and intentions and know whether they are pleasing to God or not.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

- examines
- discovers
- causes...to be exposed

thoughts and intentions: The words thoughts and intentions are used together to describe what a person thinks. The Greek word which the BSB translates as thoughts refers to “the process of considering something, thought, reflection, idea.” *ἐνθύμησις* BDAG, page 336. It occurs only three other times in the New Testament: Matthew 9:4, 12:25 and Acts 17:29.

The word that the BSB translates as intentions is also rare in the New Testament. It occurs only once more, in 1 Peter 4:1. It refers to what a person thinks, his “thoughts, knowledge, and insights.” *ἐννοια* BDAG, page 337. The two Greek words that the BSB translates as thoughts and intentions here both begin with the prefix en- and are related in meaning. Their use in this verse is an example of the author’s frequent wordplay.

Some other ways to translate thoughts and intentions are:

- what a person thinks and plans
- our thinking and the purposes in our heartsUma back translation on TW.

of the heart: In both Greek and Hebrew the heart refers to the part of a person that thinks and feels. In some languages a phrase like of the heart may not be necessary in this context. The source of the “thoughts and intentions” may already be implied by referring to the person (or people) who think them. See the first example in the preceding note. For more information, see heart, sense 1(b), in KBT.

General Comment on 4:12a–e

In some languages you may need to make the comparison in this verse more explicit. For example:

God’s word is powerful and active. It exposes what people think and what they want/intend to do as precisely as a knife with two sharp edges cuts into skin.

God’s word is strong and does great deeds. Like a knife with two sharp edges, it cuts open a person’s thoughts and shows what he secretly thinks and wants to do.

Hebrews 4:13

Section 4:1–13: We must have faith in God and enter his rest

The word “rest” is used in 4:1, and it is the important topic that connects chapter 4 to chapter 3. It is the link between chapters 3 and 4, just as 2:1 was the link between chapter 1 and chapter 2, and 3:1 was a link between chapter 2 and chapter 3. The author used the word “rest” in a figurative way to refer to depending on God. God wants his people to rest from their own work, as God rested from his work on the seventh day after he created the world. In chapter 3, God promised the people of Israel a place to rest. In chapter 4, the author used a special time of rest as a symbol. This time was one day each week, which the people called the Sabbath Day (seventh day). Both the place and the time of rest are symbols of the rest that God’s people have when they depend on him for everything.

Two sentences in this section are especially important in stating this theme:

4:9	There remains, then, a Sabbath rest for the people of God. (BSB)
4:11	Let us, therefore, make every effort to enter that rest, (BSB)

The theme of this section is clear: God has planned a good life of rest for believers when they depend on him. We must be careful to believe and obey him so that we do not miss the life of rest that he promised. Some words that are connected to this theme in chapters 3 and 4 are “faith,” “believe,” “unbelief,” and “disobedience.”

Some other examples of headings for this section are:

- God’s people can still experience God’s rest
- We should trust God and receive his promise of rest

4:13

In 4:12 the author said that God's word is like a sword which cuts people open and shows what they are like inside. In 4:13 the author indicates that God sees every person and everything that he created, and he knows all about them. No one can hide anything from him, and everyone must give an account to him for what they do.

The statements in 4:13a and 4:13b are parallel, and 4:13b repeats the idea of 4:13a. The parallel parts are indicated here by underlining or bolding:

^{13a}And before him **no creature is hidden**

^{13b}but **all are naked** and **laid bare** to the eyes of the one

^{13c} to whom we must render an account.

In some languages it is more natural to combine these statements. For example:

^{13a-b}No one can hide anything from God, and he is the one ^{13c}to whom we must give an account.

4:13a

Nothing in all creation is hidden from God's sight;

- Nothing in all of God's creation is hidden from him.
- God clearly sees all that he has created.

Nothing in all creation is hidden from God's sight:

The word hidden refers here to something that is not able to be seen or known. Louw-Nida, 28.68. ἀφανής, page 343. The clause indicates that God can see everything and everyone that he created. Nothing can be hidden from God so that he does not see it.

Some other ways to translate the statement are:

No creature can hide from God (GW)

There is really nothing that can be hidden from God. Tagbanwa back translation on TW.

God can see every one of his creatures, and none of them is hidden from him.

creation: The word creation refers to anything that God created. God created everything.

4:13b

everything is uncovered and exposed before the eyes

- Everything is clear and completely exposed to him,
- Nothing is hidden or invisible to him, and he is the one
- He sees everything exactly as it is,

everything is uncovered and exposed before the eyes:

The words uncovered and exposed mean "uncovered, bare," γυμνός BDAG, page 208. and they are used in a figurative way here. It indicates that God knows everything about every creature, just as people can see the whole body of a naked person. Even if a person tries to hide something about himself from God, God will still see it clearly. He will know all about it.

Some other ways to translate this meaning are:

everything is uncovered...for him to see (GW)

whatever creature, it is as if they are all naked in his sight

exposed: The Greek word that the BSB translates as exposed occurs only here in the Bible. It probably refers to the custom of exposing the neck of a person or animal in order to cut his throat and kill him. Here the word is used as a figure of speech. It indicates that everything (and every person) is completely known to God, and God has power over each one. The root of this word, τραχηλίζω, which only occurs here in the NT, is "neck" or "throat." The picture seems to be of a victim, whether an animal for sacrifice, or a wrongdoer, whose neck is bent back and the throat exposed for cutting.

Some other ways to translate this figure of speech are:

exposed/clear

there is nothing of our thoughts closed to him
O-tomi back translation on TW.

He can always see anything that we are doing/
thinking

4:13c

of Him to whom we must give account.

- and we^(incl) must explain to him the way we have lived.
- who will ask us to tell him about what we^(incl) have done and thought.

- and we^(incl) must answer to him.

of Him to whom we must give account: The phrase of Him to whom we must give account refers to God. It indicates that God is the judge of what people do and think throughout their lives. He is the one to whom we will explain the way we have lived.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

And he is the one to whom we will answer for all that we have done and thought. Kankanaey back translation on TW.

It is to him that we must admit/confess our behavior. Uma back translation on TW.

This is the God to whom we must explain all that we have done. (NLT)

give account: The phrase give account means “give an answer for our actions” or “say why we have done what we have done.” See the preceding note for translation examples.

Division 4:14–8:13 is the second major division of Hebrews. In this division the author discusses Jesus’ work as high priest for us his people. It is important to remember that in the OT God gave the people of Israel instructions about who could serve as high priest. Only one person served as high priest, and he served until he died. Then another priest was chosen. Only the high priest could make atonement for the people’s sins on the Day of Atonement. The other priests had different duties. As you translate, be sure that your translation fits with this background information.

Hebrews 4:14

Section 4:14–16: So let’s be faithful to Jesus, our great high priest

This short section (4:14–16) has three main points:

1. It encourages the readers to continue to believe the truth about Jesus that they publicly accepted.
2. It repeats that Jesus is our high priest (see 2:17), and it describes what kind of priest he is.
3. It introduces the next section, which describes Jesus’ work as high priest.

Remember to translate the section before choosing a heading for it. Some other possible headings are:

Jesus Is the Great High Priest (CEV)

Jesus Our Compassionate High Priest (NET)

Christ Is Superior to Other Chief Priests (GW)

4:14

This verse summarizes what the author taught in 4:1–13.

4:14a

Therefore, since we have a great high priest

- ¶ So then, we know that we^(incl) have a great/mighty high priest,
- ¶ Now we know that we^(incl) have the most powerful high priest,

Therefore, since we have: The phrase Therefore, since we have is more literally “Having, therefore.” In the Greek text there is no conjunction which is translated as “since,” but the BSB correctly interprets the participial phrase to be giving a basis for the following clause, which encourages readers to hold firmly to their confession of faith. The word “therefore” implies that the author already taught his listeners about their great high priest (4:14a). He taught them that he is Jesus, the Son of God (4:14b). These teachings are the basis for what the author told them to do (4:14c). He told them to hold firmly to their confession of faith, because they know that their great high priest is Jesus the Son of God.

Some ways to translate 4:14a–c are:

So now we understand that we have a great high priest, Jesus the Son of God, and he has gone into heaven. So let us firmly continue to believe our confession of faith.

We have a great high priest, who has gone into heaven, Jesus the Son of God. That is why we must hold on to what we have said about him. (CEV)

In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of the clauses in this verse. See the General Comment on 4:14a–c at the end of 4:14c for examples.

we have a great high priest: The phrase we have a great high priest indicates that there is a great high priest who represents us to God.

Some other ways to translate we have a great high priest are:

there is a great high priest for us

the most powerful/important of all chief priests represents us

we: The pronoun we refers to both the author and the people who listened to him. This applies to each we and “us” in the rest of the chapter.

great high priest: The people of Israel had one great high priest, who was the leader of all the other priests. He was greater than all of them, and he was responsible to make atonement for the people’s sins. Here the word great is added to the term high priest to emphasize even more the supreme greatness of Jesus.

You should translate high priest as you did in 2:17 and emphasize his greatness in a natural way in your language. See the examples in the preceding note. For more information on how to translate high priest, see the note on 2:17b.

4:14b

who has passed through the heavens, Jesus the Son of God,

- and he has gone into heaven itself. He is Jesus, the Son of God.
- Jesus the Son of God. He has gone through the sky/heaven to God.

who has passed through the heavens: The clause who has passed through the heavens is a figure of speech. It indicates that Jesus entered heaven and came to God. It implies a comparison between Jesus and each high priest of Israel.

Once a year the person who was the high priest of Israel came into the tabernacle. He passed through the outer room and came into the inner room. After he finished his work in that room, he left. In contrast with those high priests, Jesus came to God himself in heaven. The phrase “passed through the heavens” indicates that Jesus returned to God, and he is there in God’s presence. Some scholars have suggested that this phrase refers to Jesus’ ascension to heaven after his death and resurrection (For a description of his ascension, see Luke 24:51 and Acts 1:9.) Jesus passed through the sky, and the disciples watched until the clouds made them unable to see him any longer. and he is still in the presence of God.

Some ways to translate who has passed through the heavens are:

who has gone up into heaven

He went through the sky/heavens and came to God

Jesus the Son of God: The phrase Jesus the Son of God expresses the fact that Jesus has the same nature and character as God. This is the only place in Hebrews where the author puts the name Jesus and the phrase the Son of God together. For more information about how to translate the title the Son of God, see the note on “his Son” in 1:2a.

4:14c

let us hold firmly to what we profess.

- Because of this, we^(incl) must continue to be true to our statement of faith in him.
- So let us continue to believe strongly the things we^(incl) publicly declared that we believe.

let us hold firmly to what we profess: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as let us hold firmly is a command. It means that we must continue to be firmly committed. It is interesting that the author of Hebrews is the only New Testament author to use the corresponding adjective phoberos, “fearful” in connection with God and his judgment. For other examples, see 10:27, 10:31 and 12:21. (Remember that it is not a request for permission.) The phrase what we profess refers here to a statement of what we believe (about Jesus). It includes a declaration of commitment to him.

Some other ways to translate this command are:

we must hold firm to our profession of faith (NJB)

it is necessary/essential that we continue to be committed to our declaration of faith in Jesus

Translate this command in a way that is natural in your language.

what we profess: The phrase what we profess means “what we say/declare that we believe.” The word profess refers here to making a statement about what followers of Jesus believe. A follower of Jesus makes this statement in public and expresses agreement with those beliefs. It is a way for the person to publicly state his allegiance (devotion) to Jesus. The word profess does not refer here to confessing sins.

Some other ways to translate what we profess are:

what we believe about Jesus

acknowledging Jesus as our Lord

The Greek word translated here as profess occurs six times in the NT. Three of those are in the book of Hebrews (here and in 3:1 and 10:23).

General Comment on 4:14a–c

In 4:14c the author told his listeners to hold firmly to their profession of faith. In some languages it may be more natural to put this exhortation at the beginning of 4:14, and then give the description of Jesus in 4:14a–b. Then that description will connect with the description of the high priest in 4:15. For example:

^{14c}Let us, then, hold firmly to the faith we profess.

^{14a}For we have a great high priest ^{14b}who has gone into the very presence of God—Jesus, the Son of God. ¹⁵Our High Priest is not one who cannot feel sympathy for our weaknesses. (GNT)

^{14c}So then, we must hold firmly to what we believe and declare ^{14b}about Jesus. He is the Son of God, and he has gone into heaven ^{14a}as our great high priest to represent us. ¹⁵This high priest of ours understands our weaknesses...

Hebrews 4:15

Section 4:14–16: So let's be faithful to Jesus, our great high priest

This short section (4:14–16) has three main points:

1. It encourages the readers to continue to believe the truth about Jesus that they publicly accepted.
2. It repeats that Jesus is our high priest (see 2:17), and it describes what kind of priest he is.
3. It introduces the next section, which describes Jesus' work as high priest.

Remember to translate the section before choosing a heading for it. Some other possible headings are:

Jesus Is the Great High Priest (CEV)

Jesus Our Compassionate High Priest (NET)

Christ Is Superior to Other Chief Priests (GW)

4:15a

For we do not have a high priest who is unable to sympathize with our weaknesses,

- For our^(incl) high priest has compassion for us in our human weakness/temptations,
- We^(incl) have a high priest who is able to help us when we are weak/tempted,

For: The word For introduces a basis for “holding firmly to our confession” of faith (4:14c). The author already gave one basis in 4:14a (We have a great high priest, Jesus the Son of God). He introduces the second basis here at the beginning of 4:15a.

In some languages it is more natural to introduce this second basis by referring back to the word “high priest” in 4:14. For example:

Our High Priest (GNT)

And this Highest Priest of oursKankanaey back translation on TW.

we do not have a high priest who is unable to sympathize with our weaknesses: This statement indicates that our high priest is able to sympathize with us in our weaknesses. The two negative phrases do not have and unable (not able) emphasize the fact that our high priest is able to sympathize with us.

In some languages it is more natural to translate the statement without using two negative phrases. For example:

We have a chief priest who is able to sympathize with our weaknesses. (GW)

And this Highest Priest of ours, he knows how to feel with us in our weaknessKankanaey back translation on TW.

Emphasize this statement in a natural way in your language.

sympathize with our weaknesses: The Greek word that the BSB translates as sympathize occurs only twice in the New Testament. It means to “suffer with” or “feel with” people. It implies the type of sympathy that motivates someone to offer active help.

The phrase sympathize with our weaknesses indicates that Jesus understands the ways that we are weak in resisting temptations to sin. He feels compassion for us. He is able to help us, and he offers us help.Koester (page 283) says, “Jesus sympathized with people by sharing their flesh and blood, suffering to deliver them...and offering help.” Other ways to translate this phrase are:

understands every weakness of ours (CEV)

feeling our weaknesses with us (NJB)

has compassion for us when we are weak/
tempted

our weaknesses: The phrase our weaknesses refers to the ways that human beings are limited or inadequate. In this context it refers especially to being weak in resisting temptations to sin. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

our weakness because of our humanity
Western Bukidnon Manobo back translation on TW.

our weaknesses which lead us into sin
Tagbanwa back translation on TW.

the ways we^(incl) are not strong to refuse sin

4:15b

but we have one who was tempted in every way that we are, yet was without sin.

- since he has been tempted in every way like us^(incl), but without sinning.
- For he has been tempted with all kinds of temptation just as we^(incl) have, yet as for him, he did not sin.

but: The Greek connector that the BSB translates as but connects the clause in 4:15a with the one in 4:15b. These clauses have similar meanings, and 4:15b explains more about 4:15a. In some languages, a connector like but implies too much contrast in meaning between 4:15a and 4:15b.

If that is true in your language, some other ways to connect the clauses are:

- Use a connector which indicates that 4:15b explains or adds to 4:15a. For example:

^{15a}This High Priest of ours understands our weaknesses, (NLT96)

^{15b} for he faced all of the same temptations that we do, yet he did not sin.

- Do not use a connector. For example:

^{15a}We have a high priest who is able to sympathize with our weaknesses. (GW)

^{15b}He was tempted in every way that we are, but he didn't sin.

Connect the two statements in a natural way in your language.

we have one who was tempted in every way that we are: The Greek word that the BSB translates as tempted can also mean “tested.” (See the note on 2:18a.) Scholars disagree about what it means here:

1. It means “tempted to sin.” For example:

he was tempted in every way that we are (CEV)
(BSB, CEV, NLT96, RSV, GNT, NIV, NASB, ESV, NET, NCV, JBP, GW)

1. It means “tested.” For example:

in every respect has been tested as we are (NRSV)
(NRSV, REB, NLT, NAB, NJB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), along with most English versions and many Bible scholars. This interpretation fits the context of not sinning as a result of the temptation.

one who was tempted in every way that we are: This statement indicates that our high priest has been tempted in every way, just as every human being is tempted. That is the reason that Jesus, our high priest, is able to sympathize with our weaknesses.

The verb was tempted is passive, and the clause does not specify who tempted Jesus. Other verses in Scripture indicate that Satan tempted Jesus. Some ways to translate the passive clause are:

- Keep the passive verb. For example:

he, too, has been urged to sin in all the ways that we are urged to sin

- Use a different verb that does not require specifying the tempter. For example:

our high priest experienced/faced all the kinds of temptation that we experience/face

- Use an active verb and refer to Satan as the tempter. For example:

Satan has tempted him in every way like he tempts us

Translate this clause in a natural way in your language.

in every way: The phrase in every way means that Jesus experienced all the same kinds of temptations that other people have. Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

all of the same testings we do (NLT)

all the types of temptations that human beings face

that we are: The phrase that we are refers in general to human beings. (See the examples in the preceding note.) If you use a pronoun like we, it should refer to both the author and the readers.

yet was without sin: The clause yet was without sin is literally just without sin. It indicates that Jesus faced every temptation without sinning. The BSB adds the word yet, which is not in the Greek text. It makes explicit the contrast between Jesus and other human beings. Jesus did not sin when he was tempted, but every other human being has sinned.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

yet he did not sin (NLT96)

except that he never sinned (JBP)

but as for him by contrast, he absolutely didn't sin
Kankanaey back translation on TW.

Hebrews 4:16

Section 4:14–16: So let's be faithful to Jesus, our great high priest

This short section (4:14–16) has three main points:

1. It encourages the readers to continue to believe the truth about Jesus that they publicly accepted.
2. It repeats that Jesus is our high priest (see 2:17), and it describes what kind of priest he is.
3. It introduces the next section, which describes Jesus' work as high priest.

Remember to translate the section before choosing a heading for it. Some other possible headings are:

Jesus Is the Great High Priest (CEV)

Jesus Our Compassionate High Priest (NET)

Christ Is Superior to Other Chief Priests (GW)

4:16a

Let us then approach the throne of grace with confidence,

- So, let's come confidently to the seat of our^(incl) merciful/gracious God,
- Therefore let us^(incl) come near our God without hesitation/fear. He is very kind,

Let us then: Here the word then introduces an exhortation that is based on 4:14–15. It is the same word that was used in 4:14a. Connect this exhortation with 4:15 in a way that is natural in your language.

Let us...approach the throne of grace with confidence: In this exhortation the author used a figure of speech. Literally, the word throne refers to the chair or seat on which a king sits to rule his people. Figuratively, the phrase approach the throne refers to coming to God by praying to him. The phrase of grace indicates that God rules with kindness and generosity. The author used the whole exhortation to encourage his listeners to pray to God with confidence (confidence).

Some ways to translate this clause are:

we should come bravely before the throne of our merciful God (CEV)

let's come to God's seat with confidence, knowing that he is gracious

In some languages a translation like "come to the throne of God" may wrongly imply that a person dies and comes to God in heaven. If that is true in your language, you should translate the meaning without the figure of speech. For example:

let's pray with assurance to God, our gracious King

let's come with confidence into the presence of God. He shows grace/kindness

Let us...approach: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as Let us...approach is an exhortation. See also 10:22. We can approach God because of what Jesus, the high priest, has done. This is a major theme of Hebrews. The English words Let us indicate that the exhortation includes the author. It is not a request for permission here. In many languages (as in Greek), words like "let us" are not needed because the form of

the verb indicates who should approach. Another way to translate this exhortation is:

we should approach

let's come/pray to

approach: The verb approach is important in this context. It implies that God's people can now freely come to God by praying. In the OT, no one except the high priest could approach the "mercy seat," which symbolized God's presence. Now because of Jesus, all of God's people can come to him.

Some other ways to translate this meaning are:

get near to God by means of praying
Based on the Western Bukidnon Manobo back translation on TW.

come into God's presence

go/come to God

the throne of grace: The word throne usually refers to a special chair that is reserved for the king. It also refers to the king's authority. The phrase the throne of grace is a figure of speech to refer to God himself. It indicates that he rules with grace and mercy. The term throne of grace is similar to the term "mercy seat," which was used in the OT. It also symbolized God's presence.

Some other ways to translate the throne of grace are:

- Translate the figure of speech. For example:

God on his Seat in heaven
Uma back translation on TW. If you use this option, be sure that it does not imply coming to God in heaven after death.

- Translate the meaning without the figure of speech. For example:

God who rules with mercy/grace

God, the source/owner of grace

God praying to him because he loves and is merciful
Yakan back translation on TW.

For more translation examples, see the note on grace in the next part of the verse.

with confidence: The phrase with confidence refers here to having a confident attitude toward God, not being afraid of him. BDAG, *παρρησία*, meaning 3b, page 781. It was also used in 3:6, where the BSB translated it as "confidence." and it will occur again in 10:19 and 10:35.

Some ways to translate with confidence are:

confidently

without fear

4:16b

so that we may receive mercy

- so that we^(incl) may receive his mercy
- and he will be merciful/kind to us^(incl)

4:16c

and find grace to help us in our time of need.

- and obtain/receive his grace to help us^(incl) when we need it.
- and will give us^(incl) the help that we need.

4:16b–c

so that we may receive mercy and find grace to help us in our time of need: This clause tells the purpose of coming near to God in 4:16a. We come to him so that he will be merciful to us, and so that he will help us with his grace. Another way to translate this purpose is:

so that we will receive help and gracious kindness when we need it

The context indicates that God is the source of the mercy and grace that we receive. In some languages it is more natural to make that explicit in this clause. For example:

so that God will be merciful to us and graciously help us when we are in need

mercy: The Greek word that the BSB translates as mercy refers to an act of kindness for someone in need. It does not refer only to feeling pity for a person. In this verse it refers to the kind of help that God gives to people in need. He heals them, forgives their sins, and provides what they need. He comforts and sustains them when they endure sorrow, danger, or persecution.

Some other ways to translate mercy are:

show kindness

have compassion/pity on us

The word mercy occurs only here in Hebrews. For more information, see mercy, sense 2, in KBT.

find grace: The phrase find grace refers to receiving grace. The grace is given by God, just as “mercy” is in the preceding phrase. In some languages a word like find may imply the wrong meaning that the grace was discovered by accident. The context indicates that God is the source of the grace, and this should be clear in your translation of the verse.

Other ways to translate find grace are:

receive grace

experience grace

grace: The Greek word that the BSB translates as grace, refers to kindness or help that is given to people freely, not because they have done anything to deserve it. In this context, the word refers to God’s grace. He is good to people because he loves them. The people have not done anything to deserve his goodness.

Some other ways to translate grace in this context are:

kindness

generous help

In many languages it may be more natural to translate grace with a verb or verb phrase. In this context the implied subject is God. For example:

so that God will be kind/generous to you

so that God will graciously help you

For more information, see grace, sense A2(b), in KBT.

to help us in our time of need: The phrase to help us in our time of need means “to help us when we need help.” Some ways to translate the phrase are:

whenever we need help (NET)

and He will help us at the time of difficulties
West-ern Bukidnon Manobo back translation on TW.

Hebrews 5:1

Section 5:1–10: God appointed Jesus Christ to be our high priest

The term “high priest” connects Section 4:14–16 with this section (5:1–10). In this section the author gives more information about the high priests of Israel and the work that they did. Then he compares the work of those high priests to the work of Christ as our high priest. The main point of this section is that Christ is the high priest because God said that he is.

The author mentions three facts about a high priest’s role and applies them to Christ:

1. A high priest is appointed by God. The Scriptures show that Jesus Christ was appointed by God. In Hebrews 5:5–6, the author quotes Psalm 2:7 and 110:4 as evidence that God appointed him. Lane (page 118) says, “The writer correctly interprets Ps 2:7 as a declaration of appointment.... The same emphasis is evident in the quotation of Ps 110:4.”
2. A high priest should understand and sympathize with the weaknesses of his people. In 5:7–8 the author talked about how Christ suffered and prayed to God with tears.
3. A high priest must offer a sacrifice to atone for the sins of the people. In 5:8–9 the author indicated that when Christ suffered and offered himself as a perfect sacrifice, he obtained eternal salvation for his people. This implies that he atoned for their sins.

In the Greek text for this section, the author usually used a pronoun (“he” or “him”) to refer to Christ. He referred to him as “Christ” only once (5:5), and he did not use the term “Jesus” in this section. However, in the previous section (4:14) the author used the term “Jesus, the Son of God.” Consider carefully how to refer to Christ in the verses where only a pronoun is used in Greek or English. You should use the term “Christ” instead of a pronoun in places where you think that the reader will be confused about who the pronoun refers to.

Remember to read the section carefully before deciding on a heading for it. Some other examples of headings for this section are:

Jesus Christ is the perfect high priest

God made his Son the high priest for his people

God declares that Jesus is a priest

Paragraph 5:1–4

This paragraph explains the duties of a high priest. He must offer the people's gifts to God, and he must offer sacrifices for their sins. He must also offer sacrifices for his own sins, since he, too, is sinful. He is a weak human being, so he is able to sympathize with his fellow human beings.

5:1a

Every high priest is appointed from among men

- ¶ Each high priest is chosen from among other human beings and appointed
- ¶ Every high priest whom God selects for us^(incl) Israel people is a human being like us.
- ¶ Whenever God chooses a high priest, he chooses a human being like other human beings.

In the Greek text, this verse begins with a conjunction that is often translated as “for.” It introduces background information about the high priests of the people of Israel. The author gives this information because in 5:5–10 he will compare these priests to Christ, our great high priest.

Every high priest is appointed from among men:

This clause indicates that each high priest is a human being like other human beings. The verb appointed is passive. It implies that God selects a person from among other people to be the high priest.

Some other ways to translate the passive clause are:

it is from among people that he is chosen

God selects him from among his fellow human beings

is chosen from among other people (NCV)

Every high priest: The phrase Every high priest refers to each high priest of the people of Israel. It does not include the high priests of other peoples or religions. In some languages it is necessary to indicate that the phrase refers to high priests of Israel. For example:

The one who is appointed highest priest for us

With us Israel people, each time the Most-important Priest is chosen

Each high priest of Israel

Remember that the Jewish author was speaking to Jewish people who were Christians. When Jews spoke of themselves, they used the term “Israel.” Notice the final two examples in the note above, which correctly use “Israel.” For more information, see Israel, Jew, Hebrew, the Circumcised in KBT.

high priest: The term high priest occurred first in Hebrews at 2:17. Translate it as you did there.

from among men: The Greek word that the BSB translates as men means “people.” The word refers to human beings, male and female (though the high priest was always male). He was chosen from among his fellow human beings. Some other ways to translate from among men are:

from his fellow men

from among other human beings

5:1b

to represent them in matters relating to God,

- to represent them as they worship God.
- God gives him responsibility for the people's service/worship

to represent them in matters relating to God: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as to represent them means “appoint (assign) someone to be in authority.” See *καθίστημι* meaning 2 BDAG, page 492, “to assign someone a position of authority, appoint, put in charge.” The verb is passive. It implies that God is the one who puts the high priest in charge.

The phrase to represent them in matters relating to God means that God gives the high priest authority to represent the people in serving God. The high priest brings the people's sacrifices to God and communicates with God for the people.

Some other ways to translate this part of the verse are:

is appointed to represent the people in the things/matters that God has determined

God entrusts him with the work of serving him in the name of the people

to represent them: The phrase to represent them means “representing the people,” “for the people,” “for the people's benefit.” The high priest had the authority to speak to God for the people. He also did other things for God as the people's representative,

such as offer sacrifices. The Greek text is literally, “for them” or “on behalf of them.” The author makes a contrast between *ex anthrōpōn* (“from men”) and *huper anthrōpōn* (“for men” or “on behalf of men”).

Some other ways to translate the phrase to represent them are:

bringing the name of the people
Uma back translation on TW.

to be their representatives

matters relating to God: The phrase matters relating to God refers to matters that are related to God. In this context it refers to service to God. This service includes things that are done for God, to him, or with him, or things that he himself does. Here the author refers mainly to matters of worshiping God and making sacrifices to him.

This phrase was also used in 2:17, where the BSB translates it as “in service to God.” You may be able to translate it in a similar way here. However, it is a general phrase, so it may be translated in different ways to fit the context.

5:1c

to offer gifts and sacrifices for sins.

- The high priest must offer gifts and sacrifices to God because of the people’s sins.
- to offer gifts and animal sacrifices so that God will forgive their sins.

to offer gifts and sacrifices for sins: This clause tells the purpose of appointing the high priest on behalf of other people. He is appointed to offer gifts and sacrifices to God so that God will forgive the people’s sins.

Some other ways to translate this purpose are:

so that he may present their offerings and sacrifices to God to atone for their sins

to offer to God the animals or other offerings that they bring so that God will forgive their sins

to help others by offering gifts and sacrifices to God because of their sins (CEV)

In some languages it is more natural to begin a new sentence here. For example:

He offers gifts and sacrifices to God so that God will forgive their sins.

offer: The Greek word that the BSB translates as offer is a common word that often means “bring (or take).” In this context it refers to bringing something (to offer or present) to God. When an Israelite brought an animal or a different offering for God, a priest took the offering and presented it to God in the proper way. If the offering was an animal, the priest killed it. Then he burned all or part of it on the altar or in another special place.

Some other ways to translate offer are:

give to God

sacrifice/present to God

take/bring to God

In some languages there are special ways to refer to making offerings to God. If you must use different terms for different types of offerings in your language, you may refer here to the type of sacrifice that requires killing an animal or bird. Use a natural way in your language to refer to a priest presenting this type of offering to God.

gifts and sacrifices for sins: The author connected the words gifts and sacrifices with two Greek conjunctions. This connection probably implies that both the gifts and the sacrifices are offered to obtain forgiveness for sins. Allen (page 315, Kindle edition) says, “The final phrase ‘for sins’ probably refers to both gifts and sacrifices since the two nouns are connected by the Greek particle *te*.” However, some scholars consider that the word gifts has no connection with the phrase “for sins,” implying that the gifts are offered for a different purpose. Most English versions are ambiguous about this. The NLT and JBP are the only English versions on TW that explicitly do not connect gifts with the phrase “for sins.” O’Brien (page 190) says, “The sphere in which the high priest represents men and women is ‘in matters related to God’.... This general expression is further explained in the words that follow, to offer gifts and sacrifices for sins. Although it has been suggested that the gifts are peace and cereal offerings, while the ‘sacrifices’ are animal sacrifices, the terms are probably being used synonymously, even as a fixed phrase for sacrifices generally (as elsewhere in Heb. 8:3–4; 5:9; 11:4; see 5:3). Thus, the prepositional phrase, for sins, qualifies the whole, not simply the latter term. The expiatory activity of offering gifts and

sacrifices for sins was integral to the work of Israel's high priest, and is central to the work of Jesus as high priest, as Hebrews will proceed to show (9:26; 10:12)."

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

taking the gifts and sacrifices that the people bring and giving them to God so that he will forgive their sins

gifts and sacrifices: The Greek words that the BSB translates as gifts and sacrifices are similar in meaning. The word gifts refers to whatever people bring to the priest to give to God for them. The word sacrifices refers to offerings that involve killing an animal or bird as a gift to God. The people of Israel brought both animal sacrifices and other types of offerings to God. Montefiore (page 93) says, "if sacrifice was at the heart of the Hebrew religion, gifts were at the heart of sacrifice. No-one could appear before God with empty hands; the gift represented the worshipper's acknowledgment of God in His sovereign lordship;... The sacrifice must also be offered for expiation of sins."

Use appropriate words in your language to describe such offerings to God. Avoid words that refer only to offerings made to spirits, idols, rulers, or something else besides God. For more information, see sacrifice, sense 1(a), in KBT.

for sins: The phrase for sins implies the meaning "in order to atone for sins" or "to remove sins." For more translation examples, see the first note in 5:1c.

Hebrews 5:2

Section 5:1-10: God appointed Jesus Christ to be our high priest

The term "high priest" connects Section 4:14-16 with this section (5:1-10). In this section the author gives more information about the high priests of Israel and the work that they did. Then he compares the work of those high priests to the work of Christ as our high priest. The main point of this section is that Christ is the high priest because God said that he is.

The author mentions three facts about a high priest's role and applies them to Christ:

1. A high priest is appointed by God. The Scriptures show that Jesus Christ was appointed by God. In Hebrews 5:5-6, the author quotes Psalm 2:7 and 110:4 as evidence that God appointed him. Lane (page 118) says, "The writer correctly interprets Ps

2:7 as a declaration of appointment.... The same emphasis is evident in the quotation of Ps 110:4."

2. A high priest should understand and sympathize with the weaknesses of his people. In 5:7-8 the author talked about how Christ suffered and prayed to God with tears.
3. A high priest must offer a sacrifice to atone for the sins of the people. In 5:8-9 the author indicated that when Christ suffered and offered himself as a perfect sacrifice, he obtained eternal salvation for his people. This implies that he atoned for their sins.

In the Greek text for this section, the author usually used a pronoun ("he" or "him") to refer to Christ. He referred to him as "Christ" only once (5:5), and he did not use the term "Jesus" in this section. However, in the previous section (4:14) the author used the term "Jesus, the Son of God." Consider carefully how to refer to Christ in the verses where only a pronoun is used in Greek or English. You should use the term "Christ" instead of a pronoun in places where you think that the reader will be confused about who the pronoun refers to.

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Jesus Christ is the perfect high priest

God made his Son the high priest for his people

God declares that Jesus is a priest

Paragraph 5:1-4

This paragraph explains the duties of a high priest. He must offer the people's gifts to God, and he must offer sacrifices for their sins. He must also offer sacrifices for his own sins, since he, too, is sinful. He is a weak human being, so he is able to sympathize with his fellow human beings.

5:2

He is able to deal gently...since he himself is beset by weakness: This verse tells the reason that human high priests are able to be gentle with weak people.

The high priests are able to be gentle (5:2a) because they know that they themselves are weak and sinful (5:2b).

In some languages it is more natural to change the order of 5:2a and 5:2b, so that the reason in 5:2b comes first. For example:

^{2b}Since he himself is weak in many ways, ^{2a}he is able to be gentle with those who are ignorant and make mistakes. (GNT)

^{2b}Chief Priests are just human too, and they certainly also have many weaknesses. ^{2a}That's why they know how to be gentle to take care of people who are not yet mature and who do not yet know the right way.

If you put the reason first like this, it may also affect the first part of 5:3. You may need to repeat information in 5:3a. For an example, see the General Comment on 5:2-3 at the end of 5:3a-b.

5:2a

He is able to deal gently with those who are ignorant and misguided,

- He knows how to show compassion to people who do not know God's ways and to people who are easily deceived
- The high priest can be merciful to people when they do not understand God's will and do not know that what they are doing is wrong.

He is able to deal gently with those who are ignorant and misguided: This clause indicates that the high priest was able to be calm and moderate with those who were weak and ignorant. He controlled himself so that he would not become angry.

Other ways to translate this clause are:

he knows how to be gentle/merciful towards ignorant people and people who go astray

he can be patient with people who do not know how to do God's will and do wrong

deal gently with: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as deal gently with occurs only here in the New Testament. It refers to treating other people with calmness and respect. It indicates that the high priest should control his own feelings so that he will be patient even with the sinfulness of the people. He should be gentle with them and not treat them harshly.

Some other ways to translate this verb are:

be patient with

treat with compassion

feel pity for

those who are ignorant and misguided: Here the words ignorant and misguided both refer to the same type of people. These people sin because they do not know the way that God wants them to live or they do not seem to be able to live that way.

The word ignorant indicates that the people do not know how to behave. The word misguided indicates that they live without knowing what they should do. They act without being aware of the purpose of those actions. The author uses these similar words to emphasize the meaning.

Some other ways to translate this meaning are:

his fellow men who do not know what to do, who are overcome by sin because they are not strong. Otomi back translation on TW.

his companions who go astray who don't know that what they are doing is not right. Kankanaey back translation on TW.

5:2b

since he himself is beset by weakness.

- because he also is only a weak human being.
- He knows that he himself also has many weaknesses/faults.

since he himself is beset by weakness: This clause tells the reason why the high priest was able to help weak and ignorant people (5:2a). He could help them because he himself was a weak human being, so he understood the weakness of others.

beset by weakness: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as beset by weakness is more literally "surrounded by weakness" or "clothed with weakness." It indicates that a high priest is affected in many ways by human weakness. The word weakness refers here to a type of weakness that makes it difficult for a person to do what is right. It refers to moral or spiritual weakness, not to bodily weakness.

Some other ways to translate the phrase beset by weakness are:

he also has faults. Kankanaey back translation on TW.

he also is not strong/able to overcome all sins

Hebrews 5:3

Section 5:1–10: God appointed Jesus Christ to be our high priest

The term “high priest” connects Section 4:14–16 with this section (5:1–10). In this section the author gives more information about the high priests of Israel and the work that they did. Then he compares the work of those high priests to the work of Christ as our high priest. The main point of this section is that Christ is the high priest because God said that he is.

The author mentions three facts about a high priest’s role and applies them to Christ:

1. A high priest is appointed by God. The Scriptures show that Jesus Christ was appointed by God. In Hebrews 5:5–6, the author quotes Psalm 2:7 and 110:4 as evidence that God appointed him. Lane (page 118) says, “The writer correctly interprets Ps 2:7 as a declaration of appointment.... The same emphasis is evident in the quotation of Ps 110:4.”
2. A high priest should understand and sympathize with the weaknesses of his people. In 5:7–8 the author talked about how Christ suffered and prayed to God with tears.
3. A high priest must offer a sacrifice to atone for the sins of the people. In 5:8–9 the author indicated that when Christ suffered and offered himself as a perfect sacrifice, he obtained eternal salvation for his people. This implies that he atoned for their sins.

In the Greek text for this section, the author usually used a pronoun (“he” or “him”) to refer to Christ. He referred to him as “Christ” only once (5:5), and he did not use the term “Jesus” in this section. However, in the previous section (4:14) the author used the term “Jesus, the Son of God.” Consider carefully how to refer to Christ in the verses where only a pronoun is used in Greek or English. You should use the term “Christ” instead of a pronoun in places where you think that the reader will be confused about who the pronoun refers to.

Remember to read the section carefully before deciding on a heading for it. Some other examples of headings for this section are:

Jesus Christ is the perfect high priest

God made his Son the high priest for his people

God declares that Jesus is a priest

Paragraph 5:1–4

This paragraph explains the duties of a high priest. He must offer the people’s gifts to God, and he must offer sacrifices for their sins. He must also offer sacrifices for his own sins, since he, too, is sinful. He is a weak human being, so he is able to sympathize with his fellow human beings.

5:3a

That is why he is obligated to offer sacrifices for his own sins,

- That is why he must offer sacrifices for his own sins
- So he must make a sacrifice to atone for sins that he himself did,

5:3b

as well as for the sins of the people.

- and also for the sins of the people.
- and he must also make another sacrifice to atone for the sins of the people.

5:3a–b

That is why: The Greek word that the BSB translates as “That is why” refers back to 5:2b (“he himself is beset by weakness”). This statement in 5:2 implies that the OT high priests were too weak to overcome temptation. They also sinned, just as the people did. In 5:3 the author tells the result of the high priest being weak and sinful. He must also offer sacrifices for his own sins, in addition to the people’s sins.

Some other ways to translate this connection are:

and because of this (NRSV)

and for this reason (NET)

In some languages it is helpful to make the connection more explicit. For example:

Because he is weak (NCV)

So, since he is weak and also sins

And because he also sins Tagbanwa back translation on TW.

he is obligated to offer sacrifices for his own sins, as well as for the sins of the people: This statement indicates that the high priest also sinned (in addition to the people sinning). Because of that, the high priest had to offer sacrifices for his own sins, in addition to the sacrifices that he made for the sins of the people.

Some other ways to translate this statement are:

That is why he must offer sacrifices for his own sins and for the sins of others. (CEV)

So when he goes to offer a sacrifice for the sins of the people, he must also offer something for his own sins.

for the sins of the people: The phrase for the sins of the people indicates that he also offers sacrifices for the people's sins. See the examples in the preceding note.

General Comment on 5:2–3

In 5:2 it may be more natural in some languages to change the order of clauses so that 5:2b comes at the beginning of the sentence. If you do this in your language, you may need to repeat 5:2b at the beginning of 5:3 to make that verse clear. For example:

^{2b}Since he himself is weak, ^{2a}he is able to be gentle with those who do not understand and who are doing wrong things. ^{3a}And because ^{2b}he is himself weak, ^{3a}he must offer sacrifices ^{3b}not only for the sins of the people ^{3a}but also for his own sins. (NCV)

Translate 5:2–3 in the order that is most natural in your language.

Hebrews 5:4

Section 5:1–10: God appointed Jesus Christ to be our high priest

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The author mentions three facts about a high priest's role and applies them to Christ:

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Paragraph 5:1–4

This paragraph explains the duties of a high priest. He must offer the people's gifts to God, and he must offer sacrifices for their sins. He must also offer sacrifices for his own sins, since he, too, is sinful. He is a weak human being, so he is able to sympathize with his fellow human beings.

5:4a

No one takes this honor upon himself;

- No one can take the honor of being the high priest for/upon himself.
- A person cannot choose himself for the privilege of being the high priest.

No one takes this honor upon himself: In Greek this clause is more literally “and not to/for himself does anyone take the honor.” It indicates that no one must claim the honor of being high priest for himself. The BSB uses the phrase No one takes...upon himself to emphasize that no person has the right to make

himself a high priest. It is God who must choose the high priest. This implies that if a person tries to claim the honor of high priest for himself without God's choosing him, that person is daring to challenge God.

Some other ways to translate the clause are:

No one chooses for himself the honor of being a high priest. (GNT)

To be a high priest is an honor, but no one chooses himself for this work. (NCV)

And no one can become a high priest simply because he wants such an honor. (NLT)

this honor: The phrase this honor refers to the important role and work of being a high priest. See *τιμή*, meaning 2d. BDAG, page 1005. It indicates that being the high priest is a privilege. God has honored the person whom he chooses as high priest. Some other ways to translate the phrase are:

the important position of highest priest

this great respect that the high priest receives

5:4b

he must be called by God, just as Aaron was.

- He can take that honor only if God appoints him, as he appointed Aaron.
- God is the one who must call/choose him to be the high priest, as he called/chose Aaron.

he must be called by God: This clause tells how a person can become the high priest. He can have that role only if he is called by God. Notice that the verb called is passive here, though the text indicates that the subject is God. In some languages it is more natural to use an active verb. For example:

but rather it is necessary that God call him
Kankanaey back translation on TW.

he can take that work/role only if God chooses him to do it

he receives it when called by God (NIV)

called by God: The Greek word that the BSB translates as called means "to choose (a person) to receive a

special benefit or experience." Adopted from the entry on *καλέω*, meaning 4, BDAG, page 503. God chooses the person whom he wants to be the high priest and to do that special work.

Some other ways to translate the phrase called by God are:

when God chooses him and tells him to do that work

God must appoint him.

It is God who chooses him.

just as Aaron was: The clause just as Aaron was is a short way to say "in the same way that Aaron was called (chosen)" or "like God chose Aaron." Aaron was the older brother of Moses (see Exodus 7:7), and he was the first high priest. God chose him and his sons to be consecrated as priests after the people of Israel left Egypt.

Some ways to translate this clause are:

like God/he chose Aaron long ago

as Aaron was chosen by God in the past

See Exodus 28–29 and Leviticus 8–9 for more information about God choosing Aaron as the high priest.

Hebrews 5:5

Section 5:1–10: God appointed Jesus Christ to be our high priest

The term "high priest" connects Section 4:14–16 with this section (5:1–10). In this section the author gives more information about the high priests of Israel and the work that they did. Then he compares the work of those high priests to the work of Christ as our high priest. The main point of this section is that Christ is the high priest because God said that he is.

The author mentions three facts about a high priest's role and applies them to Christ:

1. A high priest is appointed by God. The Scriptures show that Jesus Christ was appointed by God. In Hebrews 5:5–6, the author quotes Psalm 2:7 and 110:4 as evidence that God appointed him. Lane (page 118) says, "The writer correctly interprets Ps 2:7 as a declaration of appointment.... The same emphasis is evident in the quotation of Ps 110:4."

2. A high priest should understand and sympathize with the weaknesses of his people. In 5:7–8 the author talked about how Christ suffered and prayed to God with tears.
3. A high priest must offer a sacrifice to atone for the sins of the people. In 5:8–9 the author indicated that when Christ suffered and offered himself as a perfect sacrifice, he obtained eternal salvation for his people. This implies that he atoned for their sins.

In the Greek text for this section, the author usually used a pronoun (“he” or “him”) to refer to Christ. He referred to him as “Christ” only once (5:5), and he did not use the term “Jesus” in this section. However, in the previous section (4:14) the author used the term “Jesus, the Son of God.” Consider carefully how to refer to Christ in the verses where only a pronoun is used in Greek or English. You should use the term “Christ” instead of a pronoun in places where you think that the reader will be confused about who the pronoun refers to.

Remember to read the section carefully before deciding on a heading for it. Some other examples of headings for this section are:

Jesus Christ is the perfect high priest

God made his Son the high priest for his people

God declares that Jesus is a priest

Paragraph 5:5–10

After the author described the call and duties of a high priest of Israel in 5:1–4, he applied this description to Jesus Christ in 5:5–10.

5:5a

So also Christ did not take upon Himself the glory of becoming a high priest,

- ¶ In the same way, Christ did not take the glory of being high priest upon himself.
- ¶ So also, Christ did not call/choose himself for the honor of being high priest.

So also Christ: Here the phrase So also introduces a comparison. It means “in the same way also.” It links 5:4 with 5:5: No one can claim the honor of being high priest unless God calls him (5:4). In the same way, Christ also did not take that honor for himself. He became high priest because God called him.

Some other ways to introduce the comparison are:

That is how it was with Christ (CEV)

In the same way, Christ (GNT)

Likewise also Christ

Introduce this comparison in a natural way in your language.

Christ: For information about how to translate Christ, see the note on “Christ” in 3:6a.

did not take upon Himself the glory of becoming a high priest: The phrase did not take upon Himself indicates that Christ did not take the glory of being a high priest on himself. He was not the one who decided that he should be the high priest. As 5:5b indicates, it was God who appointed him.

Some other ways to translate this meaning are:

did not choose himself for the honorable work of being high priest

did not decide on his own to take the privilege of being high priest

did not become the high priest by appointing himself for that honor

5:5b

but He was called by the One who said to Him:

- But it was God who said to him,
- God himself called/chose him, just as God said earlier and as it is written in the Scriptures,

but He was called by the One who said to Him:

This part of the verse is more literally, “but the one who said to him.” The word but Greek *alla*. implies a contrast with 5:5a (“Christ did not take upon Himself the glory of becoming a high priest”). It implies that someone else glorified him and made him high priest. That person was God. The BSB supplies the passive phrase was called by to imply that.

Some other ways to translate the contrast with 5:5a are:

- Refer to God giving Christ the glory of being high priest. This option supplies the contrast with “did not take upon Himself the glorify” in 5:5a. For example:

Instead, the glory was given to him by God, who said (GW)

it was God who gave him the honor of being the high priest

- Refer to God calling, appointing, or choosing Christ. This option supplies the comparison with “be called” in 5:4. For example:

but God chose him (NCV)

he was appointed/called by God

- Refer to God telling Christ. This option is a more literal translation of the Greek text. For example:

It was God who told him (CEV)

Use a natural option in your language.

who said to Him: The phrase who said to Him introduces a quotation from Psalm 2:7. The author also quoted this same verse in 1:5. Here it implies that when God said this, he was appointing Jesus to be the high priest. Some other ways to introduce the quotation are:

God said to him (NCV)

God who declared to him

5:5c

“You are My Son;

- “You^(sing) are my Son;
- “I am your^(sing) Father,

5:5d

today I have become Your Father.”

- and today I declare/show that I am your^(sing) Father.”
- and on this day I give you^(sing) the honor/authority that you deserve as my Son.”

5:5c–d

Here in 5:5c–d the author quoted from Psalm 2, just as he did in 1:5. Scholars call Psalm 2 a “messianic psalm” or a “royal psalm,” because it refers to the Messiah whom God promised to send as king. God fulfilled these promises when Christ came to the earth many years later. Remember that the words “Christ” and “Messiah” have the same meaning. Translate this quotation in the same way as you did in 1:5.

You are My Son; today I have become Your Father:

Christ has always been God’s Son, so this quotation does not refer to his birth. It refers to the time when God gave him glory as his Son. In the context it also specifically implies the honor of being the high priest for God’s people. Translate the quotation in the same way as you did in 1:5b–c. For more information, see the notes on 1:5b–c.

You...Your: The pronouns You and Your are singular and refer to Christ, the Son.

I: The pronoun I refers to God.

Hebrews 5:6

Section 5:1–10: God appointed Jesus Christ to be our high priest

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2. A high priest should understand and sympathize with the weaknesses of his people. In 5:7–8 the author talked about how Christ suffered and prayed to God with tears.
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In the Greek text for this section, the author usually used a pronoun (“he” or “him”) to refer to Christ. He referred to him as “Christ” only once (5:5), and he did not use the term “Jesus” in this section. However, in the previous section (4:14) the author used the term “Jesus, the Son of God.” Consider carefully how to refer to Christ in the verses where only a pronoun is used in Greek or English. You should use the term “Christ” instead of a pronoun in places where you think that

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God declares that Jesus is a priest

Paragraph 5:5–10

After the author described the call and duties of a high priest of Israel in 5:1–4, he applied this description to Jesus Christ in 5:5–10.

5:6a

And in another passage God says:

- And he said in another Scripture,
- And in another part/verse of God's Book/Word God said,

And in another passage God says: The clause And in another passage God says introduces another quotation from the OT. It refers to another verse of scripture that tells something that God said. It does not refer to a location. Some other ways to translate the clause are:

And in another verse God also saidUma back translation on TW.

And there is another word written in the Holy Book which says:Otomi back translation on TW.

Use the normal way in your language to refer to a specific verse or part of the Scriptures.

5:6b

“You are a priest forever in the order of Melchizedek.”

- “You^(sing) are a priest forever in Melchizedek's way/order.”
- “I declare that there will be no end to your^(sing) being a priest. Your priesthood is the type of priesthood that Melchizedek had.”

This part of the verse is a quotation from Psalm 110:4. In Psalm 110 its author speaks about the Messiah (Christ), so the psalm is called a “Messianic psalm.” It indicates that the Messiah is a priest and also a king. Psalm 2 (quoted in 1:8) is also a messianic psalm. It

speaks of the Messiah as king. The book of Hebrews indicates that Jesus our Messiah is both king and priest.

You are a priest forever in the order of Melchizedek:

Here the author quotes from the Old Testament. This quotation tells what God spoke to Christ. God spoke to Christ and announced that Christ is a priest forever with the type of priesthood that Melchizedek also had.

Some other ways to translate this statement are:

You are a priest forever, in the way that Melchizedek was a priest.

You will be a priest forever, and your priesthood will be the type of priesthood that Melchizedek had.

priest: The word priest refers to a person who speaks to God for people and makes sacrifices on their behalf so that God will forgive their sins. The author of Hebrews often uses the terms priest and “high priest” to refer to Jesus, as well as to other priests. The word priest is a general word, and it can refer to both ordinary priests and to the high priest.

Some ways to translate priest are:

- Use a descriptive term that focuses on the function of a priest. For example:

sacrificer

man/person who offers sacrifices to God

one who represents people to God

- Use a local word for priest. This option fits best if the local word can be used in a general way to refer to any priest. Test the word carefully throughout Hebrews to be sure that it does not imply a wrong meaning. The word is more likely to fit if the duties of a local priest are similar to the duties of a priest of Israel.

The author used the term priest in this verse for the first time in Hebrews. However, he uses the term often in chapter 7 and a few times in chapters 8–10. The term you use for priest here should be the same as the one that you use in the gospels, for example, in Luke 1:5. If possible, choose a term that can be used in both Old Testament and New Testament contexts.

forever: The word forever refers to a time that continues and never ends throughout eternity. Here it refers to Jesus' priesthood that will continue forever. He will always be a priest, so he is very different from other priests who lived and died. The word forever is similar to the word "eternal," which is a key word in the book of Hebrews.

Some other ways to translate "You are a priest forever" are:

you will be a priest for eternity

As for you, you will be priest without ending
Tagbanwa back translation on TW.

there is no end to your being a priest
Western Bukidnon Manobo back translation on TW.

in the order of Melchizedek: The phrase in the order of Melchizedek indicates that the priesthood of Jesus was of the same type as the priesthood of Melchizedek. It cannot refer here to a sequence of priests, because Melchizedek was the only priest of that type except for Jesus.

Some other ways to translate in the order of Melchizedek are:

like the priesthood that Melchizedek had

in the tradition of Melchizedek's priesthood

of Melchizedek's type

Melchizedek: This is the first time that the author mentions Melchizedek. Hebrews is the only NT book that refers to Melchizedek, but Genesis describes him as the King of Salem, and "the priest of the Most High God." For more information about him, see Genesis 14:18-20. The author will compare Melchizedek and Christ in greater detail in chapter 7.

Hebrews 5:7

Section 5:1-10: God appointed Jesus Christ to be our high priest

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The author mentions three facts about a high priest's role and applies them to Christ:

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Jesus Christ is the perfect high priest

God made his Son the high priest for his people

God declares that Jesus is a priest

Paragraph 5:5-10

After the author described the call and duties of a high priest of Israel in 5:1-4, he applied this description to Jesus Christ in 5:5-10.

5:7-10

The verses in 5:7-10 are parallel to 5:1-3 in the chiasm of 5:1-10. In Greek these verses continue the long sentence that began in 5:5. The sentence continues until

the end of 5:10. Most versions divide these verses into shorter sentences. Connect the clauses in a natural way in your language.

These verses describe a time or times in Jesus' life when he prayed with great distress. Many scholars believe that the author referred to Christ's prayers in the Garden of Gethsemane before he was arrested and killed. Other scholars point out that there are also many other times in Jesus' life when he prayed in distress. God heard Jesus during all those times.

5:7a

During the days of Jesus' earthly life,

- During his/Christ's mortal life,
- While he/Jesus was living as a human being on earth,

During the days of Jesus' earthly life: The phrase During the days of Jesus' earthly life refers to the time when Jesus lived as a mortal human being. He was a person with flesh and blood, like other people on earth. He knew that he would die.

Another way to translate During the days of Jesus' earthly life is:

During his mortal life

While he shared in human weakness

In some languages it may be helpful to translate earthly life as "life on earth," as many English versions do. For example:

During his life on earth (GW)

5:7b

He offered up prayers and petitions with loud cries and tears

- he prayed with weeping and tears, and pleaded
- he shouted loudly and wept as he earnestly begged

He: The Greek word that the BSB translates as He is a pronoun that is often translated as "who." It refers back to "Christ" in 5:5 (5:5-10 is one long sentence in Greek), and some versions have the word "Christ" here.

Some versions supply the name "Jesus," as in the NRSV. Such versions may refer back to the phrase "Jesus, the Son of God" in 4:14. In some languages it may be helpful to refer to "Jesus Christ." Refer to him here in a clear way in your language.

offered up prayers and petitions with loud cries and tears: This phrase describes a time when Jesus prayed earnestly to God. The description has two emphatic phrases: offered up prayers and petitions and with loud cries and tears.

In some languages it is more natural to change the order of these phrases so that loud cries and tears comes first. For example:

he cried out weeping, petitioning, and uttering his requests
Uma back translation on TW.

his tears flowed and he wailed as he prayed and begged God

offered up prayers and petitions: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as offered up can be used in a general way to mean "bring to." It can also mean "bring an offering to" God. Here the author used it in a figurative way to mean that Christ's prayers and supplications were like an offering to God. προσφέρω, meaning 2b, BDAG, page 886. This figure of speech emphasizes that Jesus prayed earnestly.

In some languages it may be more natural to translate the meaning without the figure of speech. For example:

He prayed and pleaded (GW)

prayers and petitions: Here the author used two words that have almost the same meaning. Repeating the meaning like this emphasizes it. It implies here that Jesus prayed very earnestly. In some languages it is more natural to emphasize the statement in some other way. For example:

he prayed fervently

The Greek word that the BSB translates as prayers means "urgent requests to God to meet certain needs." The word petitions means "requests to God." It occurs only here in the NT. Some ways to translate the two words are:

prayers and requests (GNT)

prayers and pleadings (NLT)

begged God, praying earnestly

loud cries and tears: The Greek word that is translated as loud cries refers to “loud calls or shouts.” The word tears refers to water that comes from a person’s eyes in times of distress or strong feeling. Some other ways to translate the phrase loud cries and tears are:

His tears flowed and he wailed Western Bukidnon Manobo back translation on TW.

weeping and crying out loud

5:7c

to the One who could save Him from death,

- with the one who could rescue him from dying.
- God to help him, knowing that God had the power to save him from dying.

to the One who could save Him from death: The phrase the One who could save Him from death refers to God. In the Greek text it is emphasized. Scholars interpret the phrase save Him from death in different ways. The three main views are:

1. It means “save him from dying.”
2. It means “save him out of death—to give him life again after he died.” (This happened at his resurrection.)
3. It means “save him from the fear of death.”

Most English versions are ambiguous. God was able to save Jesus from death in every sense, because he can do anything. If you need to choose one of the interpretations, it is recommended that you choose either interpretation (1) or (2). Both interpretations are based on common uses of the Greek word that can be translated either as from or “out of.”

5:7d

and He was heard because of His reverence.

- And he was heard because he was willing to submit to God.
- Because he devoted himself humbly/respectfully to God, God listened to his prayer.
- He submitted himself willingly to God, so God answered his prayer.

and He was heard because of His reverence: The phrase because of His reverence gives the reason that Jesus was heard when he prayed to God. In some languages it is more natural for this reason to come before the result He was heard. For example:

He submitted humbly to the will/desire of God.
That is why God heard his request.

And because His respect for God was great, and also His obedience to the commands of God, God heard his praying. Western Bukidnon Manobo back translation on TW.

He was heard: The phrase He was heard is passive. It implies that God heard Jesus’ prayer. It does not only indicate that he heard what Jesus said. It also implies that God listened and gave Jesus the help that he needed.

Some ways to translate the phrase are:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

And his prayers really were answered Tagbanwa back translation on TW.

- Use an active verb and supply God as the subject. For example:

God heard his praying Western Bukidnon Manobo back translation on TW.

because of His reverence: The phrase because of His reverence indicates the reason why God heard Christ’s prayer. The Greek word that the BSB translates as reverence refers to awe or fear of God that causes a person to obey God. It implies that because of Jesus’ respect for God, he submitted to God and obeyed him. This word occurs only here and in 12:28 in the NT, but it also occurs in other Greek writings.

Some other ways to translate this meaning are:

because he honored God by submitting to him

because he humbled/lowered himself to obey what God wanted Kankanaey back translation on TW.

Hebrews 5:8

Section 5:1–10: God appointed Jesus Christ to be our high priest

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Jesus Christ is the perfect high priest

God made his Son the high priest for his people

God declares that Jesus is a priest

Paragraph 5:5–10

After the author described the call and duties of a high priest of Israel in 5:1–4, he applied this description to Jesus Christ in 5:5–10.

5:8a–b

Although He was a Son, He learned obedience from what He suffered: This statement expresses surprise. It expresses a fact that is contrary to what people expect. That even Christ, the Son of God, needed to suffer in order to fully obey God. The phrase learned obedience does not imply that the Son was disobedient or that he did not know how to obey. It indicates that when the Son was a man on earth, he had to

suffer in order to obey the Father. Then he learned the type of obedience that involves suffering or causes suffering.

In some languages it may be helpful to mention “suffering” before learned obedience. For example:

He, being Son of God, still suffered. Through his suffering, he learned/experienced obedience.

Some other ways to translate the meaning are:

but Son though he was, he had to prove the meaning of obedience through all that he suffered (JBP)

Even though Christ was the Son of God, yet in order that he might obey God, he let himself go through suffering.

5:8a

Although He was a Son,

- He is God’s Son, but still
- But even though he was the Son of God,

Although He was a Son: In Greek this phrase is more literally, “Though being Son.” It emphasizes Christ’s identity as the Son of God. It does not imply that there was more than one son. In some languages it is necessary to supply the word for “God.” For example:

But even though he was God’s Son (GNT)

Jesus is God’s own Son, but still... (CEV)

5:8b

He learned obedience from what He suffered.

- he learned to obey God by means of the suffering that he endured.
- he suffered much and discovered how to obey God as a human being.

He learned obedience from what He suffered: The phrase He learned obedience indicates that Christ learned (experienced) submitting to God even when the submission caused him to suffer. In some languages a phrase like learned obedience wrongly implies that Christ was only pretending to obey. The note in the Uma back translation (TW) says, “in Uma to say ‘he learned to obey’ implies that he was just pretending or imitating.” In other languages it wrongly implies that Christ was disobedient until he learned from suffering that he ought to obey.

If this phrase implies such a wrong meaning in your language, use a different way to describe Jesus' experience of obeying God as he suffered. For example:

he experienced the meaning of obeying God through/by what he suffered

through all that he endured, he realized the meaning of following/obeying God

he too underwent suffering, and he submitted to God like mankindUma back translation on TW.

obedience: The word obedience refers to listening to someone (here, listening to God) and doing what he says to do. In some languages it is more natural to translate obedience as a phrase or clause. For example:

to obey God

to listen to God and do as he says/commands

from what He suffered: The phrase from what He suffered indicates the means by which Christ "learned obedience." He learned it by suffering and in the process of suffering. The phrase what He suffered is a general way to refer to all the pain, sorrow, tortures, and agony that Christ endured when he died to atone for our sins.

For translation examples, see the first note on 5:8b.

Hebrews 5:9

Section 5:1–10: God appointed Jesus Christ to be our high priest

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Paragraph 5:5–10

After the author described the call and duties of a high priest of Israel in 5:1–4, he applied this description to Jesus Christ in 5:5–10.

5:9a

And having been made perfect,

- And after he was made completely qualified/prepared,
- Then after God used all these sufferings to prepare him,

And: Here some translations continue the sentence that started at the beginning of verse 5:8. In some languages, it is more natural to begin a new sentence at 5:9, as modelled by the BSB.

having been made perfect: The Greek word that the BSB translates as having been made perfect is a form of the same verb that was used in 2:10. The verb has

several meanings, which are based on being complete or mature. In this context the verb refers to being completely qualified. It indicates that Christ was totally prepared for the work of being high priest.

Jesus never sinned, so the phrase having been made perfect does not refer to being purified from sin. Rather, it refers back to 5:8 where Christ obeyed God, though it caused him to suffer and die. The phrase indicates that when Christ obeyed God like that, he became completely qualified to give his people eternal salvation.

Some other ways to translate the verb in this context are:

In this way, God qualified him as a perfect High Priest (NLT)

And then after he was completely prepared

See how you translated this verb in 2:10, and translate it in a similar way here.

5:9b

He became the source of eternal salvation

- he became the cause/giver of salvation that continues forever
- he was able to save/rescue forever

5:9c

to all who obey Him

- for all those who obey/submit to him.
- everyone who listens to and obeys him.

5:9b–c

He became the source of eternal salvation to all who obey Him: The Greek word that the BSB translates as source can also mean “cause.” In this context both meanings indicate that Christ became the one who can cause people who obey him to receive eternal salvation.

Some other ways to translate this meaning are:

he became the one who can cause all people who obey him to receive eternal salvation

now he is able to give/offer eternal salvation to everyone who obeys him

now he is the one who is able to save forever all who listen to him and do what he says

He: Remember that He refers back to “Christ” in 5:5.

eternal salvation: The phrase eternal salvation refers to salvation that continues forever. The word salvation occurred in 1:14 with the same meaning as it has here. You may translate it in the same way here.

In some languages it is more natural to translate salvation as a verb or a phrase. For example:

to save forever

to rescue people to live forever with God

As mentioned in 5:6b, eternal is a key word in Hebrews. For more information on salvation, see save, sense B, in KBT.

to all who obey Him: The phrase to all who obey Him means “for each person who obeys Christ.” It indicates that people who submit to Christ will receive the salvation which he provided for them. The verb obey has the same meaning as the noun “obedience” in 5:8b. Translate it in a similar way here.

Some other ways to translate the phrase to all who obey Him are:

all the people who do what he tells them

all people who listen and follow/obey him

Him: The pronoun Him refers to Christ.

Hebrews 5:10

Section 5:1–10: God appointed Jesus Christ to be our high priest

The term “high priest” connects Section 4:14–16 with this section (5:1–10). In this section the author gives more information about the high priests of Israel and the work that they did. Then he compares the work of those high priests to the work of Christ as our high priest. The main point of this section is that Christ is the high priest because God said that he is.

The author mentions three facts about a high priest’s role and applies them to Christ:

1. A high priest is appointed by God. The Scriptures show that Jesus Christ was appointed by God. In Hebrews 5:5–6, the author quotes Psalm 2:7 and 110:4 as evidence that God appointed him. Lane (page 118) says, “The writer correctly interprets Ps 2:7 as a declaration of appointment.... The same emphasis is evident in the quotation of Ps 110:4.”

2. A high priest should understand and sympathize with the weaknesses of his people. In 5:7–8 the author talked about how Christ suffered and prayed to God with tears.
3. A high priest must offer a sacrifice to atone for the sins of the people. In 5:8–9 the author indicated that when Christ suffered and offered himself as a perfect sacrifice, he obtained eternal salvation for his people. This implies that he atoned for their sins.

In the Greek text for this section, the author usually used a pronoun (“he” or “him”) to refer to Christ. He referred to him as “Christ” only once (5:5), and he did not use the term “Jesus” in this section. However, in the previous section (4:14) the author used the term “Jesus, the Son of God.” Consider carefully how to refer to Christ in the verses where only a pronoun is used in Greek or English. You should use the term “Christ” instead of a pronoun in places where you think that the reader will be confused about who the pronoun refers to.

Remember to read the section carefully before deciding on a heading for it. Some other examples of headings for this section are:

Jesus Christ is the perfect high priest

God made his Son the high priest for his people

God declares that Jesus is a priest

Paragraph 5:5–10

After the author described the call and duties of a high priest of Israel in 5:1–4, he applied this description to Jesus Christ in 5:5–10.

5:10

In this final verse of Section 5:1–10 the author said that God appointed Christ as a high priest in the order of Melchizedek. In 5:6 the author quoted the words that God said to Christ at that time: “You are a priest forever in the order of Melchizedek.” The author repeated what God said to Christ to emphasize the importance of Jesus being a priest in the order of Melchizedek.

5:10a

and was designated by God as high priest

- He was appointed by God to be high priest
- God chose/designated him as high priest,
- God is the one who made him high priest.

and was designated by God as high priest: The people of Israel had only one high priest at a time,

and each high priest served until his death. Since God appointed Christ as high priest and Christ will never die again, he will be the only high priest forever.

The verb that the BSB translates as designated only occurs here in the NT. Its meaning is similar to the verb that is translated as “appointed.” The form of the verb is passive, but God is mentioned as the one who appointed Christ to be high priest.

Some other ways to translate the statement are:

and God declared him to be high priest (GNT)

God appointed him to become the high priest
O-tomi back translation on TW.

high priest: The Greek word that the BSB translates as high priest was used in 5:1, but the more general word “priest” was used in 5:6. Use the same word or phrase that you used in 5:1a.

5:10b

in the order of Melchizedek.

- in the tradition/way of Melchizedek’s priesthood.
- saying, “You^(sing) are a priest forever in Melchizedek’s way/order.”
- God said, “I declare that there will be no end to your being a priest. Your priesthood is the type of priesthood that Melchizedek had.”

in the order of Melchizedek: The phrase in the order of Melchizedek was used in 5:6b. Translate it in the same way here.

General Comment on 5:10a–b

In some languages it is more natural to translate 5:10 as a separate sentence. For example:

God appointed him chief priest in the way
Melchizedek was a priest. (GW)

Hebrews 5:11

Section 5:11–6:12: Grow up in your faith, and do not give up

In Section 5:11–6:12 the author interrupted his teaching about God appointing Christ as the high priest in order to tell his listeners to mature in their faith and to warn them not to stop believing in Christ. After this warning (6:4–12), he will continue to teach them in 6:13–7:28 about the priesthood of Jesus and Melchizedek.

Remember to translate the section before choosing a heading for it. Some other possible headings are:

Warning about abandoning Christ

Do not be lazy but become mature followers of Christ

Paragraph 5:11–14

In verses 11–14 the author told his listeners that they were like babies who do not understand much about God and his Word. He told them that they ought to be like teachers, not like babies.

5:11a

We have much to say about this,

- ¶ There are many things that I want to say about this,
- ¶ I have much to teach you^(plur) about this topic of Christ's priesthood in the order of Melchizedek.

We have much to say about this: The author put the phrase about this. Most English versions and commentators interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as “this” to refer to a topic (the high priesthood of Christ in the order of Melchizedek). However, a few versions and commentators believe that it refers to a person, either Melchizedek or Christ. at the beginning of the sentence to emphasize it. In some languages it is more natural to begin the sentence in a different way, as modelled by the BSB. In other languages it may be preferable to follow the Greek word order. For example:

About this we have much to say (NRSV)

We: Here the author used the word We to refer to himself, as was common for Greek authors. The word We does not include the readers, and it does not indicate that there is more than one author of Hebrews. In many languages it is more natural and accurate to use “I” here. See the examples in the following note on “have much to say.”

have much to say: In Greek the phrase have much to say is more literally “much (is) the word.” It indicates that the author wants to explain much more about Christ being our high priest in the order of Melchizedek. Some other ways to translate the phrase are:

there is much to tell you

There are many more things I would like to tell you

The author already said something about Christ and Melchizedek in 5:7 and 10. So in some languages it may be helpful to indicate that he has more to say about that topic. For example:

There is much more we would like to say about this (NLT)

about this: The phrase about this refers to the topic that the author has been discussing in 4:14–16 and 5:1–10. That topic is that Christ is our great high priest and his priesthood is like the priesthood of Melchizedek (5:10).

Some ways to refer back to this topic are:

- Refer to the topic in a general way. For example:

About this topic/matter

- Refer to the topic more specifically. For example:

There is much that I could say here concerning the priesthood of Jesus and Melchizedek Tagbanwa back translation on TW.

5:11b

but it is hard to explain, because you are dull of hearing.

- but it is difficult to explain to you^(plur) because you are slow/lazy learners.
- However, you^(plur) do not think carefully/hard about such matters, so it is difficult for me to help you understand them.

but it is hard to explain, because you are dull of hearing: In this part of the verse the author tells his listeners why it is difficult to explain Christ's high priesthood to them. The reason is that they are dull of hearing. As a result, it is hard to explain the topic to them in a way that they can understand. Some other ways to translate this result and its reason are:

it is hard to make it clear to you because you no longer try to understand (NIV)

it is not easy to explain it to you because you do not seem to really listen

In some languages it is more natural to change the order of the reason and result so that the reason comes first. For example:

But you don't seem to listen, so it's hard to make you understand. (NLT96)

hard to explain: The BSB phrase hard to explain is one word in Greek. This word often refers to a topic that is difficult to understand in itself. However, in this context the author indicates that his topic is hard to explain to them because they are lazy in listening to it. They do not think about it carefully enough to understand it. Some other ways to translate this word are:

difficult to make it clear to you

hard to make you know/understand

because you are dull of hearing: This clause tells the reason why it was difficult for the author to explain the high priesthood of Christ to his listeners. The reason is that they were too lazy (slow) to understand it. The word the BSB translates as dull means "slow/lazy" and is translated as "sluggish" in 6:12, but it does not occur anywhere else in the NT.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

because you are so slow to understand (GNT)

you have become too dull/lazy to understand it

In some languages there is a figure of speech for this meaning. For example:

your heads/ears have become too hard

The author said this to encourage his listeners to try harder to understand what he wanted to teach them. Translate this meaning in a natural way in your language.

Hebrews 5:12

Section 5:11–6:12: Grow up in your faith, and do not give up

In Section 5:11–6:12 the author interrupted his teaching about God appointing Christ as the high priest in order to tell his listeners to mature in their faith and to warn them not to stop believing in Christ. After this warning (6:4–12), he will continue to teach them in 6:13–7:28 about the priesthood of Jesus and Melchizedek.

Remember to translate the section before choosing a heading for it. Some other possible headings are:

Warning about abandoning Christ

Do not be lazy but become mature followers of Christ

Paragraph 5:11–14

In verses 11–14 the author told his listeners that they were like babies who do not understand much about God and his Word. He told them that they ought to be like teachers, not like babies.

5:12

In this verse the author rebuked his listeners for not understanding more about God's word. He implied that they had known about Christ for a long time, so they should be ready to teach others about him. Instead they still needed someone to teach them the most basic truths that God has revealed to people.

5:12a–b

by this time you ought to be teachers, you need someone to reteach you: This statement implies that the listeners still did not understand basic truths about being a Christian. They had been Christians for a long time, so now they should be able to teach people about the Christian faith. However, they still needed other people to teach them.

Some other ways to translate the statement are:

By now you should have been teachers, but you still need a teacher to repeat to you what you learned before.

At a time when you should be teaching others, you need teachers yourselves (JBP)

Notice that the word reteach refers specifically here to teaching about God's word and the Christian faith. It does not imply that the listeners should have become professional teachers or teachers of other subjects. In some languages it is necessary to refer specifically to Christian teaching. For example:

Now for a long time you have heard about Jesus Christ. If you had not been sluggish in listening, you would now be teaching other people about him.

5:12a

Although by this time you ought to be teachers,

- By now you should already be teachers of these things/truths.

- Indeed, you should already be teaching them to others,

Although: The common Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *Although* introduces an explanation. It supports what the author said about the readers being “dull of hearing” (5:11). The word *Although* indicates that what the author is about to say in 5:12a is unexpected. Some other ways to translate the connection between these clauses in English are:

There has been enough time for you to be teachers—yet you still need someone to teach you (GNT)

You have been believers so long now that you ought to be teaching others. Instead, you need someone to teach you (NLT)

By now you should be teachers, but you need someone to teach you (NCV)

Connect the clauses in a natural way in your language.

by this time: The phrase *by this time* refers to the time when the author was writing to his listeners. The author implied that as he was writing to them, they had already been Christians for some time. He also implied that since they first trusted in Christ, they had been hearing God’s word, so now they should know enough to teach it to others. Other ways to translate the phrase are:

Actually it is time

By now (NET)

by this time...because you began to trust in Jesus long ago Ellis Diebler, SSA of Hebrews, chapter 5, page 8, prepublication copy.

you ought to be teachers: The clause *you ought to be teachers* indicates that the listeners should be teaching other people about God’s word. Some other ways to translate this clause are:

you ought to be teaching others (NLT)

you should be the ones who are teaching your companions Kankanaey back translation on TW.

You ought to be able to preach/teach now Yakan back translation on TW.

you: The pronoun *you* is plural and refers to the people who were listening to the book of Hebrews.

teachers: The word *teachers* refers to people who teach others. It is a general word that can refer to anyone who teaches, either formally or informally. It was often used to describe people who taught about God. For example, it is used of John the Baptist (Luke 3:12) and of Jesus (Mark 4:38).

In some languages it is more natural to use a verb. For example:

you^(plur) should be able to explain these truths to others

By now you^(plur) should be teaching other people these truths.

5:12b

you need someone to reteach you the basic principles of God’s word.

- Instead, you^(plur) need someone to teach you again the first lessons of God’s word.
- but you^(plur) need someone to repeat for you even the basic teachings about God’s message.

you need someone to reteach you: The clause *you need someone to reteach you* implies that someone already taught the listeners about Christ. When they joined the Christian community, they were taught the basic truths that Christians believe. Now they seem to have forgotten these truths, so they need someone to teach them again.

Some other ways to translate 5:12b are:

you still need to have someone else to teach you again Western Bukidnon Manobo back translation on TW.

you still have to be taught/preached-to again Yakan back translation on TW.

the basic principles of God’s word: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as *basic principles* is more literally “fundamental principles of the beginning.” The phrase is more literally “fundamental-principles of the beginning.” The phrase “of the beginning” adds emphasis here to the basic meaning of *στοιχείων*, which is “fundamental principles” (meaning 1c, BDAG, page

946). It refers to the simple truths and principles on which our trust in God is based.

These principles are usually the first truths that people are taught about God, Christ, and salvation when they become Christians. They are God's word because God is the one who spoke them and revealed them to his people.

Some other ways to translate the basic principles of God's word are:

the elementary truths of God's word (NIV)

the first lessons of God's message (NCV)

the simplest things about what God has said (CEV)

5:12c

You need milk, not solid food!

- You^(plur) still seem to need milk, not solid/proper food!
- You^(plur) still need simple teaching, like a child who still needs milk and cannot eat other food.
- You are like a young child who can understand only simple teaching. You^(plur) are not mature enough to understand more difficult teaching.

You need milk, not solid food: Here the author used a metaphor. He compared basic teaching to milk. The word milk often refers to "breast milk" that babies and young children take directly from their mothers' breasts. The author compared the teaching about Jesus being our high priest to solid food. It is a teaching for mature Christians.

In some languages this metaphor may not be clear. Some other ways to translate it are:

- Use a simile. For example:

You are like babies who need milk and cannot eat solid food. (NLT)

You still need basic/simple teaching that is like milk. You are not yet ready for the advanced teaching that is like solid food.

- Use a more general comparison. For example:

You are like a young child who can understand only simple teaching. You are not mature enough to understand more difficult teaching.

solid food: The phrase solid food refers to food that must be chewed, like meat or vegetables. Small babies cannot eat that kind of food because they cannot chew it. Remember that the author used solid food as a metaphor to refer to the complex truths that he wanted to teach them.

In some languages a word like solid is not necessary, because food already contrasts with milk. For example:

You again want to be like babies who are nursing, and yet it is necessary that you eat food. Otomi back translation on TW.

It's as if you have become a baby who still needs to nurse, because he can't chew food. Kankanaey back translation on TW.

Hebrews 5:13

Section 5:11–6:12: Grow up in your faith, and do not give up

In Section 5:11–6:12 the author interrupted his teaching about God appointing Christ as the high priest in order to tell his listeners to mature in their faith and to warn them not to stop believing in Christ. After this warning (6:4–12), he will continue to teach them in 6:13–7:28 about the priesthood of Jesus and Melchizedek.

Remember to translate the section before choosing a heading for it. Some other possible headings are:

Warning about abandoning Christ

Do not be lazy but become mature followers of Christ

Paragraph 5:11–14

In verses 11–14 the author told his listeners that they were like babies who do not understand much about God and his Word. He told them that they ought to be like teachers, not like babies.

5:13–14

In 5:13–14, the author explained the figure of speech "You need milk, not solid food" (5:12c). People who do not know what God says about righteousness are like babies who only drink milk (5:13). Mature believers know the difference between right and wrong. They are like mature people who eat "solid food." (5:14).

5:13a–b

For everyone who lives on milk is still an infant, inexperienced in the message of righteousness: This

verse indicates that people who only pay attention to simple teaching are like babies who still drink only milk. They do not understand much about the word of righteousness.

In some languages it is necessary to make the comparison more explicit. For example:

for a person like that who lives only on the “milk” of simple teachings is like an infant. He does not know much about the word of righteousness.

A person who only understands simple teachings is like an infant living on milk. He is not trained in the teaching about righteousness.

5:13a

For everyone who lives on milk is still an infant,

- Anyone who drinks only milk is still a baby.
- Anyone who learns/studies only the basic teachings is still like a nursing infant.

everyone who lives on milk is still an infant: The Greek text of 5:13 has the explanatory conjunction *gar*, as did 5:12. The BSB, RSV, NRSV and NASB translate it as “For.” But many newer versions leave the connection implicit, as being more natural in current English. The phrase everyone who lives on milk is still an infant refers to someone who has no nourishment except milk because he is a baby. He cannot digest any food except milk until he becomes old enough to eat other food. In many cultures infants take only milk from their mother’s breast until they are ready to eat other food.

Another way to translate this meaning is

anyone who drinks/takes-in only milk because he is still like a baby

5:13b

inexperienced in the message of righteousness.

- He does not understand the teaching about righteousness/goodness.
- He is ignorant of God’s teaching about what is right and what is wrong/evil.

inexperienced in the message of righteousness: The phrase inexperienced in the message of righteousness has several interpretations. The most likely interpretations are:

1. It means that a person “is unskilled in the matter of what is right.” It indicates that he does not know

how to decide what is right and what is wrong. For example:

without any experience in the matter of right and wrong (GNT) (GNT, CEV, NLT)

1. It means that a person “does not understand the teaching about righteousness.” It indicates that he does not understand the teaching about Christ as high priest atoning for his people’s sins and making them righteous. For example:

not acquainted with the teaching about righteousness (NIV) (NIV, NET, NCV)

1. It means that a person “is not experienced in speaking about what is right.” For example:

lack the experience to talk about what is right (GW) (GW)

Some English versions are ambiguous. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It fits best with the contrast in 5:14 with the mature who know how to discern between right and wrong. Another way to translate this meaning is:

is not able to distinguish between what is right and what is wrong

For more information, see just, sense C3, in KBT.

Hebrews 5:14

Section 5:11–6:12: Grow up in your faith, and do not give up

In Section 5:11–6:12 the author interrupted his teaching about God appointing Christ as the high priest in order to tell his listeners to mature in their faith and to warn them not to stop believing in Christ. After this warning (6:4–12), he will continue to teach them in 6:13–7:28 about the priesthood of Jesus and Melchizedek.

Remember to translate the section before choosing a heading for it. Some other possible headings are:

Warning about abandoning Christ

Do not be lazy but become mature followers of Christ

Paragraph 5:11–14

In verses 11–14 the author told his listeners that they were like babies who do not understand much about God and his Word. He told them that they ought to be like teachers, not like babies.

5:14a

But solid food is for the mature,

- Strong food/teaching is for experienced/grown people.
- But mature people eat/chew food, just as people who are mature in their faith

But solid food is for the mature: This clause contrasts with 5:13b. Everyone who lives on “milk” is still an infant. In contrast, mature people eat solid food. In the Greek text, the word mature comes first in the sentence. For example:

Mature people eat solid food.

Translate the contrast in a natural way in your language. In some languages a conjunction is not needed. For example:

Solid food is for mature people (CEV)

solid food: The phrase solid food was used in 5:12c. It refers to food which needs to be chewed. It also refers figuratively to teaching that requires a person to think seriously before he can understand it. See how you translated this phrase in 5:12.

mature: The Greek word that the BSB translates as mature means “full-grown, mature, adult.” It contrasts with “infant” in 5:13. Some other ways to translate it are:

adults (GNT)

a mature person

Here the word mature is used in two different ways:

1. It refers literally to adults in contrast to infants.
2. It refers figuratively to people who are mature in following Christ and understanding Christian teaching.

The figurative use (b) will become clear in 5:14b–c, where the text speaks of being able to distinguish good from evil.

5:14b–c

who by constant use have trained their senses to distinguish good from evil: This part of the verse describes the mature people in 5:14a. They have the ability to distinguish good and evil because they have been trained by experience to know the difference. Some other ways to translate this meaning are:

whose minds are trained by practice to know the difference between good and evil (GW)

who through training have the skill to recognize the difference between right and wrong (NLT)

5:14b

who by constant use have trained their senses

- Such people have trained their minds/consciences and become experienced
- have trained their moral senses by using them

by constant use have trained: The verb have trained means “have trained themselves” or “have learned.” The phrase by constant use refers to the experience that a person gains when he does something many times. A mature person has made decisions many times about whether various actions or attitudes are good or evil.

Some other ways to translate the phrase by constant use have trained are:

by constant use are trained/able

through training/practice have the skill

has accustomed his mind

their senses: The Greek word that the BSB translates as senses refers to a person’s ability to perceive and discern. His senses make him able to know the difference between good and evil so that he can decide which actions or attitudes are right and which are wrong.

Languages have different ways to refer to a person’s ability to distinguish good and evil. In some languages a specific part of a person is used to describe this ability. In other languages it is more natural to refer to a person himself, rather than to a part of the person. Use a natural way in your language to speak about a person’s ability to discern good and evil.

Some other ways to translate it are:

his mind/conscience

have the skill to (NLT)

their senses (NASB)

5:14c

to distinguish good from evil.

- in knowing/recognizing the difference between what is right and what is sinful.
- to discern/know the difference between good and evil.

to distinguish good from evil: The phrase to distinguish good from evil refers to making decisions about what is morally right and what is morally wrong. It describes a person who is able to know the difference between what God considers good and what he considers evil.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

tell what is the difference between what is the good way and what is the evil way. Western Bukidnon Manobo back translation on TW.

choosing/deciding what is right and what is wrong

has the ability to know the difference between what is right to do and what is wrong and to choose to do what is right

Hebrews 6:1

Section 5:11–6:12: Grow up in your faith, and do not give up

In Section 5:11–6:12 the author interrupted his teaching about God appointing Christ as the high priest in order to tell his listeners to mature in their faith and to warn them not to stop believing in Christ. After this warning (6:4–12), he will continue to teach them in 6:13–7:28 about the priesthood of Jesus and Melchizedek.

Remember to translate the section before choosing a heading for it. Some other possible headings are:

Warning about abandoning Christ

Do not be lazy but become mature followers of Christ

6:1a–b

Therefore let us leave the elementary teachings about Christ and go on to maturity: Here the BSB follows the order of phrases in the Greek text. Some translations use a different order of phrases. For example:

Therefore let us go on toward perfection, leaving behind the basic teaching about Christ (NRSV)

Choose the order that is most natural in your language.

let us leave the elementary teachings about Christ and go on to maturity: Here the author told his listeners to stop repeating only the elementary teachings about Christ and go on to become mature. The phrase let us leave indicates that we must advance from basic teachings to learn what mature believers need to know. The phrase is not a request for permission.

Some other ways to translate this exhortation in 6:1a are:

in our study of Christ it is necessary that we become mature by learning more complex matters. Let's not continue studying only the basic teaching.

we should stop repeating only the easiest teachings concerning Christ. Now we should learn the deeper teachings so that our faith will become mature.

6:1a

Therefore let us leave the elementary teachings about Christ

- ¶ So, let us leave behind the first/simple lessons which people taught us^(incl) about Christ
- ¶ Because of this, we^(incl) must progress beyond the most basic things that we^(incl) learned about Christ

Therefore: The conjunction Therefore introduces an exhortation based on what the author told his hearers in 5:11–14. He said that they need to stop listening only to simple teaching and listen to teaching that is for mature believers. He assumes that they will now listen to the more advanced teaching about Jesus being our high priest.

Some other ways to translate Therefore here are:

So (NLT)

Because of this/that

Now therefore

With this in mind (GW)

The word Therefore occurs often in Hebrews. It occurred already in 3:7 and 3:10. However, many versions translate it differently in these verses. You will need to think carefully about the connections in each context to make them clear and natural in your language.

let us leave the elementary teachings about Christ:

The author implies here that his listeners need to add to the basic truths that they learned about Christ. He did not imply that they should leave the basic truths and stop thinking about them. He meant that they should not be content with only those basic truths. He wanted them to also learn more complex truths about Christ to help them to mature in their faith.

Other ways to translate this meaning are.

we must progress beyond the elementary instructions about Christ (NET)

We must...start thinking about more than just the basic things we were taught about Christ. (CEV)

the elementary teachings about Christ: The phrase elementary teachings about Christ refers to the first truths about Christ that the church teaches to a new believer in him. The phrase is similar to the phrase “basic principles” in 5:12. For more information and translation examples, see the note on 5:12a–b.

6:1b

and go on to maturity,

- and become mature in our^(incl) knowledge about him.
- so that we^(incl) study/learn what will make us mature followers of his.

and go on to maturity: The phrase go on to maturity is more literally “we-must-be-moved-on to maturity.” It indicates that we must develop (grow, progress) toward becoming mature as believers in Christ. It also implies that we must learn and understand the truths that mature believers need to know. Some scholars distinguish the two aspects of meaning (becoming mature believers and studying advanced teachings) as different interpretations of “go on to maturity.” This distinction results in the following breakdown of English versions: (1)–It means “become mature” as Christians, e.g., “go on to maturity” (BSB), followed by

the BSB, NIV, NRSV, CEV, ESV, REB, and the NASB, or (2) It means “go on to more advanced teaching,” e.g., “Let us go forward, then, to mature teaching” (GNT), followed by the GNT, NCV, GW, and the NJB. The NLT rendering is a little different from either (1) or (2), since it focuses specifically on becoming mature in understanding, which involves a narrower meaning than the general “go on to maturity,” and implies absorbing teaching that is for mature people in order to gain maturity of understanding. Looking at the English versions, interpretation (1) seems to have somewhat more support. However, the back translations on TW tend to favor interpretation (2). BDAG (page 996) defines it in this verse as “maturity in contrast to the stage of elementary knowledge.” Since there is little practical difference in the interpretations, it seems best for translators to follow the interpretation that communicates most clearly in this context.

Some ways to translate the phrase go on to maturity are:

let us also learn the deeper teachings so that our faith will become mature. Kankanaey back translation on TW.

let’s develop/grow and become complete in our understanding

maturity: The Greek word that the BSB translates as maturity means “completeness, perfection.” *τελειότης*, BDAG, page 996. The word occurs only here and in Colossians 3:14. However, the corresponding verb “to make perfect” or “complete” occurs over twelve times in Hebrews. See the preceding note for translation examples.

6:1c–2

In 6:1d–2 the author listed six basic teachings that are part of the foundation of Christian faith. He mentions them in three pairs. Some commentators take the first pair in 6:1 (repentance and faith), as being the foundation, which is then expanded in the two pairs of items in 6:2. But the BSB, RSV, GNT and the NIV list all six items as being the foundation.

1. repentance from dead works and faith in God,
2. instruction about baptisms, laying on of hands,
3. resurrection of the dead, and eternal judgment.

In (a) the author summarizes the crucial first things that a person does in coming to God: he repents of his sins and puts his faith in God. In (b) the author summarizes ceremonies of the church like baptism, in which a person is publicly initiated. In (c) he summa-

izes beliefs about future resurrection and judgment. The author implied that the readers already knew these truths and no one should have to teach them again.

6:1c

not laying again the foundation

- We^(incl) should not need to lay the foundation of our faith all over again.
- We^(incl) should not keep studying again and again the first lessons

not laying again the foundation: Here the author used a metaphor. He compared the elementary teachings about Christ to the foundation of a building. A foundation is its base and support. After the foundation is finished, the building needs walls and a roof. After a Christian has the foundation of basic beliefs, he needs to “build on” his faith by learning what mature believers need to know.

Some other ways to translate the metaphor are:

- Use a simile. For example:

Let’s not continue to repeat the same basic teachings like someone who builds only the foundation of a house

- Translate the meaning without the metaphor. For example:

without going over the fundamental doctrines again (NJB)

Translate the meaning in a clear way in your language.

6:1d

of repentance from dead works,

- We^(incl) should already know that it is necessary to repent of sinful/useless actions
- about repenting from acts that cause eternal/spiritual death,

repentance from dead works: The Greek word that the BSB translates as repentance refers to a person changing his mind, heart, or will. When a person repents from dead works, he realizes that they are wrong. He is sorry and stops doing them.

Some other ways to translate repentance from dead works are:

rejecting sins, which bring death

to quit/stop doing evil, which leads to death

For more information, see repent in KBT.

dead works: In this context, the phrase dead works refer to deeds that are both sinful and useless. They have no value, because they do not please God. They cannot help anyone to know God and go to heaven. They actually cause a person to be separated from God, which is spiritual death.

Some ways to translate the phrase dead works are:

- Refer to them as useless actions. For example:

useless works (GNT)

deeds/activities that have no value

- Refer to them as deeds that bring eternal death or punishment. For example:

not to do the evil that brings punishment
Otomi back translation on TW.

The text does not imply that the sins cause immediate physical death. Also, it does not imply that only some sins lead to death. Some other ways to translate dead works are:

sinful acts, which lead to death

evil deeds (NLT)

6:1e

and of faith in God,

- and trust in God.
- and about believing in God.

and of faith in God: The phrase faith in God refers to trusting God. It is listed here as the second teaching that is part of the foundation of Christian faith. In this context it refers especially to people trusting God to save them from sin and eternal death. In some languages it is more natural to express the noun faith as a verb. For example:

believing in God (GNT)

trust in God

depending/relying on God

For more information, see believe, sense C, in KBT.

Hebrews 6:2

Section 5:11–6:12: Grow up in your faith, and do not give up

In Section 5:11–6:12 the author interrupted his teaching about God appointing Christ as the high priest in order to tell his listeners to mature in their faith and to warn them not to stop believing in Christ. After this warning (6:4–12), he will continue to teach them in 6:13–7:28 about the priesthood of Jesus and Melchizedek.

Remember to translate the section before choosing a heading for it. Some other possible headings are:

Warning about abandoning Christ

Do not be lazy but become mature followers of Christ

6:2

This verse continues the list of basic teachings about the Christian life.

This verse mentions four more topics that are basic Christian teachings. The phrase instruction about applies to each of these topics. Some ways to make this clear are:

- Use an introductory phrase that obviously applies to all the following topics. For example:

and other basic teachings like these:

- Use an introductory phrase or word before each topic or each two topics. For example:

teaching about baptisms or about the laying on of hands or about people being raised from death and the future judgment

- Use more than one sentence to translate the topics. For example:

They are taught to request to be baptized in the name of the Lord Jesus and a...leader puts hands on their head. They are taught what will happen in the future. God will make dead people live again and he will punish forever people whose behavior is evil.

Remember that the author wants his listeners to realize that these matters are basic truths that new Chris-

tians learn. By now they should be mature enough to consider topics for believers who are ready for more advanced truths. They will continue to think about the beginning topics as needed, but they will already know the basic truths about them.

6:2a

instruction about baptisms,

- We^(incl) should know the teaching about baptisms/washings,
- Let us^(incl) not keep studying about ceremonial washings,

baptisms: There is a textual variant here between “teaching”/“of teaching” with the UBS going with “of teaching” but it does not seem to make any significant difference in the meaning of the verse. The Greek word for baptisms literally means “washings.” It is slightly different from the usual word used for “baptism” in the NT. Scholars interpret it in different ways in this context:

1. It refers to Christian baptism and other types of baptism.

the teaching about baptisms (GNT) (BSB, GNT, NIV, NRSV, CEV, GW, NCV, NET, NJB) It is difficult to be certain about which interpretation English versions follow. However, English dictionaries commonly list Christian baptism as the first meaning of “baptism,” so the use of the term “baptisms” tends to imply that there were different types of baptism.

1. It refers to ceremonies to make a person ritually clean. For example:

instruction about cleansing rites (REB) (ESV, RSV, REB, NASB)

1. It refers only to Christian baptism. For example:

baptism (JBP)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). In Hebrews the author spoke to Jewish Christians, who knew about different types of baptism and cleansing ceremonies. They needed to be taught the meaning of Christian baptism and how it is different from other types of baptism. Cockerill (page 266) says, “One of the best suggestions is that the pastor uses the plural because he is referring to teachings that distinguish Christian baptism from various OT or contemporary Jewish washings.” The Exegetical Summary

on Hebrews (Greenlee, page 190) says, “The plural implies a contrast between Christian baptism and all other religious washings known to the readers [NTC]. Instructions would be about how the cleansing by Christ’s blood, symbolized by baptism, now abrogated Jewish cleansing rites and also possibly instruction about the differences between Christian baptism, Jewish proselyte baptism, John’s baptism, and Jesus’ baptism, and the work of the Holy Spirit [EGT, Hu]”

In some languages it may be helpful to make the meaning more explicit. For example:

teaching about the difference between the baptism of a believer in Christ and other baptisms

purification rituals and baptism

6:2b the laying on of hands,

- and about the meaning of laying hands on believers.
- and about blessing people by putting hands on their head,

the laying on of hands: The action laying on of hands has a special meaning here. It refers to a Christian laying his hand or hands gently on another person (usually on his head or shoulders) to ask the Holy Spirit to come to that person. In some languages it may be necessary to use a more specific phrase. For example:

the placing of hands on the head of a companion
Kankanaey back translation on TW.

about placing hands on the head of people to ask a blessing for him from God
Yakan back translation on TW.

The laying on of hands was done for different purposes. At baptism, it was done to ask the Holy Spirit to be with the new believer and give him power to live for the Lord. It was also done when a person was appointed to do special work for the Lord or in order to ask for healing or for a special gift for ministry.

In some languages a phrase like laying on of hands implies a wrong meaning. For example, it may imply that a person lays hands on another person to harm him or restrain him. If that is true in your language, you may need to translate only the meaning of the action. For example:

the receiving of the Holy Spirit
Western Bukidnon Manobo back translation on TW.

6:2c the resurrection of the dead,

- We should also know that people will rise again from the dead,
- about God giving people life again after they have died,

6:2d and eternal judgment.

- and be judged with a decision that lasts forever.
- and that God will judge them with a decision that will continue forever.

6:2c–d the resurrection of the dead, and eternal judgment:

In 6:2c–d the author lists the final two basic teachings: After people have died, God will make them alive again, and he will judge them. His decision about them will be eternal. Some ways to translate this meaning are:

dead people coming back to life, and eternal judgment (GW)

God making dead people live again and making an eternal judgment/decision about each of them

eternal judgment: The phrase eternal judgment refers to the future time when God will judge all human beings. At that time he will make a decision about each person. His decision will determine what will happen to each one forever.

Some other ways to translate eternal judgment are:

God’s judging of people which has no end to its result
Kankanaey back translation on TW.

people will be judged and God will determine what will happen to each person.
Otomi back translation on TW.

Hebrews 6:3

Section 5:11–6:12: Grow up in your faith, and do not give up

In Section 5:11–6:12 the author interrupted his teaching about God appointing Christ as the high priest in order to tell his listeners to mature in their faith and to warn them not to stop believing in Christ. After this warning

(6:4-12), he will continue to teach them in 6:13-7:28 about the priesthood of Jesus and Melchizedek.

Remember to translate the section before choosing a heading for it. Some other possible headings are:

Warning about abandoning Christ

Do not be lazy but become mature followers of Christ

6:3

And this we will do, if God permits.

- This is what we will do, if God allows us^(incl).
- So if God allows/helps us, we^(incl) will study/learn other things that will help us become mature believers.

And: The word And connects “go on to maturity” with “we will do this, if God permits.” In some languages it is more natural to connect these clauses in a different way. For example:

And so (NLT)

²Let us not repeatedly.... ³but rather let us Western Bukidnon Manobo back translation on TW.

this we will do, if God permits: There is a textual variant here. Most manuscripts have “we will do,” but some old and generally reliable texts have “Let us do.” The difference tends to be more a matter of style of discourse rather than of meaning. The word this refers to leaving behind elementary teaching and going on to maturity (6:1-2). The author intends that he and his listeners will become mature believers who understand what God wants them to know. However, he knows that they can only become mature if God allows it.

In some languages it is necessary to repeat some implied information from 6:1 to make the meaning of the phrase this we will do clear. For example:

So let’s learn the mature/deeper teachings, if God allows us.

Let us go forward! And this is what we will do, if God allows. (GNT)

And we will go on to grown-up teaching if God allows. (NCV)

In some languages it may be more natural to reverse the order of phrases in this verse. For example:

And God permitting, we will do so. (NIV)

if God permits: The phrase if God permits means “if God allows.” In some languages there is a special saying to express this meaning. For example:

God willing (NLT)

if God still gives us opportunity. Uma back translation on TW.

Hebrews 6:4

Section 5:11-6:12: Grow up in your faith, and do not give up

In Section 5:11-6:12 the author interrupted his teaching about God appointing Christ as the high priest in order to tell his listeners to mature in their faith and to warn them not to stop believing in Christ. After this warning (6:4-12), he will continue to teach them in 6:13-7:28 about the priesthood of Jesus and Melchizedek.

Remember to translate the section before choosing a heading for it. Some other possible headings are:

Warning about abandoning Christ

Do not be lazy but become mature followers of Christ

Paragraph Group 6:4-8

In the second (6:4-6) and third (6:7-8) paragraphs in this chapter the author gave the third warning in Hebrews (as indicated in the Outline). In 6:4-6 he warned that if people “fall away” from their faith, they bring disgrace to God’s Son. It is impossible to make them repent again. In 6:7-8 he compared faithful and unfaithful believers to fruitful and unfruitful land. Land that produces only thorns must be burned.

6:4a

It is impossible for those who have once been enlightened,

- ¶ Some people cannot be caused to repent again. Such people knew God’s/his truth at one time
- ¶ As for people who stop believing, no one can make them repent again. At one time, they understood the truth.

The Greek begins this verse with a conjunction that is usually translated as “for” or “because.” In some versions, a conjunction introduces a warning. It is based on what the author said in 6:1–3 about becoming mature. In 6:4–6 he warned his listeners that if we do not become mature, we may “fall away” from our faith (6:6). When that happens, it is impossible to be brought back to repentance.

Notice that here a conjunction connects paragraphs (1–3 and 4–6), rather than sentences. In some languages a conjunction is not needed. It is often helpful to translate the two paragraphs before deciding how to connect them.

It is impossible for those: The phrase It is impossible for those describes an action that no one can do. No one can help certain people to repent a second time. Some other ways to translate this meaning are:

It is not possible to help certain people

as for people who deliberately retreat from their faith, they can no longer be led back to repent from their sinUma back translation on TW.

Notice that the second example supplied a phrase from 6:6 (“who deliberately retreat from their faith”).

who have once been enlightened: The verb have... been enlightened is passive, and it is used as a figure of speech here. It indicates that God caused the people to know the truth. In this context it especially implies knowing the truth of the Gospel that God revealed through his Son.

Some ways to translate the figure of speech are:

- Use a figure of speech in your language that has the same meaning. For example:

their minds have already been illuminated-Kankanaey back translation on TW.

Some people once had God’s light. (GW)

their minds/eyes had been opened

- Translate the meaning without the figure of speech. For example:

they understood the truth

once: The Greek word that the BSB translates as once refers here to the time in the past when the people understood the gospel. Some other ways to translate it are:

at one time

at one point

6:4b who have tasted the heavenly gift,

- and experienced his gift from heaven.
- They accepted God’s gift,

who have tasted the heavenly gift: The clause who have tasted the heavenly gift means “and have experienced what God gave.” The word tasted is a figure of speech that implies a full experience. It does not imply that the experience is limited. It implies that the person has not only been told about the gift—he has actually experienced it. The meaning is similar to its meaning in 2:9, where the phrase “tasted death” indicates that Jesus experienced death fully.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

enjoyed heaven’s gift (NCV)

they have benefited from what God has givenKankanaey back translation on TW.

experienced the gift from God

the heavenly gift: The word heavenly here is an indirect way to say “from God.” The word gift probably refers here to the gift of new life through Christ. God sent Jesus to save us from sin and to bring us into fellowship with God. In some languages it is more natural to translate the noun gift with a verb phrase or clause. For example:

what God gave

the new life that God gives

6:4c who have shared in the Holy Spirit,

- They shared in the Holy Spirit.
- and received his Holy Spirit.

who have shared in the Holy Spirit: The phrase have shared in the Holy SpiritThe Greek phrase is literally

“who have become sharers/partners in the spirit.” The author used a word *metochoi*, “partners” which he has used already in 3:1a (“who share in the heavenly calling”) and 3:14a (“share in Christ”), and which he will use again in 12:8. indicates that they were among those who experienced the Holy Spirit’s presence and power. Some other ways to translate this meaning are:

have shared in experiencing the Holy Spirit
itKankanaey back translation on TW.

among those who were blessed with the Holy Spirit

the Holy Spirit: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the Holy Spirit refers to the Spirit of God. Translate the term the Holy Spirit in the same way as you did in 2:4 and 3:7.

Hebrews 6:5

Section 5:11–6:12: Grow up in your faith, and do not give up

In Section 5:11–6:12 the author interrupted his teaching about God appointing Christ as the high priest in order to tell his listeners to mature in their faith and to warn them not to stop believing in Christ. After this warning (6:4–12), he will continue to teach them in 6:13–7:28 about the priesthood of Jesus and Melchizedek.

Remember to translate the section before choosing a heading for it. Some other possible headings are:

Warning about abandoning Christ

Do not be lazy but become mature followers of Christ

Paragraph Group 6:4–8

In the second (6:4–6) and third (6:7–8) paragraphs in this chapter the author gave the third warning in Hebrews (as indicated in the Outline). In 6:4–6 he warned that if people “fall away” from their faith, they bring disgrace to God’s Son. It is impossible to make them repent again. In 6:7–8 he compared faithful and unfaithful believers to fruitful and unfruitful land. Land that produces only thorns must be burned.

6:5a–b

Most scholars indicate that 6:5a–b adds two experiences to the list in 6:4:

1. The people experienced for themselves the goodness of God’s word (5a).

2. They also experienced the powers of the coming age (5b).

In 6:5b the author did not imply that people were able to visit the future. He indicated that some people were already able to experience miracles that will be common in the age to come.

who have tasted the goodness of the word of God and the powers of the coming age:

The verb *tasted* is the same verb that was used in the phrase “tasted the heavenly gift” 6:4b. As in 6:4b, the word *tasted* means “to actually experience” something. It does not imply that the experience is limited like a little taste of food.

Languages have different ways to speak of experiencing something. They may use verbs that mean “see” or “feel.” There may also be different ways to speak of different types of experiences. In some languages it is necessary to translate *tasted* in two different ways in 6:5a and 6:5b. For example:

They found out how good God’s word is, and they received the powers of his new world. (NCV)

they knew from experience that God’s word is good, and they had felt the powers of the coming age (GNT)

Translate the verb in a natural way in your language for this context.

6:5a

who have tasted the goodness of the word of God

- They experienced/discovered for themselves that God’s word is good,
- They realized/accepted that God’s words to them were good,

the goodness of the word of God: The phrase the goodness of the word of God indicates that God’s message is good. The word of God probably refers specifically here to the good message that God saves us through Christ. Some other ways to translate it are:

the good message of God (CEV)

that God’s word is good

6:5b

and the powers of the coming age—

- and they experienced the mighty works of the time that is coming.

- and they felt/saw the power that he will reveal more fully in the future.

the powers of the coming age: This phrase implies that in the future God will show his power in special ways. Miracles will be common. God will give his people special power to do great things. The word powers does not imply that the power will come from any spirit or “god” except the Creator.

Some other ways to translate the phrase are:

the power of God that he will make clear in the future

the powerful miracles that will be common in the coming age

what can be done through the power which God will reveal in the future at the last days
Western Bukidnon Manobo back translation on TW.

powers: In this context the word powers refers to actions that require God’s power to accomplish. These actions will be miraculous and extraordinary. The word is plural because the author referred to more than one event or miracle. It also occurs with the words “wonders” and “signs” in Acts 2:12 and 2 Corinthians 12:12. See the preceding note for translation examples.

the coming age: The coming age refers to a new period of time that will begin in the future. Most scholars believe that this new age will begin at Christ’s second coming. However, some scholars believe that it began with Christ’s first coming and will be consummated at his second coming. The former is the preferred meaning. The text does not specify exactly which future time that will be.

Some other ways to translate this meaning are:

the future world (CEV)

in the coming time
Tagbanwa back translation on TW.

Hebrews 6:6

Section 5:11–6:12: Grow up in your faith, and do not give up

In Section 5:11–6:12 the author interrupted his teaching about God appointing Christ as the high priest in order to tell his listeners to mature in their faith and to warn them not to stop believing in Christ. After this warning

(6:4–12), he will continue to teach them in 6:13–7:28 about the priesthood of Jesus and Melchizedek.

Remember to translate the section before choosing a heading for it. Some other possible headings are:

Warning about abandoning Christ

Do not be lazy but become mature followers of Christ

Paragraph Group 6:4–8

In the second (6:4–6) and third (6:7–8) paragraphs in this chapter the author gave the third warning in Hebrews (as indicated in the Outline). In 6:4–6 he warned that if people “fall away” from their faith, they bring disgrace to God’s Son. It is impossible to make them repent again. In 6:7–8 he compared faithful and unfaithful believers to fruitful and unfruitful land. Land that produces only thorns must be burned.

6:6a

and then have fallen away—to be restored to repentance,

- If such people turn away/back from their faith, they cannot repent again.
- If they deliberately reject what they believed, they are unable to repent again.

and then have fallen away: The Greek word that the BSB translates as have fallen away. The Greek verb is a participle, which is rightly interpreted in this context as a condition. It is used only here in the New Testament. In general, it means “to fail to keep a commitment.” BDAG, (page 770) has for *παραπίπτω*: “to fail to follow through on a commitment, fall away, commit apostasy.” Although BDAG includes the meaning “commit apostasy,” some other scholars disagree with that definition. In a lengthy discussion of the topic, David Allen (Kindle edition, pages 260–261) indicates that elsewhere in Scripture, the word is not used with the meaning “commit apostasy.” Instead, it means “turn away.” He points out that the author of Hebrews warns the readers not to follow the example of the Israelites (Numbers 14), who turned away from God in the wilderness. Although God punished them severely, he still considered them his people and continued to take care of them. Allen considers the penalty for this type of turning away to be temporal punishment and loss of rewards. No amount of regret will change the results of that turning away, but he believes that the results do not involve eternal loss of salvation. There are different ways to interpret the word in this context. The most likely view is that it refers here to

a person refusing to keep the commitment to follow Jesus. It implies a deliberate action.

Some other ways to translate this part of the verse are:

if they deliberately retreat from their faith
back translation on TW.

and then they refuse to continue believing

In many languages it is natural to translate the meaning with a figure of speech. For example:

turn away from God (NLT)

they have deserted Christ (GW)

to be restored to repentance: The verb that the BSB translates as restored means “renew.” It occurs only here in the NT. This is the main verb that follows “it is impossible” in 6:4a. The author indicated that it is impossible to renew/restore some people to repentance. In this context it indicates that it is impossible to cause some people to repent a second time. These are the people who trusted Jesus to save them from their sins but after that, they decided not to trust him.

Some ways to translate this passive verb are:

- As a passive verb. For example:

be led a second time to God (GW)

to bring them back to a changed life again (NCV)

- As an active verb. For example:

to make them repent as they did at first (JBP)

cause them to repent again

repentance: The word repentance occurred in 6:1d. You should translate it in a similar way here.

6:6b

because they themselves are crucifying the Son of God all over again

- They themselves are nailing the Son of God to a cross again to be crucified
- It is as if they themselves are nailing the Son of God to the cross to die again.

because they themselves are crucifying the Son of God all over again: The word because indicates the reason or explanation why they cannot repent. In Greek, the verb is a participle without any connective, as was the condition in 6:6a. This is figurative language. When people reject the Son of God, it is like crucifying him again. They refuse to believe that he is God’s Son and that he can save them from their sins. Rejecting him is their greatest sin. That is why it is impossible for them to repent while they are rejecting him.

The meaning here is similar to the action “turns away from the living God” in 3:12. Some other ways to translate it are:

it’s as if they are again nailing God’s Son to the cross

what they have done is like they nailed the Son of God to the cross with their own hands

they themselves: The Greek word that the BSB translates as they themselves is more literally “to/for themselves.” Here is another way to translate this:

they again crucify to themselves the Son of God (NASB)

There are three main ways to interpret the word “for themselves” here:

1. It means that they themselves crucify God’s Son. For example:

they themselves are nailing him to the cross once again (NLT) (BSB, NET, NLT, JBP, NRSV, NJB)

1. It means “to their own loss.” For example:

for they are crucifying to their own hurt the Son of God (REB) (NIV, ESV, REB)

1. It adds emphasis and does not need to be translated specifically. For example:

because they are nailing the Son of God to a cross again and are shaming him in front of others (NCV) (NCV, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The author emphasizes that they themselves commit

the same sin of rejecting Christ that the people who crucified him committed. They were not present at Christ's crucifixion, but they figuratively crucify him again by rejecting him.

the Son of God: The title the Son of God indicates that Jesus has the same nature and character as God. See how you translated the Son of God at 4:14. For more information, see the note on "his Son" in 1:2a.

6:6c

and subjecting Him to open shame.

- and openly/publicly dishonor him.
- They bring public shame to him by saying that Christ is not important.

and subjecting Him to open shame: The Greek word that the BSB translates as subjecting Him to open shame was most often used of shaming a person by punishing him in public. Here it indicates that if people claim to be Christians and then reject Christ, they disgrace him and cause other people also to dishonor him. Some other ways to translate this meaning are:

insulting him in public (CEV)

They cause that all the people make fun of him again. Otomi back translation on TW.

This word occurs only here in the NT. However, in other literature it is used to refer to shaming a criminal by punishing him in public. A related word occurs in Matthew 1:19.

Hebrews 6:7

Section 5:11–6:12: Grow up in your faith, and do not give up

In Section 5:11–6:12 the author interrupted his teaching about God appointing Christ as the high priest in order to tell his listeners to mature in their faith and to warn them not to stop believing in Christ. After this warning (6:4–12), he will continue to teach them in 6:13–7:28 about the priesthood of Jesus and Melchizedek.

Remember to translate the section before choosing a heading for it. Some other possible headings are:

Warning about abandoning Christ

Do not be lazy but become mature followers of Christ

Paragraph Group 6:4–8

In the second (6:4–6) and third (6:7–8) paragraphs in this chapter the author gave the third warning in Hebrews (as indicated in the Outline). In 6:4–6 he warned that if people "fall away" from their faith, they bring disgrace to God's Son. It is impossible to make them repent again. In 6:7–8 he compared faithful and unfaithful believers to fruitful and unfruitful land. Land that produces only thorns must be burned.

6:7a

For land that drinks in the rain often falling on it

- ¶ Some land absorbs the rain that often falls on it.
- ¶ People are like soil/ground. Some soil/ground soaks up rain water, as often as the rains come.
- ¶ God blesses land that has rain often falling on it,

For: This verse illustrates two different responses to the blessings of following Christ. Some of these blessings are listed in 6:4–5 ("the heavenly gift, the Holy Spirit, the word of God, the powers of the coming age"). The author introduces the illustration with the Greek word that the BSB translates as For.

Some other ways to introduce the illustration are:

- Use a phrase that indicates what the paragraph will illustrate. For example:

Some people are like land that.... (NCV)

An example of this is earth/ground. If it is... Tagbanwa back translation on TW.

- Change the order of phrases in the verse so that 6:7c ("receives a blessing from God") comes at the beginning. For example:

God blesses the land which... (GNT)

The people whom God blesses are like land...

It is good to read 6:4–8 carefully again before you decide how to connect 6:4–6 with 6:7–8. In some languages an introductory word or phrase may not be needed, as in the NRSV. See the General Comment on 6:7–8 at the end of 6:8b for more information.

land that drinks in the rain often falling on it: This phrase describes a farm or garden that often receives rain. The verb drinks in means "absorbs" or "soaks in." It implies that the farm has a type of soil that absorbs the rain so that the plants can use it. Describe this process in a natural way in your language.

Some ways to translate this phrase are:

the ground that has soaked up the rain that frequently falls on it (NET)

Some people are like a farm that receives plenty of rain

land: The word land refers here to land that is farmed. Some other ways to translate it are:

farm

field

ground

6:7b

and that produces a crop useful to those for whom it is tended

- Then it produces a harvest which helps/benefits those who own the land.
- Then the seeds that the farmer planted grow well and mature, and the crops/plants are useful to him.

that produces a crop useful to those for whom it is tended: The Greek word *botanē* which is translated “crops” only occurs here in the NT. This clause refers to land where useful plants grow. These plants could be food crops or crops that are used for other purposes. In some languages it is not natural to speak of ground or land producing a crop. Some other ways to translate the meaning are:

where plants grow that are useful to the land owner
Kankanaey back translation on TW.

the plants are healthy there and this is of great value to the owner of the land

for whom it is tended: The verb it is tended is passive. The phrase implies that people farm the land for themselves or for other owners. In some languages it is more natural to use an active verb. For example:

The land produces a good crop for those who cultivate/dig (NCV)

6:7c

receives the blessing of God.

- That is the kind of land which God blesses.
- God is pleased with people who are like that soil/ground, and he continues to do good to them.

receives the blessing of God: The phrase receives the blessing of God indicates that God does good to the land. He continues to cause it to be fruitful. For example:

God blesses well-watered land that produces a crop.

People who are like such land receive God’s favor.

the blessing: The word blessing refers to favor from God. It implies that God is pleased with the person or things that he blesses, and he does good things for them. See blessing, sense C1(a), in KBT.

Hebrews 6:8

Section 5:11–6:12: Grow up in your faith, and do not give up

In Section 5:11–6:12 the author interrupted his teaching about God appointing Christ as the high priest in order to tell his listeners to mature in their faith and to warn them not to stop believing in Christ. After this warning (6:4–12), he will continue to teach them in 6:13–7:28 about the priesthood of Jesus and Melchizedek.

Remember to translate the section before choosing a heading for it. Some other possible headings are:

Warning about abandoning Christ

Do not be lazy but become mature followers of Christ

Paragraph Group 6:4–8

In the second (6:4–6) and third (6:7–8) paragraphs in this chapter the author gave the third warning in Hebrews (as indicated in the Outline). In 6:4–6 he warned that if people “fall away” from their faith, they bring disgrace to God’s Son. It is impossible to make them repent again. In 6:7–8 he compared faithful and unfaithful believers to fruitful and unfruitful land. Land that produces only thorns must be burned.

6:8

In this verse the author compares worthless land to the fruitful land in 6:7. In some languages it is necessary to make the comparison explicit. This may be done either at the beginning of the verse or at its end. For example:

But other people are like land that produces only thorns and thistles...

...This represents the people whom God will punish. Otomi back translation on TW.

6:8a

But land that produces thorns and thistles is worthless,

- However, other land also receives rain, but it produces only thorny weeds. That land has no value,
- Other people are like useless soil. When that land soaks up the rain water, it produces only plants that no one wants/needs.

But: The particle But introduces a contrast to the fruitful land in 6:7. In 6:8 the land produces useless plants like thorns and thistles and must be burned. The author implies that this land is like people who fall away from Christ (6:4–6). Translate the contrast in a natural way in your language.

land that produces thorns and thistles is worthless: Here the author refers to land where nothing grows except thorns and thistles. As in 6:7, in some languages it may not be natural to speak of land “producing” plants. Translate this meaning in a similar way as you did in 6:7. Some other ways to translate it are:

But the bad soil where weeds and thorns grow is useless. Kankanaey back translation on TW.

But if that land has nothing growing on it but thorns and thistles it has no value

thorns and thistles: The words thorns and thistles refer to the most common weeds in Israel. Thorn bushes and thistle plants are not useful for anything. Even most animals will not eat them. It is fine to translate the phrase thorns and thistles with similar useless, thorny weeds that are found in your area or with general terms.

Some other ways to translate the phrase are:

nothing but sword-grass and thorns growing on it Uma back translation on TW.

weeds and thorny plants Tagbanwa back translation on TW.

These two types of plants are very similar. The word thorns refers to “plants that have thorns.” Thorns are sharp spikes that can hurt someone who touches them. The word thistles refers to prickly weeds. This word only occurs here and in Matthew 7:16. The author probably mentioned both of these plants to emphasize his meaning. In some languages it may be more natural to emphasize the meaning in a different way. For example:

only thornbushes (CEV)

only useless/harmful plants

only weeds

Both words occur in Matthew 7:16. See how you translated them there.

is worthless: The word worthless indicates here that the land produces nothing of value. It is barren, and its owners do not get anything good from it. The author implies that it is like the people who go away from Christ. They cannot do anything good to please God. Other ways to translate this meaning are:

has no use/value

is worth nothing

6:8b

and its curse is imminent. In the end it will be burned.

- and it is almost ready to be cursed by God and burned.
- If it continues to be like that, God will soon punish it, and it will be burned.

and its curse is imminent: The Greek word that the BSB translates as imminent is often translated as “near.” There are two main ways to interpret it here:

1. It means “in danger of.” For example:

and is in danger of being cursed (NIV) (NRSV, NIV, GNT, CEV, NCV, GW, REB)

1. It means “soon.” For example:

The farmer will soon condemn that field (NLT) (BSB, NLT, NRSV, NET)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It is supported by more English versions and commentators.

its curse: The Greek word that the BSB translates as its curse refers here to a decision that God may make to condemn the people who are like the worthless land. When God speaks the condemnation (curse), it is a judgment that cannot be avoided.

In some cultures the meaning of curse is different from the biblical meaning here. If that is true in your culture you may have to use a different word. For example:

being judged/condemned

being punished/destroyed

The text strongly implies that God is the one who will punish the land (people). In some languages it is necessary to make that explicit. For example:

being cursed/punished by God

God may soon condemn it.

In the end it will be burned: In Greek this clause is more literally “its end [is] for burning.” It means that, finally, the land will be burned. This implies that fire will burn all the plants on the land. (It does not imply that the land itself will burn.) In many places in the world, it is common to burn a field to prepare it for planting.

Some ways to translate this clause are:

finally, it will be burned

in the end, the farmer must burn the weeds off of it

In some languages it is necessary to make the meaning more explicit. For example:

it's burned over by the owner. And the same way also, the person like this land, he will be punished by God. Western Bukidnon Manobo back translation on TW.

General Comment on 6:7–8

Paragraph 6:7–8 compares soil and people. In some languages it is necessary to make the comparison more explicit. For example:

⁷Some people are like land that gets plenty of rain. The land produces a good crop for those who work it, and it receives God's blessings. ⁸Other people are like land that grows thorns and weeds and is worthless. It is in danger of being cursed by God and will be destroyed by fire. (NCV)

Hebrews 6:9

Section 5:11–6:12: Grow up in your faith, and do not give up

In Section 5:11–6:12 the author interrupted his teaching about God appointing Christ as the high priest in order to tell his listeners to mature in their faith and to warn them not to stop believing in Christ. After this warning (6:4–12), he will continue to teach them in 6:13–7:28 about the priesthood of Jesus and Melchizedek.

Remember to translate the section before choosing a heading for it. Some other possible headings are:

Warning about abandoning Christ

Do not be lazy but become mature followers of Christ

Paragraph 6:9–12

This paragraph is an obvious contrast to 6:7–8. In 6:7–8 the author sternly warned his readers that they must not give up their faith in Christ. Here in 6:9–12 he assured them that he believed better things about them. He encouraged them not to become lazy but to keep trusting Christ so that they will obtain all that Christ promised.

6:9a–c

Even though we speak like this, beloved, we are convinced of better things in your case—things that accompany salvation: The Greek text uses a different order of clauses than most English versions. It is more literally:

But we are convinced about you, beloved, of better things and things belonging to salvation, though thus we speak.

Use the order of clauses that is most natural in your language here. See the General Comment on 6:9a–c at the end of 6:9b–c for more information.

6:9a**Even though we speak like this, beloved,**

- ¶I Dear friends, even though we^(excl) are talking to you^(plur) like this,
- ¶I I speak severely like this to you^(plur), but I love you,

Even though we speak like this, beloved: Here the author introduces a contrast to what he said in 5:11–6:8. In 5:11–14 he told the listeners that they were still immature. Then in 6:1–8 he told them that it is a terrible sin to stop believing in Christ. Here in 6:9 he will begin to encourage them.

Some other ways to introduce this contrast and encouragement are:

But even if we speak like this, dear friends (GNT)

My friends, we are talking this way. But (CEV)

Yet although we speak as we do, we are convinced that you, dear friends (REB)

Notice that English versions translate the word beloved in different places in the sentence. In many languages it is most natural to put such a direct address at the beginning of the sentence. Do what is natural in your language.

we speak like this: The clause we speak like this implies that the author spoke sternly to his listeners (in 5:11–6:8). He warned them severely. He seemed to imply that maybe they had stopped believing in Christ. In some languages it may be necessary to make the meaning more explicit. For example:

Although we have spoken so sternly

We have warned you like this, but

we: The author used the word we here to refer only to himself. In some languages it is more natural to make that clear. For example:

even though my words to you are like thisWestern Bukidnon Manobo back translation on TW.

even though I am speaking like thisYakan back translation on TW.

beloved: After the severe words of the previous verses, the author addressed his listeners in a loving

way. He called them beloved. He did not use vocatives often in this letter. The only other places are in 3:1a (“holy brothers”), and in 3:12a; 10:19; and 13:22 (“brothers”). because he still loved them and considered them to be his fellow Christians. In some languages it is more natural to use a different phrase. Some languages use kinship terms or other terms for fellow believers. For example:

you relatives whom we loveUma back translation on TW.

my dear friends/brothers

In other languages it may be more natural to translate the meaning beloved as a phrase. For example:

Although we are talking to you like this, we/I love you

6:9b–c**we are convinced of better things in your case—things that accompany salvation:**

Here the author assured his listeners that he believed better things about them than the things he described in 6:1–8. There he described people who were going away from Christ. Here he indicates that he did not believe that his listeners were going away from Christ like that. He believed that they were receiving the blessings of salvation and doing the good things that saved people do.

Other ways to translate this clause are:

we are convinced of better things concerning you—things that accompany salvation (NIV)

We are confident that you are meant for better things, things that come with salvation (NLT)

better things...that accompany salvation: The phrase better things...that accompany salvation refers to at least two types of better things:

1. It refers to good things that saved people do. For example:

But we are sure that you are doing those really good things that people do when they are...saved (CEV)

1. It refers to good things that God does for people who are saved. For example:

We know that you have the better blessings that belong to your salvation. (GNT)

In some languages it may be necessary to focus on one of these types of better things rather than to try to mention them both. For example:

We know that you have better fruit...that is fitting for those who have obtained salvation from God. Uma back translation on TW.

Translate in a way that is natural in your language.

6:9b

we are convinced of better things in your case—

- we^(excl) believe much better things about you^(plur),
- and I believe that you^(plur) are not like that useless land, but your faith has good results/fruits,

better: The word better is one of the key words in Hebrews. It may be helpful to translate this word the same way whenever it occurs.

in your case: The phrase translated as in your case is literally “about you.” The pronoun your is plural and refers to the author’s listeners. Some other ways to translate the phrase here are:

about you (GNT)

as for you

6:9c

things that accompany salvation.

- and these things show that you^(plur) are saved.
- which show that God has saved you^(plur).

things that accompany salvation: This phrase refers to results or evidence of salvation. It implies that people who are saved will live as Christ wants them to live and do the good things that he wants them to do. Some other ways to translate the phrase things that accompany salvation are:

your doings are good and that is a sign that you are saved already Yakan back translation on TW.

your souls are saved, and therefore you do what is good. Otomi back translation on TW.

General Comment on 6:9a–c

There are different ways to order the clauses in 6:9. For example, the NASB follows the order of clauses in the Greek text:

^{9b}But, beloved, we are convinced of better things concerning you, ^{9c}and things that accompany salvation, ^{9a}though we are speaking in this way. (NASB)

In other languages it is more natural to reorder the clauses. For example:

^{9a}But even if we speak like this, dear friends, ^{9b}we feel sure about you. We know that ^{9c}you have the better blessings that belong to your salvation. (GNT)

Hebrews 6:10

Section 5:11–6:12: Grow up in your faith, and do not give up

In Section 5:11–6:12 the author interrupted his teaching about God appointing Christ as the high priest in order to tell his listeners to mature in their faith and to warn them not to stop believing in Christ. After this warning (6:4–12), he will continue to teach them in 6:13–7:28 about the priesthood of Jesus and Melchizedek.

Remember to translate the section before choosing a heading for it. Some other possible headings are:

Warning about abandoning Christ

Do not be lazy but become mature followers of Christ

Paragraph 6:9–12

This paragraph is an obvious contrast to 6:7–8. In 6:7–8 the author sternly warned his readers that they must not give up their faith in Christ. Here in 6:9–12 he assured them that he believed better things about them. He encouraged them not to become lazy but to keep trusting Christ so that they will obtain all that Christ promised.

6:10

In Greek this verse is one long sentence. In many languages it is more natural to use two or more sentences. See the General Comment on 6:10a–b at the end of 6:10b for more information.

For: Here the word For introduces a reason for the author’s statement in 6:9. It tells why he is confident

that his listeners have God's salvation. God is not unjust, so he will not forget what they have done for him. Some versions leave the connection implied. Indicate the connection between 6:9 and 6:10 in a natural way in your language.

6:10a

For God is not unjust.

- God is not unfair,
- God is always just/righteous,

God is not unjust: The phrase not unjust is an emphatic way to say "God is just." The author used two negatives not and "unjust" to emphasize the meaning. He also emphasized it by putting the word not first in the Greek sentence. In some languages, it may be more natural to emphasize the statement in a different way. For example:

God is always fair. (CEV)

God really is completely righteous.

God always treats people fairly.

not unjust: In many languages it is necessary to translate the phrase not unjust as "fair, righteous" and then to emphasize the meaning. See the examples in the preceding note.

6:10b

He will not forget your work

- and he will always remember all you^(plur) do
- so he will never forget the good things that you^(plur) have done.

He will not forget your work: The word He refers to God. The phrase will not forget tells a result of 6:10a, God is just (he is not unjust). Because he is just, he will not disregard the work that they did for him. In Greek the negative will not forget emphasizes that God will notice it. It implies that he will reward them for the work that they have done.

Some other ways to translate this statement are:

He will not forget how hard you have worked for him (NLT)

He will remember how you helped his people (CEV)

Notice that the phrase not forget is similar to the phrase "not unjust" in 6:10a, because it uses a negative phrase to emphasize a positive statement.

your work: The phrase your work refers here to everything that the Hebrews did for the Lord and the ways that they served him by serving God's people (as he says in 6:10c). It does not refer to work for which they were paid. In some languages it is more natural to translate the phrase your work more specifically. For example:

the good that you have doneKankanaey back translation on TW.

the work of God that you are doingOtomi back translation on TW.

your: The pronoun your is plural and refers to the people who heard or read what the author said.

General Comment on 6:10a–b

In the Greek text, 6:10a and 6:10b are part of one clause. For example:

For God is not so unjust as to overlook your work... (RSV)

Many English versions translate 6:10a and 6:10b as two sentences. For example:

God is not unfair. He will not forget your work... (GNT)

Translate the connection in a way that is natural in your language.

6:10c–d

and the love you have shown for His name as you have ministered to the saints and continue to do so:

Here the author tells the second thing about his listeners that God will not forget. God will not forget that they showed their love for him by serving their fellow Christians and continuing to serve them. He will remember that they love him and that they proved their love by helping his people.

Some other ways to translate 6:10c–d are:

and how you have shown your love to him by caring for other believers, as you still do (NLT)

and your love for him that you have continued to show...in your helping your companions who believe Kankanaey back translation on TW.

6:10c

and the love you have shown for His name

- and how you^(plur) show that you^(plur) love him
- You^(plur) have shown that you^(plur) love him

the love you have shown for His name: In this context the word love refers to the love that the listeners showed for God by helping his people. They did practical things to help other Christians who needed it, and their actions showed that they loved God.

In some languages it is more natural to translate love as a verb instead of a noun. For example:

and the ways you have shown that you love him

how you continue to show that you love him

See love, sense A, in KBT.

for His name: The phrase for His name means “for God.”

6:10d

as you have ministered to the saints and continue to do so.

- by serving your^(plur) fellow-believers. And you^(plur) are continuing to serve them.
- by taking care of the needs of his people, both in the past and now.

as you have ministered to the saints and continue to do so: The phrase as you have ministered to the saints means “by helping his people.” This is the way the listeners showed that they love God. In some languages it is natural to begin a new sentence here and repeat part of 6:10a–b. For example:

It is clear that you love God, for much is your helping your one-faith relatives, both in past times and at the present time. Uma back translation on TW.

as you have ministered: Here the Greek word that the BSB translates as as you have ministered means “to help by providing what someone needs.” Compare *διακονέω* BDAG, page 229, meaning 3 “to meet an immediate need, help.” Some other ways to translate the phrase are:

as you have helped (NIV)

by caring for (NLT)

the saints: The phrase the saints is literally “the holy ones.” It refers to people who are dedicated to God. In this context it refers specifically to people who follow Christ. The phrase is often used in this way in the epistles to refer to Christians. Some other ways to translate the phrase are:

his holy people (GW)

his people (NIV)

other believers (NLT)

For more information, see holy, sense 3(a), in KBT.

and continue to do so: In Greek this phrase is more literally “and serving.” It completes the meaning of the preceding phrase. It indicates that the listeners continued to help their fellow believers as they did in the past. Some other ways to translate the phrase are:

and you continue to help them (GW)

And he will remember that you are still serving them. (NCV)

General Comment on 6:10a–d

There are different ways to divide this verse into sentences and to connect the clauses. For example:

God is fair. He won’t forget what you’ve done or the love you’ve shown for him. You helped his holy people, and you continue to help them. (GW)

God is not unfair. He will not forget the work you did or the love you showed for him in the help you gave and are still giving to other Christians. (GNT)

Connect the clauses in a natural way in your language.

Hebrews 6:11

Section 5:11–6:12: Grow up in your faith, and do not give up

In Section 5:11–6:12 the author interrupted his teaching about God appointing Christ as the high priest in order to tell his listeners to mature in their faith and to warn

them not to stop believing in Christ. After this warning (6:4-12), he will continue to teach them in 6:13-7:28 about the priesthood of Jesus and Melchizedek.

Remember to translate the section before choosing a heading for it. Some other possible headings are:

Warning about abandoning Christ

Do not be lazy but become mature followers of Christ

Paragraph 6:9-12

This paragraph is an obvious contrast to 6:7-8. In 6:7-8 the author sternly warned his readers that they must not give up their faith in Christ. Here in 6:9-12 he assured them that he believed better things about them. He encouraged them not to become lazy but to keep trusting Christ so that they will obtain all that Christ promised.

6:11

There are several ways to order the phrases in this verse. Be sure to use a natural way in your language to express the relationship of the phrases. See the General Comment on 6:11 at the end of 6:11 for examples.

We want each of you to show this same diligence to the very end, in order to make your hope sure:

There are two views about what the phrase to the very end is connected to in this verse:

1. It is connected to “show the same diligence.” It means that they should be diligent to the very end. For example:

We want each of you to show this same diligence to the very end, so that what you hope for may be fully realized. (NIV) (BSB, NIV, NLT, GNT, NCV, REB, NJB)

1. It is connected to “realize the full assurance of hope.” It means that they should be eager to realize the hope until the end. For example:

And we desire that each one of you show the same diligence so as to realize the full assurance of hope until the end. (NASB) (NRSV, NASB, ESV, GW)

Some English versions are ambiguous. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), along with most English versions and commentators.

We want each of you to show this same diligence to the very end: In 6:10 the author indicated that the listeners had showed love for God by serving other believers. Here in 6:11 the author told them to continue to show that same eagerness to serve until the end of their lives. Some other ways to translate this meaning are:

and we earnestly request that every one of you will continue to behave like that for as long as you live

Our great desire is that you will keep on faithfully doing this until you die

6:11a

We want each of you to show this same diligence

- We^(excl) earnestly desire/plead that each of you will be faithful/eager to do this
- My great desire is for each of you to continue to show your love for him faithfully like that

We: The word We refers here to the author of Hebrews. It does not include the listeners. At the time when Hebrews was written, it was common for an author to use a plural form to refer to himself. In some languages it is more natural to use a singular form like “I.”

want: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as want means “to earnestly desire.” This Greek verb is used only here in Hebrews, but it occurs sixteen times in the NT. It indicates here that the author strongly desired his listeners to be diligent. Other ways to translate this meaning are:

greatly desire

earnestly beg/plead

In some languages it may be more natural to use a noun to translate the meaning. For example:

great desire (NLT)

earnest wish (JBP)

longing

to show this same diligence: The phrase this same diligence refers to the same type of eager effort and perseverance that the listeners showed in the past

when they served God's people. It indicates that they were devoted to what they were doing. In some languages it is more natural to use a verb to translate this phrase. For example:

to persevere

to faithfully continue to do this

6:11b

to the very end, in order to make your hope sure.

- to the end of your^(plur) lives to ensure that you will receive what you^(plur) hope for.
- until you^(plur) die. Then you^(plur) will fully experience what you expect from him.

to the very end: In Greek this phrase is more literally, “until the end.” There are two ways to interpret this phrase:

1. It means “to the end of their lives.” For example:

as long as life lasts (NLT) (NLT, NCV)

1. It means “until the end of time when the Lord returns.” For example:

until the last dayKankanaey back translation on TW.

Most English versions are ambiguous. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). In the context of Hebrews, the believers suffered persecution and might be killed for following Jesus. It is important for believers to be faithful to him for as long as we live.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

all your lives (NCV)

as long as you liveYakan back translation on TW.

in order to make your hope sure: This clause indicates the purpose of continuing to be diligent. The listeners should continue to be diligent so that they will be sure to receive what they hope for. Some other ways to translate this clause are:

so that you will receive what you have fully/confidently expected

so you will surely get what you hope for (NCV)

hope: The Greek word that the BSB translates as hope refers to expecting something with confidence that it will happen. That expectation is based on a reason. For more information, see ἐλπίζ meaning 1b β. page 320. In this context hope refers to being confident that God will do the good things that he promised to do for his people.

In some languages it is more natural to express hope with a clause. For instance:

what you hope for

what you confidently expect

This word occurred also in 3:6. See how you translated it there. It also occurs in 6:18, 7:19 and 10:23.

General Comment on 6:11

In this verse the author indicated that the listeners should continue to do what he praised them for doing in 6:10. Be sure that the reference back to those actions is clear. Some other ways to make it clear are:

We really request that every one of you exert effort to have behavior like that until the end so that you will indeed get what you are hoping for from God.Uma back translation on TW with omission of the conjunction and vocative.

That is what we wish, that each one of you simply/ just perseveres doing like that as long as you live so that your expectation from God will be fulfilled.

Hebrews 6:12

Section 5:11–6:12: Grow up in your faith, and do not give up

In Section 5:11–6:12 the author interrupted his teaching about God appointing Christ as the high priest in order to tell his listeners to mature in their faith and to warn them not to stop believing in Christ. After this warning (6:4–12), he will continue to teach them in 6:13–7:28 about the priesthood of Jesus and Melchizedek.

Remember to translate the section before choosing a heading for it. Some other possible headings are:

Warning about abandoning Christ

Do not be lazy but become mature followers of Christ

Paragraph 6:9–12

This paragraph is an obvious contrast to 6:7–8. In 6:7–8 the author sternly warned his readers that they must not give up their faith in Christ. Here in 6:9–12 he assured them that he believed better things about them. He encouraged them not to become lazy but to keep trusting Christ so that they will obtain all that Christ promised.

6:12a

Then you will not be sluggish,

- Be^(plur) careful not to become dull/lazy,
- We^(excl) urge you^(plur) not to be lazy.

Then you will not be sluggish: This clause tells the result of the listeners being diligent to care for other believers. When they do that, they will not become lazy so that they stop listening to God and serving him. Instead, they will be eager to learn more about him and to serve his people.

Some other ways to translate this result are:

Then you will not become spiritually dull (NLT)

Because if you do that, you will not become lazy
Kankanaey back translation on TW.

you: The pronoun you is plural and refers to all the people who listened to what the author said in Hebrews.

sluggish: The Greek word that the author used here was also used in the first verse of this section (5:11). There the BSB translated it as “dull.” In Hebrews this word refers to being lazy, dull, and sluggish, especially about faith in Christ. In this context it implies that the people may become lazy. Then they may not try hard to understand what God said and obey him.

Translate this word in the same way (or a similar way) as you did in 5:11.

6:12b

but will imitate those who through faith and patience inherit what has been promised.

- but imitate people who trust in God and are patient. Then they receive all that he has promised.
- Instead, we want you to be like those people who inherit God’s promises because they patiently believe him.

but will imitate those: The word but introduces a contrast with 6:12a. In 6:12a the author told the Hebrews not to be sluggish. Here in 6:12b he tells them what they should do instead. They should imitate faithful believers by following their example.

Some other ways to introduce this contrast are:

Instead, you will follow the example of those...
(NLT)

but to be like those... (GNT)

In some languages the contrast connection is implied by the context and a conjunction is not needed. For example:

Be like those who... (NCV)

What you should copy is the people who...
Tagbanwa back translation on TW.

who...inherit what has been promised: This phrase describes the people whom the Hebrews should imitate. They should imitate the people who inherit what has been promised. The word inherit is used in a figurative way here to mean “receive.”

Some other ways to translate the phrase who...inherit what has been promised are:

those who receive what was promised

people who obtain what God promised

inherit what has been promised: The word inherit refers here to people receiving what God promised them. It implies that God made the promises for all the people who will faithfully believe what he said. The promises were not only for the first people to whom God spoke them. The phrase does not imply that someone died and other people inherited the promises from him.

Some other ways to translate inherit what has been promised are:

receive what God has promised (GNT)

are given what God promised

obtain what he has promised to themUma back translation on TW.

This phrase is similar to the phrase “inherit salvation” in 1:14. You can probably translate the word inherit in a similar way here.

what has been promised: The phrase what has been promised refers to the good things that God promised to do for his people and to what he promised to give them. God made the promises because of his grace and goodness, not because his people did something to deserve them.

The word “promise” was also used in 4:1, and you should translate a plural form of the word here. Remember that a promise tells a person’s intention to do something. The person is obligated to do what he has said or he will be disgraced. A promise is different from an oath, so you should use different ways to translate these two words.

through faith and patience: The phrase through faith and patience tells how the people obtained what God promised. They patiently believed what God said, and as a result, God did fulfill his promises to them. Notice that the words faith and patience are used here to describe one action. The people patiently had faith in God. Because of their patient faith, they received what he promised.

Some other ways to translate the phrase “those who through faith and patience inherit the promises” are:

people who believe God and who patiently wait until they obtain what he has promised to themUma back translation on TW.

those who receive what God has promised because of their persevering faith and patienceKankanaey back translation on TW.

the ones who are patient and continue to trust in God and so they receive what he promised them

faith and patience: The words faith and patience are closely related here. Together the two words describe the people’s attitude toward God. They patiently had faith in him. They continued to faithfully believe in him until he did what he promised.

In some languages it is more natural to translate the two words as one action and the manner in which the action is done. For example:

people who patiently believe in God, for because of this, they will receive...Western Bukidnon Manobo back translation on TW.

faith: The word faith refers to trusting God and believing that what he says is true. It implies here that the people have confidence in God and in what God says. In some languages it is more natural to translate the word faith as a verb here. For example:

because they trust/believe God

See the other examples in the preceding notes on 6:12b. For more information, see believe, sense C, in KBT.

patience: The Greek word that the BSB translates as patience refers to being calm and steadfast while waiting for something to happen. In this context where patience is used along with “faith” and “promises” the word patience refers to steadfastly continuing to wait and expect God to fulfill his promises.

Some other ways to translate patience here are:

patiently waitUma back translation on TW.

who really persevereYakan back translation on TW.

Hebrews 6:13

Section 6:13–20: We can trust God’s promises because he does not lie

This section is the final part of the long appeal that the author began to make to his readers in 5:11. He urged them to keep on believing. He warned them not to give up what they believed. In this final section, he reminded them of God’s promise to Abraham, and he encouraged them that God always keeps his promises. We can come into God’s presence because Jesus, our high priest, is already there (6:20). He is a high priest like Melchizedek.

The last verse of this section is similar to 5:10, and connects this section to chapter 7. The author finished his long appeal to his readers in 6:20, and in 7:1 he continued his teaching about Jesus, our high priest.

Some other possible section headings are:

God always does what he promises to do

We can believe God because he always does what he said he would

6:13a

When God made His promise to Abraham,

- ¶ When God gave Abraham his promise,
- ¶ God promised to bless Abraham, and swore to fulfill the promise.
- ¶ God made a promise to our^(incl) ancestor Abraham,

In Greek the author connects this verse to the preceding section with a conjunction that is often translated as “for.” It indicates that the author will give support for what he said in the preceding verses. Here is another way to translate this conjunction:

For example (NLT)

The author also linked 6:13 with 6:12 by referring to the meaning “promise” in both. Use a natural way in your language to introduce such supporting comments. See the next note for more examples. In some languages a connector is not necessary.

When God made His promise to Abraham: In this clause the author wrote about God’s promises at the end of 6:12. Here he continued to say more about them. He used Abraham as an example. God promised to bless Abraham and give him many descendants, as in Genesis 12:1–4 and 15:1–5. Then after Abraham was willing to offer Isaac as a sacrifice to him (Genesis 22:1–14), God added an oath to his promise. After the drama of Isaac’s birth in Genesis 21, and the testing experience of Genesis 22, God emphasizes his promise to Abraham with an oath. The words “I swear by myself” only occur four times in the Old Testament—in Genesis 22:16; Isaiah 45:23; Jeremiah 22:1, 49:13. See also Genesis 22:15–18.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

Let’s consider Abraham, because there is also that which God promised him Kankanaey back translation on TW.

Remember God’s promise to Abraham. Tagbanwa back translation on TW.

Abraham: In some languages it is more natural to identify Abraham more explicitly. For example:

our^(incl) ancestor Abraham

Abraham, who is the ancestor for our^(incl) tribe

6:13b

since He had no one greater to swear by,

- God knew that there was no one who was greater than himself to guarantee/support the promise,
- Since no one is higher/greater than God so that God could swear by him,
- and there was no one greater than himself to support/confirm what he promised.

6:13c

He swore by Himself,

- so he swore by himself.
- he swore by his own name.
- So God used his own name to take an oath to do what he promised.

6:13b–c

since He had no one greater to swear by, He swore by Himself: In 6:13b–c the author tells why God swore by himself. God swore by himself because there is no one greater than he is. He himself was the only one who was able to fulfill the promise. There was also no one else to whom people could appeal to cause God to fulfill what he promised. Some other ways to translate this reason are:

Since there was no one greater than himself, he used his own name when he made his vow. (GNT)

There is nothing greater than God, so he swore naming himself. Western Bukidnon Manobo back translation on TW.

one greater to swear by: The phrase to swear by refers to anyone to whom God could appeal to enforce or strengthen his oath. The text implies that a person who could enforce the promise must be more powerful than the person who makes the promise. That is the only way that such a person could punish him if he did not fulfill what he swore to do. Since no one is as powerful as God, no one could punish him if he did not do what he promised to do. Another way to translate this meaning is:

to guarantee his oath

who could make him fulfill his oath

swear: To swear is to take an oath or to make a promise to do something. When someone adds an oath to what he is saying, it means “What I am saying

is true.” It does not imply that the person is using bad or inappropriate words. For more information, see also the note on 6:16a.

He swore by Himself: The clause He swore by Himself means “he promised that he would enforce the promise on himself.” Men have to swear by someone or something greater than themselves to guarantee that the promise is kept. But God swore by himself that he would keep his promise, because there is no one greater than himself to guarantee it. Other ways to translate this meaning are:

he used himself when he swore (NCV)

God took an oath in his own name (NLT)

God’s word can be trusted without the help of an oath, but God made it twice as dependable by adding an oath. See also 7:20 and the following verses. It is similar to the words “As I live...” which God often said in the Old Testament when he was speaking.

General Comment on 6:13b–c

In some languages it may be more natural to reorder 6:13b–c. For example:

^{13a}When God made his promise to Abraham, ^{13c}he swore by his own name. ^{13b}He did this because there was no one who was greater than himself.

The NJB translates 6:13 clearly as one sentence:

When God made the promise to Abraham, he swore by his own self, since there was no one greater he could swear by. (NJB)

In some languages it is more natural to use two sentences to translate this verse. For example:

God made a promise to Abraham. Since he had no one greater on whom to base his oath, he based it on himself. (GW)

Hebrews 6:14

Section 6:13–20: We can trust God’s promises because he does not lie

This section is the final part of the long appeal that the author began to make to his readers in 5:11. He urged them to keep on believing. He warned them not to give up what they believed. In this final section, he reminded them of God’s promise to Abraham, and he

encouraged them that God always keeps his promises. We can come into God’s presence because Jesus, our high priest, is already there (6:20). He is a high priest like Melchizedek.

The last verse of this section is similar to 5:10, and connects this section to chapter 7. The author finished his long appeal to his readers in 6:20, and in 7:1 he continued his teaching about Jesus, our high priest.

Some other possible section headings are:

God always does what he promises to do

We can believe God because he always does what he said he would

6:14a saying, “I will surely bless you

- He promised, “I will certainly bless you^(sing)
- God said, “It is absolutely true that I will bless you^(sing)

6:14b and multiply your descendants.”

- and give you^(sing) many children and descendants.”
- by causing you^(sing) to have many descendants.”

6:14

saying: The word saying introduces the words that God said when he made his promise to Abraham. In some languages it may be more natural to begin a new sentence here. For example:

He said to AbrahamKankanaey back translation on TW.

I will surely bless you and multiply your descendants: The statement I will surely bless you and multiply your descendants tells what God promised and swore to do. It is a quotation from Genesis 22:17. God repeated this promise to Abraham after Isaac was born. Since God swore by himself here, it may be helpful in some languages to refer to him more explicitly. For example:

I, the Lord, will bless you with many descendants. (CEV)

surely: The word surely means “certainly, indeed.” It indicates that God was making a very strong promise. Some other ways to indicate this are:

Without a doubt I will bless you

I will certainly bless you richly (NLT)

Really-really I say that I will fulfill what I am promising to you: I bless you with a big blessing. Uma back translation on TW.

bless: The word bless means “to do good to (someone).” For more information, see bless, sense A1, in KBT.

you: The pronoun you is singular and refers to Abraham.

multiply your descendants: The verb multiply here indicates that God will cause Abraham to have children and descendants. In this context it implies that God will cause Abraham to have many children and grandchildren for many generations.

your: The pronoun your is singular and refers to Abraham.

Hebrews 6:15

Section 6:13–20: We can trust God’s promises because he does not lie

This section is the final part of the long appeal that the author began to make to his readers in 5:11. He urged them to keep on believing. He warned them not to give up what they believed. In this final section, he reminded them of God’s promise to Abraham, and he encouraged them that God always keeps his promises. We can come into God’s presence because Jesus, our high priest, is already there (6:20). He is a high priest like Melchizedek.

The last verse of this section is similar to 5:10, and connects this section to chapter 7. The author finished his long appeal to his readers in 6:20, and in 7:1 he continued his teaching about Jesus, our high priest.

Some other possible section headings are:

God always does what he promises to do

We can believe God because he always does what he said he would

6:15a

And so Abraham, after waiting patiently,

- So after Abraham waited patiently for God to do what he said,
- Abraham waited patiently for many years, and then

And so: The phrase And so means “So,” or “Because of that.”

Abraham, after waiting patiently: In this context the phrase after waiting patiently indicates when Abraham received what God promised him. He received it after he waited patiently. Abraham had to wait many years for God’s promises to be fulfilled. He was seventy-five years old when God first spoke to him (Genesis 12:3–4), and he was one hundred years old when Isaac was born (Genesis 21:5).

Some other ways to translate the phrase are:

Abraham was patient, and so (GNT)

And so by persevering, Abraham (NET)

6:15b

obtained the promise.

- he received what God promised him.
- God gave him the son that he promised him.

obtained the promise: The phrase obtained the promise indicates that Abraham received what God promised to give him. The birth of Isaac was a fulfillment of God’s promise. Here is another way to translate this:

And so by persevering, Abraham was given the promise. (NET)

The phrase obtained the promise implies that Abraham received the promise from God, as 6:13 says. In some languages it is more natural to repeat “God” here. For example:

obtained what God promised him

received the child whom God promised to give him

General Comment on 6:15a–b

In some languages it may be natural to translate this verse as a reason and result. For example:

Abraham was patient, and so he received what God had promised. (GNT)

Abraham waited patiently for this to happen, and he received what God promised. (NCV)

Hebrews 6:16

Section 6:13–20: We can trust God's promises because he does not lie

This section is the final part of the long appeal that the author began to make to his readers in 5:11. He urged them to keep on believing. He warned them not to give up what they believed. In this final section, he reminded them of God's promise to Abraham, and he encouraged them that God always keeps his promises. We can come into God's presence because Jesus, our high priest, is already there (6:20). He is a high priest like Melchizedek.

The last verse of this section is similar to 5:10, and connects this section to chapter 7. The author finished his long appeal to his readers in 6:20, and in 7:1 he continued his teaching about Jesus, our high priest.

Some other possible section headings are:

God always does what he promises to do

We can believe God because he always does what he said he would

Paragraph 6:16–20

In 6:16–20 the author continued to explain about God's oath. In Greek, these verses are one long sentence, but English versions have divided it into shorter ones. The most solemn oath which the people of Israel used was "As (surely as) the Lord lives."

6:16a

Men swear by someone greater than themselves,

- ¶ People swear an oath by someone who is greater than themselves,
- ¶ When people swear, they swear by someone more important/powerful than themselves who can confirm/guarantee the oath.

Men swear by someone greater than themselves:

This clause indicates that when people swear an oath, they swear by someone who has more power than they do. Their oath implies that they are asking someone greater than themselves to enforce the oath. If they do not do what they have sworn to do, someone greater than themselves will punish them.

Some other ways to translate this statement are:

When people take oaths, they base their oaths on someone greater than themselves. (GW)

People swear by what is greater than themselves (REB)

6:16b

and their oath serves as a confirmation to end all argument.

- and their oath confirms/strengthens what they say so that no one contradicts them.
- Their oath shows that they will do what they say they will do. Then people stop arguing with them about it.

and their oath serves as a confirmation: The phrase their oath serves as a confirmation implies that the oath will confirm that the person who swears it will really do what he has said that he will do. Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

and the oath confirms what is said (NIV)

If a person wants to make known to his companions that what he is saying is true, he swears by someone....Kankanaey back translation on TW.

they show that what they are saying is trustworthy by making a vow

their oath: The word oath refers to a person calling on someone or something greater than himself to ensure that he will fulfill what he promises (or that what he says is true). The oath implies that if he does not fulfill it, God (or whatever he called on) will punish him.

In some languages there are specific words that are used when a person makes the oath. You should use a natural expression in your language. Some other ways to translate it are:

make a vow in the name of one who is higher/more-important than theyTagbanwa back translation on TW.

the thing he uses to strengthen his promise is, he calls upon God who is greater than he isWestern Bukidnon Manobo back translation on TW.

to end all argument: The phrase to end all argument means "stops people from arguing." It implies that people will not argue with what a person has said after he makes an oath. The people will believe that if the person did not speak truthfully, God (or whoever the person swore by) will punish him. People will

believe that the person will do what he said he will do so that he will not be punished.

argument: The word argument refers to people arguing with each other. In some languages it is more natural to translate the noun argument with a verb. For example:

disagreeing with each other

This word also occurs in 7:7, 12:3, and Jude 11.

Hebrews 6:17

Section 6:13–20: We can trust God’s promises because he does not lie

This section is the final part of the long appeal that the author began to make to his readers in 5:11. He urged them to keep on believing. He warned them not to give up what they believed. In this final section, he reminded them of God’s promise to Abraham, and he encouraged them that God always keeps his promises. We can come into God’s presence because Jesus, our high priest, is already there (6:20). He is a high priest like Melchizedek.

The last verse of this section is similar to 5:10, and connects this section to chapter 7. The author finished his long appeal to his readers in 6:20, and in 7:1 he continued his teaching about Jesus, our high priest.

Some other possible section headings are:

God always does what he promises to do

We can believe God because he always does what he said he would

Paragraph 6:16–20

In 6:16–20 the author continued to explain about God’s oath. In Greek, these verses are one long sentence, but English versions have divided it into shorter ones. The most solemn oath which the people of Israel used was “As (surely as) the Lord lives.”

6:17

In this verse the author applied what he said in 6:16 to God. God made a promise and then he also swore an oath. He used the oath to show people that he will surely do what he has promised.

6:17a

So when God wanted to make the unchanging nature of His purpose very clear

- Similarly, God wanted to show very clearly that he will not change what he decided to do

- In a similar way, God also wanted to strongly assure us that he will not change his plans/mind.

So when God wanted to make the unchanging nature of His purpose very clear: The word So is more literally “in which.” It indicates that God also did what the author said that human beings do (6:16). Just as a human being swears an oath so that people will believe him, God also wanted his people to believe him. So he swore an oath to show his people that he will truly do what he promised them. Here is another way to translate this:

God...wanted to make this perfectly clear (GW)

the unchanging nature of His purpose: The Greek word which the BSB translates as the unchanging nature means “unchangeableness.” It is used to refer to something that will never change. Here it refers to what God decided and promised to do. His decision is permanent and remains the same forever. It cannot be changed. Another way to translate this part of the verse is:

he will certainly not change what he planned/decided

of His purpose: The phrase of His purpose means “of his will,” or “of what he wants.” In some languages it is more natural to translate the noun purpose as a verb: For example:

his plans for them

what he decided/intended to do for them

For more translation suggestions, see the General Comment on 6:17a–c at the end of 6:17c.

6:17b

to the heirs of the promise,

- for the recipients of his promise.
- I am speaking of us who will receive what he promised.

to the heirs of the promise: The phrase the heirs of the promise means “those who would later receive what God had promised.” It does not imply here that anyone will die so that others will inherit what they owned. In some languages it is more natural to translate the phrase in a different way. For example:

those who would receive what he was promising-
Tagbanwa back translation on TW.

of the promise: The phrase of the promise includes what God promised Abraham and also what God promised to all who believe in his Son.

6:17c

He guaranteed it with an oath.

- Because of that, he confirmed his promise with an oath.
- So he added an oath to what he promised in order to make the promise even more emphatic.

He guaranteed it with an oath: The clause “he confirmed it with an oath” means “he made his promise stronger by adding an oath.” The word it refers to his promise.

Other ways to translate the clause are:

made the promise stronger by adding/swearing an oath

confirmed the promise with an oath

General Comment on 6:17a–c

The author talks about several actions in this verse, and he also mentions reasons for those actions. It is important to use a natural order in your language to translate the actions and the reasons for them. For example:

^{17c}So God added an oath ^{17b}for those who would receive what he had promised, ^{17a}because he wanted to show them very clearly that his purpose/will could not be changed.

^{17a}God wanted to show very clearly ^{17b}to those who would inherit what he had promised, ^{17a}that he would not change his plans for them. ^{17c}So he added an oath to what he had promised in order to make it stronger.

^{17a}God would not change his plan. He wanted to make this perfectly clear ^{17b}to those who would receive his promise, ^{17c}so he took an oath. (GW)

6:17a–c

(reordered) It is impossible that God will change his plans for the people who received his promise. He wanted to show them very clearly that he would

never fail to fulfill those plans. So he added an oath to his promise.

Hebrews 6:18

Section 6:13–20: We can trust God’s promises because he does not lie

This section is the final part of the long appeal that the author began to make to his readers in 5:11. He urged them to keep on believing. He warned them not to give up what they believed. In this final section, he reminded them of God’s promise to Abraham, and he encouraged them that God always keeps his promises. We can come into God’s presence because Jesus, our high priest, is already there (6:20). He is a high priest like Melchizedek.

The last verse of this section is similar to 5:10, and connects this section to chapter 7. The author finished his long appeal to his readers in 6:20, and in 7:1 he continued his teaching about Jesus, our high priest.

Some other possible section headings are:

God always does what he promises to do

We can believe God because he always does what he said he would

Paragraph 6:16–20

In 6:16–20 the author continued to explain about God’s oath. In Greek, these verses are one long sentence, but English versions have divided it into shorter ones. The most solemn oath which the people of Israel used was “As (surely as) the Lord lives.”

6:18

In this verse the author showed that God gave us two things (a promise and an oath), so that we would be very encouraged. In some languages it is more natural to change the order of clauses in this verse. See the General Comment on 6:18a–d at the end of 6:18d for examples.

6:18a

Thus by two unchangeable things

- God gave both his promise and his oath, and neither of them can be changed.
- He gave his people these two assurances that cannot change

Thus: The Greek conjunction translated Thus introduces the purpose for God confirming his promise with an oath (in 6:17). Indicate this purpose in a natural way in your language.

by two unchangeable things: The phrase by two unchangeable things indicates the means by which God assured people that he will do what he said. He reassured them in two ways: (1) by making a promise to them and (2) by confirming his promise with an oath.

Some ways to translate by two unchangeable things are:

by saying two things which cannot be changed

He did that so there would be two unchanging means by which people will know...

6:18b

in which it is impossible for God to lie,

- It is also impossible that God would fail to fulfill either his promise or his oath.
- and about which he cannot lie.

in which it is impossible for God to lie: This part of the verse refers to the two unchangeable things mentioned in 6:18b. It indicates that God cannot fail to keep either his promise or his oath. He is certain to keep both of them. Another way to translate this is:

and God cannot break either of them

to lie: The verb to lie refers here to not doing what was said or promised. Here it indicates that God will never fail to do what he says. He will always do what he says he will do, and no one can ever truly say that God has not kept his promise. Another way to say this is:

to not fulfill his promise

6:18c

we who have fled

- So he wants us who have fled to him
- He did that so that when we^(incl) run to him for safety

we who have fled: Here the author described his readers and himself as people who have fled to find refuge. He did not say what they had found refuge from. He said what they found refuge in. They took refuge in their certainty that God will do what he promised them. In many languages it is helpful to make God explicit here. For example:

we have run to God for safety (CEV)

we have fled to him for refuge (NLT)

we: The pronoun we is inclusive and refers to both the author and the readers.

have fled: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as have fled also means “flee to a place.” It implies fleeing somewhere where they will be safe. In this context the refuge is God, and people trust him to save them.

6:18d

to take hold of the hope set before us may be strongly encouraged.

- to hold tightly to the hope that he gave us.
- we will have confidence to receive what God told us to expect.

to take hold of the hope set before us may be strongly encouraged: The phrase may be strongly encouraged is more literally “will have strong encouragement.” It indicates God’s purpose for giving us his promise and oath. He wanted to give us great courage to persevere in trusting him to fulfill his promise. Some other ways to translate 6:18d are:

can have great confidence as we hold to the hope (NLT)

we will persevere in hoping/expecting what he has promised

the hope: The Greek word that the BSB translates as hope refers here to what we expect with confidence (from God). It includes all the good things that God has promised and prepared for us, including eternal life. It occurs also in 3:6, 6:11, 7:19, 10:23.

set before us: The phrase set before us is one word in Greek. It means “lying before us,” and it refers to what God will do for us in the future. The verb is passive. In some languages it is more natural to translate this with an active verb. For example:

which God has given to us

that God promised us

us: The pronoun us is inclusive and refers to both the author and the readers.

General Comment on 6:18a–d

In 6:18 the author indicated that God gave us both his promise and his oath to give us great confidence that he will save us as he promised. Neither the promise nor the oath can be broken, because it is impossible for God to lie.

In some languages it may be helpful to change the order of phrases in this verse. For example:

So we have both his promise and his oath which cannot be broken because it is impossible for God to lie. God confirmed his promise with an oath so that we might be very encouraged. We are people who have found refuge and firmly expect with hope what God has for us.

God did this so that we would be encouraged. God cannot lie when he takes an oath or makes a promise. These two things can never be changed. Those of us who have taken refuge in him hold on to the confidence we have been given. (GW)

Hebrews 6:19

Section 6:13–20: We can trust God's promises because he does not lie

This section is the final part of the long appeal that the author began to make to his readers in 5:11. He urged them to keep on believing. He warned them not to give up what they believed. In this final section, he reminded them of God's promise to Abraham, and he encouraged them that God always keeps his promises. We can come into God's presence because Jesus, our high priest, is already there (6:20). He is a high priest like Melchizedek.

The last verse of this section is similar to 5:10, and connects this section to chapter 7. The author finished his long appeal to his readers in 6:20, and in 7:1 he continued his teaching about Jesus, our high priest.

Some other possible section headings are:

God always does what he promises to do

We can believe God because he always does what he said he would

Paragraph 6:16–20

In 6:16–20 the author continued to explain about God's oath. In Greek, these verses are one long sentence, but English versions have divided it into shorter ones. The most solemn oath which the people of Israel used was "As (surely as) the Lord lives."

6:19–20

Some versions begin a new paragraph here. In 6:18 the author said that we can be absolutely certain or sure of the things we hope for. In 6:19–20 he used three different figures of speech to describe what this

hope is like, and what its results are. The three figures are an anchor, the curtain covering the inner part of the temple, and a forerunner. These figures of speech follow immediately one after the other.

6:19a

We have this hope as an anchor for the soul, firm and secure.

- This hope makes us^(incl) secure and strong.
- This expectation is like a strong anchor/support that will not let us^(incl) slip away.
- When we^(incl) know that God will bless us like this, we^(incl) are safe and strong.

We have this hope as an anchor for the soul, firm and secure:

Here the author compared our hope to an anchor. Literally, an anchor is a heavy object to which a boat is tied, so that it will not move. As a metaphor, it indicates that our souls are secure. We are supported by our confidence that Jesus has become the source of eternal salvation for us (5:9).

In many cultures anchors are unknown. Some other ways to translate the metaphor are:

- Translate anchor as a simile. For example:

This hope is like a firm and steady anchor for our souls. (CEV)

The way we hope in God is like the heavy weight that keeps a boat from drifting away.

- Use a similar figure of speech or one that is more general. For example:

That hoping of ours is like a foundation stone that makes our hearts stay so that our faith does not shake/rock. Uma back translation on TW.

- Translate the meaning without the figure of speech. For example:

This hope of ours, that is what makes firm/stable our faith, because it is certain to be fulfilled. Kankanaey back translation on TW.

We: The pronoun We is inclusive and refers to both the author and the readers.

this hope: The hope refers to looking forward to something and expecting it with confidence. Compare ἐλπίς meaning 1c, BDAG, pages 319–320. It does not imply that a person is not sure that he will receive it,

as the English word sometimes does. Some other ways to translate it are:

confidence (GW)

our hoping

our expecting to receive the promise

The phrase this hope refers specifically to expecting that we will receive “the promise” that the author mentioned in 6:17. Receiving what God promised is the hope that the author referred to in 6:18d.

anchor for the soul: The phrase anchor for the soul implies here that our confidence in God makes us firm and steadfast in trusting him. Some other ways to translate this meaning are:

our hope helps us trust God steadily

it is like a firm foundation that keeps us from moving away from God

soul: The word soul refers to the inner part of a person which thinks and feels and makes decisions. It was also used in 4:12c–d.

For more information, see soul, sense A1c, in KBT.

firm and secure: Here the author used two similar words to emphasize his meaning (as he often does in Hebrews). The word firm means “stable, steadfast, and strong.” The word secure means “safe,” or “reliable.” Some other ways to translate this emphasis are:

strongly/completely trust

6:19b

It enters the inner sanctuary behind the curtain,

- It has gone behind the dividing curtain into the holiest place
- It is as if we ourselves can see into the inner holy place behind the temple curtain,
- We^(incl) may enter into the presence of God himself

It enters the inner sanctuary behind the curtain:

This statement is a figure of speech. The pronoun It refers here to confidence in God’s promise and oath. It indicates that because of this confidence, we can approach God himself.

In many languages it is not natural to speak of It as entering a place. If that is true in your language, you may need to make the meaning more explicit. For example:

Because of our hope, it is as if we have already entered the exact place of God like the entering of the highest priest into the Holiest Room in the Temple which a curtain hid from view. Kankanaey back translation on TW.

enters the inner sanctuary behind the curtain: The phrase enters the inner sanctuary means “goes inside the most holy place behind the curtain where God is.” In the OT, the inner sanctuary behind the curtain was the holiest part of the tabernacle. It was the place where God met with the high priest. The high priest represented the people of Israel there. This shrine was separated from the rest of the tabernacle by a curtain. The shrine was such a holy place that only the high priest could enter it, and he entered it only once a year. In 9:1–7 the author describes this place again.

The inner sanctuary was a place, not an altar. It was the most holy place of all in both the tabernacle and the temple, and was the place where God himself dwells. The phrase behind the curtain implies “into the presence of God.”

the curtain: In the Gospels, the word curtain always refers to the curtain that divided the most holy place in the temple from the other parts of the temple. This curtain was torn apart when Jesus died, as a sign that the way into God’s presence was now open (Matthew 27:51; Mark 15:38 and Luke 23:45). The author will refer to this curtain again later in 9:3 and 10:20.

Hebrews 6:20

Section 6:13–20: We can trust God’s promises because he does not lie

This section is the final part of the long appeal that the author began to make to his readers in 5:11. He urged them to keep on believing. He warned them not to give up what they believed. In this final section, he reminded them of God’s promise to Abraham, and he encouraged them that God always keeps his promises. We can come into God’s presence because Jesus, our high priest, is already there (6:20). He is a high priest like Melchizedek.

The last verse of this section is similar to 5:10, and connects this section to chapter 7. The author finished his long appeal to his readers in 6:20, and in 7:1 he continued his teaching about Jesus, our high priest.

Some other possible section headings are:

God always does what he promises to do

We can believe God because he always does what he said he would

Paragraph 6:16–20

In 6:16–20 the author continued to explain about God's oath. In Greek, these verses are one long sentence, but English versions have divided it into shorter ones. The most solemn oath which the people of Israel used was "As (surely as) the Lord lives."

6:20a

where Jesus our forerunner has entered on our behalf.

- that Jesus entered for us^(incl),
- where Jesus has gone in before us^(incl) on our^(incl) behalf.
- where Jesus is. He has gone ahead of us^(incl),

where Jesus our forerunner has entered on our behalf: Here the word forerunner is a figure of speech. Literally, the word refers to someone who runs ahead and prepares the way for others who will come after him. Jesus is our forerunner. He has gone ahead of us into God's presence, and he has prepared the way for us also to come to God.

Other ways to translate 6:20a are:

Jesus has entered there first on our^(incl) behalf

Jesus has gone into that holy place before us^(incl) to speak to God for us

The word where refers back to "the inner shrine." That was the place that Jesus entered to prepare the way for us also to enter it. In some languages it is more natural to begin a new sentence here. For example:

That is the place where Jesus preceded us to speak to God for us.

our: The pronoun "us" is inclusive and refers to both the author and his hearers.

6:20b–c

Between 5:10 and 6:20, there is a long section of exhortation and warning. Now, in the last sentence of this chapter, the author repeated what he said in 5:10 about Jesus being a high priest according to the order of Melchizedek. There are some changes here in 6:20.

The differences in these two verses are underlined below:

5:10 having been designated by God a high priest according to the order of Melchizedek.

6:20b–c having become a high priest forever according to the order to Melchizedek.

Try to preserve the similarities and differences in these two verses in your translation.

6:20b

He has become a high priest forever

- He has become the high priest forever
- Now he is our eternal high priest
- and he has the position of high priest forever

He has become a high priest forever: This phrase indicates that when Jesus came into the presence of God on our behalf, he had already become a high priest forever. At that time he had offered himself and his own blood as a sacrifice to atone for our sins. In some languages it is helpful to begin a new sentence here. For example:

He had become a high priest forever.

In 5:10, the author described Jesus as "designated" by God to be a high priest. Here the verb is simply "became." Try to maintain the similarities and differences in 5:10 and 6:20 in your translation.

high priest: The author calls Jesus high priest often in Hebrews. Translate the term as you did in 2:17b or 5:1a.

forever: The word forever indicates that Jesus will always be the high priest. He will never die, so no one will ever come after him to be high priest for us. Jesus' priesthood is eternal.

6:20c

in the order of Melchizedek.

- in the tradition/way of Melchizedek's priesthood.
- in Melchizedek's way/order.
- with the type of priesthood that Melchizedek had.

in the order of Melchizedek: Translate this phrase as you did in 5:6b.

General Comment on 6:20a–c

In some languages it may be more natural to start a new sentence at 6:20. For example:

On our behalf Jesus has gone in there before us and has become a high priest forever, in the priestly order of Melchizedek. (GNT)

Jesus has gone there ahead of us, and he is our high priest forever, just like Melchizedek. (CEV)

In some languages it is natural to translate 6:20 as two sentences:

Jesus has already gone in there for us. He has become our eternal High Priest in the line of Melchizedek. (NLT)